

The Mahabharata

Vyasa's Epic, Told in Plain English

Book One: Adi Parva

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Chapter 1

The Storyteller in the Forest

Bow to Narayana, and to Nara, the best of men, and to the goddess Sarasvati. Then let the word Victory be spoken.

In the Naimisha forest, the sage Shaunaka and the brahmins of his household were holding a sacrifice that was to last twelve years. One day a visitor came to them there. His name was Ugrashravas. He was the son of Lomaharshana, and he was a suta, one of the bards who keep the old stories. He knew those stories well. People called him Sauti, the suta's son.

He came humbly, with his head bowed. The hermits who lived in the forest saw him arrive and gathered round him, eager to hear wonderful tales. He joined his palms and greeted every one of them, and asked how their austerities were going, and they made him welcome. When all the hermits had sat down, he took the seat they showed him, as a well-mannered guest should.

They let him rest. When they saw that he was comfortable, one of the seers began the talk.

"Where have you come from, Sauti?" he asked. "And where have you been all this time? Tell us."

Ugrashravas, who spoke well, gave them a proper answer.

"I have come from the snake sacrifice of King Janamejaya, the royal seer, the son of Parikshit. There, in front of the king, Vaishampayana told the many holy stories that Krishna Dvaipayana made. He told them fully and in the proper way. I heard those wonderful stories, all of them belonging to the Mahabharata.

"After that I wandered through many holy bathing places and shrines. I went to the sacred country called Samantapanchaka, where the brahmins go. It is the place where the war was fought long ago, between the Pandavas and the Kurus and all the kings of the earth. From there I came here, because I wanted to see you. Long life to you all. To me, you are holy men.

"You have bathed and made yourselves pure. You have said your prayers and fed the sacred fires. You shine like the sun, and like fire, and you sit here at ease at your sacrifice. What shall I tell you, brahmins? Holy tales from the ancient lore? Tales of dharma, the right way to live? Or the deeds of the great kings and the great seers?"

The seers answered him.

"Tell us the ancient story that the supreme seer Dvaipayana made. The gods heard it, and the brahmin seers, and they honoured it. It is the finest of all tales, rich in its words and its parts, subtle in meaning, sound in reason, and adorned with the meaning of the Vedas. It is the history of the Bharatas: holy, finely made, filled out with learning of every kind. It is the collection made by Vyasa, whose deeds were wonderful, and it stands equal to the four Vedas. It teaches dharma and it takes away the fear of wrongdoing. Vaishampayana told it to King Janamejaya at the sacrifice, gladly and faithfully, because Dvaipayana told him to. That is the story we want to hear."

Before he began, the bard bowed to God.

"I bow to the first Person, the Lord, on whom many call and whom many praise. He is truth. He is the single sacred syllable. He is Brahman, seen and unseen, eternal. He is what is and what is not, and the whole world, and he is beyond both what is and what is not. He made the high and the low. He is ancient, supreme, unchanging. He is Vishnu, blessed and the source of blessing, the most worthy, pure and without fault. He is Hrishikesha, and Hari, the teacher of all that moves and all that stands still.

"Having bowed to him, I will tell you the whole thought of Vyasa, the great seer whom every world honours, whose power has no measure.

"Some poets have told this history before. Some are telling it now. And others will tell it on this earth in times to come. It is great knowledge, and it is established in all three worlds. The twice-born, the learned classes, keep it both in full and in brief. It is adorned with fine words, with the ways of gods and of men, and with every kind of metre, and the learned love it."

Then he told them how the world began.

In the beginning there was no light. Nothing could be seen, and darkness covered everything on every side. Then one great egg came into being, the seed of all creatures, which never fails. At the start of the age, so they say, this was the great and divine cause of things. In it, it is said, was the true light, the eternal Brahman: wonderful, beyond thought, the same everywhere, the subtle and unseen cause of what is and what is not.

From it was born the Grandsire, the one lord of creatures: Brahma, teacher of the gods, who is also called Sthanu, and Manu, and Ka, and Parameshthin. After him came Prachetas, and Daksha, and the seven sons of Daksha, and then the twenty-one lords of creatures. Then came the Person whose self is beyond measure, whom all the seers know. Then came the Vishvedevas, the Adityas, the Vasus and the two Ashvins, the yakshas and the sadhyas, the pishachas and the guhyakas, and the spirits of the ancestors. Then were born the brahmin seers, wise and pure, and many royal seers endowed with every virtue. Then came the waters, the sky, the earth, the wind, the air between, and the directions; the year and the seasons, the months and the fortnights, and day and night in their turn. Everything else, too, came into being, and the world was its witness.

All that is seen here, whatever moves and whatever stands still, is drawn back in again when the age comes to its end. When a season comes round, its signs appear again, in all their different forms. In the same way, when a new age begins, all things appear again. So this wheel turns in the world, without beginning and without end, making creatures and unmaking them.

Thirty-three thousand, thirty-three hundred and thirty-three gods were created. That is creation, told in brief.

The sons of Vivasvat, the sun, were Divasputra, Brihadbhanu, Chakshus, Atman, Vibhavasus, Savitri, Richika, Arka, Bhanu, Ashavaha and Ravi. The youngest of them was Mahya. His son was Devabhrat, and Devabhrat's son was called Subhrat. Subhrat had three sons, learned and blessed with children: Dashajyoti, Shatajyoti and Sahasrajyoti. Dashajyoti

had ten thousand sons, Shatajyoti ten times as many, and Sahasrajyoti ten times as many again. From them came the line of the Kurus, and the lines of the Yadus and of Bharata, of Yayati and of Ikshvaku, and the lines of all the royal seers. Many lines came from them, and many kinds of creatures, in all their variety.

The seer saw it all come into being: the dwelling places of all creatures, the threefold mystery, the Veda and its discipline and the knowledge that goes with them, dharma and wealth and pleasure, the teachings on each of these and many other sciences, and the rules by which the world goes on. The histories with their explanations, and the sacred texts of every kind: all of them are gone through here. That is the mark of this book. The seer set out this great knowledge at length, and then he told it in brief as well, for the learned of the world like to hold a thing both ways.

Some brahmins learn the Bharata starting from Manu. Some start from the story of Astika, and some from the tale of Uparichara. Wise men bring to light the many kinds of knowledge in the collection. Some are skilled at explaining it, and others at keeping it by heart.

The maker of this holy history was the son of Satyawati. By austerity and by a celibate life he divided the eternal Veda, and then he made this story. He was Krishna Dvaipayana, the learned son of Parashara, a brahmin seer, strict in his vows, whose heart was set on dharma.

Long ago, at the command of his mother and of the wise Bhishma, he fathered three sons for the line of Vichitravirya, and they were like three sacred fires: Dhritarashtra, Pandu and Vidura. Then the wise seer went back to his hermitage to live in austerity. When his sons had been born, and had grown old, and had gone to the highest goal, the great seer told the Bharata in this world of men.

King Janamejaya asked him for it, and thousands of brahmins asked with him. So Vyasa told his pupil Vaishampayana, who sat beside him, to tell it. Vaishampayana sat with the priests of the sacrifice, and in the pauses between the rites he told the Bharata, and they urged him on again and again.

In it Dvaipayana told the whole story of the Kuru line. He told of Gandhari's devotion to dharma, of Vidura's wisdom and Kunti's strength of mind. He told of Krishna's greatness, of the truthfulness of the Pandavas, and of the wickedness of Dhritarashtra's sons.

He made the Bharata as a collection of twenty-four thousand verses. Without its side stories, that much is what the learned call the Bharata. Then the seer made a summary of a hundred and fifty verses more: the first chapter, which lists the events and the books.

Dvaipayana taught it first to his son Shuka. After that he gave it to other pupils who were worthy of it. Narada told it to the gods. Asita Devala told it to the spirits of the ancestors. And Shuka told it to the gandharvas, the singers of heaven, to the yakshas, the spirits of the wild places, and to the rakshasas, the night-walkers.

This is the story in brief, as the bard told it.

Duryodhana is a great tree made of anger. Karna is its trunk and Shakuni its branches.

Duhshasana is its rich flower and fruit. Its root is the foolish king Dhritarashtra.

Yudhishtira is a great tree made of dharma. Arjuna is its trunk and Bhimasena its branches. The two sons of Madri are its rich flower and fruit. Its root is Krishna, and the Veda, and the brahmins.

Pandu conquered many lands by his courage in battle. Then he went to live in the forest with his people, for he loved to hunt. There he killed a deer while it was mating, and that brought a terrible misfortune on him.

His two wives, following a secret teaching of dharma, went to the gods: to Dharma, to Vayu the wind, to Indra, and to the twin Ashvins. So the sons of Pritha were born, and from their birth they were brought up there in the proper way. The boys grew up among ascetics, guarded by their two mothers, in holy forests and in the hermitages of great men.

Then the seers themselves brought them to the sons of Dhritarashtra. They were handsome children with matted hair, living the life of young students of the Veda.

"These are your sons and your brothers, your pupils and your friends," the sages said.

"These are the Pandavas." And then the sages vanished.

The Kauravas saw the Pandavas presented to them. So did the good citizens of every class. They all shouted aloud for joy.

Some said, "They are not his."

Others said, "They are his."

Others said, "Pandu has been dead a long time. How can they be his?"

And on every side voices were heard: "Welcome, all of you! What good fortune that we see Pandu's children! Say welcome to them!"

When that noise died down, a great roar rose from beings no one could see, and it filled every direction. Flowers rained down, there were sweet scents, and conches and drums sounded as the Pandavas entered the city. It was a wonder. The citizens were delighted, and their joy rose in a great sound that reached the sky and spread the Pandavas' fame.

The Pandavas learned all the Vedas and many other sciences, and they lived there honoured, afraid of nothing. The people loved Yudhishtira for his purity, Bhimasena for his steadiness and Arjuna for his courage. They loved Kunti for the care she gave to her elders, and the twins for their modesty. The whole world was glad of the brothers, for their courage and their goodness.

In time the kings gathered for a princess who would choose her own husband, and Arjuna did a thing that was very hard to do and won Draupadi. From then on every archer in the world honoured him, and in battle he was like the sun: too bright to look at. He conquered all the kings of the earth, and all the great peoples, and so he brought his brother the king the great sacrifice of kings, the Rajasuya.

So Yudhishtira held the Rajasuya, rich in food and in gifts, perfect in every part. He

held it through Krishna's good counsel and the strength of Bhima and Arjuna, once they had killed Jarasandha and the proud king of the Chedis.

Gifts came in from every side, and it was Duryodhana who received them: gems and gold and jewels, cattle, elephants, horses and riches. When he saw how the Pandavas prospered, a great anger rose in him, born of envy. He saw the assembly hall that Maya, the builder of the asuras, had made for them, as fine as the flying palaces of the gods, and the sight tormented him. In that hall he stumbled, confused, and Bhima laughed at him like a boor, in front of Krishna.

Duryodhana had pleasures of every kind and jewels of every kind. Yet word came to Dhritarashtra that his son had grown pale and sallow and thin. So Dhritarashtra, who loved his son, allowed the game of dice.

When Krishna heard of it, a great anger rose in him. He was far from pleased. Yet he let the quarrels take their course, and he looked on as the dice and the other terrible wrongs grew. Then, setting aside Vidura and Drona, Bhishma and Kripa, he made the warriors of the earth kill one another in that fearful war.

When the sons of Pandu were winning, and all the news was bitter, King Dhritarashtra knew what Duryodhana intended, and what Karna and Shakuni intended. He thought for a long time. Then he spoke to Sanjaya.

"Listen to all of it, Sanjaya, and do not think ill of me. You are learned, and clever, and wise, and the wise respect you.

"I never wanted war. The ruin of the Kurus gave me no joy. I made no difference between my own sons and the sons of Pandu. But my sons are full of anger, and they resent me because I am old. And I am blind. I am weak, and I love my son, and so I put up with it. Duryodhana loses his senses, and I lose mine with him.

"At the Rajasuya he saw the glory of Pandu's mighty son. When he climbed up into that hall to look at it, they laughed at him. He could not bear it. He could not beat the Pandavas in battle by himself, and he had no heart to win fortune for himself, the way a kshatriya, a man born to fight, should win it. So he and Shakuni, the king of Gandhara, planned a crooked game of dice.

"Now hear from me, Sanjaya, everything I came to know, as it came to me, one thing after another. When you have heard my words and seen that they are reasoned and true, then you will know, son of a suta, that I am a man who sees with his mind."

Chapter 2

When I Heard

Then the blind king told Sanjaya what he had heard, one thing after another. And after each one, he said the same words.

"Arjuna drew the wonderful bow and pierced the target and brought it down to the ground. He carried off Draupadi while all the kings looked on. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"In Dvaraka, Arjuna took Subhadra of the Madhu clan by force. The two heroes of the Vrishnis came to Indraprastha. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"Indra, king of the gods, poured down his rain, and Arjuna held it back with his divine arrows. He gave the fire god his fill in the Khandava forest. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"Yudhishtira was beaten at the dice by Shakuni, the son of Subala, and lost his kingdom. And his brothers, whose strength has no measure, still followed him. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"Draupadi was brought into the hall, choking with tears, suffering, in a single garment, in her monthly season. She had husbands to protect her, and no one protected her. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"Those righteous men set out for the forest, and I heard of all they did as they went. The Pandavas suffered for love of their eldest brother. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"Thousands of brahmins who had finished their studies went with the king of dharma into the forest, and great-souled brahmins who lived on alms. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"The three-eyed god of gods, Shiva, came to Arjuna in the form of a mountain hunter. Arjuna fought him and pleased him, and won the great weapon of Pashupata. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"Arjuna, true to his word and praised by all, went up to heaven. There he learned the divine weapons from Indra himself, in the proper way. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"Bhima and the other sons of Pritha met Kubera, lord of riches, in a country where no human being can go. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"My sons, who followed Karna's advice, went out to see the cattle. The gandharvas took them prisoner, and Arjuna set them free. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"Dharma came to the king of dharma in the form of a yaksha and asked him questions, and he answered them rightly. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"While Arjuna was living in Virata's kingdom, he broke my greatest warriors, alone on a

single chariot. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"The king of the Matsyas offered Arjuna his daughter Uttara, with every honour, and Arjuna accepted her for his son. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"Yudhishtira was beaten and penniless, driven out and cut off from his own people, and still he had seven full armies behind him. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"Narada said that Krishna and Arjuna are Nara and Narayana, and that he himself has always seen them so in the world of Brahma. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"Krishna of the Madhu clan, Vasudeva, whose single stride, they say, is this whole earth, gave himself heart and soul to the Pandavas' cause. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"Karna and Duryodhana made up their minds to seize Krishna, and he showed himself in many forms. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"As Krishna was leaving, Pritha stood alone in front of his chariot in her grief, and he comforted her. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"Krishna was their counsellor. Bhishma, son of Shantanu, and Drona gave them their blessing. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"Karna said to Bhishma, 'I will not fight while you are fighting.' And he left the army and went away. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"Krishna and Arjuna and the Gandiva bow, whose power has no measure, those three fierce powers, came together. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"Arjuna sank down on his chariot, overcome with despair, and Krishna showed him all the worlds inside his own body. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"Bhishma, the scourge of his enemies, was killing ten thousand chariot-fighters in the battle, and not one of the Pandavas' great men was killed. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"Bhishma, bravest of the brave, whom no one could defeat, was struck down in battle by Arjuna, who put Shikhandi in front of him. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"The old hero Bhishma lay on a bed of arrows, brought down by bright-feathered shafts, after he had cut the Somakas down until few were left. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"As Bhishma lay there, he asked for water. Arjuna split the earth and gave him water to drink. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"The planet Venus and the sun stood in their places for the victory of Kunti's sons, and the beasts of prey howled at us day after day. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope

of victory.

"Drona, that wonderful fighter, showed every way of fighting with weapons, and still he did not kill any of the greatest of the Pandavas. Then, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"Our great chariot-fighters, the Samshaptakas, swore themselves to Arjuna's death, and Arjuna killed them. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"Drona himself, weapons in hand, guarded a battle array that no one else could break, and Subhadra's heroic son broke into it alone. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"Our great chariot-fighters could not stand against Arjuna. So they all surrounded the boy Abhimanyu and killed him, and they were glad. Then, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"When they had killed Abhimanyu, Dhritarashtra's sons were shouting, drunk with joy, and Arjuna turned his anger on Jayadratha. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"Arjuna swore to kill Jayadratha, and he made his vow come true in the middle of his enemies. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"Arjuna's horses were exhausted. Krishna unyoked them, let them drink, brought them back, yoked them again and drove on. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"While his horses rested, Arjuna stood on his chariot with the Gandiva bow and held off every warrior. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"Satyaki of the Vrishnis crushed Drona's army, with its elephant troops that no one could withstand, and went to where Krishna and Arjuna were. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"Karna had Bhima in his power. He insulted him and prodded him with the tip of his bow, and let him go alive. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"Drona and Kritavarma and Kripa, Karna and Drona's son and the brave king of Madra let Jayadratha be killed. Then, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"Indra had given Karna a divine spear, and Krishna turned it aside onto Ghatotkacha, the terrible rakshasa. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"In the fight between Karna and Ghatotkacha, Karna threw the spear that was meant to kill Arjuna in battle. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"The teacher Drona sat alone on his chariot, and he had given himself up to death. Dhrishtadyumna stepped beyond dharma and cut him down. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"Nakula, the son of Madri, fought Drona's son chariot to chariot, in front of everyone,

and held his own. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"After Drona was killed, his son used the divine weapon of Narayana, and still he did not make an end of the Pandavas. Then, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"Karna, bravest of the brave, whom no one could defeat, was killed by Arjuna in that war between brothers, which was the gods' secret. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"Drona's son and Kripa, Duhshasana and fierce Kritavarma could not overpower Yudhishtira, though he stood alone. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"The brave king of Madra, who was always Krishna's rival in battle, was killed by the king of dharma. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"Shakuni, root of the quarrel and of the dice, whose strength was trickery, was killed in battle by Sahadeva the Pandava. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"Duryodhana, worn out and alone, went into a lake and stilled its waters and lay there, with no chariot, his pride broken. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"The Pandavas stood at the lake of the Ganga with Krishna and insulted my son, who never could bear an insult. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"My son moved round the circle in the mace fight, trying every skill, and he was killed unfairly, by Krishna's design. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"Drona's son and the others killed the Panchalas and the sons of Draupadi in their sleep. It was a foul and shameful deed. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"Ashvatthama, chased by Bhimasena, in his anger let loose the supreme weapon, the Aishika, and it struck down the child in the womb. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"Arjuna let loose the Brahmashiras weapon, crying 'Peace!', and quieted that weapon with his own, and Ashvatthama gave up his jewel. When I heard that, Sanjaya, I had no hope of victory.

"Drona's son was bringing his great weapon down on the child in the womb of Virata's daughter. And Dvaipayana and Krishna laid their curses on him.

"Gandhari is to be pitied, robbed of her sons and her grandsons. So are the wives of my sons, robbed of fathers and of brothers. The Pandavas have done a thing that was very hard to do. They have won back their kingdom, and no one stands against them.

"Oh, the pity of it! I hear that only ten are left alive after the war: three of ours, and seven of the Pandavas. Eighteen full armies of warriors were killed in that battle.

"Darkness has spread over me, and a kind of madness seems to be coming into me. I cannot find my senses, son of a suta. My mind is reeling."

When he had said this, Dhritarashtra wept and grieved bitterly, and he fainted. When he came to himself again, he spoke to Sanjaya.

"Sanjaya, things being as they are, I want to give up my life, and soon. I cannot see the smallest good in staying alive."

The king was grieving and talking like this, broken. Then Sanjaya, the wise son of Gauthama, spoke to him, and his words were full of meaning.

"You have heard Dvaipayana and the wise Narada tell of kings of great courage and great strength. They were born in great royal lines rich in virtue. They knew the divine weapons and blazed like Indra. They won the earth by dharma, held sacrifices and gave the priests their fees, and won fame in this world. And then they fell into the power of Time.

"There was Vainya, the great chariot-fighter, and Srinjaya, the best of victors. There were Suhotra, and Rantideva, and Kakshivat, son of Ushij. There were Bahlika, Damana, Shaibya, Sharyati, Ajita and Jita. There were Vishvamitra, the slayer of enemies, and mighty Ambarisha, and Marutta, and Manu, and Ikshvaku, and Gaya, and Bharata. There were Rama, son of Dasharatha, and Shashabindu, and Bhagiratha. There was Yayati, whose deeds were good, for whom the gods themselves made sacrifice, whose earth was marked all over with shrines and sacrificial posts, and was full of sacrifices. These are the twenty-four kings of whom the divine seer Narada told King Shaibya long ago, when grief for his son was burning him.

"And before them other kings have gone, stronger still: great chariot-fighters and great souls, rich in every virtue. There were Puru, Kuru, Yadu and Shura, and Vishvagashva of great strength of mind. There were Yuvanashva, Kakutstha, and brave Raghu. There were Ushinara, and Vena, and Sagara, and Nimi, and Nala of the Nishadhas, and many more besides. These and many others we hear of, by hundreds and by thousands, and still others by the ten thousand, in numbers too vast to name.

"Great kings, wise and strong, far greater than your sons, left their vast pleasures behind them and met their deaths. Their deeds were divine, and so were their courage and their giving. Great poets of old tell of their greatness and their faith, their truth, their purity and their honesty. They had every blessing and every virtue, and they died too.

"Your sons were wicked. They burned with anger. They were greedy, and most of what they did was wrong. You should not grieve for them.

"You are learned and clever and wise, and wise men respect you. Those whose minds follow the scriptures do not lose their senses, Bharata. You know how to punish and how to show mercy, lord of men. And it is not taught that a father should go to any length to shield a son.

"It was to be, and so you must not grieve. Who can turn back fate by any cleverness? No one steps outside the path the Maker has laid down. All this has its root in Time: being and not being, joy and sorrow.

"Time ripens all creatures. Time destroys them. When Time burns up the creatures, Time

again puts out the fire. Time makes all things in the world, good and bad. Time draws all creatures in, and sends them out again. Time moves through all beings, and no one holds it back, and it treats all alike.

"All that has been, all that will be, and all that is now: know that Time has made them, and do not let go of your senses."

Here Ugrashravas turned back to the sages in the forest.

"In this," he said, "Krishna Dvaipayana spoke a holy and secret teaching. If a man with faith learns even a quarter of a verse of the holy Bharata, every one of his sins is washed away.

"Here the holy divine seers are praised, and the brahmin seers and the royal seers whose deeds were good, and the yakshas and the great serpents too. And here the blessed Krishna, son of Vasudeva, is praised, the eternal one. He is truth and right. He is pure and holy. He is Brahman, eternal and supreme, the unchanging, everlasting light, whose divine deeds the wise tell over. From that god come what is and what is not, and what is both. From him come the flow of life and all its striving, birth and death and birth again. What the scriptures call the self, made of the qualities of the five elements, and what lies beyond the unseen: that is he, and it is of him that they sing. The best of ascetics, steady in yoga, strong in meditation, see him standing inside themselves, like a reflection in a mirror.

"A man who has faith, who is always diligent and holds to truth and dharma, and who keeps to this chapter, is set free from sin. Whoever listens always, with faith, to this first chapter of the Bharata, which sets out its whole course, does not sink down when troubles come. Whoever recites some of it at dawn and at dusk is freed at once from any sin gathered by day or by night.

"This is the body of the Bharata. It is truth and it is nectar. As butter is the best of curds, as the brahmin is best of those who walk on two feet, as the ocean is best of all waters and the cow the best of beasts that walk on four, so the Bharata is called the best.

"If a man has even a quarter of a verse of it recited to brahmins at a rite for the dead, the food and drink he offers will reach his ancestors and never fail them.

"Let a man make the Veda larger with the histories and the old stories. The Veda is afraid of a man with little learning. 'He will do me harm,' it thinks.

"A learned man who recites this Veda of Krishna Dvaipayana to others wins his purpose. He is freed even from the sin of killing an unborn child, of that there is no doubt. I believe that a man who reads this chapter, pure, at every change of the moon, has read the whole Bharata. And whoever listens to this work of the seer every day, with faith, will win long life and fame and the road to heaven.

"Long ago the gods and the divine seers came together and set up a pair of scales. They put the four Vedas on one side and the Bharata alone on the other. The Bharata was heavier, and greater. Because of its greatness and its weight it is called the Mahabharata, the Great Bharata. Whoever knows what its name means is freed from every sin.

"Austerity is not wrong. Study is not wrong. The rites that the Veda lays down are not wrong. Winning wealth by force is not wrong. But all of these, done with a spoiled heart, are wrong."

Chapter 3

The Hundred Parts

"You spoke of Samantapanchaka, son of the suta," said the seers. "We would like to hear all about it, as it should be told."

"Listen, then, good brahmins," said Ugrashravas, "if you wish to hear good stories, and hear about the place called Samantapanchaka.

"Between the second age of the world and the third, Rama, the son of Jamadagni, the greatest of all who bear arms, was driven by his rage to kill the kshatriyas of the earth, the whole warrior class, again and again. He blazed like fire. By his own strength he wiped out all the kshatriyas, and at Samantapanchaka he made five lakes of their blood. There, beside himself with anger, he offered their blood to his ancestors. So we have heard.

"Then Richika and his other ancestors came to him, that bull among brahmins, and held him back. 'Forgive,' they said. And he stopped.

"The land around those lakes of blood is called Samantapanchaka, the Place of the Five, and it is holy. The wise say that a place should be called by the mark it bears. And when the time came between the third age and the last, the Kali age, the war between the armies of the Kurus and the Pandavas was fought at Samantapanchaka. Eighteen full armies came together in that land, eager to fight. It is a land of the highest dharma, and nothing on it is flawed. That is how the place got its name, brahmins. I have told you all of it now: how that holy and lovely land became famous in the three worlds."

The seers spoke again. "You spoke of the full army, the akshauhini, son of the suta. We would like to hear exactly what it is: how many chariots and horses, men and elephants. Tell us, for you know it all."

"One chariot, one elephant, five men on foot and three horses make a patti," said Ugrashravas. "So say those who know. Three pattis make an army's head. Three heads make a troop, three troops a company, three companies a column. Three columns make a division, three divisions a host, three hosts a force. And ten forces, the learned say, make a full army, an akshauhini.

"Those who know how to count have counted the chariots in a full army: twenty-one thousand, eight hundred and seventy. The elephants are the same. There are a hundred and nine thousand, three hundred and fifty men on foot, and sixty-five thousand, six hundred and ten horses. That is the full army, the akshauhini, as I have described it to you.

"Counted this way, the armies of the Kurus and the Pandavas together came to eighteen full armies. They came together in that land and they died there, for the Kauravas' sake, by the working of Time, whose deeds are wonderful.

"Bhishma, who knew the highest weapons, fought for ten days. Drona guarded the Kuru army for five. Karna, who crushed enemy armies, fought for two. Shalya fought for half a day, and after that came the fight with maces. And at the end of that same day, Kritavarma, Drona's son and Kripa killed Yudhishtira's army at night, while it slept, trusting them.

"Now, at this sacrifice of yours, Shaunaka, I will tell the Bharata in full, beginning with the story of Pauloma. It is a story of many meanings and many words, full of the customs of the world. The wise take to it the way men who seek release take to giving up the world. Among all that can be known, it is like the self. Among all that is dear, it is like life. Among all the sacred traditions, this history is the best, and it has the highest purpose. The best of minds is set in this best of histories, the way all speech, in the world and in the Veda, rests on vowels and consonants.

"Listen now to the parts of this Bharata history, so full of wisdom, so rich in its words and its parts."

So the bard went through the whole of it for them, book by book, naming each part and telling what it held. There were a hundred parts in all, gathered into eighteen books.

The first book is the Beginnings. Its parts are these: the Table of Contents; the Summary of the Parts; Paushya; Pauloma; Astika; the Descent of the Lines; the wonderful part of the Births, which the gods themselves made; the Burning of the House of Lac; Hidimba; the Killing of Baka; Chaitraratha; the Bride-choice of the Panchala princess; the Wedding, after the princess was won by a warrior's rules; the Coming of Vidura; the Gaining of the Kingdom; Arjuna's Stay in the Forest; the Carrying Off of Subhadra; the Bringing of the Wedding Gifts; and the Burning of the Khandava Forest, where Maya is seen.

In Paushya, the greatness of Uttanka is told. In Pauloma, the family of Bhrigu is described at length. In Astika come the births of all the snakes and of Garuda, the churning of the ocean of milk, and the birth of the horse Uchchaisravas; and it tells how this story of the great Bharatas first came to be told, at the snake sacrifice of King Janamejaya, son of Parikshit.

The part of the Births tells how many kings came to be born, and many brahmins, and the seer Dvaipayana. It tells how the gods came down to earth in portions of themselves, and so did the daityas and danavas, the mighty yakshas, the nagas, the snakes, the gandharvas, the birds and all kinds of other beings. It tells how the Vasus were born again of the river Ganga, in Shantanu's house, and went back up to heaven. It tells how Bhishma was born from the joined portions of their power; how he gave up the kingdom and held to his vow of celibacy, and kept his promise; how he protected Chitrangada, and when Chitrangada was killed, protected his younger brother, and put Vichitravirya on the throne. It tells how Dharma was born among men because of the curse of Animandavya; how Dhritarashtra and Pandu were born of Krishna Dvaipayana, by a boon; and how the Pandavas were born.

Then comes the journey to Varanavata, and Duryodhana's plot, and the tunnel dug on Vidura's advice. The Pandavas, in a terrible forest, meet Hidimba, and here the birth of Ghatotkacha is told. The Pandavas live unknown in a brahmin's house, and Baka is killed, and the townspeople marvel. Arjuna defeats the gandharva Angaraparna on the bank of the Ganges, and goes with all his brothers towards the Panchalas. Here are the fine tales of Tapati, of Vasishtha and of Aurva, and the wonderful tale of the five Indras. Drupada wonders whether one woman may be the wife of five men, and Draupadi's marriage is made by the gods, not by men. Vidura comes; the Pandavas see Krishna; they live in Khandavaprastha and rule half the kingdom. At Narada's bidding, they make their agreement about Draupadi, and the tale of Sunda and Upasunda is told. Arjuna goes to live in the forest and on the way meets Ulupi; he visits holy places, and Babhravahana

is born. In Dvaraka, Arjuna of the diadem wins Subhadra, who loves him, with Krishna's blessing. When Krishna, Devaki's son, comes with the wedding gifts, the discus and the bow are won and the Khandava forest is burned. Abhimanyu, full of fire, is born to Subhadra. Maya is saved from the fire, and so is a snake, and the sons of the great seer Mandapala are born of the bird Sharngi.

That is the first book, and it is very long. The supreme seer Vyasa counted two hundred and eighteen chapters in it, and seven thousand, nine hundred and eighty-four verses.

The second book is the Assembly Hall, and much happens in it. Its parts are: the Assembly Hall; the Counsel; the Killing of Jarasandha; the Conquest of the Directions; the Royal Consecration; the Taking of the Guest Gift; the Killing of Shishupala; the Dice; and the Second Dice Game.

The Pandavas' hall is built, and the servants seen. Narada, who has seen the gods, tells of the halls of the guardians of the world. The Rajasuya begins, Jarasandha is killed, and Krishna sets free the kings locked up in Girivraja. At the Rajasuya, in the quarrel over the guest gift, Shishupala is killed. Duryodhana sees the splendour of the sacrifice and is full of grief and resentment, and Bhima laughs at him on the floor of the hall. From that his anger grows, and it makes him set up the game of dice. In the dice game, Shakuni the gambler beats the son of Dharma. The Pandavas are drowning in an ocean of dice, and Draupadi carries them across it, as a boat carries men across the sea. When King Duryodhana learns that they have got across, he challenges the Pandavas to dice again. The great seer counted seventy-two chapters in this book, and two thousand, five hundred and eleven verses.

The third book is the great book of the Forest. Its parts are: the Forest; the Killing of Kirmira; the Mountain Hunter, the fight between the Lord and Arjuna; the Journey to Indra's World; the Pilgrimage of the wise king of the Kurus; the Killing of Jatasura; the Battle with the Yakshas; the Python; the Session with Markandeya; the Talk between Draupadi and Satyabhama; the Cattle Expedition; the Dream of the Deer; the Story of the Measure of Rice; the Carrying Off of Draupadi; the Taking of the Earrings; and the Fire-Sticks.

The citizens follow the wise son of Dharma, and the Vrishnis and all the Panchalas come. The story of the killing of Saubha is told, and Kirmira is killed. Arjuna, whose power has no measure, goes away to win weapons. He fights Mahadeva, the great god, who takes the form of a mountain hunter, and sees the guardians of the world, and goes up to heaven. The great seer Brihadashva comes, and Yudhishtira pours out his grief in his troubles. Here is the tale of Nala, full of dharma and full of pity, where Damayanti stands firm when disaster falls on Nala. Lomasha tells the Pandavas, in their exile, how Arjuna is faring in heaven. The Pandavas go on pilgrimage, and Jatasura is killed. Draupadi sends Bhimasena to Gandhamadana for the flowers of the mandara tree, and he breaks into the lotus pool; there he fights a great battle with rakshasas, and with mighty yakshas led by Maniman. Here is the tale of Agastya, who ate the asura Vatapi, and who went to Lopamudra so that he might have a son. Then comes the tale of the hawk and the dove, in which Indra, Agni and Dharma test King Shibi. Here are the life of Rishyashringa, a celibate from boyhood, and the life of Rama, the mighty son of Jamadagni, with the killing of Kartavirya and the Haihayas. Here is Sukanya's story, in which Chyavana of the Bhrigus gives the two Ashvins a share of soma at King Sharyati's sacrifice, and they give the sage his youth again. Here is the story of Jantu, in which King Somaka sacrifices his son to have sons, and gets a hundred of them. Here is the

story of Ashtavakra, who beats Bandin in debate and gets back his father from the sea.

Arjuna, the left-handed archer, having won the divine weapons, fights for his teacher's sake with the Nivatakavachas who live in the city of gold. He meets his brothers again on Gandhamadana. Then comes the cattle expedition, where Arjuna fights the gandharvas; the return to the lake of Dvaitavana; and Jayadratha's carrying off of Draupadi from the hermitage, when Bhima, swift as the wind, runs after him. In the session with Markandeya, many tales are told, one after another. Krishna visits them, and Draupadi talks with Satyabhama. Here are the story of the measure of rice, the story of Indradyumna, the stories of Savitri, of Auddalaki and of Vainya, and the long story of Rama. Here Indra robs Karna of his earrings. And here is the story of the fire-sticks, in which Dharma teaches his son, and after which the Pandavas, rewarded with boons, go away to the west. That is the third book. The supreme seer counted two hundred and sixty-nine chapters in it, and eleven thousand, six hundred and sixty-four verses.

The fourth book is Virata, and it is broad and full. Its parts are: Virata; the Killing of the Kichakas; the Cattle Raid; and the Wedding of Abhimanyu and Virata's daughter.

The Pandavas go to Virata's city. In the cremation ground they see a great shami tree and hide their weapons in it. They go into the city and live there in disguise. Bhima kills the wicked Kichaka. In the cattle raid, Arjuna defeats the Kurus in battle, and the Pandavas win back Virata's herds. Virata gives Uttara to Arjuna as a daughter-in-law, a wife for Abhimanyu, Subhadra's son, the slayer of enemies. The great seer counted sixty-seven full chapters in this book, and two thousand and fifty verses.

The fifth book is the Effort. Its parts are: the Effort, which is very wonderful; Sanjaya's Journey; the Sleepless Night of Dhritarashtra's worry; the Teaching of Sanatsujata, which shows the secret of the self; the Terms of the Treaty; the Lord's Journey; the Quarrel of Karna; the March Out of the Kuru and Pandava Armies; the Counting of Chariot-fighters and Great Chariot-fighters; the Coming of Uluka the Envoy, which feeds the anger; and the Story of Amba.

When the Pandavas are camped at Upaplavya, eager to win, Duryodhana and Arjuna both come to Krishna. "You must help us in this war," they say. And Krishna, whose wisdom is great, answers, "I will be one man who does not fight, a counsellor. Or else I will give a full army. Which shall I give to which of you, best of men?" The foolish, wicked Duryodhana chooses the army. Arjuna chooses Krishna, who will not fight, as his counsellor. The mighty king Dhritarashtra sends Sanjaya to the Pandavas as his envoy, to make peace. When he hears that the Pandavas are led by Krishna, Dhritarashtra lies awake all night with worry. Vidura tells the wise king many good and varied things. And Sanatsujata teaches the king the highest knowledge of the self, while he is sick at heart and sunk in sorrow. In the morning, in the assembly of kings, Sanjaya tells the king that Krishna and Arjuna are one. Krishna, full of pity and wanting peace, goes himself to Hastinapura to make it. King Duryodhana refuses him, though Krishna begs for a peace that is good for both sides. Krishna learns of the wicked plot of Karna, Duryodhana and the others, and shows the kings that he is the lord of yoga. Krishna takes Karna up into his chariot and gives him counsel, and Karna, out of pride, refuses him. Then the army marches out of Hastinapura, chariots and horses, men and elephants, and its strength is counted. The king sends Uluka, a cruel-tongued envoy, to the Pandavas on the eve of the great battle. The chariot-fighters and the great chariot-fighters are counted, and the story of Amba is told. That is the fifth book, full of events, about peace and war. The great-minded Vyasa counted one hundred and

eighty-six chapters in it, and six thousand, six hundred and ninety-eight verses.

The sixth book is Bhishma, full of wonders. Its parts are: the Consecration of Bhishma, whose cause is wonderful; the Making of the Land of Jambu; the Earth, which tells of the continents at length; the Song of the Lord; and the Killing of Bhishma.

Sanjaya describes the making of the land of Jambu. A terrible war is fought for ten days, cruel beyond words, and Yudhishtira's army falls into the deepest despair. Wise Krishna drives out Arjuna's despair, which comes of confusion, with reasons that show the way to release. And the great archer Arjuna puts Shikhandi in front, strikes Bhishma again and again with sharp arrows, and brings him down from his chariot. That is the sixth great book of the Bharata. Vyasa, who knew the Veda, counted a hundred and seventeen chapters in it, and five thousand, eight hundred and eighty-four verses.

The seventh book is Drona, full of wonders and events. Its parts are: the Consecration of Drona; the Killing of the Samshaptakas; the Killing of Abhimanyu; the Vow; the Killing of Jayadratha; the Killing of Ghatotkacha; the Killing of Drona, which makes the hair stand up; and the Release of the Narayana Weapon.

The Samshaptakas draw Arjuna away from the battlefield. King Bhagadatta, Indra's equal in battle, is killed by Arjuna of the diadem, together with his elephant Supratika. Many great chariot-fighters, famous in the world, with Jayadratha at their head, kill Abhimanyu, a brave boy not yet grown to manhood. When Abhimanyu is dead, Arjuna in his anger kills seven full armies in the battle, and King Jayadratha, and destroys what is left of the Samshaptakas. Alambusa and Shrutayus, mighty Jalasandha, Somadatta's son, Virata, the great chariot-fighter Drupada, Ghatotkacha and others are killed in the book of Drona. And here Ashvatthama, when Drona has fallen in the fighting, in his fury calls up the terrible Narayana weapon. That is the seventh great book of the Bharata. In it most of the kings of the earth, the heroes named in it, meet their deaths. The seer, the son of Parashara, after careful thought, counted one hundred and seventy chapters in it, and eight thousand, nine hundred and nine verses.

The eighth book is Karna, most wonderful. The wise king of Madra is made Karna's charioteer, and the ancient tale of the fall of the Triple City is told. As they drive out to battle, Karna and Shalya trade harsh words, and here is the story of the swan and the crow, told as an insult. Yudhishtira and Arjuna turn on each other in anger. And Arjuna kills the great chariot-fighter Karna in single combat. Those who study the Bharata call it the eighth book. It has sixty-nine chapters, and four thousand, nine hundred verses.

The ninth book is Shalya, with its many meanings. Its parts are: Shalya; the Entering of the Lake; the Mace Fight; and the Sarasvati, which tells of the holy bathing places one after another. When the Kuru army's great heroes have been killed, the king of Madra becomes its leader. The chariot fights are told one by one, and the destruction of the chief Kurus. King Yudhishtira, the great chariot-fighter, kills Shalya. The terrible fight with maces is told, and the holiness of the bathing places of the river Sarasvati. That is the ninth book, wonderful and full of meaning. Those who know how to count have counted fifty-nine chapters in it, full of events, and three thousand, two hundred and twenty verses, which the sage made about the Kauravas and their fame.

The tenth book is the terrible book of the Night Raid. Its parts are the Night Raid, which is dreadful, and the Reed Weapon, which is more dreadful still. When the Pandavas

have gone away, three chariot-fighters, Kritavarma, Kripa and Drona's son, come in the evening, spattered with blood, to King Duryodhana, who lies raging with his thighs broken. Drona's son, the great chariot-fighter, holding fast to his anger, makes a vow: "I will not take off my armour until I have killed all the Panchalas, with Dhristadyumna at their head, and the Pandavas with their counsellors." And those bulls among men, led by Drona's son, kill the Panchalas and all their followers at night, as they sleep, trusting. The five Pandavas escape, because they shelter under Krishna's strength, and so does the great archer Satyaki; all the rest are killed. Draupadi, grieving for her sons and stricken by the killing of her father and brothers, makes up her mind to fast to death, and sits down in front of her husbands. At her word, Bhima of the fearful courage runs in his fury after the son of their teacher. Afraid of Bhima, and driven by fate, Drona's son looses his weapon in rage: "Let there be no Pandavas!" "Not so!" says Krishna, to quiet that word, and Arjuna quiets that weapon with a weapon of his own. Drona's son, Dvaipayana and the others lay curses on one another. Water is offered for all the dead kings, and the story is told of Karna, the son whom Pritha bore in secret. That is the tenth book, the Night Raid. The great-souled seer set out eighteen chapters in it, and eight hundred and seventy verses, in the book that joins the Night Raid and the Reed Weapon.

The eleventh book is the Women, and it moves to pity. Its parts are the Offering of Water, the Women, and the Rites for the Dead of the Kurus. Here the wives of the heroes weep, and it is the most pitiful lament of all. Here Gandhari and Dhritarashtra are seized by anger, and grow calm again. They see the brave kshatriyas who never turned back and who met their fated end: sons, brothers and fathers, killed in battle. And the wise king, best of all who keep dharma, has the bodies of the kings burned according to the scriptures. That is the eleventh book, very great and very pitiful. It has twenty-seven chapters and seven hundred and seventy-five verses. The great-souled maker of the Bharata made it to melt the hearts of good people and bring tears to their eyes.

The twelfth book is Peace, and it makes the mind grow. Its parts are: the Consecration of the wise king of dharma; the Crushing of Charvaka, a rakshasa disguised as a brahmin; the Sharing of the Houses; and then Peace, which tells of the duties of kings, the duties in times of distress, and the duties that lead to release.

Here King Yudhishtira, the king of dharma, is sick of the world, because he has caused the deaths of fathers, brothers, sons, kinsmen and friends. Here the duties spoken from the bed of arrows are explained, which kings who want to know good government should learn. Here are the duties for times of distress, which show the times and the reasons, and by learning them a man may come to know everything. And the many and wonderful duties that lead to release are told at length. That is the twelfth book, dear to the wise. There are three hundred and thirty-nine chapters in it, and fourteen thousand, five hundred and twenty-five verses.

The thirteenth book is the best of all, the book of Instruction. Its parts are the Instructions and the Going to Heaven of the wise Bhishma. Here Yudhishtira, king of the Kurus, hears from Bhishma, son of the river Ganga, the final word on dharma, and comes back to himself. The whole practice of dharma and of wealth is shown. The fruits of every kind of gift are set out: who is worthy to receive, and the highest rule of giving; the rules of good conduct; and the highest end of truth. Here too Bhishma's going to heaven is told. It has a hundred and forty-six chapters and six thousand, seven hundred verses, and it settles what dharma is.

The fourteenth book is the Horse Sacrifice, which destroys all sins. Its parts are the Horse Sacrifice and the Song After, which speaks of the self. Here is the fine story of Samvarta and Marutta. The treasure of gold is found. Parikshit is born, burned by the fire of the weapon, and brought back to life by Krishna. The horse is let loose for the sacrifice, and the Pandava follows it, fighting resentful princes wherever it goes. Arjuna comes close to death in battle with Babhruvahana, the son of Chitrangada, whose father had made her his heir. And here is the story of the mongoose at the great horse sacrifice. That is the fourteenth book, very wonderful. It has a hundred and thirty-three chapters, and three thousand, three hundred and twenty verses.

The fifteenth book is the Hermitage. Its parts are: Living in the Hermitage; Seeing the Sons; and the Coming of Narada. Here the king, Dhritarashtra, gives up the kingdom and goes with Gandhari and Vidura to the hermitage. When she sees him set out, the good Pritha follows him, giving up her sons' kingdom, for she delights in serving her elders. Here the king sees his dead sons and grandsons and the other kings, the heroes who had gone to the other world, come back again, by the grace of the seer Krishna Dvaipayana. He sees that highest wonder and lets go of his grief, and with his wife he reaches the highest perfection. Here Vidura, holding to dharma, goes the good way, and so does Sanjaya, the wise and self-controlled son of Gaurama. And here Yudhishtira, the king of dharma, sees Narada, and hears from him of the great slaughter of the Vrishnis. It has forty-two chapters, and one thousand, five hundred and six verses.

The sixteenth book is the terrible book of the Iron Club. Here the Vrishnis, tigers among men who could bear the touch of weapons in battle, are crushed by the curse of the brahmins near the salt sea. At a drinking party, drunk and driven by fate, they kill one another with blades of eraka grass that turn into thunderbolts. Having brought about the end of everything, Balarama and Krishna do not pass beyond Time when it comes, for Time takes all things equally. Arjuna comes to Dvaravati, empty of the Vrishnis, and falls into despair and the deepest pain. He honours his mother's brother, Vasudeva, the best of the Yadus, and sees the great slaughter of the Yadu heroes at their drinking place. He has the bodies of Krishna and of great Balarama cremated, and of the chief Vrishnis. He takes the old men and the children away from Dvaravati, and in that bitter disaster he sees the Gandiva bow defeated, all the divine weapons deaf to his call, the Vrishni women lost, and how nothing that is powerful lasts. Seeing this, he is sick of the world, and, urged by Vyasa's words, he goes to the king of dharma and chooses to renounce it all. It has eight chapters and three hundred verses.

The seventeenth book is the Great Journey. Here the Pandavas, bulls among men, give up the kingdom and, with the lady Draupadi, reach the highest perfection. It has three chapters and a hundred and twenty verses.

The eighteenth book is Heaven, divine and more than human. It has five chapters and two hundred verses.

Those are the eighteen books, told in full. After them come the supplements: the Harivamsha, the Lineage of Hari, which is called an old story, and the Future, a great and wonderful book among the supplements. So the hundred parts are complete, as the great Vyasa spoke them, and as the son of the suta, Lomaharshana's son, told them again, rightly, in the Naimisha forest.

"That is the whole Bharata," said Ugrashravas, "told in brief, by its parts. Eighteen full armies came together, eager to fight, and that great and terrible war lasted

eighteen days.

"A twice-born man who knows the four Vedas, with their limbs and their Upanishads, but does not know this story, cannot be called learned.

"Once you have heard this tale, nothing else is worth hearing. It is like hearing the cuckoo's song, after which the crow's voice is harsh. The minds of poets are born from this best of histories, as the three worlds are made from the five elements. The old stories live inside this one, brahmins, as the four kinds of creatures live inside the sky. Every deed and every virtue rests on it, as all the senses rest on the mind's many workings. There is no tale on earth that does not lean on this one, as the body cannot live without food. All the best poets live on it, as servants who want to rise depend on a noble master.

"It came from the lips of Dvaipayana. It has no measure. It is holy and purifying, it takes away sin, and it brings good. Whoever takes in the Bharata as it is recited, what need has he to bathe in the waters of the holy lake Pushkara?

"This is the greatest of all stories, and its meaning is great. It has been laid out here, in its parts. Once men have heard it first like this, it is easy to enter, the way a boat makes the wide salt sea easy to cross."

Chapter 4

The Teacher's Pupils

The bard began the first story.

King Janamejaya, the son of Parikshit, was holding a long sacrifice at Kurukshetra with his brothers. He had three brothers: Shrutasena, Ugrasena and Bhimasena.

While they sat at the sacrifice, a dog came there, a puppy, the son of Sarama, the dog of the gods. Janamejaya's brothers beat him, and he ran howling back to his mother.

His mother saw him howling. "Why are you crying?" she asked. "Who beat you?"

"Janamejaya's brothers beat me," he said.

"You must have done something wrong there," said his mother, "or they would not have beaten you."

"I did nothing wrong," he said. "I did not look at the offerings. I did not lick them."

When his mother Sarama heard this, she was stricken with grief for her son. She went to the sacrifice where Janamejaya and his brothers were sitting, and she spoke to him in anger.

"My son did nothing wrong. Why was he beaten? He did you no harm, and you beat him. So a danger will come upon you, a danger you cannot see."

When Sarama, the dog of the gods, spoke to him like that, Janamejaya was badly shaken, and his heart sank.

When the sacrifice was over, he went back to Hastinapura. There he tried very hard to find a family priest who would be right for him. *He must be a priest who can quiet this evil that hangs over me*, he thought.

One day Janamejaya, son of Parikshit, went out hunting, and in a part of his own country he saw a hermitage. A seer named Shrutashravas lived there, and with him lived his son Somashravas, whom he loved. Janamejaya went to the son and asked for him as his family priest. He bowed to the seer.

"Holy one," he said, "let this son of yours be my priest."

The seer answered him. "Janamejaya, this son of mine was born of a snake-woman. She drank my seed, and he grew in her womb, and so he was made out of my power as an ascetic. He is a great ascetic himself, and learned in the Veda. He can quiet every evil that threatens you, except any that comes from Mahadeva, the great god. But he has one secret vow. If a brahmin asks him for anything, he will give it to him. If you can accept that, take him."

"Holy one," said Janamejaya, "it shall be so."

He took the priest with him and went back to his brothers. "I have chosen this man as our teacher," he told them. "Whatever he tells you to do, do it, and do not question

it."

His brothers did as he said. Having given them these orders, Janamejaya set out for Takshashila, and he brought that country under his rule.

At this time there was a seer named Dhaumya, of the Ayoda family, and he had three pupils: Upamanyu, Aruni and Veda.

He sent one of them, Aruni of Panchala, on an errand. "Go," he said. "There is a breach in the bank of a field. Close it."

Aruni of Panchala went there as his teacher had told him, but he could not close the breach. He struggled, and then he saw a way. So be it, he thought. *I will do this*. He lay down in the breach, and while he lay there, the water stopped.

Some time later the teacher, Dhaumya of the Ayodas, asked his pupils, "Where has Aruni of Panchala gone?"

"You sent him yourself, holy one," they answered. "You said, 'Go and close the breach in the bank of the field.'"

"Then let us all go where he is," said Dhaumya.

When he got there, he called out to him. "Aruni! Aruni of Panchala! Where are you? Come here, child!"

Aruni heard his teacher's voice. He jumped up out of the breach at once and came and stood before his teacher.

"Here I am," he said. "I was lying in the breach, to hold back the water that was flowing out and could not be stopped. I heard your voice, holy one, and I broke through the bank at once and came to you. I greet you, holy one. Tell me what to do."

"You broke open the bank and rose up out of it," said the teacher. "So your name will be Uddalaka, the one who breaks open."

Then the teacher blessed him. "Because you did what I told you, you will win what is good. All the Vedas will shine out in you, and all the teachings on dharma."

When his teacher had said this, Aruni went where he wished.

Dhaumya of the Ayodas had another pupil, named Upamanyu.

The teacher sent him out. "Upamanyu, my child," he said, "look after the cows."

So, as his teacher had told him, Upamanyu looked after the cows. He guarded them all day, and at the end of the day he came home and stood in front of his teacher and bowed.

The teacher saw that he was plump. "Upamanyu, my child," he said, "how do you keep yourself? You are very plump."

"I live on alms, teacher," said Upamanyu. "I beg for my food."

"You must not eat what you beg without giving it to me first," said the teacher.

"Yes," said Upamanyu, and he went on guarding the cows. When he had guarded them, he came home in the same way, and stood in front of his teacher and bowed.

Even so, the teacher saw that he was still plump. "Upamanyu, my child," he said, "I take every scrap of your alms. How do you keep yourself now?"

"First I give you what I beg, holy one," said Upamanyu. "Then I go begging a second time, and I live on that."

"That is not the right way to serve a teacher," said the teacher. "Living like that, you take food away from others who live on alms. You are greedy."

"Yes," said Upamanyu, and he guarded the cows. When he had guarded them, he came back to his teacher's house again, and stood in front of him and bowed.

The teacher saw that he was still plump. "I take all your alms," he said, "and you do not go begging a second time. Yet you are plump. How do you keep yourself?"

"Sir," said Upamanyu, "I live on the milk of these cows."

"It is not right for you to drink their milk," said the teacher. "I have not allowed it."

Upamanyu promised he would not, and guarded the cows, and came back to his teacher's house, and stood in front of his teacher and bowed.

The teacher saw that he was still plump. "You do not eat what you beg," he said. "You do not go begging again. You do not drink the milk. Yet you are plump. How do you keep yourself?"

"Sir," said Upamanyu, "I drink the froth that the calves bring up when they suck from their mothers."

"These good calves pity you," said the teacher, "and so they bring up more froth than they should. Living like that, you are taking food from the calves. You must not drink the froth either."

Upamanyu promised, and he guarded the cows with nothing to eat. He was forbidden everything. He did not eat what he begged, he did not go begging again, he did not drink the milk, and he did not take the froth.

One day, in the forest, tormented by hunger, he ate the leaves of the arka plant. Those leaves are salty and sharp and hot, and they are harsh when they are digested. They struck his eyes, and he went blind. Even blind, he kept wandering about, and he fell into a well.

When he did not come back, the teacher spoke to his pupils. "I have forbidden Upamanyu everything. He is surely angry. That is why he has been gone so long and has not come back."

So he went to the forest and called for him. "Upamanyu! Where are you? Come here, child!"

Upamanyu heard his teacher calling and answered loudly. "Here I am, teacher! I have fallen into a well."

"How did you fall into a well?" asked the teacher.

"I ate arka leaves and went blind," said Upamanyu. "That is how I fell into the well."

"Praise the Ashvins," said the teacher. "They are the physicians of the gods. They will give you back your sight."

So, as his teacher told him, Upamanyu began to praise the twin gods, the Ashvins, with words from the verses of the Rig Veda:

You go first, you were born first; your light is many-coloured. I praise you with my voice, you who blaze and have no end: two birds of heaven, spotless, beyond all measure, dwelling above all the worlds. Golden birds, guides to the world beyond, Nasatya and Dasra, fair of face and always winning, you weave swiftly on your fine loom, weaving the white and the dark. When the quail was caught in the eagle's grip, you set her free, Ashvins, for her good fortune. Three hundred and sixty cows give birth to one calf, and they milk it; they stand in many stalls, yet they give a single milking. You milk the hot offering from them. Seven hundred spokes rest in one hub, and twenty more are set in the rims; a wheel with no rim turns and never grows old. One wheel turns, with twelve spokes, six hubs and one axle, and it holds the nectar of immortality, and all the gods cling to it. Ashvins, set it free, and do not fail. You split the mountain and drove the cows out. At the beginning you made the ten directions, and the seers follow where you go; gods and men walk the earth. You make every colour of every form, and they dwell in all the worlds. Nasatyas, Ashvins, we come to you, and to your garland of lotuses. Immortal ones, who make the truth grow: set the cows free, so that we may live.

When he had praised them like this, the Ashvins came. "We are pleased," they said. "Here is a cake for you. Eat it."

"You have never said anything untrue," said Upamanyu. "But I cannot eat this cake without first offering it to my teacher."

"Your teacher once praised us in just this way," said the Ashvins, "and we were pleased and gave him a cake. He ate it without offering it to his own teacher. You do as your teacher did."

"I beg your pardon, Ashvins," said Upamanyu. "I cannot eat it without offering it to my teacher."

"We are pleased with you," said the Ashvins, "for the way you serve your teacher. Your teacher's teeth are made of black iron. Yours will be made of gold. You will see again, and you will win what is good."

When the Ashvins had said this, Upamanyu had his sight back. He went to his teacher, greeted him, and told him everything. His teacher was pleased with him.

"You will win what is good," he said, "as the Ashvins told you. And all the Vedas will shine out in you."

That was Upamanyu's test.

Dhaumya of the Ayodas had a third pupil, named Veda.

The teacher gave him his orders. "Veda, my child, stay here. You must live in my house for a while and serve me. It will be good for you."

"Yes," said Veda, and he lived for a long time in his teacher's house, giving himself to his teacher's service. Like an ox, he was always yoked to his teacher's loads. He bore cold and heat, hunger and thirst and pain, and he never went against his teacher in anything.

After a long time, his teacher was satisfied with him. Because his teacher was satisfied, Veda won what is good, and came to know everything.

That was Veda's test.

Then, with his teacher's leave, Veda finished his studies and left his teacher's house, and became a householder. While he lived in his own home, he had three pupils of his own. He never told them, "Do this work," or "Serve your teacher." He knew how hard it is to live in a teacher's house, and he did not want to lay those hardships on his pupils.

Chapter 5

The Queen's Earrings

Some time later, two kshatriyas came to the brahmin Veda, King Janamejaya and King Paushya, and chose him as their teacher and priest.

Once, when Veda was setting out on some business for one of his patrons, he put a pupil of his named Uttanka in charge. "Uttanka," he said, "whatever runs short in our house while I am away, I want you to see that it does not run short."

With these orders to Uttanka, Veda went away on his journey. Uttanka stayed in his teacher's house, serving his teacher and doing as he had been told.

While he was living there, the women of his teacher's household called him to them. "Your teacher's wife is in her season," they said, "and your teacher is away. Do what must be done so that her season is not wasted. It is making her miserable."

"I will not do a wrong thing because women tell me to," Uttanka answered. "My teacher never told me, 'Do what should not be done.'"

After a time his teacher came home from his journey. He heard everything that had happened, and he was pleased.

"Uttanka, my child," he said, "what can I do for you in return? You have served me as dharma asks, and so the love between us has grown. I give you leave to go. You will win every success. Go."

"What can I do to please you?" Uttanka answered. "For they say this: 'When one man teaches and another learns against dharma, one of the two will die, or become the other's enemy.' You have given me leave, and I want to bring you a gift for my teaching, whatever you wish."

"Uttanka, my child," said the teacher, "stay a while."

Some time later Uttanka spoke to his teacher again. "Tell me, sir," he said. "What would you like me to bring you, as the fee for my teaching?"

"Uttanka, my child," said the teacher, "you keep pressing me about bringing me a fee. Go in, then, and ask your teacher's wife what you should bring. Bring whatever she tells you."

So Uttanka asked his teacher's wife. "Lady, my teacher has given me leave to go home. I want to bring you a fee for my teaching, whatever you would like, and leave free of debt. Tell me, lady, what shall I bring?"

"Go to King Paushya," she told him. "Ask him for the earrings his queen wears, and bring them here. Four days from now there will be a holy day, and I want to wear them when I serve the brahmins their food. See to it that I shine in those earrings on that day. Do this, and good will come to you."

With these words from his teacher's wife, Uttanka set out. As he went along the road, he saw a bull of enormous size, and riding on it a man, also enormous.

The man spoke to him. "Uttanka, eat this bull's dung."

Uttanka did not want to.

The man spoke again. "Eat it, Uttanka. Don't stop to think about it. Your teacher ate it too, before you."

"Very well," said Uttanka. He ate the bull's dung and drank its urine, and went on to where the kshatriya Paushya was.

He came to him and found him seated. He greeted him with blessings and said, "I have come to you to ask for something."

The king bowed to him. "Holy one, I am Paushya. What can I do for you?"

"I have come to ask for a pair of earrings, as a fee for my teacher," said Uttanka.

"Please give me the earrings your queen wears."

"Go into the women's quarters," said Paushya, "and ask the queen."

Uttanka went into the women's quarters, but he could not see the queen. He came back to Paushya.

"It is not right for you to treat us with a lie," he said. "Your queen is not in the women's quarters. I cannot see her."

"You are unclean just now," said Paushya. "Think back. A woman who is true to her husband cannot be seen by someone who is unclean or impure. Because of her faithfulness, she does not come into the sight of the unclean."

Uttanka thought back. "It is true," he said. "I rinsed my mouth after eating, but I did it quickly, while I was walking."

"That is it," said Paushya. "Rinsing while walking does not make you clean, and neither does rinsing while standing."

"Very well," said Uttanka. He sat down facing east. He washed his hands and feet and face thoroughly. He sipped water three times without a sound, water that reached his heart, and wiped his lips twice, and touched water to the openings of his head. Then he went into the women's quarters, and he saw the queen.

As soon as she saw Uttanka, she rose and greeted him. "Welcome, holy one," she said. "Tell me what I can do for you."

"Please give me these earrings," he said. "I have come to ask for them as a fee for my teacher."

She was pleased by his goodness. He is a worthy one, she thought, *and he must not be refused.* She took off the earrings and gave them to him.

"Takshaka, the king of the snakes, wants these earrings," she told him. "You must carry

them with great care."

"Put your mind at rest, lady," Uttanka answered. "Takshaka, the king of the snakes, cannot get the better of me."

Uttanka took leave of the queen and went back to Paushya. "Paushya," he said, "I am pleased with you."

"Holy one," said Paushya, "a worthy guest comes to us only once in a long while, and you are a guest of true merit. I will hold a feast for you. Stay a moment."

"I am ready now," said Uttanka. "But I am in a hurry. Have food served to me quickly, whatever is ready."

"Yes," said Paushya, and he fed him with whatever food was ready.

Uttanka saw that the food was cold and had a hair in it. He decided it was unclean, and he said to Paushya, "You have given me unclean food. So you will go blind."

"And you have called clean food unclean," answered Paushya. "So you will have no children."

Then Paushya looked into it, and found out that the food was indeed unclean: it had been brought by a woman whose hair was loose, and so it had a hair in it. He tried to calm Uttanka.

"Holy one," he said, "I did not know. The food was brought to you cold and with a hair in it. I ask your forgiveness. Let me not go blind."

"I do not speak lies," said Uttanka. "You will go blind, and then before long you will see again. Now let your curse on me be taken back too."

"I cannot take back my curse," said Paushya. "Even now my anger has not cooled. Don't you know the saying?"

A brahmin's heart is butter, but a sharp-edged razor is in his words. In a kshatriya both are the other way round: his words are butter, his heart a sharp-edged razor.

"That is how it is. My heart is sharp, and I cannot change the curse. Go."

"You yourself found out that the food was unclean," said Uttanka, "and then you tried to calm me. And before that, what you said was, 'You have called clean food unclean, so you will have no children.' But the food was unclean. So your curse will not touch me."

"We must be going," said Uttanka. And he set out with the earrings.

On the way, Uttanka saw a naked beggar coming towards him, a wandering monk. Again and again he could be seen, and then he could not be seen. Uttanka put the earrings down on the ground and went to fetch water.

While he was gone, the beggar ran up quickly, snatched the earrings and fled. Uttanka ran after him and caught him. But the beggar dropped that shape and became Takshaka, and

at once he slipped into a great hole that had opened in the earth. He went down into the world of the nagas, the snake-people, to his own home.

Uttanka followed him down through the same hole. When he had come into the world of the nagas, he praised the nagas with these verses:

Snakes whose king is Airavata, shining in their gatherings, pouring down like rain-clouds driven by lightning and wind; handsome ones and strange ones, with spotted earrings, born of Airavata, you shine like suns on the vault of heaven. Many are the paths of the nagas on the north bank of the Ganga. Who but Airavata would choose to move among the armies of the sun's rays? When Dhritarashtra the naga moves, twenty-eight thousand, eight hundred snakes go with him as his reins. I bow to those who come near him, and to those who have gone far away: I bow to the elder brothers of Airavata. I have praised Takshaka, son of Kadru, for the sake of the earrings, who has always lived in Kurukshetra and in the Khandava forest. Takshaka and Ashvasena, two who are always together, live in Kurukshetra, along the river Ikshumati. And his younger brother, known as Shrutasena, who lived at Mahadyumna, longing to be chief of the nagas: to that great one, too, I bow always.

He praised the nagas like this, but still he did not get the earrings back. Then he saw two women weaving cloth on a loom. The threads on the loom were black and white. He saw a wheel, turned by six boys. And he saw a man, beautiful to look at.

He praised them all with these verses of power:

Three hundred and sixty spokes are set in the middle of this fixed wheel, the wheel of twenty-four joints, which six boys turn. Two young women weave this loom of every form, turning the threads without rest, the black threads and the white, turning out creatures and worlds, without end. Bearer of the thunderbolt, guardian of the world, slayer of Vritra and slayer of Namuchi, great one who wears two black garments, who parts truth from falsehood in the world; who took for his mount the horse, the ancient child of the waters, the fire Vaishvanara: I bow always to him, lord of the world, lord of the three worlds, Purandara, breaker of cities.

Then the man spoke to him. "I am pleased with you for this hymn of praise. What can I do for you?"

"Let the nagas come under my power," said Uttanka.

"Blow into this horse's hindquarters," said the man.

Uttanka blew into the horse's hindquarters. As he blew, flames and smoke burst out of every opening of the horse's body, and the world of the nagas filled with smoke.

Takshaka was thrown into confusion. Terrified of the heat of the fire, he took the earrings and rushed out of his home. "Here are the earrings, sir," he said to Uttanka. "Take them."

Uttanka took them. Holding the earrings, he thought: *Today is my teacher's wife's holy day, and I have come so far. How can I possibly get back in time?*

While he was still thinking this, the man spoke to him. "Uttanka, get up on this horse.

It will take you to your teacher's house in a moment."

"Yes," said Uttanka. He got up on the horse and rode back to his teacher's house.

His teacher's wife had bathed and was sitting and having her hair done. *Uttanka is not coming*, she thought, and she had made up her mind to curse him. Then Uttanka came in and greeted her, and gave her the earrings.

"Uttanka," she said, "you have come to the right place at the right time. Welcome, my child. I very nearly cursed you, but I did not. Good fortune is waiting for you. May you succeed."

Then Uttanka greeted his teacher.

"Welcome, Uttanka, my child," said his teacher. "What kept you so long?"

"Sir," said Uttanka, "Takshaka, the king of the nagas, got in my way, and he took me to the world of the nagas. There I saw two women weaving on a loom, and the threads were black and white. What was that? I saw a wheel with twelve spokes, and six boys were turning it. What was that too? And I saw a man. Who was he? And a horse of great size. Who was that?"

"And on the road, as I went, I saw a bull with a man riding on it. He spoke to me kindly. 'Uttanka,' he said, 'eat this bull's dung. Your teacher ate it too.' So, because he told me to, I ate the bull's dung. I would like you to tell me what that was."

"The two women are Dhatri and Vidhatri, the Maker and the Arranger," said his teacher. "The black and white threads are the nights and the days. The wheel with twelve spokes, turned by six boys, is the year, and the boys are the six seasons. The man is Parjanya, the god of rain. The horse is Agni, the fire."

"The bull you saw on the road was Airavata, king of the nagas, and the man riding it was Indra. The dung you ate was the nectar of immortality. That is why you came to no harm in the home of the nagas. Indra is my friend. By his kindness you got the earrings and came back. Now go, my dear. I give you leave. You will win what is good."

With his teacher's leave, Uttanka set out for Hastinapura. He was angry, and he wanted to pay Takshaka back.

When he reached Hastinapura, that best of brahmins went before King Janamejaya. The king had come back a little while before from Takshashila, undefeated and victorious, and his ministers stood all round him. Uttanka first blessed him and wished him victory, in the proper way. Then, at the right moment, he spoke to him, and his voice was clear and strong.

"Best of kings, there is one thing you ought to be doing. Yet you are busy with something else, like a child."

The king received his words kindly and honoured the sage with due respect. "I keep my own dharma as a kshatriya by protecting these people of mine," he answered. "But tell me, best of brahmins, what should I do? I am ready to listen."

Then that best of brahmins, the most virtuous of men, told the king, whose spirit was never low, what the king had to do and what he himself wanted.

"Lord of kings, it was Takshaka who killed your father. Pay back that evil snake. I think the time has come for the deed that the scriptures lay down. Go, king, and take vengeance for your great father. He had done no wrong, and that wicked-hearted snake bit him, and he died, like a tree struck by lightning. Proud and puffed up with his strength, Takshaka, lowest of snakes, did an evil thing when he bit your father. That wicked one killed the king, the protector of the line of royal seers, a king like the gods, and he turned Kashyapa back.

"You must burn that evil one in the blazing fire, great king, at a snake sacrifice. That is the deed ordained for you. So you will pay what you owe to your father, and you will do me a great kindness too, lord of the earth. For that wicked one got in my way, great king, when I was trying to bring my teacher his fee."

When the king heard this, he was furious with Takshaka. Uttanka's words fed his anger like butter poured on a fire. In great sorrow, with Uttanka standing beside him, the king questioned his ministers about how his father had gone to heaven. For the king was flooded with grief and pain at the very moment he heard from Uttanka how his father had died.

Chapter 6

The Fire's Witness

Ugrashravas, the son of Lomaharshana, a suta who knew the old stories, went again to the seers who had gathered at the twelve-year sacrifice of Shaunaka, head of the household, in the Naimisha forest. He had worked hard at the old lore. He stood before them with joined palms.

"What would you like to hear?" he asked. "What shall I tell you?"

"Son of Lomaharshana," the seers said, "we will ask you about the highest things, and you will tell us, for we are eager to hear your tales. But the holy Shaunaka is still in the house of the sacred fire. He knows the stories of heaven, the tales of the gods and the asuras, and all the tales of men, of snakes and of gandharvas. He is the learned head of the household at this sacrifice, Sauti, a brahmin who is skilful, firm in his vows and wise, and a teacher of the forest texts. He speaks the truth, loves peace, lives in austerity and keeps his vows. All of us honour him. Wait for him. When our teacher has taken his seat of honour, then tell whatever that best of brahmins asks you."

"So be it," said the bard. "When the great teacher is seated, and he asks me, I will tell holy stories of many kinds."

That bull among brahmins finished all his tasks in their proper order. He satisfied the gods with prayers and the ancestors with water. Then he came to where the brahmin seers were sitting at the place of sacrifice, perfect in their vows, with the suta's son at their head. When the priests and all the company were seated, Shaunaka, the head of the household, sat down with them and spoke.

"Your father learned the whole of the old lore long ago, my friend. Have you learned all of it too, son of Lomaharshana? The old lore holds divine stories, and the first lines of the families of wise men. We heard them long ago from your father. First of all, I want to hear about the line of Bhrigu. Tell me that story. We are ready to hear you."

"I will tell you what the great ones learned rightly long ago," said the bard, "Vaishampayana and the other brahmins, and what they told. I will tell you what my father learned, and after him I. Listen, then, son of the Bhrigus, to the great line of the Bhrigus, which the gods honour, with Indra, with Agni and with the Maruts. This is your own family, great sage, and I will tell it to you together with its stories, as the old lore gives them.

"Bhrigu's dear son was Chyavana. Chyavana's heir was the righteous Pramati. Pramati had a son by Ghritachi, named Ruru. And Ruru had a son by Pramadvarya, named Shaunaka, who knew the Vedas through and through: a righteous man, your own forefather. He was an ascetic, famous and learned, the best of those who know Brahman. He loved dharma, spoke the truth, and held himself and his senses in check."

"Son of the suta," said Shaunaka, "tell me how that great son of Bhrigu came to be called Chyavana."

"Bhrigu had a dear wife," said the bard, "named Puloma, and she was carrying Bhrigu's child. The child was growing in the womb of that good wife, who was famous and as

virtuous as her husband. One day Bhrigu, best of all who keep dharma, went out for his ritual bath. And a rakshasa named Puloman came to his hermitage.

"The rakshasa came into the hermitage and saw Bhrigu's blameless wife, and he was seized by desire and lost his senses. Lovely Puloma offered the visitor forest food, fruit and roots. The rakshasa looked at her, tormented by desire, and he was glad, for he meant to carry her off.

"Then, in the house of the sacred fire, he saw Agni, the fire god, burning bright, and he questioned him.

"Tell me whose wife this is, Agni,' he said. 'I ask you by the truth. You are truth itself, Pavaka. Tell me the truth. Long ago I chose this lovely woman to be my wife. But afterwards her father gave her to Bhrigu, who played me false. If this fair woman, here alone, is Bhrigu's wife, tell me so truly, for I mean to carry her off from the hermitage. Anger is burning in my heart today, because Bhrigu has the slender woman who was mine first.'

"The rakshasa was not sure she was Bhrigu's wife, and he asked the blazing fire again and again. 'Agni, you move always inside all creatures, like a witness to their good deeds and their bad. Speak true words, wise one. The woman I chose first was stolen by Bhrigu, who played me false. If this is she, you must tell me truly. When I have heard it from you, I will carry off Bhrigu's wife from the hermitage while you watch. Tell me the truth, Agni.'

"When the seven-flamed fire heard him, he was deeply troubled. He was afraid of telling a lie, and he was afraid of Bhrigu's curse. He answered softly, and he told the truth.

"When the rakshasa heard what Agni said, he took the form of a boar and carried her off, swift as the mind and the wind. And the child who lived in her womb, in that fury, slipped out of his mother's belly. Because he slipped out, he became Chyavana, the Fallen One.

"The rakshasa saw the child slip from his mother's womb, shining like the sun, and he let the woman go, and he fell, burned to ashes.

"Puloma of the lovely hips took up her child, Chyavana, son of Bhrigu, and went on her way, faint with grief. Brahma himself, the grandfather of all the worlds, saw Bhrigu's blameless wife weeping, her eyes full of tears, and the holy grandfather comforted her, for she was his son's wife. From her tears a great river began to flow, and it followed the path of the famous wife of Bhrigu. When the grandfather of the worlds saw the river following her path, he gave it a name: Vadhusara, the River of the Bride, and it flows towards Chyavana's hermitage.

"So Chyavana, Bhrigu's mighty son, was born. His father saw him there, and his wife. Bhrigu was angry, and he questioned Puloma.

"Who told that rakshasa who you were, when he wanted to carry you off? The rakshasa did not know you were my wife, you with your lovely smile. Tell me, for in my anger I mean to curse him. Who is there who is not afraid of my curse? Whose wrong is this?'

"Agni told the rakshasa about me, holy one,' said Puloma. 'Then the rakshasa carried me

off, crying out like an osprey. I was set free by the power of this son of yours. The rakshasa let me go and fell, burned to ashes.'

"When Bhrigu heard this from Puloma, he was beside himself with rage, and he cursed Agni. 'You will eat everything!'

"Agni, cursed by Bhrigu, was angry too, and he spoke.

""What rash thing have you done now, brahmin? I strive for dharma. I speak the truth to all alike. I was asked, and I told the truth. Where is my fault? If a witness is asked, and knows, and says otherwise, he destroys seven generations of his family before him and seven after. And whoever knows the truth of a matter and does not speak is stained with the same sin. There is no doubt of it.

""I could curse you too. But brahmins are to be honoured by me. You know this already, yet I will say it plainly. Listen.

""By my power of yoga I make myself many, and I live in many forms: in the daily fire offerings, in the long sacrifices, in the rites and in the ceremonies. When an offering is poured into me by the rule of the Veda, the gods and the ancestors are fed by it. The waters are all the gods, and the waters are all the ancestors, and the offerings at the new moon and the full moon belong to the gods together with the ancestors. So the gods are the ancestors and the ancestors are the gods. They are worshipped as one, and they are worshipped apart, on the days of the moon. What is offered into me is always eaten by the gods and by the ancestors. That is why I am called the mouth of the thirty gods and of the ancestors. At the new moon the ancestors, and at the full moon the gods, receive their offerings through my mouth, and eat what is offered. How can I be their mouth and eat everything?'

"Agni thought it over, and then he drew himself back. He withdrew from the brahmins' daily offerings, from their sacrifices, their long rites and their ceremonies. There was no Om and no Vashat, no Svadha and no Svaha: no more sacred cries. Without the fire, all creatures were in great distress.

"The seers were alarmed. They went to the gods and said, 'The fire is lost and the rites have stopped, and the three worlds are in confusion. You who are without sin, decide what must be done, and let there be no delay.'

"The seers and the gods went together to Brahma, and told him of Agni's curse and how all the rites had stopped. 'Blessed one, Bhrigu has cursed Agni,' they said, 'for some reason of his own. How can Agni, the mouth of the gods, who eats first of the offerings, the eater of offerings in all the worlds, become the eater of everything?'

"When the maker of the worlds heard them, he called Agni, and spoke gently to him, to the fire that brings beings into being and never fails.

""You are the maker of all these worlds and their end,' he said. 'You hold up the three worlds, and you set all the rites going. Act, lord of the world, so that the rites are not cut off. Why are you so bewildered, when you are the lord, the eater of offerings? You are what makes things pure in the world, and you move in all creatures. You will not eat everything with your whole body. Only the flames in your lower part will burn everything, bright one. Whatever the sun's rays touch is held to be pure. In the same

way, whatever your flames burn will be pure.

"Agni, you are a great power, and you came forth from your own strength. By your own power, lord, make the seer's curse come true. And take your share, and the gods' share, that is offered into your mouth.'

"So be it,' said Agni to the grandfather, and he went to do as the supreme god had commanded.

"The divine seers were glad, and went back the way they had come. The seers began all their rites again as before. The gods in heaven rejoiced, and so did all the creatures of the world. And Agni was filled with the highest joy, for the stain was gone from him.

"That is the old story, the history that grew out of Agni's curse: how Puloman was destroyed, and how Chyavana was born."

Chapter 7

Half a Life

"Chyavana, the son of Bhrgu," the bard went on, "had a son by Sukanya: great Pramati, blazing with power. Pramati had a son by Ghritachi, named Ruru. And Ruru had a son by Pramadvarya, named Shunaka. Now I will tell you the whole life of Ruru, who had such great power, brahmin, in full. Listen to all of it.

"Long ago there was a great seer named Sthulakesha, rich in austerity and learning, who delighted in the good of all creatures. At that time the king of the gandharvas, whose name was Vishvavasu, fathered a child on Menaka, the apsaras. When her time came, Menaka gave birth near Sthulakesha's hermitage, and she left the baby, a girl, on the bank of a river and went away. The girl shone like a child of the immortals, blazing with beauty.

"The great seer Sthulakesha, full of power, saw her abandoned on the river bank, in a lonely place, with no one to care for her. When that best of brahmins saw the girl, he was filled with pity, and he took her in and raised her. The lovely girl grew up in his hermitage. She was the finest of all young women, and she had every beauty and every virtue, so the great seer named her Pramadvarya, Finest of Women.

"Ruru saw Pramadvarya in Sthulakesha's hermitage, and that righteous young man fell in love with her. He sent word to his father through his friends, and his father Pramati heard it and went to the famous Sthulakesha. So her father gave the girl Pramadvarya to Ruru, and fixed the wedding for the day of the star of Bhaga.

"A few days before the wedding, the lovely girl was playing with her friends. She did not see a snake lying asleep across her path. She stepped on it. She was going to die. Time had driven her to it. Driven by the law of Time, the snake sank its poisoned fangs deep into the careless girl's body.

"She was bitten. She fell to the ground at once, senseless, lifeless. She had been the loveliest of sights, and now no one could bear to look at her. And yet, lying on the ground, struck down by the snake's poison, she seemed only asleep, and the slender girl was more lovely than ever.

"Her father saw her fallen on the ground, lying still, as bright as a lotus, and so did the other ascetics. All the best of the brahmins came there, full of pity: Svastyatreya, Mahajanu, Kushika, Shankhamekhala, Bharadvaja, Kaunakutsa, Arshtishena, Gautama, Pramati with his son, and others who lived in the forest. When they saw the girl lying dead, killed by the snake's poison, they wept with pity. But Ruru, in his pain, went out alone.

"While the brahmins sat all round her, Ruru went deep into the forest, and there he cried out in his great sorrow. Struck down by grief, he wept and lamented, and thought of his beloved Pramadvarya.

"She lies on the ground, my slender one, and my grief grows and grows, and so does the grief of all our kin. What sorrow could be greater than this? If I have given gifts, if I have practised austerity, if I have truly honoured my elders, then by that merit let my love live again. From my birth I have held myself in check and kept my vows. By that, let lovely Pramadvarya rise up today.'

"Then a messenger of the gods spoke to him.

"Ruru, what you say in your grief is useless. A mortal whose life is spent has no life left, righteous one. This poor girl, the daughter of a gandharva and an apsaras, has come to the end of her life. So do not give your mind to grief, my son. But the great gods have laid down a way, long ago. If you are willing to follow it, you will have Pramadvarya back.'

"What is the way the gods have made?' said Ruru. 'Tell me truly, you who move through the sky. When I have heard it, I will do it. You must save me.'

"Give half your life to the girl, son of the Bhrigus,' said the messenger. 'Then your wife Pramadvarya will rise up, Ruru.'

"I give half my life to the girl, best of sky-travellers,' said Ruru. 'Let my love rise up in her beauty, in her finery and her jewels.'

"Then the king of the gandharvas and the messenger of the gods, those two good beings, went to Yama, the king of dharma, and spoke to him. 'King of dharma, let Ruru's wife Pramadvarya, who is dead, rise up again with half of Ruru's life, if you agree.'

"If you wish it, messenger of the gods,' said the king of dharma, 'let Pramadvarya, Ruru's wife, rise up, with half of Ruru's own life.'

"As soon as he had said it, the girl, lovely Pramadvarya, rose up with half of Ruru's life, as if she had only been asleep. For this was what had been seen long before in the future of Ruru, whose power was great: that of his very long life, half should be cut away for his wife's sake.

"Then, on a chosen day, the fathers of the two held the wedding with joy, and the two of them were happy together, each wishing only good for the other.

"Ruru had won a wife who was hard to win, bright as the heart of a lotus. And he made a vow, firm in his vow: to destroy the snakes. Whenever he saw a snake, he was seized with fierce anger, and he always took up whatever weapon was at hand and struck it down.

"One day the brahmin Ruru came to a great forest, and there he saw an old dundubha lying asleep, a snake of the harmless kind. Ruru was furious. He raised his stick, like the staff of Death, and struck it.

"Then the dundubha spoke to him. 'I have done you no wrong today, ascetic. Why do you strike me in such rage?'

"My wife, dear to me as my own life, was bitten by a snake,' said Ruru. 'And then, snake, I made myself a terrible vow: that I would always kill every snake I saw. So I mean to kill you. You will lose your life.'

"The snakes that bite men are other snakes, brahmin,' said the dundubha. 'You should not kill dundubhas just because they smell like snakes. We share the other snakes' troubles but not their purposes, their sorrows but not their joys. You know dharma. You should not kill dundubhas.'

"When Ruru heard the snake speak like this, he was frightened. He thought the dundubha must be a seer, and he did not kill it. Instead the blessed Ruru spoke to it, gently, as if to calm it. 'Tell me, snake, if you will: who are you, who have come to this changed form?'

""Long ago, Ruru, I was a seer named Sahasrapat,' said the dundubha. 'I became a snake through a brahmin's curse.'

""Why did the brahmin curse you in his anger, best of snakes?' asked Ruru. 'And how long will you keep this body?'

""Long ago I had a friend,' said the dundubha, 'a brahmin named Khagama. His words were very sharp, my son, and he was strong with the power of his austerity. Once, when we were boys, I was playing, and I made a snake out of grass. He was busy at his fire offering, and I frightened him with it, and he fainted.

""When the ascetic came to himself again, true in his words and strict in his vows, he spoke to me, as if he would burn me up with his anger. "You made this snake to frighten me, and it has no power. So by my anger you will become a snake with no power."

""I knew the power of his austerity, ascetic, and my heart was full of dread. I stood before that forest-dweller, bowing, with my palms joined, shaking and careful. "Friend," I said, "I did it for fun. I was laughing. Please forgive me, brahmin. Take back this curse."

""He saw how frightened I was. He was shaken himself, and he sighed hot sighs again and again. "What I have said is not false," he told me. "It will surely happen. But listen to what I say to you, you who keep your vows, and keep these words in your heart, ascetic. A pure son will be born to Pramati, named Ruru. When you see him, you will soon be freed from the curse."

""You are the one called Ruru, the pure son of Pramati.'

"And the seer, having taken back his own form, said, 'Now I will tell you what is good for you.

""Not harming any living thing is the highest dharma of all creatures that breathe. That is the teaching. So a brahmin should never harm any living creature anywhere. A brahmin is born gentle in this world; that is the highest teaching of the Veda. He knows the Vedas and their limbs, and he gives safety to every creature. Not harming, speaking the truth, and forgiving: this is settled as a brahmin's highest dharma, higher even than holding the Vedas in his memory.

""The dharma of a kshatriya is not meant for you: to carry the rod of punishment, to be fierce, and to protect the people. Listen, Ruru. That was a kshatriya's work: Janamejaya's killing of the snakes, long ago, righteous one. And listen to how the frightened snakes were saved, too, and saved by a brahmin: by Astika, chief of the brahmins, strong in the power of his austerity, master of the Vedas and their limbs, at the snake sacrifice, best of brahmins.'

""How did the kshatriya Janamejaya harm the snakes?' asked Ruru. 'And why were the snakes harmed, best of brahmins? And why did Astika set them free? Tell me. I want to

hear all of it.'

"'You will hear the whole great story of Astika, Ruru,' said the seer, 'from brahmins telling it.' And with that he vanished.

"Ruru ran all over the forest, searching everywhere, trying to find the seer, and at last he fell to the ground, exhausted. When he came to himself, he went home and told his father what had happened. And when he asked, his father told him the whole story."

Chapter 8

The Churning of the Ocean

"Why did King Janamejaya, that tiger among kings, try to put an end to the snakes with his snake sacrifice?" asked Shaunaka. "Tell me. And why did Astika, the best of brahmins and the best of those who pray, save the snakes from that blazing fire? Whose son was the king who held the snake sacrifice? And whose son was that best of brahmins? Tell me."

"All this is told in the great story of Astika," said the bard. "Listen, and I will tell you all of it."

"I want to hear the whole of this lovely tale," said Shaunaka, "the story of the ancient and famous brahmin Astika."

"The elders who live in the Naimisha forest call this history ancient," said Ugrashravas. "Krishna Dvaipayana told it. My father, the suta Lomaharshana, the wise pupil of Vyasa, once told it when the brahmins asked him. I heard it from him, and I will tell you this story of Astika exactly as it is, Shaunaka, since you ask."

"Astika's father was a lord like the creator himself. He was a celibate student, sparing in his food, and always given to fierce austerity. His name was Jaratkaru. He was a great seer who never spilled his seed, the best of the Yayavaras, a wandering order, and he knew dharma and kept strict vows."

"Once, as he wandered, he saw his own forefathers hanging head down in a great pit, their feet in the air. As soon as he saw them, Jaratkaru spoke to them."

"'Who are you, hanging head down in this pit? You are clinging to a clump of virana grass, and a rat hidden in the pit, who lives there always, has gnawed it all round.'

"'We are the Yayavaras, seers of strict vows,' they said. 'Our line is dying out, brahmin, and so we are sinking down into the earth. We have one descendant left, called Jaratkaru, an unlucky son of unlucky fathers. He cares for nothing but austerity. The fool does not want to take a wife and have sons. So we hang in this pit, because our line is dying out. He is our protector, and yet we have no protection, as if we were wrongdoers. Who are you, good man, who grieve for us as if you were our kin? We want to know who you are, brahmin, standing here. Why do you pity us, who are to be pitied?'

"'You are my forefathers, my fathers and grandfathers,' said Jaratkaru. 'Tell me what I should do now. I myself am Jaratkaru.'

"'Try, son, and try hard, to keep our family going,' they said, 'for your own sake and for ours, lord. That is dharma. Not by the fruits of dharma, son, and not by austerities, however great the store of them, do people reach the place that those who have sons reach. So make the effort to take a wife, and set your mind on children, son. We command it. This is the greatest good you can do us.'

"'I will not take a wife,' said Jaratkaru. 'I have always been set on that. But for your good I will take one, on one condition, and by the proper rites. If I find a wife like this, I will marry her, and not otherwise. She must have the same name as I do, and her kin must wish to give her. Then I will marry that girl by the rules, as if she were

alms. For who will give his daughter to a poor man like me? But if someone gives her, I will take her as alms. This is how I will set about marrying, forefathers, and I will never do it any other way. And from her a child will be born who will save you. Let my forefathers reach a place that lasts for ever, and be glad.'

"So that brahmin of strict vows wandered the earth to marry, looking for a wife, and did not find one. One day he went into a forest, remembering what his forefathers had said, and he called out softly three times, asking for a girl as alms.

"Vasuki, the king of the snakes, came forward with his sister and offered her to him. But Jaratkaru did not accept her, thinking, She does not have my name. For the great Jaratkaru's mind was fixed: *I will take a wife who is offered to me, and who has my name.*

"The wise Jaratkaru, great in austerity, said, 'What is your sister's name? Tell me the truth, snake.'

"'Jaratkaru,' said Vasuki, 'this younger sister of mine is Jaratkaru. I have kept her for you all this time. Take her, best of brahmins.'

"For long before, best of those who know Brahman, the snakes had been cursed by their own mother: 'The fire, whose charioteer is the wind, will burn you at Janamejaya's sacrifice.' To quiet that curse, the chief of the snakes gave his sister to that ascetic seer of good vows. Jaratkaru took her by the rites the scriptures lay down, and a son named Astika was born to her from that great man. He was an ascetic and a great soul, and he knew the Vedas and their limbs through and through. He treated the whole world alike, and he took away the fear of both his father's family and his mother's.

"Then, after a long time, a king descended from Pandu held the great sacrifice known as the snake sacrifice. So we have heard. When that sacrifice was under way, to destroy the snakes, the famous Astika set them free from the curse. He saved the nagas, his mother's brothers, and all his other kin. He saved his father's forefathers too, by giving them descendants, and by his austerity. Through his many vows and his study, he paid all his debts, brahmin. He satisfied the gods with sacrifices and many gifts to the priests. He satisfied the seers by his celibate study. And he satisfied the forefathers with children.

"So Jaratkaru, strict in his vows, took the heavy burden off his forefathers and went to heaven with them. The sage Jaratkaru, having won a son, Astika, and the highest dharma, went to heaven after a very long time.

"That is the story of Astika, as I have told it rightly. Tell me, tiger of the Bhrgus, what more shall I tell?"

"Sauti," said Shaunaka, "tell us this story again, in full: the story of the wise and good Astika. We are longing to hear it. You tell it sweetly, my friend, with smooth words and syllables, and we are delighted. You speak as your father spoke. Your father was always ready to serve us. Tell this story the way your father told it."

"I will tell you this story of Astika, which brings long life," said the bard, "just as I heard it from my father.

"Long ago, brahmin, in the age of the gods, there were two sisters, daughters of the creator, lovely, wonderful and without fault. They were the wives of Kashyapa, and their names were Kadru and Vinata. Their husband, who was like the creator himself, was delighted with his two lawful wives, and he offered them each a boon. When they heard that Kashyapa would give them a boon, a very great one, the two fine women were filled with a joy past all comparing.

"Kadru chose to have a thousand nagas as her sons, all equal in splendour. Vinata chose to have two sons, stronger than Kadru's sons, greater than they in strength, in splendour and in courage. Her husband gave her the boon of one son and a half, as she wished, and Vinata said to Kashyapa, 'So be it.'

"Vinata had what she wanted: two sons of greater strength. And Kadru had what she wanted: a thousand sons of equal splendour. 'Carry the children with care,' said Kashyapa, the great ascetic, and he went away into the forest, leaving his two wives happy with their boons.

"After a long time, Kadru laid a thousand eggs, brahmin, and Vinata laid two. Their serving women, delighted, put the eggs in warm, moist jars, and there they lay for five hundred years. When the five hundred years were over, Kadru's sons came out. But from Vinata's two eggs, no children could be seen.

"Vinata, the ascetic goddess, longed for a son, and she was ashamed. She broke one of the eggs, and there she saw a son. The upper half of his body was fully formed, and the rest was not yet there. So we have heard. The son was angry, and he cursed her.

"'Mother, you were greedy, and so you have made me like this, with only half a body. So you will be the slave of the woman you compete with, for five hundred years. And this other son, mother, will free you from slavery, if you do not break his egg too, as you broke mine, and leave him with no body, or maimed, this ascetic son. If you want a son of great strength, you must have patience, and wait more than five hundred years for his birth.'

"Having cursed Vinata, the son went up into the sky. He is Aruna, brahmin, whom you can always see at the time of dawn.

"And Garuda too was born when his time came, the destroyer of snakes. As soon as he was born, he left Vinata and flew up into the sky, hungry, eager to eat, to take the food that the Maker had set aside for him, tiger of the Bhrigus.

"At this time the two sisters saw the horse Uchchaisravas coming near them, ascetic. All the hosts of the gods had honoured him with joy. He was the jewel of horses, the finest, born when the nectar of immortality was churned: strong as a great flood, the best of horses, the fastest of all that run, glorious, ageless and divine, with every sign of good fortune."

"How did the gods churn the nectar?" asked Shaunaka. "And where? Tell me, where that king of horses was born, so strong and so bright."

"There is a mountain," said the bard, "Meru, blazing and unshakeable, a heap of light beyond compare. Its golden peaks outshine the sun. It is adorned with gold, bright with colours, and the gods and gandharvas go there. It is beyond measuring, and men who live

in wrongdoing cannot come near it. Fierce beasts roam it, and divine herbs light it up. It is a great mountain that stands so high it covers the vault of heaven. No one else can reach it even in the mind. It has rivers and trees, and it rings with the lovely songs of flocks of birds of every kind.

"All the gods, in their great power, climbed up onto its bright back, which was studded with jewels and rose up beyond all measure. They sat there together, firm in austerity and self-control, and began to take counsel about the nectar of immortality.

"While the gods were thinking and talking on every side, the god Narayana spoke to Brahma.

"Let the gods and the hosts of asuras churn the ocean, as if it were a great pot. When the great ocean is churned, the nectar will come out of it. Gods, throw in all the herbs and all the jewels, and churn the ocean. Then you will find the nectar.'

"There was a mountain called Mandara, the best of mountains, adorned with peaks like the tops of clouds and covered in nets of creepers. Birds of every kind sang on it, and fanged beasts of every kind crowded it. The kinnaras, the apsaras, and the gods themselves went there. It rose eleven thousand yojanas high, and as many thousand went down below the earth.

"The gods, all of them together, could not lift it. So they went to Vishnu, who sat with Brahma, and said, 'You two must find the best way for us. Make the effort to lift Mandara, for our good.'

"So be it,' said Vishnu, and Brahma with him, son of Bhrigu. Then Ananta rose up. Brahma urged him to it, and Narayana gave him the task, and he was mighty. He tore up by force that king of mountains, with its forests and all that lived in them.

"The gods went with him to the ocean and said to it, 'We are going to churn your waters for the nectar.'

"The lord of the waters answered, 'Then I must have a share of it too, for I will bear the great crushing when Mandara whirls round.'

"The gods and the asuras said to Akupara, the king of the tortoises, 'You must be the base for this mountain.'

"So be it,' said the tortoise, and he offered his back. And Indra pressed down the top of the mountain with a machine.

"So they made Mandara the churning stick and Vasuki the rope, and the gods began to churn the ocean, the store of all the waters, for the nectar, brahmin. And with them churned the daityas and the danavas, the tribes of the asuras. The great asuras held one end of the snake king, and all the gods stood together at the end where the tail was. The blessed god Ananta stood where Narayana was, and again and again he lifted the snake's head and flung it down.

"As the gods jerked Vasuki hard, winds full of smoke and flame burst from his mouth, again and again. The smoke gathered into clouds full of lightning, and they rained on the hosts of gods, who were worn out with toil and heat. And from the mountain's high

peaks, flowers came showering down, and covered the gods and the asuras with garlands on every side.

"The ocean, churned with Mandara by the gods and the asuras, gave out a great roar, like the roar of great thunderclouds. Many kinds of water creatures were crushed by the great mountain, and by the hundreds they perished in the salt sea. The mountain destroyed many of Varuna's creatures of every kind, who lived in the depths below the earth.

"As the mountain whirled, great trees full of birds rubbed against each other and fell from its summit. The rubbing kindled a fire that flared up again and again, and it wrapped Mandara in flame, the way lightning wraps a dark cloud. It burned the elephants and the lions that fled from it, and every other kind of creature lost its life. Indra, the best of the immortals, put the fire out everywhere with water from the clouds.

"Then many kinds of resin from the great trees, and the juices of herbs, ran down into the water of the ocean. By the milk of those juices, which had the power of the nectar, and by the melted gold that flowed with them, the gods became immortal. The ocean water turned to milk, mixed with the finest of those juices, and from the milk came butter.

"Then the gods went to Brahma, the giver of boons, where he sat, and said, 'Brahma, we are worn out, and still the nectar does not come. The daityas and the great snakes are worn out too, all of us but the god Narayana. And the churning of the ocean has gone on for so long.'

"Brahma spoke to the god Narayana. 'Give them strength, Vishnu. You are our last refuge here.'

"I give strength to all who have taken up this work,' said Vishnu. 'Let everyone stir the pot. Let Mandara be turned.'

"When they heard Narayana's words, they were strong, and all together they churned the milk of the great ocean hard again, and threw it into turmoil. Then the moon rose out of the ocean, cool-rayed and clear-shining, like a second sun with a hundred thousand rays. After it, Shri rose from the butter, the goddess of fortune, dressed in white. The goddess Sura rose, the goddess of wine, and a white horse. The divine jewel Kaustubha rose, born from the nectar, glorious and radiant, and it went to rest on Narayana's chest. Shri and Sura and the Moon, and the horse as swift as thought, went to where the gods were, taking the path of the sun.

"Then the god Dhanvantari rose in bodily form, carrying a white water pot, and in it was the nectar of immortality.

"When the danavas saw that great wonder, a great uproar rose among them over the nectar. 'It's mine!' they shouted.

"Then Narayana, the lord, used his power of illusion, a power that bewitches. He took the form of a wonderful woman and went among the danavas. The danavas and the daityas were bewildered, and their minds were all on her, and they gave the nectar to that woman.

"Then the daityas and danavas took up their best armour and all kinds of weapons, and together they attacked the gods. And mighty Vishnu, with Nara, carried the nectar away

from the lords of the danavas. Then all the gods drank the nectar, taking it from Vishnu, in the uproar and confusion.

"While the gods were drinking the nectar they had longed for, a danava named Rahu took the form of a god and drank it too. When the nectar had reached the danava's throat, the Moon and the Sun told what he had done, wishing the gods well. Then, with his might, the blessed one who carries the discus cut off Rahu's head, with all its ornaments, while he was drinking the nectar. The danava's head, huge as a mountain peak, cut off by the discus, fell and shook the earth. Since then, Rahu's mouth has held a lasting feud with the Moon and the Sun, and to this day he swallows them.

"Hari, the blessed one, gave up his matchless woman's form, and with terrible weapons of many kinds he made the danavas tremble. Then near the salt sea a great battle began between the gods and the asuras, the most terrible of all battles. Huge sharp darts fell by the thousand, and sharp-pointed lances, and weapons of every kind. The asuras, cut by the discus, fell to the ground vomiting blood, struck down by swords and spears and maces. Heads cut off by battle-axes, with nets of burnished gold on them, fell ceaselessly in that cruel fight. The great asuras lay dead, their bodies smeared with blood, like mountain peaks red with ore. On every side, by thousands, rose cries of pain, as they hacked at each other with their weapons and the sun turned red. They killed each other with iron clubs, and when they came close, with their fists, and the noise seemed to touch the sky. 'Cut! Pierce! Run! Bring him down! At him!' The most terrible cries were heard on every side.

"While that dreadful battle raged, the two gods Nara and Narayana came to the fight. The blessed Vishnu saw the divine bow in Nara's hand, and he called to mind his discus, the destroyer of the danavas. At once, as soon as he thought of it, it came down from the sky: the great, shining discus Sudarshana, the scorcher of enemies, bright as fire, its rim never blunted, terrible, unconquerable, supreme. Achyuta, whose arms were like the trunks of elephants, hurled that blazing, frightening, swift and shining discus, which breaks open the cities of enemies. With the brightness of the fire at the end of time, it fell again and again, and struck down the sons of Diti and Danu by the thousand, hurled in that battle by the greatest of beings. Here it burned like fire, and there it licked them up. It cut the hosts of the asuras to pieces. Thrown into the sky and down onto the earth again and again, it drank their blood in battle like a ghoul.

"Then the asuras, undaunted, attacked the gods again and again with mountains. Mighty and dark as broken clouds, they rose into the sky by the thousand. And from the sky there fell, terrifying, great mountains with their trees on them, like clouds of every kind, their summits crumbling, crashing against each other with a roar. The earth and its forests shook on every side, struck by the falling mountains, as the fighters roared at one another on the field.

"Then Nara covered the path of the sky with great arrows tipped with gold, and with his feathered shafts he split the mountain peaks in that terrible battle with the hosts of the asuras. At last the great asuras, harried by the gods, saw the blazing Sudarshana in the sky, full of anger, and they fled into the earth and into the salt sea.

"So the gods won the victory. They took Mandara back to its own place with every honour, and the clouds, which had filled the sky and heaven with their roar, went back the way they had come. The gods, overjoyed, put the nectar away safely. And Indra, slayer of Bala, with the immortals, gave that treasure of nectar to the Diademed One to keep."

Chapter 9

The Wager

"So I have told you everything," said the bard, "how the nectar was churned, and where that glorious horse of matchless speed was born.

"When Kadru saw the horse, she said to Vinata, 'What colour is Uchchaihshravas? Tell me quickly, my dear.'

"This king of horses is white,' said Vinata. 'What do you think, lovely one? Tell me his colour too, and we will make a bet on it.'

"I think this horse has a black tail, you of the bright smile,' said Kadru. 'Come, play me for it, proud lady, and let the loser be the other's slave.'

"So they made their agreement, that the loser would be a slave, and they went home, saying, 'We will look tomorrow.'

"Then Kadru, meaning to cheat, gave an order to her thousand sons. 'Turn yourselves into hairs as black as kohl, and go into the horse's tail quickly, so that I do not become a slave.'

"They would not agree to what she said. So she cursed the snakes. 'When the snake sacrifice of the wise royal seer Janamejaya, of Pandu's line, is under way, the fire will burn you.'

"The Grandfather himself heard this curse, which Kadru had spoken, a curse far too cruel. It was the work of fate. With all the hosts of the gods he approved her words, for he saw how many snakes there were, and he wished the creatures of the world well. These biters were very strong, and their poison was fierce and deadly. Because their poison was so sharp, and for the good of creatures, he gave the great Kashyapa the knowledge that takes poison away.

"When the night had passed and the sun had risen, the two sisters, Kadru and Vinata, were angry and fierce with each other, for they had wagered slavery. They went to look closely at the horse Uchchaihshravas.

"There they saw the ocean, the store of all the waters. It teemed with whales, with fish and with the great beasts that swallow whales. Crocodiles filled it, and many thousands of creatures of every shape. Fierce creatures lived there, so that no one could ever safely enter it, and it swarmed with tortoises and sharks.

"It was the mine of every jewel, Varuna's home, and the lovely home of the nagas. It was the lord of rivers, the dwelling of the fire below the world and the prison of the asuras, terrible to living things, the store of the waters. It was bright and divine, the great source of the immortals' nectar. No one could measure it or even imagine it, and its waters were holy and wonderful.

"It was dreadful, fierce with the cries of the creatures in it, and its roar was frightening. It was full of deep whirlpools, and it terrified every creature. The wind at the shore rocked it back and forth, and it rose up in restless turmoil, and its waves moved everywhere like hands, so that it seemed to be dancing. As the moon waxed and

waned, its waves swelled high and no one could come near it. It had given birth to the conch Panchajanya, and it was the finest of all the mines of jewels.

"Its waters had been churned and muddled to their depths when the blessed Govinda, whose power has no measure, took the form of a boar and went looking for the earth. The brahmin seer Atri practised austerity for a hundred years and could not find its bottom. Its floor is the world below, and it never wastes away. It is the bed where Vishnu, whose splendour has no measure, whose navel bears a lotus, lies in the sleep of yoga at the beginning of each age. It is the blessed giver of water, as an offering, to the blazing fire of the Mare's Mouth. It is the lord of rivers, bottomless and boundless, wide beyond measure.

"They saw the great ocean, and many great rivers by the thousand hurrying into it without rest, as if racing each other. They saw it deep and full of whales and fierce sea monsters, roaring with the dreadful cries of the creatures in the water, vast and bright as the sky, bottomless, the endless store of the waters. Looking on that ocean, full of fish and sea monsters and waves, deep and spreading, bright as the sky and lit by the flames of the fire below the world, the two women flew on quickly.

"Kadru crossed that ocean with Vinata, and flew fast, and soon came down close to the horse. She saw many black hairs clinging to its tail. And she put Vinata, whose face had fallen, into slavery. So Vinata lost the wager. She lived as a slave, burning with sorrow.

"Meanwhile, when his time came, Garuda was born. He split the egg without his mother there, and he blazed with power. He shone like a mass of fire, kindled and terrifying. The bird grew huge all at once, with a vast body, and rose into the sky.

"When all creatures saw him, they went to Agni, the fire, for refuge. They bowed to him where he sat, in his form that holds all forms, and said to him, 'Agni, do not grow any more! Do you mean to burn us up? For that great mass of yours, all ablaze, is spreading.'

"'It is not what you think, you crushers of the asuras,' said Agni. 'This is Garuda, the mighty. He is my equal in splendour.'

"When he had told them this, the gods and the hosts of seers went close to Garuda and praised him.

"'You are a seer, greatly blessed. You are a god, the lord of birds. You are the master, bright as the sun. You are our highest protection. You are a sea of strength. You are good and undaunted, rich in power, and hard to withstand. You whose fame never fails, you are all austerity and all sacred learning, all that is to come and all that has come.

"'You are the highest. You light up this whole world, moving and unmoving, with your rays, like the sun. Again and again you outshine the light of the sun itself. You are the end of all this world, of what lasts and what passes. As the angry sun would burn all creatures, so you burn them, bright as the fire. You are terrible, like the fire that rises at the end of the world, destroying, bringing all to an end when the ages turn.

""We have come to you for refuge, lord of birds, mighty one, you who are free of darkness and move among the clouds. We have come to mighty Garuda, who flies in the sky, the highest and the lowest, the giver of boons, whose courage no one can overcome.'

"When the gods and the hosts of seers had praised him like this, Suparna, the bird of the beautiful wings, drew his splendour back into himself.

"Then the bird, great in courage and strength, who could go wherever he wished, went to his mother on the far shore of the great ocean. There Vinata, beaten in the wager, had become a slave, and she was bitterly unhappy.

"Then one day, at the proper time, Kadru called Vinata, who was bowing low where her son was near, and said this. 'My good woman, there is a lovely home of the nagas, a charming place, in a lonely spot in the ocean's belly. Carry me there, Vinata.'

"So Suparna's mother carried the mother of the snakes. And Garuda, urged by his mother, carried the snakes. The son of Vinata, the bird, flew up towards the sun, and the snakes, caught in the sun's rays, fainted.

"When Kadru saw her sons in that state, she praised Indra.

""Homage to you, lord of the gods of gods! Homage to you, slayer of Bala! Slayer of Namuchi, homage to you, thousand-eyed, husband of Shachi! Be a raft of water for the snakes the sun is burning. You are our highest protection, best of the immortals. You have the power to pour out water in plenty, Purandara, breaker of cities. You are the cloud, you are the wind, you are the fire of the lightning in the sky. You scatter the massed clouds, and they say you are the massed cloud itself. You are the matchless, terrible thunderbolt. You are the roaring storm cloud.

""You make the worlds, and you destroy them, and no one conquers you. You are the light of all beings. You are the sun, the bright one. You are the great wonder among beings. You are the king, you are the best of the gods. You are Vishnu, you are the thousand-eyed, you are the god, you are the last refuge. You are all the nectar, god. You are the soma, honoured above all. You are the hour, the day of the moon, the moment and the instant. You are the bright half of the month and the dark half, and the smallest measures of time. You are the year and the seasons, the months, the nights and the days.

""You are the fair earth, with her mountains and forests, and the sky, with its sun, free of darkness. You are the great ocean with its whales and the beasts that swallow whales, its great waves and its many sea monsters, the home of the fish. You are great glory. Wise, great seers always worship you with glad hearts. Praised at the sacrifice, you drink the soma, and the offerings made with the cry of Vashat, for the good of the world. Brahmins worship you here always, to win the fruits of it, and you are sung in the limbs of the Veda, you flood of matchless strength. It is for your sake that the best of the brahmins, given to sacrifice, learn the limbs of the Veda along with all the Vedas.'

"When Kadru had praised him like this, the blessed Indra, whose horses are bay, covered the whole sky with masses of dark clouds. The clouds poured down water in floods, bright with lightning, thundering all the time in the sky as if at one another. The sky seemed packed with vast and wonderful clouds, pouring out water beyond measure without a pause,

with a great roar. The sky seemed to dance with the waves of the downpour, and it filled with the rolling of the thunder. As Indra rained, the joy of the nagas was very great, and the earth filled with water on every side.

"Carried by Suparna, the snakes soon came to that place. It was ringed by the waters of the ocean and loud with flocks of birds. Lines of forest covered it, with fruits and flowers of every colour, and lovely houses, and lotus pools. It was bright with lakes of clear water, and pure breezes fanned it, carrying heavenly scents. Sandalwood trees that seemed to reach up to the sky made it beautiful. When the wind shook them, they let fall showers of flowers, as if they were raining flowers on the nagas there. It was a holy place that made the heart glad, dear to the gandharvas and the apsaras, lovely with the songs of many birds, and it delighted Kadru's sons.

"The snakes came to that forest and played there happily. Then they said to Suparna, the mighty, the best of birds, 'Carry us to another island, a lovely one with plenty of water. You fly, sky-traveller, and you see many lovely lands.'

"The bird thought it over, and then he said to his mother, Vinata, 'Mother, why must I do what the snakes tell me?'

"'Best of birds,' said Vinata, 'I have become the slave of my sister, who is not noble. The snakes played a trick, and made the wager false.'

"When his mother had told him the reason, the sky-traveller was pained by her pain, and he spoke to the snakes. 'What must I bring, or what must I learn, or what brave deed must I do here, to be freed from slavery to you? Tell me the truth, you flickering tongues.'

"When they heard him, the snakes said, 'Bring the nectar of immortality by your own strength. Then you will be freed from slavery, sky-traveller.'"

Chapter 10

The Elephant and the Tortoise

"When the snakes had said this," the bard went on, "Garuda said to his mother, 'I am going to bring the nectar. I want to know what I may eat.'

"'In a lonely place in the ocean's belly,' said Vinata, 'there is a fine home of the Nishadas, many thousands of them. Eat them, and bring the nectar. But you must never think of killing a brahmin, not in any way. A brahmin must not be killed by any creature. He is like fire. When he is angry, a brahmin becomes fire, and the sun, and poison, and the sword. The brahmin eats first of all beings. He is the best of the classes, a father and a teacher.'

"'Mother,' said Garuda, 'tell me the good signs by which I will know a brahmin. I ask you for good reason.'

"'If one goes down your throat like a swallowed fishhook,' said Vinata, 'and burns you like a live coal, my son, know that he is a bull among brahmins.'

"Vinata knew her son's strength had no equal, and still, out of love for him, she said these words and gave him her blessing.

"'May the Wind guard your wings, my son, and the Moon your back. May Fire guard your head, and the Sun guard all of you. And I, my son, will always be given to your peace and your welfare. Go safely on your way, my child, and do what you have to do.'

"When he heard his mother's words, he spread his wings and flew up into the sky. Then, mighty and hungry, he went to the Nishadas, like Time, the great ender, come to make an end. As he fell upon the Nishadas, he raised a great cloud of dust that touched the sky. He dried up the water in the ocean's belly, and he shook the mountains near by.

"Then the king of the birds made his mouth huge, and blocked the Nishadas' path. The Nishadas ran in haste straight towards the mouth of the eater of snakes. They went into that wide, gaping mouth by the thousand, like birds flying in terror into the sky, when the wind and the dust bewilder them and a great storm shakes the trees of the forest. Then the bird, the scorcher of enemies, restless and mighty, closed his mouth. Hungry, the lord of the sky-travellers destroyed those fish-eaters of many kinds.

"A brahmin went down his throat, together with his wife, and burned like a live coal. The sky-traveller said to him, 'Best of brahmins, come out quickly from my mouth. I have opened it for you. I must never kill a brahmin, even one who is always given to wrongdoing.'

"The brahmin answered Garuda as he said this. 'This Nishada woman is my wife. Let her come out with me.'

"'Take the Nishada woman too, and fly out quickly,' said Garuda. 'Save yourself fast, while my heat has not yet digested you.'

"So the brahmin came out, with the Nishada woman, and he blessed Garuda and went on to the place he wished. When the brahmin and his wife had come out, the king of the birds spread his wings and flew up into the sky, swift as thought.

"Then he saw his father. When his father asked him, he told him everything. 'The snakes have sent me to bring the soma, and I am ready. I will bring it today, to free my mother from slavery. My mother told me to eat the Nishadas. But I have eaten them by the thousand and I am still not satisfied. So show me something else to eat, blessed father, so that when I have eaten it I will be able to bring the nectar, my lord.'

"There was a great seer named Vibhavasū," said Kashyapa, 'who was very quick to anger. He had a younger brother, Supratika, a great ascetic. The great sage Supratika did not want to keep his wealth together with his brother's. He always spoke of dividing it.

"Then his brother Vibhavasū said to Supratika, "Many people are always wanting to divide what they own, out of folly. Once they have divided it, their wealth bewitches them and they no longer respect each other. Enemies who look like friends see that they are fools, each out for himself, each cut off with his own wealth, and they split them further apart. Others see that they are divided, and they fall on them through the gaps. Ruin beyond measure comes quickly to those who are divided. That is why the wise do not praise division, among those who should be bound by the rule of their elders and who suspect each other. You will not be held back, Supratika. You want your wealth divided. So you will become an elephant."

"Cursed like this, Supratika said to Vibhavasū, "And you will become a tortoise, living under the water."

"So Supratika and Vibhavasū cursed each other, and for the sake of wealth, in their folly, they became an elephant and a tortoise. Their anger was at fault. Even though they have been born as animals, they delight in hating each other, and they are proud of their size and strength. The two huge creatures are in this lake, and they keep up their old feud.

"Here comes one of them now, the glorious great elephant. At the sound of his trumpeting, the huge tortoise who lies under the water rises too, and churns the whole lake. When he sees him, the mighty elephant curls up his trunk and falls upon the water. He churns the lake full of fish with the force of his tusks and the tip of his trunk, his tail and his feet, and the mighty tortoise raises his head and comes to fight. The elephant stands six yojanas high and twice that in length. The tortoise is three yojanas high and ten yojanas round. They are mad for battle, and each of them wants to beat the other. Eat them quickly, and do what you want to do.'

"When he heard his father's words, the sky-traveller of terrible speed seized the elephant in one claw and the tortoise in the other. He flew high up into the sky, and came to the Alamba ford, and went to the trees of the gods.

"Struck by the wind from his wings, the heavenly trees with their golden branches trembled with fear. May he not break us! they thought. He saw that their limbs were shaking, those trees whose fruits and shoots are the wishes of the heart, and the sky-traveller went on to others, of matchless beauty: great trees shining with fruits of gold and silver and branches of beryl, with the waters of the ocean all around them.

"There a very great rohina tree, grown enormously tall, spoke to the best of birds as he flew towards it, swift as thought. 'This great branch of mine stretches a hundred yojanas. Sit on this branch and eat the elephant and the tortoise.'

"Then the best of birds, whose body was like a mountain, came down fast on that tree, the home of thousands of birds, and shook it. And he broke that branch, thick with leaves.

"At the mere touch of mighty Garuda's feet, the branch of the tree broke, and he caught the broken branch. He looked in surprise at the great broken branch, and he saw the Valakhilya seers hanging from it head down. Afraid that he would kill them, the lord of birds swooped after it and took the branch in his beak, watching over them. The bird flew slowly, knocking down mountains as he went. So he flew over many lands, with the elephant and the tortoise, out of pity for the Valakhilyas, and he could find no place to come down.

"He went to Gandhamadana, the best of mountains, that never passes away, and there he saw his father, Kashyapa, deep in austerity.

"His father saw him too: the bird of heavenly form, full of splendour, courage and strength, as swift as mind and wind, like a mountain peak, raised like the staff of Brahma. He was beyond thought, beyond knowing, terrifying to every creature. He had the power of illusion, and he was like blazing fire, rising. Gods, danavas and rakshasas could not assail him or defeat him. He split mountain peaks and dried up the waters of rivers. He was terrible, a stirrer of worlds, and to look at he was like Death.

"When the blessed Kashyapa saw him come, he knew what he meant to do, and he said, 'My son, do nothing rash, or you will soon be in pain. Do not let the Valakhilyas, who drink the rays of the sun, burn you in their anger.'

"For his son's sake, Kashyapa made peace with the Valakhilyas, whose austerity had made them perfect, and told them the reason. 'Garuda has set out to do something for the good of all creatures, you ascetics. He means to do a great deed. Please give him leave.'

"When the blessed one said this, the sages let go of the branch and went to the holy Himalaya to practise austerity.

"When they had gone, Vinata's son, his mouth full of the branch, asked his father, Kashyapa, 'Blessed one, where shall I let go of this branch of the tree? Tell me of a place where there are no brahmins.'

"Kashyapa told him of a mountain where no people lived, its caves shut in by snow, a place no one else could reach even in thought. Tarkshya, the bird, set his mind on the great hollow of that mountain and flew there fast, with the branch, the elephant and the tortoise. A thong made from a hundred hides could not have gone round the great branch the bird carried as he flew. Garuda, the best of flying things, covered a hundred thousand yojanas, and it did not take him long.

"At his father's word, he reached that mountain in a moment, and there the sky-traveller let go of the great branch, and it fell with a crash. The king of mountains shook, struck by the wind of his wings, and its trees broke and fell and let loose a shower of flowers. All around the mountain, its peaks, bright with jewels and gold, the pride of the great mountain, broke and crumbled. Many trees that the branch struck down shone with their golden flowers like clouds lit with lightning. Blossoming in gold, mixed with the coloured ores of the mountain and reddened by the rays of the sun, the trees glowed

there.

"Then the best of birds perched on a peak of that mountain, and Garuda ate both of them, the elephant and the tortoise. And he flew up from the mountaintop, swift as thought.

"Then omens rose among the gods, warning of danger. Indra's beloved thunderbolt blazed up, as if in pain. A meteor, smoking and flaming, fell from the sky in the daytime. The weapons of the Vasus, the Rudras, the Adityas, the Sadhyas, the Maruts and all the other hosts of gods turned on one another. This had never happened before, not even in the war of the gods and the asuras. Winds blew, with thunder, and meteors fell on every side. The cloudless sky thundered with a great roar, and even the god of the gods rained blood. The gods' garlands faded, and their splendour dimmed. Fierce clouds of evil omen rained blood in torrents, and dust rose up and fouled their crowns.

"Then Indra of the hundred sacrifices, shaken with fear, with the gods around him, saw these terrible omens and said to Brihaspati, 'Why have these great and terrible omens appeared, blessed one? I see no enemy who could attack us in battle.'

"This has come of your fault, lord of the gods, and your carelessness, Indra of the hundred sacrifices,' said Brihaspati. 'By the austerity of the Valakhilyas a wonderful being has arisen. The son of the sage Kashyapa and of Vinata, a sky-traveller, has come to take the soma. He is mighty, and he can take whatever form he wants. That bird, the best of the strong, is able to take the soma. I believe anything of him. He could do even what cannot be done.'

"When Shakra heard this, he said to the guardians of the nectar, 'A bird of great courage and strength has set out to take the soma from here. I am warning you, so that he does not take it by force. Brihaspati has told me his strength has no equal.'

"When the gods heard this, they were amazed, and they took great care. They stood round the nectar, and Indra of the hundred sacrifices stood with them, holding the thunderbolt. They wore costly armour, golden and bright, set with beryl, those proud gods. They raised terrible weapons of every kind by the thousand, sharp and keen-edged, sparking, flaming and smoking on every side: discuses and iron clubs, tridents and axes, sharp spears of many kinds, spotless swords and fearsome maces, each suited to its bearer's body. With those shining weapons, and adorned with heavenly ornaments, the hosts of the gods stood shining and free of stain.

"The gods, whose strength, courage and splendour had no equal, who break open the cities of the asuras, set their minds on guarding the nectar, and their bodies shone like blazing fire. So the gods held that great field of battle, crowded with hundreds of thousands of clubs, and it shone in the rays of the sun like a piece of the sky that had fallen."

Chapter 11

The Nectar

"Son of the suta," said Shaunaka, "what was great Indra's fault, and what was his carelessness? How was Garuda born by the austerity of the Valakhilyas? How did the king of birds come to be the son of Kashyapa, a brahmin? How did he become one whom no creature could attack or kill? And how could that sky-traveller go wherever he wished, with whatever strength he wished? I want to hear this, if it is told in the old lore."

"What you ask me is a matter for the old lore," said the bard. "Listen, brahmin, and I will tell you all of it in brief."

"Once, they say, when Kashyapa, the lord of creatures, was holding a sacrifice because he wanted a son, the seers, the gods and the gandharvas all came to help him. Kashyapa set Indra to fetch the firewood, and with him the sages called the Valakhilyas, and other hosts of gods."

"Indra, in his power, lifted a load of wood as big as a mountain, to match his strength, and carried it without much trouble. On the way he saw some seers, very small, no bigger than the joint of a thumb, carrying a single leaf stalk of the palasha tree together. They were shrunk into themselves, as if into their own limbs, and they did not eat, for all their wealth was austerity. They were struggling, and weak, and they had sunk into the water that had gathered in a cow's hoofprint."

"Indra, the breaker of cities, was full of pride, and drunk with his own strength. He laughed at them all, and stepped over them, and scorned them, and went quickly on."

"They were overcome with rage, and a great fury rose in them. They began a great rite that would frighten Indra. Those brahmins of fierce austerity poured offerings into the fire by the rules, with mantras high and low. Hear what they wished for, those seers of strict vows."

"'Let there be another Indra of all the gods, with whatever strength he wishes, going wherever he wishes, bringing fear to the king of the gods. Let him be a hundred times greater than Indra in valour and strength, and as swift as thought. By the fruit of our austerity, let a terrible one be born today.'

"When Indra of the hundred sacrifices, the king of the gods, learned of this, he was in great distress, and he went for refuge to Kashyapa of the strict vows. When Kashyapa, the lord of creatures, heard it from the king of the gods, he went to the Valakhilyas and asked whether their rite would succeed."

"'It will be so,' answered the seers, who always speak the truth."

"Then Kashyapa, the lord of creatures, spoke to them gently. 'This Indra of the three worlds was made Indra by the command of Brahma. And you, who are rich in austerity, are working for an Indra too. You should not make Brahma's word false, good sirs. And I do not wish to make false what you have set your hearts on. So let this one be the Indra of the winged creatures, full of strength and power. And be gracious to the king of the gods, who begs you.'

"When Kashyapa said this, the ascetic Valakhilyas honoured him, the best of sages and

lord of creatures, and answered. 'All of us began this rite for an Indra, lord of creatures. And you began your rite, which you have longed for, for a child. So take this rite and its fruit, and do as you see best.'

"At this very time the goddess Vinata, the lovely and famous daughter of Daksha, who wanted a son, had practised austerity and kept her vows. When her season came, she bathed for the rite that brings a son, and she came to her husband, pure. Kashyapa said to her, 'Goddess, the work you longed for will bear fruit. You will give birth to two sons, heroes, lords of the three worlds. By the austerity of the Valakhilyas and by my own will, you will have two sons of great fortune, honoured by the worlds.'

"And the blessed son of Marichi spoke to her again. 'Carry this child with care, for it will rise very high. One of them will make himself Indra of all the winged creatures, a hero honoured by the worlds, a bird with whatever strength he wishes.'

"Then the lord of creatures, well pleased, said to Indra of the hundred sacrifices, 'These two birds will be your helpers, and your brothers. No harm will come to you from them, breaker of cities. Let your distress go, Shakra. You alone will be Indra. But you must never again insult those who speak the sacred word. You must never scorn them in your pride, for their words are poison and they are very quick to anger.'

"When he had heard this, Indra went back to heaven with his fears gone, and Vinata was glad, for she had what she wanted. She gave birth to two sons, Aruna and Garuda. Aruna, of the two, was not whole, and he goes before the sun. And Garuda was consecrated as the Indra of the birds. Now hear his great deed, joy of the Bhrigus.

"Then, best of brahmins, while all this was astir, Garutman, the king of birds, came quickly upon the gods. When they saw how mighty he was, they trembled on every side, and they struck at one another with all their weapons.

"Among them was Bhauvana, whose spirit had no measure, bright as lightning and fire, a mighty guardian of the soma. The lord of the birds tore him with wings, beak and claws. They fought for a moment, a fight beyond compare, and he was struck down.

"With the wind of his wings, the sky-traveller raised a great cloud of dust. He made the worlds dark, and he covered the gods with it. Covered in that dust, the gods were bewildered. The guardians of the nectar were blinded by the dust and could not see him. So Garuda threw heaven into turmoil, and he tore the gods with blows of his wings and his beak.

"Then the thousand-eyed god quickly urged on the Wind. 'Scatter this shower of dust. This is your work, Maruta.'

"Then the mighty Wind swept the dust away with force. When the darkness had gone, the gods attacked the bird. As the hosts of the gods struck at him, the mighty bird roared aloud, like a great thundercloud, and frightened every creature. Then the king of birds, the killer of enemy heroes, flew up into the sky.

"All the gods in their armour, with Indra, rained weapons of every kind on him where he hung in the air above them: spears and iron clubs, tridents and maces, blazing razor-edged arrows, and discuses like the sun. Struck by all those weapons on every side, the king of birds fought a tumultuous battle and did not flinch. Vinata's son,

blazing, as if roaring in the sky, flung the gods aside on every side with his wings and his breast.

"Scattered and harried by Garuda, the gods fled. Torn by his claws and his beak, they poured out streams of blood. The Sadhyas with the gandharvas went to the east. The Vasus with the Rudras went south, beaten by the lord of birds. The Adityas went west, and the Nasatya twins north, looking back again and again, still fighting the mighty one.

"The sky-traveller fought the brave Ashvakranda, and Renuka, a winged one, and the hero Krathana, and Tapanas, and Uluka and Shvasana, and Nimesha, another winged one, and Praruja and Praliha. Vinata's son tore them with the tips of his wings, his claws and his beak, like the mighty bearer of the Pinaka bow in his anger at the end of an age. Those heroes, great in strength and courage, were wounded by him again and again, and they looked like masses of cloud pouring down streams of blood.

"When he had left them all with the life gone out of them, the best of birds went on for the nectar. He saw fire on every side of it, covering the whole sky with its blazing flames, terrible, fanned by the wind, as if it would burn up the sun.

"Then the swift and great-souled Garuda made himself ninety times ninety mouths. With those mouths he drank up rivers, and came back again very fast. And that scorcher of enemies, whose wings are his chariot, put out the blazing fire with the rivers. Then, wanting to enter, he took another body, a small one.

"He turned to gold, shining like spreading rays of light, and the bird forced his way in, like a rush of water into the sea.

"Near the nectar he saw a wheel, rimmed with razors, turning round and round without rest. It was made of iron, with a sharp edge, as bright as fire and the sun: a terrible machine, and terribly made, that the gods had built well to cut to pieces anyone who tried to steal the soma.

"The sky-traveller saw a gap in it, and turned round, and in a moment he made his body small and flew between the spokes.

"And there, below the wheel, he saw two great serpents set to guard the nectar. They shone like blazing fire. Their tongues were like lightning, their mouths and eyes were blazing, and they were terrible. Their poison was in their eyes. They were mighty and swift, and always angry. Their eyes were always furious and never closed. If either of them only looked at someone, he would turn to ash at once.

"Quickly, Suparna covered their eyes with dust. Unseen, he struck at them from every side. The son of Vinata, the sky-traveller, fell on their bodies and cut them through the middle with all his force, and then he rushed at the soma.

"The mighty son of Vinata tore up the nectar, and he flew up fast, smashing the machine. The mighty bird took the nectar quickly, without drinking it, and flew away, never tiring, blocking out the light of the sun.

"And in the sky Vinata's son met Vishnu. Narayana was pleased with him, for what he had done without greed. The imperishable god said to the sky-traveller, 'I will give you a boon.'

"The sky-traveller chose. 'Let me stand above you.' And he said this too to Narayana: 'Let me be ageless and deathless, even without the nectar.'

"Garuda received those two boons, and said to Vishnu, 'I will give you a boon too. Let the blessed one choose.'

"The blessed Krishna chose mighty Garutman to carry him. And he made him his banner, and said, 'So you will stand above me.'

"Then Indra flew after the bird, the gods' enemy, who was carrying off the nectar by force, and struck him on the body with the thunderbolt. Garuda, the best of flying things, laughed. Struck by the thunderbolt, in the middle of the battle, he spoke to Indra in a gentle voice.

"I will honour the seer from whose bones the thunderbolt was made. I will honour the thunderbolt too, and you, Indra of the hundred sacrifices. Here, I drop a single feather. You will never find the end of it. For the blow of the thunderbolt has never given me pain.'

"All creatures there were amazed when they saw that beautiful feather, and they said, 'Let this one be called Suparna, the bird of the beautiful wings.'

"When the thousand-eyed breaker of cities saw that wonder, he thought, *This bird is a great being.* And he said, 'I want to know the strength you have, which is greater than any. And I want friendship with you, best of birds, friendship without end.'

"Let there be friendship between us, god, as you wish, breaker of cities,' said Garuda. 'And know that my strength is great, and past bearing. The good do not like to praise their own strength, of course, Indra of the hundred sacrifices, nor to tell of their own virtues. But since you are my friend, and you ask me as a friend, I will tell you. No one should praise himself without a reason. I could carry this earth, with its mountains and forests and oceans, and you hanging on to it too, Shakra, on the quill of a single feather. I could carry all the worlds heaped together, with all that moves and all that does not, and never tire. Know that this is my great strength.'

"When the hero had said this, Shaunaka, the lord of the gods spoke, the Diademed One, the most glorious of the glorious, the master who wishes all creatures well. 'Accept my friendship now, the highest, without end. You have no use for the soma. Give the soma to me. Those you give it to would torment us.'

"I am taking this soma for a reason,' said Garuda. 'I will not give the soma to anyone to take. But where I set it down myself, thousand-eyed one, you can take it and carry it off quickly, lord of the thirty gods.'

"I am pleased with what you have said here, egg-born one,' said Shakra. 'Take from me whatever boon you wish, best of birds.'

"At this, Garuda remembered the sons of Kadru, and he remembered the trick by which they had made his mother a slave, and he answered. 'Though I am master of everything, I will do what you ask. Let the mighty snakes be my food, Shakra.'

"So be it," said the destroyer of the danavas, and he followed him, saying, 'I will carry off the soma when you have set it down.'

"Then Suparna came quickly to his mother. He spoke to all the snakes, as if in great delight. 'Here is the nectar. I have brought it. I will set it down for you on the kusha grass. Bathe, and perform the rites for good fortune, and then eat it, snakes. And from today let my mother be free, and no one's slave. I have done as you told me.'

"So be it," the snakes answered, and they went to bathe. And Shakra took the nectar and went back to heaven.

"Then the snakes came back to that place, wanting the soma, bathed, their prayers said and their rites for good fortune done, and full of joy. They saw that it had been taken, that a trick had been played in answer to their own. 'This is where the soma lay,' they said, and they licked the darbha grass. By that deed the snakes' tongues were split in two. And from the touch of the nectar the darbha grass became holy.

"Then Suparna, overjoyed, roamed the forest there with his mother. The eater of snakes, honoured by the birds, whose fame never fails, made Vinata glad.

"Whoever always listens to this story, or reads it aloud in a gathering of the best of brahmins, will surely go to heaven, sharing in the merit that comes of telling the praise of the great-souled lord of birds."

Chapter 12

The Snakes' Council

"Son of the suta," said Shaunaka, "you have told us why the snakes were cursed by their mother, and why Vinata was cursed by her son. You have told us of the boons their husband gave Kadru and Vinata, and the names of the two birds, Vinata's sons. But you do not tell us the names of the snakes. We want to hear their names, at least of the chief among them."

"There are so many snakes, ascetic," said the bard, "that I will not tell the names of them all. But hear me name the chief of them."

"Shesha was born first, and after him Vasuki. Then Airavata and Takshaka, Karkotaka and Dhananjaya, Kaliya and Maninaga, and the naga Apurana. Then the naga Pinjaraka, Elapatra and Vamana, the two nagas Nila and Anila, Kalmasha and Shabala, Aryaka and Adika, and the naga Shalapotaka. Sumanomukha, Dadhimukha and Vimalapindaka, Apta and Kotanaka, Shankha and Valashikha. Nishthyunaka and Hemaguha, Nahusha and Pingala, Bahyakarna and Hastipada, and Mudgarapindaka. Kambala and Ashvatara, and the naga Kaliyaka, the two nagas Vritta and Samvartaka, and the two known as Padma."

"The naga Shankhanaka, and Sphandaka too, the great naga Kshemaka and the naga Pindaraka. Karavira, Pushpadamshttra, Elaka and Bilvapanduka, Mushakada and Shankhashiras, Purnadamshttra and Haridraka. Aparajita and Jyotika, and the serpent Shrivaha, Kauravya and Dhritarashtra, Pushkara and Shalyaka. Virajas and Subahu and mighty Shalipinda, Hastibhadra and Pitharaka, Mukhara and Konavasana. Kunjara and Kurara, and the naga Prabhakara, Kumuda and Kumudaksha, Tittiri and Halika, the two called Karkara and Akarkara, and Kundodara and Mahodara."

"These are the chief nagas, best of brahmins, that I have named. There are too many names to tell the others. Their children, and their children's children, are past counting, I think, and so I do not tell them, best of brahmins. There are many thousands of snakes here, and millions, and hundreds of millions, ascetic. No one could count them."

"My friend," said Shaunaka, "the snakes had been born, mighty and dangerous. When they learned of the curse, what did they do then?"

"Among them," said the bard, "the blessed Shesha, whose fame was great, left Kadru and took up vast austerities. He lived on air and kept strict vows. He went to Gandhamadana, and to Badari, given to austerity, to Gokarna, to the Pushkara forest and to the slopes of the Himalaya. At all these holy fords and shrines, he lived alone and held himself in check, always master of his senses."

"The Grandfather saw him practising fierce austerity, the lord Shesha, with matted hair and clothes of bark, his flesh, skin and sinews dried up. And the Grandfather said to him, who was steadfast and true, as he practised his austerity, 'What are you doing, Shesha? Do what is good for the creatures of the world. By your harsh austerity, sinless one, you are tormenting all creatures. Tell me, Shesha, the wish that has been in your heart so long.'

"'All my brothers, born of the same mother, are dull of mind,' said Shesha. 'I cannot bear to live with them. Please allow me this. They are always jealous of one another,

like enemies. That is why I practise austerity, so that I will not have to see them. They never stop resenting Vinata and her sons. And Vinata's son, Grandfather, is another brother of ours. They hate him bitterly, and he is very strong, by the boon of our father, the great Kashyapa. So I have taken up austerity, and I will leave this body. How can I keep from meeting them, even after death?'

""Shesha,' said Brahma, 'I know how all your brothers behave. And I know that your brothers are in great danger, because of what they did against their mother. But a remedy for it was made here long ago, snake. You should not grieve for all your brothers. Choose a boon from me, Shesha, whatever you want. I want to give you a boon today, for I am very pleased with you. It is good fortune that your mind is set on dharma, best of the snakes. So let your mind stand firmer still in dharma.'

""This is the only boon I want today, great-grandfather,' said Shesha. 'Let my mind delight in dharma, in peace and in austerity, lord.'

""I am pleased with you, Shesha, for this self-control and this calm,' said Brahma. 'But at my command you must do something for the good of the creatures. This earth, with its mountains and forests, its seas, its mines and its towns, is unsteady and moves. Hold it rightly, Shesha, all of it, and stand so that it is still.'

""As the god, the giver of boons, the lord of creatures, the lord of the earth, the lord of beings and the lord of the world, has said,' said Shesha, 'so I will hold the earth, and hold it still. Place it on my head, lord of creatures.'

""Go down beneath the earth, best of snakes,' said Brahma. 'The earth herself will open a way for you. By holding up this earth, Shesha, you will do a great thing that is dear to me.'

"Shesha said, 'So be it,' and he went into the opening, the lord, the eldest brother of the best of snakes. And there he stays, and he holds on his head this goddess, the earth, gripping her on every side, with the ocean for her rim.

""You are Shesha, best of nagas,' said Brahma, 'the god of dharma, for you alone hold up this earth. With your endless coils you grip all of it, as I do, or as Indra does.'

"So the mighty naga Ananta lives beneath the earth, holding the world alone by the command of Brahma, the all-pervading one. And the blessed Grandfather, the best of the immortals, gave Ananta Suparna, the son of Vinata, as his friend.

"When Vasuki, the best of the snakes, heard of the curse from his mother, he thought, How can this curse be undone? Then he took counsel with all his brothers, Airavata and the others, who were devoted to dharma.

""You know this curse, sinless ones, just as it was spoken,' said Vasuki. 'Let us take counsel and try to find release from it. There is a way to turn back every curse there is. But for those cursed by their mother there is no release, snakes. We were cursed in front of the Imperishable, the Immeasurable, the True. When I hear that, my heart trembles. Surely total destruction has been declared for us, for that imperishable god did not stop her when she cursed us. So let us take counsel here, so that all the snakes may be safe. Let us not let the time slip by. If we take counsel, we may find a way to be free, as the gods long ago found Agni when he was lost and hidden in a cave. Let us

find a way so that Janamejaya's sacrifice, meant to destroy the snakes, may not happen, or may fail.'

"So be it,' said all of Kadru's sons, and they gathered there, skilled in counsel and in judgement, and they talked it over.

"Some of the nagas said, 'Let us become bulls among brahmins, and beg Janamejaya, "Do not hold your sacrifice."

"Other nagas, who thought themselves wise, said, 'Let us all become his ministers, and win his respect. He will ask us our advice in all matters of state, and we will give him counsel so that the sacrifice is stopped. The king, the wisest of the wise, will know how highly we are regarded, and he will surely ask us about the sacrifice. We will say "No!" We will show him the many terrible evils it would bring, in the next world and in this one, with reasons and causes, so that the sacrifice does not take place.

"Or else, whoever is to be the teacher at that rite, one who knows the rules of the snake sacrifice and is devoted to the king's affairs, let some snake go and bite him, and he will die. When the man who performs the sacrifice is killed, the rite will not take place. And we will bite all the others who know the snake sacrifice and would be his priests. That will be the end of it.'

"Then other snakes, who were righteous, said, 'This is folly. Killing brahmins is not good. In a disaster, the best peace is the one rooted wholly in true dharma. More and more adharma would destroy the whole world.'

"Other nagas said, 'We will become clouds, with lightning in them, and put out the blazing sacrificial fire with rain.'

"Or,' said other great snakes, 'let us go at night and quickly steal the ladles and vessels while they are off their guard. That will hinder it. Or let the snakes bite all the people at that sacrifice, by hundreds and by thousands. That will terrify them. Or let the snakes spoil the food that has been prepared, with their own urine and dung, which ruins all food.'

"Others said, 'Let us become his priests, and hinder the sacrifice by saying, "Give us our fee." Then he will be in our power, and he will do what we want.'

"Others said, 'When the king is playing in the water, we will carry him off to our home and tie him up. Then the rite will not take place.'

"And other nagas, who thought they were doing good, said, 'We will seize him and bite him quickly. That will be the end of it. When he is dead, the root of all our troubles will be cut away. This is the final plan, agreed by all of us. Or, king, whatever you think best, let it be done quickly.'

"When they had said this, they looked at Vasuki, the lord of the snakes. And Vasuki thought it over and said to the snakes, 'This final plan of yours cannot be carried out, snakes. None of your plans pleases me, not one of them. But what should be done here, for your good? It troubles me deeply, for the credit and the blame will both fall on me.'

"When he had heard all of them, saying this and that, and heard Vasuki's words, Elapatra spoke.

"That sacrifice cannot fail to happen. And Janamejaya of Pandu's line, from whom our great danger comes, is not the kind of king these plans imagine. When a man here is struck down by fate, king, he must take refuge in fate alone. There is no other refuge. This danger of ours, best of snakes, comes from fate. So let us take refuge in fate here. Now listen to what I have to say.

"When the curse was spoken, best of snakes, I climbed into my mother's lap in fear, and I heard what the gods said. They went to the Grandfather in their distress, great lord, and cried, "Cruel! Cruel!"

"What woman who has been given dear sons would curse them like this, Grandfather, except cruel Kadru, and in front of you, god of gods? And you too said 'So be it' to her words, Grandfather. We want to know why you did not stop her."

"There are many snakes," said Brahma, "cruel, of terrible strength, full of poison. I wished the creatures of the world well, and so I did not stop her then. Those that are biters, and mean, and do evil, and are full of poison, will be destroyed. But those that follow dharma will not. And hear how the snakes will be set free from that great danger when the time comes. In the family of the Yayavaras there will be a wise great seer called Jaratkaru, full of power and master of his senses. That Jaratkaru will have a son, a great ascetic named Astika. He will stop that sacrifice then, and the snakes who are righteous will be set free there."

"That best of sages, god," asked the gods, "the great ascetic Jaratkaru, so full of power: on whom will he father his great son?"

"On a girl of his own name, gods," said Brahma. "That best of brahmins, full of power, will have a child full of power by a girl with the same name as his own."

"So be it," the gods said to the Grandfather. When they had said this, the gods went away, and so did the god, the Grandfather.

"So this is what I see, Vasuki. Your sister is called Jaratkaru. Give her to that seer of good vows, when he begs for her as alms, to put an end to the nagas' fear. This is the release I heard.'

"When the nagas heard Elapatra's words, best of brahmins, they were all delighted, and they honoured him, crying, 'Good! Good!' From then on, Vasuki guarded that girl, his sister Jaratkaru, and he was full of joy.

"Then, when no great time seemed to have gone by, all the gods and asuras churned the home of Varuna, the ocean. The naga Vasuki, the strongest of the strong, was the rope. When they had finished that work, the gods went to the Grandfather, with Vasuki, and said, 'Blessed one, Vasuki is suffering terribly, for he is afraid of the curse. You must pull out this thorn from his heart, god, this thorn born of his mother's curse. He wishes his kin well. The king of the nagas has always been our friend, and he does what pleases us. Be gracious to him, lord of the gods. Calm the fever in his mind.'

"It was I who put it in his mind, immortals,' said Brahma, 'what the naga Elapatra said

to him before. Let the king of the nagas do as he was told, when the time comes. The wicked will perish, but not those who follow dharma. That Jaratkaru has been born, a brahmin given to fierce austerity. At the right time, let Vasuki give him his sister Jaratkaru. What the snake Elapatra said then is for the good of the snakes, gods. So it is, and not otherwise.'

"When the king of the nagas heard the Grandfather's words, he set many snakes to watch Jaratkaru, always on the alert. 'When the lord Jaratkaru wishes to choose a wife,' he told them, 'come quickly and tell me. That will be for our good.'"

Chapter 13

The Dead Snake

"Son of the suta," said Shaunaka, "you spoke of Jaratkaru. I want to hear about that great seer. Why is Jaratkaru the name he is known by on earth? Tell me the true meaning of the name Jaratkaru."

"Jara, they say, means wasting," said the bard, "and karu means something huge and terrible. His body was karu, huge, and the wise man wasted it away, little by little, by his fierce austerity. That is why he is called Jaratkaru, brahmin. And the same is true of Vasuki's sister."

When he heard this, righteous Shaunaka laughed and said to Ugrashravas, "That fits."

"After a long time," the bard went on, "that sage of strict vows, wise and devoted to austerity, still had no wish for a wife. Chaste, given wholly to austerity and to study, free of fear and weariness, the great man wandered over the whole earth, and he did not want a wife, not even in thought.

"Then, at another time, there was a king named Parikshit, who carried on the line of the Kauravas. Like his great-grandfather long ago, the strong-armed Pandu, the finest bowman on earth, he loved to hunt. The lord of the earth roamed about, shooting deer and boar, hyenas and buffaloes, and all kinds of other wild creatures.

"Once he shot a deer with a straight arrow, and with his bow in his hand he followed it into the thick forest, as the blessed Rudra once shot the deer of the sacrifice in heaven and followed it, bow in hand, searching for it everywhere. No deer he shot ever got away into the forest alive. So the loss of the deer that King Parikshit shot must have been a sign, surely, of his going to heaven.

"The deer led the lord of the earth far away, and he grew tired and thirsty. In the forest he came upon a sage, sitting among the pastures of the cows. The sage lived mostly on the foam that runs from the mouths of the calves as they drink their milk. The king, weary and hungry, rushed up to that sage of strict vows and raised his bow and asked him, 'Ho there, brahmin! I am King Parikshit, the son of Abhimanyu. I shot a deer, and it is lost. Have you seen it?'

"The sage did not answer him at all, for he was keeping a vow of silence. The king grew angry, and with the tip of his bow he lifted a dead snake and laid it on the sage's shoulder. Then he looked at him. And the sage said nothing to him, good or bad.

"The king let his anger go. He was troubled to see him like that, and he went back to his city. But the seer stayed just as he was.

"The sage had a son, a young man, fierce in his power, a great ascetic, named Shringin. He was quick to anger and hard to calm, and he kept great vows. From time to time, with his senses well controlled, he went to wait upon the god Brahma, the supreme lord, who delights in the good of all beings. And with Brahma's leave he had come home.

"There a friend of his, the son of a seer, named Krisha, was playing and laughing, so they say, and he teased him, the seer's son who was so hot-tempered and so quick to anger, like poison. 'Your father is full of power, and full of austerity. And yet he

carries a corpse on his shoulder. Do not be so proud, Shringin. When seers' sons like us are talking, perfected ones who know Brahman, and ascetics, you are not to say a word. Where is your manly pride now, and your proud words, when you see your father carrying a corpse like that?'

"When he heard this, the fierce Shringin was filled with anger. When he heard that his teacher and father was carrying a dead thing, he burned with rage. He looked at Krishna, and speaking plainly, he asked, 'How is my father carrying a dead thing today?'

"'King Parikshit, running about on a hunt, my friend,' said Krishna, 'hung a dead snake on your father's shoulder today.'

"'What harm did my father do that wicked king?' said Shringin. 'Tell me the truth, Krishna, and see the power of my austerity.'

"'King Parikshit, the son of Abhimanyu, went hunting,' said Krishna. 'He shot a deer with a feathered arrow and followed it alone. The king could not find the deer as he went through that great forest. Then he saw your father, and asked him, but your father did not answer. The king was weary with hunger and thirst and toil, and he asked your father again and again about the lost deer, while your father stood there like a post. Your father keeps a vow of silence, and he did not answer him at all. So the king put a snake on his shoulder with the tip of his bow. Your father, Shringin, is still sitting there now, keeping his vow. And the king has gone back to his own city, Hastinapura, the City of the Elephant.'

"When the seer's son heard this, he stood rigid, as if he were holding up the sky. His eyes were red with anger, and he blazed with fury. Overcome with rage, full of power, driven by the force of his anger, he touched water and cursed the king.

"'That wicked king has put a dead snake on the shoulder of my old father, who is in such hardship. He is a sin against kingship, a despiser of brahmins, a disgrace to the Kurus. Within seven nights, driven by the power of my word, the best of snakes, Takshaka, blazing, with venom in his fangs, will be furious with him, and will take that wicked man to the house of Yama.'

"When he had cursed the king in his anger, Shringin went to his father, who was still sitting in the pasture, carrying the dead snake. When Shringin saw his father with the dead snake on his shoulder, his anger rose again. He wept tears of pain, and he said to his father, 'Father, when I heard how that wicked King Parikshit insulted you, I cursed him in my anger, as that lowest of the Kurus deserves: a terrible curse. On the seventh day Takshaka, the best of snakes, will take that wicked man to the house of Death, a place of dread.'

"His father spoke to him, brahmin, as he stood there full of anger. 'What you have done, my son, does not please me. This is not the dharma of ascetics. We live in that king's country, and he protects us justly. I take no pleasure in harm to him. People like us must always be patient with a king, my son, whatever he does. For dharma, when it is struck, strikes back. There is no doubt of it.

"'If the king did not protect us, we would suffer terribly. We could not practise our dharma as we please, my son. We are protected, my son, by kings who see by the light of the teachings, and so we practise dharma in plenty, and by dharma a share of it belongs

to them. And Parikshit protects us above all, as his great-grandfather did, protecting his subjects as a king should. He did this today because he was hungry and tired and wretched, and he did not know of my vow. There is no doubt of it. So what you have done so rashly, out of childishness, is a wrong. The king in no way deserves a curse from us, my son.'

"Whether this was rash, father,' said Shringin, 'or whether it was wrong, whether it pleases you or not, what I have said will not prove false. It will not happen any other way, father. I tell you so. I do not speak falsely even in jest. How could I when I curse?'

"I know your power is fierce, my son,' said his father, 'and your words are true. You have never spoken a lie before, and this will not be false. A father must always guide his son, even a grown one, so that he may gain virtue and win great fame. How much more you, who are only a boy, made mighty by austerity, my lord! The anger of great souls who have power grows very great. So I see that I must speak to you, best of those who uphold dharma, seeing that you are my son, and a boy, and rash.

"Be calm, and live on the food of the forest, and give up this anger. Then you will not lose your dharma. For anger steals away the dharma that ascetics have gathered with pain, and those who have lost their dharma do not reach the goal they long for. Calm alone brings success to ascetics who forgive. This world belongs to those who forgive, and the next world too. So always live forgiving, master of your senses. By forgiveness you will win the worlds that lie next to Brahma's.

"As for me, I will keep my calm, and do what can be done today, my son. I will send word to the king: "You have been cursed by my son, a boy whose mind is not yet formed, who could not bear to see how you insulted me, king."

"So the great ascetic of good vows, full of pity, gave his instructions and sent a pupil to King Parikshit. He sent a pupil named Gauramukha, of good character and steady mind, to ask after the king's welfare and to tell him what had happened.

"Gauramukha went quickly to the king who was the pride of the Kurus. He was announced by the doorkeepers, and he entered the king's palace. The king received the brahmin Gauramukha with honour, and when he had rested, he told the king everything, in the presence of the ministers, just as Shamika had said it: terrible words.

"There is a seer named Shamika living in your country, king of kings, deeply righteous, self-controlled, calm, a great ascetic. You hung on his shoulder, tiger among men, with the tip of your bow, a snake that you had robbed of life, best of the Bharatas. He forgave you for what you did. But his son did not. Today, without his father's knowledge, he cursed you, king of kings: in seven nights Takshaka will be your death. Shamika told me again and again, "Tell him to protect himself." Nothing anyone can do will change it, for he cannot restrain his son in his anger. So he has sent me, king, for he wishes you well.'

"When the king, the joy of the Kurus, heard those terrible words, he was stricken with remorse for the wrong he had done, that king of great austerity. When he heard that the great sage had been keeping a vow of silence, he was still more tormented with grief. When he understood how compassionate Shamika was, he grieved even more for the wrong he had done the sage. The king, who was like an immortal, did not grieve so much to hear of

his own death as he grieved for having done that deed.

"Then the king sent Gauramukha back, saying, 'Let the blessed one be gracious to me again.' As soon as Gauramukha had gone, the king, his mind in turmoil, took counsel with his ministers. The king, who knew the heart of counsel, made up his mind with his ministers, and had a palace built on a single pillar, well guarded. He set guards there, and physicians with their medicines, and brahmins who had mastered their mantras, all around it. And from there, guarded on every side, he did all the business of the kingdom with his ministers, for he knew dharma.

"When the seventh day came, best of brahmins, a learned man named Kashyapa set out to heal the king. He had heard that on that day Takshaka, the best of snakes, would take the best of kings to the house of Yama. *When the king of snakes has bitten him, I will cure him of the poison, he thought. That will bring me both wealth and dharma.*

"Takshaka, the king of snakes, saw Kashyapa on the road, going on with his mind set on one thing, and he took the form of an old brahmin. The king of snakes said to Kashyapa, that bull among sages, 'Where are you going in such a hurry? What do you mean to do?'

"'Today,' said Kashyapa, 'Takshaka, the best of snakes, will burn up with his fire King Parikshit of the Kuru line, the tamer of enemies. When the king of snakes, whose fire is like the fire of Agni, has bitten that king of boundless power, who carries on the line of the Pandavas, I am going quickly, my friend, to cure him of the poison at once.'

"'I am that Takshaka, brahmin,' said Takshaka. 'I will burn that lord of the earth. Turn back. You cannot cure one whom I have bitten.'

"'I will cure that king of the poison when you have bitten him, snake,' said Kashyapa. 'That is my belief. I rely on the power of my learning.'

"'If you can cure anything I bite,' said Takshaka, 'then bring this tree back to life, Kashyapa, when I have bitten it. Show me the highest power of your mantras, and do your best. I will burn this banyan tree while you watch, best of brahmins.'

"'Bite the tree, king of snakes, whichever tree you like,' said Kashyapa. 'I will bring it back to life when you have bitten it, snake.'

"When the great Kashyapa said this, the king of snakes, the best of serpents, went up to a banyan tree and bit it. As soon as he bit it, the tree, full of the serpent's venom, blazed up on every side. When the snake had burned the tree, he said to Kashyapa again, 'Do your best, best of brahmins. Bring this lord of the forest back to life.'

"The tree was nothing but ash, burned by the fire of the king of snakes. Kashyapa gathered up all the ash and said, 'See the power of my learning in this lord of the forest, king of snakes. I will bring it back to life while you watch, snake.'

"Then the blessed and learned Kashyapa, best of brahmins, brought back to life by his learning the tree that had become a heap of ash. He made it a shoot with two leaves, and then he made it leafy, with branches, and at last a great spreading tree again.

"When Takshaka saw the tree brought back to life by the great Kashyapa, he said, 'This is a great wonder in you, brahmin, lord of brahmins, since you could destroy my poison,

or the poison of one like me. What is it you want, rich in austerity, that you are going there for? Whatever reward you hope to win from that best of kings, I will give it to you myself, however hard it is to come by. The king has been overcome by a brahmin's curse, and his life is spent. You might strive for him, brahmin, and still not succeed. Then your blazing fame, known in the three worlds, would vanish from here like the sun without its rays.'

"'I am going there for wealth,' said Kashyapa. 'Give it to me, snake, and I will turn back home, best of serpents.'

"'As much wealth as you would ask of that king,' said Takshaka, 'I will give you more, today. Turn back, best of brahmins.'

"When he heard Takshaka's words, wise Kashyapa, best of brahmins, of great power, turned his thoughts to the king. With his heavenly knowledge, the powerful Kashyapa knew that the Pandava king's life was spent. So the best of sages turned back, when he had received from Takshaka as much wealth as he wished.

"When the great Kashyapa had turned back by agreement, Takshaka went quickly to the city named for the elephant. On the way, Takshaka heard that the lord of the world was being carefully guarded with mantras and with antidotes that take away poison. He thought, *I must deceive the king by the power of illusion. How can it be done?*

"Then Takshaka, the naga, sent snakes to the king in the form of ascetics, carrying fruit and leaves and water. 'Go to the king,' said Takshaka, 'calmly, as if on some business, and have the king accept the fruit and the leaves and the water.'

"The snakes did as Takshaka told them. They brought the king darbha grass and water and fruits. The mighty king of kings accepted them all, and when he had done what they needed, he told them, 'You may go.'

"When those nagas in the guise of ascetics had gone, the lord of men said to his ministers and his friends, 'Eat these sweet fruits that the ascetics have brought, all of you, with me.'

"Then the king and his ministers went to take the fruits. In the fruit the king took there was a worm, a tiny one, short, with black eyes, and the colour of copper, Shaunaka. The best of kings held it up and said to his ministers, 'The sun is setting. I have no fear of poison today. Let the sage's word come true. Let this little worm become Takshaka and bite me. That will settle it.'

"His ministers agreed with him, driven by Time. When the king of kings had said this, he put the little worm on his neck, and laughed at once. He was about to die, and his senses had left him. And while he was still laughing, Takshaka, who had come out of the fruit that had been given to the king, wrapped him in his coils.

"When the ministers saw him wrapped in the coils like that, their faces went pale, and they all wept, in great sorrow. At that cry, the ministers ran. They saw the wonderful naga going through the sky, bright as a lotus, as if he were drawing a parting through the hair of the sky: Takshaka, the best of snakes. They were stricken with grief. The house was wrapped in fire that blazed up from the serpent's poison. In fear they left it and fled in all directions, and it fell as if struck by lightning.

"When the king had been killed by Takshaka's fire, the pure brahmin who was the king's family priest, and the king's ministers, performed all the rites for his life in the next world. Then all the people of the city gathered, and they made his son king, though he was only a child: the one people call Janamejaya, slayer of his enemies, the hero of the Kurus.

"Though he was a boy, that best of kings had a noble mind. The eldest of the bulls of the Kurus ruled the kingdom with those ministers and priests, as his heroic great-grandfather had done.

"Then the king's ministers saw that their king, the scorcher of enemies, had grown. They went to Suvarnavarman, the king of Kashi, and asked for Vapushtama as his bride. The king of Kashi tested the hero of the Kurus by dharma, and gave him Vapushtama. And he was full of joy when he had won her, and he never set his heart on any other woman. With a happy mind, the mighty king roamed among lakes and flowering forests. The best of kings took his pleasure with her, as Pururavas once did when he had won Urvashi. And Vapushtama, the lovely lady of the inner palace, had won a fine husband, a lord of the earth, handsome to look at, and in the times of pleasure she delighted him with her love."

Chapter 14

The Wife Who Woke Him

"At this very time," said the bard, "the great ascetic Jaratkaru was wandering over the whole earth, a sage who made his home wherever evening found him. Mighty in his power, he kept a vow that is hard for those who have not mastered themselves, and he wandered from one holy ford to another, bathing in each. He lived on air and ate nothing, and day by day he wasted away.

"And he saw his forefathers hanging head down in a pit. They were clinging to a clump of virana grass that had only one root left, and a rat that lived in a hole was slowly gnawing at that root. They had nothing to eat. They were thin and wretched, suffering in the pit, and they longed for someone to save them. He went up to them, wretched himself, and spoke to those wretched ones.

"Who are you, hanging here, clinging to this clump of virana grass? It is weak, for the rat that lives in the hole has eaten its roots. The one root that is left in this clump of virana, the rat is gnawing slowly away with his sharp teeth. There is so little of it left that it will soon be cut through, and then you will fall head first into this pit. It pains me to see you hanging head down, in such terrible danger. What can I do for you that you would like? Tell me quickly: can you be saved from this danger by a quarter of my austerity, or a third, or a half? Or let all of you be saved by the whole of my austerity. Let it be as you wish.'

"You are rich in austerity, celibate one,' said the forefathers, 'since you want to save us here. But this cannot be taken away by austerity, best of brahmins. We have the fruit of austerity, my son, best of speakers. It is because our line is dying out, brahmin, that we are falling into a foul hell. Hanging here, my son, our minds are dim, and so we do not know you, though you are famous in the world for your manhood. You are rich and blessed, since you come and pity us, who are so wretched and deserve pity. Listen, brahmin, to who we are.

"We are seers of strict vows, called the Yayavaras. Because our line is dying out, lord, we have fallen here from a holy world. Our austerity and our merit are lost, for we have no thread of descendants. We have one thread left today, but it is as good as none. They say he is a kinsman in our family, that unlucky son of unlucky fathers. He is known as Jaratkaru. He knows the Vedas and their limbs through and through. He is self-controlled and great-souled, of good vows and great austerity. Because of his greed for austerity, we have been brought to this misery. He has no wife, no son and no kin at all. So we hang in this pit, our senses gone, as if we had no protector.

"If you see him, speak to him, and be our protector. Tell him, 'Your forefathers are hanging head down in a pit, in misery. Take a wife, good sir, and have children, lord. You are the only thread of our family left, you who are rich in austerity.'

"This clump of virana grass that you see us clinging to, brahmin, was our family's clump. It made our family grow. The roots of this plant that you see here, brahmin, are our threads, my son, which Time has eaten away. This root that you see half-eaten, brahmin, from which we all hang, is the one who has taken up austerity. The rat you see, brahmin, is Time, of great strength. Slowly it is gnawing away and wasting that foolish one who delights in austerity, Jaratkaru, greedy for austerity, dull and thoughtless.

"His austerity will not save us, best of the good. See us, our roots cut, fallen, our minds struck by Time, bound for hell, as if we were wrongdoers. And when we have fallen here, with our forefathers before us, he too will be cut off by Time, and go to hell after us. Austerity or sacrifice, or any other great means of purifying, none of it is equal to having descendants, my son. That is the view of the good. So, my son, if you see the ascetic Jaratkaru, tell him. Tell him all of this, just as you have seen it. So that he takes a wife and has sons, you must speak to him, brahmin, as our protector.'

"When he heard this, Jaratkaru was overcome with pain and grief. He spoke to his forefathers in his sorrow, his voice choked with tears.

"I am Jaratkaru. I am your son, and the sinner. Punish me, for I have done wrong and I have not mastered myself.'

"Son,' said the forefathers, 'it is good fortune that chance has brought you to this place. Why have you not taken a wife, brahmin?'

"Forefathers,' said Jaratkaru, 'this purpose has always been turning in my heart: that I would carry this body to the next world without ever spilling my seed. But now I have seen you hanging like birds, grandfathers, I have turned my mind from the celibate life. I will do what you wish, and I will marry. There is no doubt of it. That is, if I ever find a girl with my own name, one who is offered to me of her own accord, like alms, and one whom I do not have to support. I will take her. If I can find a marriage like that, I will make it. Otherwise I will not. That is the truth, grandfathers.'

"When he had said this to his forefathers, the sage wandered the earth. And he found no wife, Shaunaka, for people thought, He is old.

"When he fell into despair, and his forefathers still urged him on, he went into the forest and cried aloud in great sorrow.

"Let all the creatures that are here, moving and unmoving, and those that are hidden, hear what I say. My forefathers, in their pain and misery, are urging me on, as I practise fierce austerity: "Marry!" To do what pleases them, I wander the whole earth wanting a wife, begging for a girl as alms. I am poor, and my life is hard, and my forefathers have commanded me. Whichever of the creatures I have named has a daughter, let them give me the girl, as I wander in every direction. A girl with my own name, offered like alms, whom I will not have to support: give me that girl.'

"Then the snakes who had been set to watch Jaratkaru took the news and told Vasuki. When he heard them, the king of the nagas took that girl, finely adorned, and went into the forest, close to where he was. There the king of the nagas, Vasuki, offered the girl to that great man as alms, brahmin. But he did not accept her. He thought she did not have his name, and the question of her keep was not settled. He was set on release, and he was of two minds about taking a wife. So he asked the girl's name, joy of the Bhrigus, and he said, 'Vasuki, I will not support her.'

"Then Vasuki said to the seer Jaratkaru, 'This girl has your name. She is my sister, and she is devoted to austerity. I will support your wife. Take her, best of brahmins. And I will protect her with all my strength, rich in austerity.'

"When the naga had promised, 'I will support my sister,' Jaratkaru went to the serpent's

house. There the best of those who know the mantras, grown great in austerity, of great vows, righteous, took her hand, with the rites and the mantras before him. Then, praised by the great seers, he took his wife to a bright chamber, which the king of the snakes had approved. A bed had been made ready there, covered with fine spreads, and there Jaratkaru lived with his wife.

"There the good man made an agreement with his wife. 'You must never do anything that displeases me, or say anything that displeases me. If you do anything displeasing, I will leave you, and I will leave my home in your house. Take these words to heart, as I have said them.'

"Then the snake king's sister, deeply anxious and in great distress, said to him, 'So be it.' And so the famous woman waited on her husband, whose ways were so hard, wanting only to please him, with the watchful care of the white crow.

"Then one day, at her season, Vasuki's sister bathed and went to her husband, the great sage, as was right. And a child was conceived in her, like a blazing fire, full of austerity, as bright as the fire that belongs to all men. It grew like the moon in the bright half of the month.

"A few days later, the great ascetic Jaratkaru laid his head in her lap and fell asleep, as if he were worn out. While that lord of brahmins slept, the sun went towards the western mountain, as the day came to an end, brahmin. Then Vasuki's sister, a woman of spirit, grew afraid that her husband would fail in his dharma, and she thought, *What should I do? Is it right to wake my husband, or not? His ways are hard, and he is righteous. How can I keep from offending him? It is either the anger of a righteous man, or his failure in dharma. Failure in dharma is the heavier. So she made up her mind. If I wake him, he will surely be angry. But if the time of twilight passes, he will surely fail in his dharma.*

"When she had settled this in her mind, the snake woman Jaratkaru, who spoke sweetly, said gently to the seer, who lay asleep, blazing with austerity, like fire, 'Rise, blessed one. The sun is setting. Say your evening prayers, lord. Touch water, you who keep your vows. This is the hour, lovely and dreadful, when the fire offerings are lit, and the twilight is coming on in the west, my lord.'

"When she said this, the blessed Jaratkaru, the great ascetic, said to his wife, his lips trembling, 'You have insulted me, snake woman. I will not live with you. I will go the way I came. I am sure in my heart, fair one, that the sun has no power to set at its proper time while I am asleep. No one would want to live where he has been insulted, let alone a righteous man like me, or one like me.'

"When her husband said this, words that made her heart shake, Jaratkaru, Vasuki's sister, said there in her home, 'I did not wake you to insult you. I did it so that you would not fail in your dharma, brahmin.'

"When she said this, the great ascetic Jaratkaru, the seer, spoke to his wife, full of anger and wanting to leave the snake woman. 'My words have never spoken a lie. I will go, snake woman. This was the agreement you and I made between us before. I have lived here happily, dear one. Tell your brother, lovely one, when I have gone from here, timid one, "The blessed one has gone." And you must not grieve when I have left.'

"When he said this, the faultless woman, Jaratkaru, answered her husband Jaratkaru. She was lost in worry and sorrow. Her voice was choked with tears and her mouth was dry. She joined her palms, the lovely woman, and her eyes were full of tears. Her heart was shaking, but she held herself steady.

"You know dharma. You should not leave me, for I have done no wrong. I keep to dharma, as you do, and I have always delighted in pleasing you and doing you good. The reason I was given to you, best of brahmins, has not yet come about. What will Vasuki say to me, poor unlucky woman that I am? My kin are overcome by their mother's curse, good sir. They wanted a child from you, and there is no sign of it yet. If I could have a child by you, my kin would be safe. Let this union of mine with you not be in vain, brahmin. I want only the good of my kin, and I beg you, blessed one, be gracious. You have planted this child in me, though its form cannot be seen yet. How can a great soul like you want to leave me, when I have done no wrong?"

"When she said this, the sage, the ascetic Jaratkaru, said to his wife words that were fitting. 'There is a child, fortunate one, in you, like the fire that belongs to all men. He will be a seer, deeply righteous, who knows the Vedas and their limbs through and through.'

"When he had said this, the righteous Jaratkaru, the great seer, went away again, his mind made up, to practise fierce austerity.

"As soon as her husband had gone, Jaratkaru went quickly to her brother and told him all that had happened, rich in austerity. Then the best of snakes heard this very unwelcome news, and he spoke to his wretched sister, more wretched himself.

"You know, good sister, what must be done, and why you were given. If a son were born to you from him, for the good of the snakes, then that mighty son, so they say, would free us from the snake sacrifice. The Grandfather told me so long ago, with the gods. Is there a child in you, fortunate one, from that best of sages? I do not want that wise man's marriage to be without fruit. It is not right for me to ask you such a thing, I know. But the matter is so grave that I have pressed you. I know how hard your husband is to live with, and how great his austerity, so I will not go after him. He might curse me. Tell me everything your husband did, good sister. Pull out this terrible thorn that has been in my heart so long.'

"When he said this, Jaratkaru answered, comforting Vasuki, the lord of the snakes, in his distress.

"I asked that great-souled, great ascetic for a child. He pointed to my womb and said, 'There is,' and then he went. I do not remember him ever saying anything false before, even in jest. How could he now, king, at such a time? He said, 'Do not worry about what has to be done, snake woman. A son will be born to you, bright as fire and the sun.' When he had said this to me, brother, my husband went to the ascetics' forest. So let this great sorrow that sits in your heart go away.'

"When he heard this, Vasuki, the king of the nagas, was filled with great joy, and he accepted his sister's words, saying, 'So be it.' And the best of snakes honoured his own sister, born of the same mother, with kind words and respect and gifts of wealth, and with the honour that was due to her.

"Then the child grew, with great power, shining like the sun, best of brahmins, like the moon rising in the sky in the bright half of the month. In time, the snake's sister gave birth, brahmin, to a boy who shone like a child of the gods, and he took away the fear of both his father's family and his mother's. He grew up there, in the house of the king of the nagas, and he learned the Vedas and their limbs from the Bhargava, Chyavana's son. He kept his vows while he was still a boy, and he was gifted with wisdom and goodness and every virtue. His name became famous in the worlds: Astika. His father had said, 'There is,' asti, and gone to the forest while he was still in the womb. So he was known by the name Astika.

"Though he was only a boy, his wisdom had no measure. As he lived there in the house of the king of the snakes, he was guarded with every care. Like the blessed lord of the gods, who holds the trident and gives gold, he grew, and he delighted all the snakes."

Chapter 15

The Snake Sacrifice

"Tell me again, in full," said Shaunaka, "what King Janamejaya asked his ministers about his father's going to heaven."

"Listen, brahmin," said the bard, "to how the king asked his ministers, and how they all told him of Parikshit's death."

"'You know how my father lived,' said Janamejaya, 'and how, when his time came, that famous man met his death. When I have heard from you the whole story of my father, I will choose what is good, and never the opposite.'"

"Then the ministers, who knew all of dharma, and were wise, answered King Janamejaya, the great-souled one who had asked them."

"'Your father was righteous and great-souled, a protector of his subjects. Hear how that great man lived here. He kept the four classes each in its own dharma, and guarded them. He knew dharma, and he ruled by dharma, like dharma in bodily form. Glorious and matchless in valour, he guarded the goddess, the earth. He had no enemies, and he hated no one. He was even-handed to all beings, like the lord of creatures. Brahmins, kshatriyas, vaishyas and shudras kept to their own work, content, king, well governed by that king."

"'He supported widows and orphans, the poor and the maimed. He was a joy to all creatures to look at, like a second moon. His people were content and well fed. He was glorious, true in his word, firm in his courage. The king learned the science of the bow from Sharadvata's son. And your father, Janamejaya, was dear to Govinda, and dear to the whole world, a man of great fame."

"'When the Kurus had been all but destroyed, he was born to Uttara. So he became Parikshit, "born when the line was wasted", the mighty son of Subhadra's son. The king was skilled in the dharma and the business of kings, and he had every virtue. He was master of his senses and of himself, wise, and he served his elders. He knew the six means of statecraft, and he had a great mind, the best of those who know policy and dharma. Your father protected these subjects for sixty years. Then he met his appointed end, from a snake, which no one can escape. Then you, best of men, received by dharma this kingdom, which has come down in the Kuru line for a thousand years. You were born of noble blood, and while you were still a child you became the protector of all beings.'"

"'There has never been a king in this family,' said Janamejaya, 'who did not work for his people's good and was not loved by them, especially when you look at the great conduct of my grandfathers, who were devoted to good conduct. How did my father, such a man, come to his death? Tell me as it happened. I want to hear the truth.'"

"When the king urged them like this, the ministers, who wanted only to please and serve him, told the lord of men all that had happened."

"'Your father, king, always loved to hunt, as the fortunate Pandu did, the finest bowman in battle. He left all the business of the kingdom to us. Once, roaming the forest, he shot a deer with a feathered arrow, and after he had shot it he followed the deer"

quickly into the thick forest, on foot, with his sword at his side and his quiver of weapons on his back. Your father could not find the lost deer in the thick forest.

""He was tired, and old. He was sixty, and age was upon him, and he was hungry. In the great forest he saw a sage nearby. The king of kings asked the sage, who was keeping a vow of silence. The sage said nothing to him, though he asked. Then the king, worn out with hunger and weariness, was suddenly overcome with anger at the calm sage, who was standing like a post, keeping his vow of silence. For the king did not know that the sage was keeping a vow of silence. In his anger, your father insulted him. He lifted a dead snake from the ground with the tip of his bow and laid it on the shoulder of that pure-hearted man, best of the Bharatas. The wise man said nothing to him, good or bad. He stood there just as he was, not angry, carrying the snake on his shoulder.'

""Then the king, faint with hunger, left the snake on the sage's shoulder, king of kings, and went back to his city. That seer had a son, born of a cow, named Shringin, of great fame and great power, fierce in his strength and very quick to anger. He had gone to Brahma and done him honour. When he was given leave and went home, Shringin heard from a friend how your father had insulted his father.

""He heard, tiger of the Kurus, that his father was carrying on his shoulder a dead snake that your father had hung on him, though he had done no harm. The sage was a great ascetic, king, the best of sages, master of his senses, pure, and engaged in wonderful works. His whole being shone with austerity, and every limb was under control. His conduct was good and his speech was good. He was steady, free of greed, not mean, not spiteful, old, keeping a vow of silence, a refuge to all creatures. And your father had wronged him.

""When the seer's son heard this, he cursed your father in his anger. He was only a boy, but he was greater than the elders, and full of power. Quickly he touched water, and in his rage, blazing as if with fire, he spoke these words at your father: "He who laid a dead snake on my teacher, who had done no wrong, the naga Takshaka will destroy in his fury with his fire, that wicked man, seven nights from now. See the power of my austerity!"

""When he had said this, he went to where his father was. And when he saw his father, he told him of the curse. And that tiger among sages sent word to your father: "You have been cursed by my son. Be on your guard, lord of the earth. Takshaka will destroy you with his fire, great king."

""When your father heard those terrible words, Janamejaya, he was on his guard, and he was very afraid of Takshaka, the best of snakes.

""Then, when the seventh day came, the brahmin seer Kashyapa wanted to go to the king. And Takshaka, the king of snakes, saw Kashyapa. The king of snakes said to Kashyapa, who was hurrying along, "Where are you going in such a hurry? What do you mean to do?"

""Where King Parikshit, the best of the Kurus, is going to be burned, they say, by the snake Takshaka, brahmin," said Kashyapa, "there I am going, quickly, to cure him of the poison at once. When I have come to him, no snake will harm him."

""Why do you want to bring him back to life when I have bitten him?" said Takshaka. "Tell me what you want, and I will give it to you today. Go back to your own home."

""I am going there because I want wealth," said Kashyapa. And Takshaka spoke to the great man gently, and honoured him: "As much wealth as you would ask from that king, take more from me, sinless one, and turn back."

""When the naga said this, Kashyapa, the best of men, received from Takshaka as much wealth as he wanted, and turned back. When the brahmin had gone back, Takshaka came in disguise, best of kings, to your righteous father, the king, who was on his guard in his palace, and burned him with the fire of his poison. Then you were consecrated for victory, tiger among men.

""What we have seen and heard, best of kings, we have told you truly, all of it, terrible as it is. Now that you have heard of the king's defeat, best of kings, do what must be done next for this seer Uttanka too.'

""I want to hear about this,' said Janamejaya, 'the talk between the king of snakes and Kashyapa, in a forest where no one lives. Who saw it and heard it, so that it came to your ears? When I have heard, I will set my mind on the destruction of the snakes.'

""Listen, king,' said the ministers, 'to how we were told long ago of the meeting on the road between the lord of brahmins and the king of snakes. Before they came, lord of the earth, a man looking for firewood had climbed that very tree, a lord of the forest with dry branches. The snake and the brahmin did not know that he was up in the tree. He was burned to ash along with the tree. By the brahmin's power, king of kings, he was brought back to life with the lord of the forest. He came to this city, best of kings, and told us everything that had happened between Takshaka and the brahmin. This is what we have told you, king, as it happened and as we heard it. Now that you have heard it, tiger among kings, do as you wish.'

""When King Janamejaya heard his ministers' words, he was filled with pain and sorrow, and he pressed his hands together, one against the other. The lotus-eyed king sighed long and hot, again and again, and tears ran from his eyes without stopping. And the lord of the earth, full of pain and grief, said, 'I have heard what you say about my father's going to heaven. Now hear what I have firmly decided.

""I think that vengeance must be taken at once on the wicked Takshaka, who killed my father. He carried out the word of the seer Shrigin, and burned the king. If that wicked one had only gone away, my father would surely be alive. What would it have cost him if the king had lived, by Kashyapa's grace and the good policy of his ministers? But in his folly he turned back the best of brahmins, Kashyapa, who had come to bring back to life the king who had never been defeated. This is a great crime of wicked Takshaka, that he gave the brahmin wealth so that he would not bring the king back to life. To please Uttanka, and to please myself greatly, and to please you all, I will take revenge for my father.'

""When he had said this, and his ministers had agreed, the glorious king made a vow to hold the snake sacrifice, brahmin, that tiger of the Bharatas, the son of Parikshit.

""Then the lord of the earth called his family priest and his ritual priests, and said to them, with well-chosen words, words that would bring his purpose about, 'Tell me how I can take revenge on wicked Takshaka, who killed my father. Do you know a rite by which I can bring the snake Takshaka, with his kin, into a blazing fire? As he burned my father

before with the fire of his poison, so I want to burn that wicked snake.'

"'There is a great sacrifice, king, that the gods made for you,' said the priests. 'It is called the snake sacrifice, and it is told of in the old lore, king. No one but you can hold that sacrifice, lord of men. So say those who know the old lore. And we know that rite.'

"When they said this, the royal seer believed that the snake Takshaka had as good as entered the blazing mouth of the fire, best of men. Then the king said to those brahmins, who knew the mantras, 'I will hold that sacrifice. Let the things for it be brought for me.'

"Then his priests, best of brahmins, measured out the ground for the place of sacrifice by the rules of the science. They knew the lore rightly, and all of them had gone far in wisdom. The place was richly furnished, pleasing, crowded with brahmins, full of wealth and grain, and well laid out by the priests. When they had built the place of sacrifice he wanted, by the rules, they consecrated the king for the snake sacrifice.

"But before the snake sacrifice took place, something happened there, a great sign that foretold a hindrance to the sacrifice. While the place of sacrifice was being built, a builder spoke, a wise man, skilled in the science of building. The master of the measuring cord, a suta who knew the old lore, said this: 'Because of the place and the time at which this measuring was begun, this rite will not be completed. A brahmin will be the cause.'

"When he heard this, the king, before his consecration, said to the doorkeeper, 'Let no one I do not know come in here.'

"Then the work of the snake sacrifice began, according to the rules, and the sacrificing priests moved about in due order, each at his own task. They wore black clothes, and their eyes were red from the smoke, and they poured offerings with mantras into the blazing fire. Making the hearts of all the serpents tremble, they called all the snakes there into the mouth of the fire.

"Then the snakes fell into the blazing fire, writhing and pitiful, calling to one another. Quivering and hissing, others twined themselves together, and they dropped head first and tail first into the bright fire. White ones, black ones and dark blue ones, old ones and young ones, they fell into the blazing fire, crying out with dreadful cries. So they perished helplessly, best of brahmins, hundreds of thousands of snakes, and millions, and hundreds of millions.

"Some there were like rats, others like the trunks of elephants, and others huge and mighty, like elephants mad in rut. Many, great and small, of many colours, full of poison, terrible, like iron clubs, mighty biters, the serpents fell into the fire, struck down by the rod of their mother's word."

Chapter 16

The Boy at the Gate

"At King Janamejaya's snake sacrifice," said Shaunaka, "the sacrifice of the wise Pandava king, who were the priests, the great seers? And who sat in the assembly at that most terrible snake sacrifice, which brought such despair and such great danger to the snakes? Tell me everything in full, my friend. Those who knew the rules of the snake sacrifice should be known, son of the suta."

"Then I will tell you," said the bard, "the names of the wise men who were that king's priests and the members of his assembly."

"The priest who called the gods was the brahmin Chandabhargava, born in the line of Chyavana, famous as the best of those who know the Veda. The chanter was an old and learned brahmin, Kautsarya Jaimini. The overseer was Sharngarava, and the priest of the offerings was Bodhapingala."

"Vyasa sat in the assembly, with his son and his pupils around him, and Uddalaka, Shamathaka, and Shvetaketu, the fifth. Asita Devala was there, and Narada and Parvata, Atreya, Kundajathara and the brahmin Kutighata, Vatsya and old Shrutashravas, given to austerity and study, Kahoda and Devasharman, Maudgalya and Shamasaubhara. These and many other brahmins of strict vows sat in the assembly at the sacrifice of Parikshit's son."

"As the priests made their offerings at that great rite, the snake sacrifice, terrible snakes fell into it, snakes that frighten every living thing. Streams of the nagas' fat and marrow began to flow, and a dreadful smell spread from those that were burning without pause. And a noise went on without stopping, the noise of the nagas falling, and of those held in the air, and of those roasting hard in the fire."

"But Takshaka, the king of the nagas, went to the palace of Indra, the breaker of cities, as soon as he heard that King Janamejaya had been consecrated. The best of snakes told him everything that had happened, and in his fear, knowing the wrong he had done, he went to Indra for refuge."

"Indra was well pleased, and said to him, 'You have nothing to fear here from that snake sacrifice, Takshaka, king of the nagas, nothing at all. I won the Grandfather's favour for your sake long ago. So you have nothing to fear. Let the fever in your mind go.'

"Comforted by these words, the best of snakes lived there in Shakra's palace, happy and content."

"But as the nagas fell into the fire without end, Vasuki was in great distress, for only a few of his family were left. A dreadful faintness came over Vasuki, the lord of the snakes, and with his heart reeling he said to his sister, 'My limbs are burning, dear sister, and I cannot tell one direction from another. I seem to be sinking into a swoon, and my mind is reeling. My sight is spinning, and my heart seems to be breaking. Today I will fall helpless into that blazing fire. That sacrifice of Parikshit's son is going on because he wants to kill us. Clearly I too must go to the house of the king of the dead.'

"This is the time for which I gave you long ago to Jaratkaru, sister. Save us and our kin. Astika, so they say, will stop that sacrifice while it is under way, best of snakes. The Grandfather himself told me so long ago. So, my child, speak to your own

dear boy, whom even the old respect, the best of those who know the Veda, to set me free today, and my people with me.'

"Then the snake woman Jaratkaru called her son, and at Vasuki's word, the word of the king of the nagas, she said, 'My son, I was given to your father by my brother for a reason. And now the time has come. Do what must be done.'

"'Why were you given to my father by my uncle?' said Astika. 'Tell me the truth. When I have heard it, I will do what must be done.'

"Then the sister of the king of the nagas, Jaratkaru, who wished her kin well, told him, without faltering.

"'The mother of all the snakes, they say, is Kadru. Hear why she cursed her sons in her anger. 'The king of horses, Uchchaihshravas, was not made false for me in the wager with Vinata, when slavery was the stake. So, my sons, at Janamejaya's sacrifice the fire whose charioteer is the wind will burn you. There you will die and go to the world of the dead.' And when she had cursed them like this, the Grandfather of the worlds himself said, 'So be it,' and approved her words.

"'When Vasuki heard the Grandfather's words, my son, he went to the gods for refuge after the nectar had been churned. And the gods had what they wanted, for they had won the matchless nectar. They went to the lord of creatures with my brother at their head. All the gods, with King Vasuki, begged the Grandfather that the curse should not come true. 'Vasuki, the king of the nagas, is in pain for his kin. Blessed one, let not his mother's curse come true.'

"'The wife whom Jaratkaru will take, called Jaratkaru," said Brahma, "a brahmin born to her will set the snakes free from the curse."

"'When he heard these words, Vasuki, the lord of the snakes, gave me, you who are like an immortal, to your great-souled father. That was long before the time. And you were born to me by him. Now the time has come. You must save us from danger. And so you must save my brother from the fire. Let what we did not prove to be in vain, when I was given to your wise father for our release. Or what do you think, my son?'

"When she said this, Astika said to his mother, 'So be it.' And he said to Vasuki, who was burning with pain, as if giving him back his life, 'I will set you free, Vasuki, best of snakes, great being, from that curse. I tell you this truly. Be at ease, naga. You have nothing to fear. I will strive, my friend, so that all will be well. My words have never spoken a lie, even in jest, still less at a time like this. I will go today to that best of kings, Janamejaya, who has been consecrated, and please him with words of good omen, uncle, so that the king's sacrifice will be stopped, good sir. Trust me in all this, wise king of the nagas. Your hopes in me will not prove false.'

"'Astika,' said Vasuki, 'my head is spinning and my heart is breaking. I cannot tell one direction from another. I am crushed by the rod of the brahmins.'

"'You must not grieve at all, best of snakes,' said Astika. 'I will destroy the danger that has risen from the blazing fire. That terrible rod of the brahmins, blazing like the fire at the end of time, I will destroy it. Do not be afraid, not in any way.'

"So he took away Vasuki's terrible fever of the mind, and took it upon himself. Then Astika, the best of brahmins, went in great haste to Janamejaya's sacrifice, which had every excellence, to set the lords of the snakes free.

"When Astika arrived, he saw the splendid place of sacrifice, crowded with members of the assembly who shone like the sun and like fire. As the best of brahmins tried to go in, the doorkeepers stopped him. So, wanting to be let in, the best of brahmins began to praise that sacrifice.

"There was the sacrifice of Soma, the sacrifice of Varuna, the sacrifice of the lord of creatures at Prayaga. So is this sacrifice of yours, first of the Bharatas, son of Parikshit. May all be well with those who are dear to us!

"Shakra's sacrifice was counted a hundredfold, and another as well, a hundred more. So is this sacrifice of yours, first of the Bharatas, son of Parikshit. May all be well with those who are dear to us!

"As was the sacrifice of Yama, and of Harimedhas, and of King Rantideva, so is this sacrifice of yours, first of the Bharatas, son of Parikshit. May all be well with those who are dear to us!

"As was the sacrifice of Gaya, and of King Shashabindu, and of King Vaishravana, so is this sacrifice of yours, first of the Bharatas, son of Parikshit. May all be well with those who are dear to us!

"As was the sacrifice of Nriga, and of Ajamidha, and of King Rama, the son of Dasharatha, so is this sacrifice of yours, first of the Bharatas, son of Parikshit. May all be well with those who are dear to us!

"We have heard in heaven of the sacrifice of Yudhishthira, the son of a god, a king of Ajamidha's line. So is this sacrifice of yours, first of the Bharatas, son of Parikshit. May all be well with those who are dear to us!

"As was the sacrifice of Krishna, the son of Satyawati, where he himself did the work, so is this sacrifice of yours, first of the Bharatas, son of Parikshit. May all be well with those who are dear to us!

"For these men, as bright as the sun and fire, sit at your rite as they sit at the rite of the slayer of Vritra. There is nothing left for them to know today. What is given to them never perishes. There is no priest in all the worlds equal to Dvaipayana. Of that I am certain. His pupils travel the earth, all of them priests, skilled each in his own work.

"The bright one, the many-bright, the great-souled, the gold-seeded, the eater of all, whose path is black, whose flame turns to the right, blazing, the god who eats the offerings, wants this offering of yours.

"There is no other king in the world of the living who protects his people as you do. I am always glad at heart at your steadfastness. You are a king, or you are the king of dharma, Yama himself. As Shakra, with the thunderbolt in his hand, protects this world, so you are the protector of the people here. We hold you to be the lord of men in this world, and there is no other master of the sacrifice like you.

"You are like Khatvanga, Nabhaga and Dilipa, as mighty as Yayati and Mandhatri. Your splendour matches the splendour of the sun, and you shine like Bhishma, you of the good vows. Your firmness is quiet like Valmiki's, and your anger held in check like Vasishtha's. Your lordship, I believe, is equal to Indra's, and your brilliance shines like Narayana's.

"You know the rulings of dharma as Yama does. You have every virtue, as Krishna does. You are the home of fortune as the Vasus are, and the store of all sacrifices. You are equal in strength to Dambhodbhava. Like Rama, you know the weapons and the divine weapons. You are equal in splendour to Aurva and Trita. You are as hard to look upon as Bhagiratha.'

"When he had praised them like this, all of them were pleased: the king, the members of the assembly, the priests and the fire. And when he saw the signs of what they felt, King Janamejaya spoke."

Chapter 17

Stop!

"Then King Janamejaya spoke," said the bard. "'This is a boy, but he speaks like an elder. I do not think he is a boy at all. I think he is an elder. I want to give him a boon. Brahmins, all of you together, give me your leave.'

"'Even a boy, if he is a brahmin, must be honoured by kings,' said the members of the assembly, 'whether he is learned or not, as is right. He deserves everything he could wish for from you today. But first let Takshaka come to us quickly.'

"The king, the giver of boons, was about to say to the brahmin, 'Choose a boon.' Then the priest who calls the gods spoke, not at all pleased at heart. 'Takshaka has not yet come into this rite.'

"'Then all of you,' said Janamejaya, 'try with all your strength, so that this rite of mine is finished, and Takshaka comes to us quickly. He is my enemy.'

"'As our books tell us, king,' said the priests, 'and as the fire tells us, Takshaka is in Indra's palace, tormented by fear.'

"The great-souled suta Lohitaksha, who knew the old lore, had said the same before. Now, when the king asked him, he told the king, 'It is as the brahmins say, god among men. I know from the old lore, and so I tell you, king: Indra has given him a boon. "Live here with me, well guarded. The fire will not burn you.'"

"When he heard this, the king, consecrated for the rite, was in torment, and he urged the priest to his work at the proper time. And the priest, on his guard, made the offering with mantras. And then Indra himself came.

"The mighty god came riding in his flying chariot, praised by all the gods, with the clouds following him, and the Vidyadharas, and the troops of apsaras. And the naga was hidden in his upper cloak, shaking with fear, and he could find no peace.

"Then the king, in his anger, wanting Takshaka's death, spoke again to the priests who knew the mantras. 'If that naga Takshaka is in Indra's palace, brahmins, then throw him into the fire, Indra and all!'

"'Here comes Takshaka now,' said the priests. 'He is quickly coming into your power, king. You can hear his great roar as he cries out in fear. Surely the thunderbolt-bearer has let the naga go. He has fallen from his lap, and his body is loosened by the mantras. Here comes the king of the snakes, whirling through the sky, senseless, gasping for breath. Your rite, king of kings, is going forward by the rules, lord. Now you should give this chief of brahmins his boon.'

"'You are only a boy, and you look like a boy,' said Janamejaya, 'but you are beyond measure. I give you a boon that befits you. Choose whatever you want, what lies in your heart, and I will give it to you, even if it is something that should not be given.'

"As Takshaka, the king of the nagas, was about to fall into the fire, Astika saw his moment, and he spoke. 'If you are giving me a boon, Janamejaya, I choose this: let this sacrifice of yours stop, and let no more snakes fall into it.'

"When he said this, brahmin, the son of Parikshit was not at all pleased, and he said to Astika, 'Gold, silver, cows, whatever else you like, my lord: that I will give you as your boon, brahmin. But do not let my rite be stopped.'

"'Gold, silver, cows, I do not ask them of you, king,' said Astika. 'Let this sacrifice of yours stop, so that my mother's family may be safe.'

"When Astika said this, the son of Parikshit said to him again and again, to that best of speakers, 'Choose another boon, best of the best of brahmins. Good fortune to you!' But he did not ask for any other boon, joy of the Bhrgus.

"Then all the members of the assembly, who knew the Veda, said together to the king, 'Let the brahmin have his boon.'"

"I want to hear the names," said Shaunaka, "of all the snakes who fell into the fire at that snake sacrifice, son of the suta."

"There were many thousands of them," said the bard, "millions, hundreds of millions. They are too many to count, you who know the Veda best. But hear me tell the names of the chief of them that were offered into the fire, as far as I remember them.

"First, hear the chief of those born in Vasuki's line, dark blue and red and white, terrible, huge, full of poison: Kotika, Manasa, Purna, Saha, Paila and Halisaka, Picchila, Konapa, Chakra, Konavega and Prakalana, Hiranyavaha, Sharana, Kakshaka and Kaladantaka. These nagas born of Vasuki went into the fire.

"I will tell you those born in Takshaka's family. Hear them: Pucchandaka, Mandalaka, Pindabhetta and Rabhenaka, Ucchikha, Surasa, Dranga, Balaheda and Virohana, Shilishalakara, Muka, Sukumara and Pravepana, Mudgara and Shasharoman, Sumanas and Vegavahana. These nagas born of Takshaka went into the fire.

"Paravata, Pariyatra, Pandara, Harina and Krisha, Vihanga, Sharabha, Moda, Pramoda and Samhatangada: these from Airavata's family went into the fire.

"Hear the nagas born in Kauravya's family, best of brahmins: Aindila, Kundala and Munda, Veniskandha and Kumaraka, Bahuka and Shringavega, Dhurtaka, Pata and Patara.

"Hear, as they were, the nagas born in Dhritarashtra's family, as I name them, brahmin, as swift as the wind and full of poison: Shankukarna and Pingalaka, Kutharamukha and Mechaka, Purnangada and Purnamukha, Prahasa, Shakuni and Hari, Amahatha and Komathaka, Shvasana, Manava and Vata, Bhairava, Mundavedanga, Pishanga and Udraparaga, the one named Rishabha and Vegavat, Pindaraka and Mahahanu, Raktanga, Sarvasaranga, Samriddha, Pata and Rakshasa, Varahaka and Varanaka, Sumitra and Chitravedika, Parashara and Tarunaka, Maniskandha and Aruni.

"These are the nagas I have named, brahmin, the chief of them, who added to their families' fame. There are too many to name them all. Their sons and grandsons, and the offspring of their offspring, who went into the blazing fire, cannot be counted. Some had seven heads, some two, and some five, terrible, their poison like the fire at the end of time, and they were offered into the fire by hundreds of thousands. They were huge and mighty, as tall as mountain peaks, a yojana long and wide, and two yojanas

long. They could take any form they wished and go wherever they wished, and their poison was like blazing fire. They were burned there at that great sacrifice, crushed by the rod of the brahmins.

"And we have heard of another great wonder of Astika's. While the son of Parikshit was pressing boons on him, the naga, fallen from Indra's hand, stayed where he was in the sky. Then King Janamejaya grew anxious. The offerings were poured into the blazing fire, by the rules, with all force, and still Takshaka, tormented by fear, did not fall into the fire."

"How was it, suta," said Shaunaka, "that the mantras of those wise brahmins did not work on the fire, so that Takshaka did not fall into it?"

"The best of snakes had slipped from Indra's hand, and he had lost his senses," said the bard. "Astika called out to him three times: 'Stop! Stop! Stop!'"

"And he stopped in the sky, his heart in torment, the way a man might stand still inside a ring of cattle.

"Then the king, pressed hard by the members of his assembly, said, 'Let it be as Astika has said. Let this rite be ended. Let the snakes be safe. Let this Astika be pleased. And let the suta's words come true.'

"Then a great shout of joy went up, halahala!, as Astika was given his boon. And so the sacrifice of the Pandava king, the son of Parikshit, came to an end. And King Janamejaya of the Bharatas was glad. To the priests and the members of the assembly who had gathered there he gave wealth by the hundred and by the thousand. And the lord gave much wealth to the red-eyed suta, the builder, who had said at the start of the rite that it would be stopped, and that a brahmin would be the cause. Then he performed the final bath, with the rites the scriptures lay down.

"The king, glad at heart, sent Astika home with every honour, glad himself, his purpose achieved, that wise man. And he said to him, 'You must come again. You will sit in my assembly at the great horse sacrifice.'

"Astika said, 'So be it,' and he hurried away, full of joy, having done his matchless work and pleased the king. Overjoyed, he went to his mother and his uncle, and he bowed and touched their feet, and told them all that had happened.

"When they heard this, the snakes who had gathered there were glad, and their fear was gone. They were full of love for Astika, and they said to him, 'Choose the boon you want.' Again and again they all said to him, 'What can we do for you today, wise one? We are glad, and we have all been set free. What would you like us to do today, child?'"

"'Brahmins, and men of every kind in this world,' said Astika, 'who, at evening and at morning, with a calm and happy heart, tell this story of dharma of mine: let them have nothing at all to fear from you.'

"And the snakes, glad at heart, said to their sister's son, 'It shall be so, just as you wish. With love, sister's son, we will do all you desire, and gladly.'

"May the famous Astika, born of Jaratkaru by Jaratkaru, true to his promise, protect me

from the snakes.' Whoever calls to mind Asita, Artimant and Sunitha, by day or by night, will have no fear of snakes.

"When he had set the snakes free from the snake sacrifice, that best of brahmins, the righteous one, came in time to his appointed end, with sons and grandsons around him.

"So I have told you the story of Astika rightly. When one tells it, one has nothing to fear from snakes anywhere. You have heard, brahmin, the righteous story of Astika that increases merit, the glorious life of the wise Astika from the beginning."

"Beginning with the line of Bhrigu," said Shaunaka, "you have told me the whole great story, my friend, Sauti. I am pleased with you for it. Now I will ask you again, son of the suta, as is right, for the story Vyasa made. Tell it to me as well. At that great snake sacrifice, which is so hard to reach, great poet, in the pauses of the rite, what wonderful stories were told among the great souls of the assembly, and on what themes? We want to hear them from you, as they were, Sauti, for you are wise."

"In the pauses of the rite, the brahmins told stories founded on the Veda," said the bard. "But Vyasa told, again and again, the great story of the Bharatas."

"The Mahabharata," said Shaunaka, "the story that spreads the fame of the Pandavas, which Krishna Dvaipayana told in the pauses of the rite when Janamejaya asked him: I want to hear that holy story, as it should be told, born from the ocean of the mind of the great seer of holy deeds. Tell it, best of the good. I never tire of it, son of the suta."

"Then I will tell you," said the bard, "the great and noble story, the Mahabharata, as Krishna Dvaipayana thought it, from the beginning. Take pleasure in it, brahmin, you of the finest mind, as I tell it. For my heart is filled with joy to tell it."

Chapter 18

The Story in Brief

"When the wise seer Krishna Dvaipayana heard that Janamejaya had been consecrated for the snake sacrifice," said the bard, "he came there.

"Kali bore him to Parashara, the son of Shakti, on an island in the Yamuna. She was still a maiden then. He was the grandfather of the Pandavas. As soon as he was born, he made his body grow by his own will, and that famous man learned the Vedas with their limbs, and the histories. No one could surpass him, not by great austerity, nor by study of the Veda, nor by vows, nor by fasting, nor by birth, nor by anger. The best of those who know the Veda divided the one Veda into four. He knew what was higher and what was lower, a brahmin seer, a poet, true to his vows and pure. He fathered Pandu, Dhritarashtra and Vidura, carrying on the line of Shantanu, a man of holy and great fame.

"With his pupils, who had mastered the Vedas and their limbs, he entered the assembly at the sacrifice of the royal seer Janamejaya. There he saw King Janamejaya seated, like Indra among the gods. Many members of the assembly surrounded him, and consecrated lords of many countries, and priests like gods, skilled in laying out the sacrifice.

"When the royal seer Janamejaya saw the seer arrive, that best of the Bharatas went quickly to meet him with his people, gladly. With the assembly's consent, the lord had a golden seat set for him, as Shakra does for Brihaspati. When he was seated there, the giver of boons, honoured by the hosts of divine seers, the king of kings honoured him with the rites the scriptures lay down. According to the rules, he offered water for his feet, water to rinse his mouth, the guest offering and a cow to his grandfather Krishna, who deserved them all.

"Vyasa accepted that honour from the Pandava Janamejaya, and told them to let the cow go, and he was pleased. When the king had honoured his great-grandfather with such care, he sat down near him, glad at heart, and asked after his health. And the blessed one looked at him and told him that he was well. Honoured by all the members of the assembly, he honoured them in turn.

"Then, when all the assembly had honoured him, Janamejaya joined his palms and asked that best of brahmins, 'You saw the Kurus and the Pandavas with your own eyes. I want to hear you tell their story, brahmin. How did the quarrel come between them, whose deeds were never mean? All my grandfathers' minds were possessed by fate. How did that great war come about among them, which made an end of so many creatures? Tell me this fully, blessed one, for you know it all.'

"When he heard these words, Krishna Dvaipayana gave an order to his pupil Vaishampayana, who was sitting near him. 'Tell him all of it, as you heard it from me: how the quarrel of the Kurus and the Pandavas happened long ago.'

"The bull among brahmins took his teacher's word, and then he told the whole ancient history to the king, and to the members of the assembly, and to all the kshatriyas: the quarrel of the Kurus and the Pandavas, and the ruin of the kingdom.

"First I bow to my teacher," said Vaishampayana, "with mind and understanding and full attention. I honour all the brahmins, and the other learned men. Now I will tell the

whole of the thought of Vyasa, this wise great seer, famous in all the worlds, whose splendour has no measure. You are a worthy listener for this story of the Bharatas, king, and now that I have you, the stirring of my teacher's words seems to urge me on with joy.

"Hear, king, how the quarrel came between the Kurus and the Pandavas, how it grew out of the dice for the sake of the kingdom, and how the exile in the forest followed. And I will tell you, bull of the Bharatas, since you ask, how the war came about that destroyed the earth.

"When their father died, those heroes came from the forest to their own home. Soon they were learned in the Veda and in the bow. The Pandavas were handsome, brave and strong, honoured by the people of the city, and full of fortune and fame. When the Kurus saw them like that, they could not bear it. Then cruel Duryodhana, and Karna, with the son of Subala, tried all kinds of ways to hold them down and drive them out.

"The wicked son of Dhritarashtra gave Bhima poison. Heroic Wolf-belly digested it along with his food. Then he tied up Wolf-belly while he was asleep at Pramanakoti, and threw Bhima into the waters of the Ganga, and went back to the city. When the son of Kunti woke, great king, he broke his bonds, and Bhimasena rose up, unharmed. And as he slept, he had him bitten on every part of his body by black cobras, full of poison. But the slayer of enemies did not die.

"Through all those wrongs, the wise Vidura was watchful, to save them and to foil the attempts. As Shakra in heaven brings happiness to the world of the living, so Vidura always brought happiness to the Pandavas.

"Duryodhana tried all kinds of means, secret and open, and he could not kill them, for fate and what was to be protected them. Then he took counsel with his advisers, with Vrisha, Duhshasana and the rest. With Dhritarashtra's leave, he ordered a house of lac to be built. He had the Pandavas, whose strength had no measure, live there. And when they trusted him, he had it set on fire. But on Vidura's word a tunnel had been dug, and by that means he set them free, and when they were free, they ran in fear.

"Then, in a great and terrible forest, Bhimasena of the terrible courage killed a rakshasa named Hidimba in his anger. Then the heroes joined together and went to Ekachakra with their mother, the scorers of enemies, in the guise of brahmins. There they killed Baka, who was very strong, for the sake of a brahmin, and then they went with brahmins to the city of the Panchalas. There they won Draupadi. They lived there a full year, and when they became known, the tamers of enemies came back to Hastinapura.

"King Dhritarashtra and the son of Shantanu said to them, 'How can we keep you from quarrelling with your brothers, my sons? We have thought that you should live in Khandavaprastha. So go and live in Khandavaprastha, which has its own country and its broad roads well laid out, and let your anger go.'

"At their word, they went with all their friends to the city of Khandavaprastha, taking every kind of treasure with them. They lived there, king, for many years, and by the might of their weapons they brought other kings under their power. So, with dharma first in their minds, devoted to their vows of truth, watchful, active and patient, they scorched their enemies.

"Mighty Bhimasena conquered the east, heroic Arjuna the north, Nakula the west, and Sahadeva, killer of enemy heroes, the south. So they brought the whole earth under their power. With the five Pandavas, true in their valour, bright as suns, and with the sun shining too, the earth seemed to shine with six suns.

"Then, for some reason, Yudhishtira, the king of dharma, sent his brother Dhananjaya to the forest. He lived in the forest for a full year and a month. Then one day he went to Hrishikesha in Dvaravati. There Bibhatsu won a wife, the lotus-eyed Subhadra, sweet of speech, the younger sister of Vasudeva. As Shachi was joined with great Indra, and Shri with Krishna, so Subhadra, glad at heart, was joined with Arjuna the Pandava.

"And the son of Kunti, Bibhatsu, with Vasudeva, gave the fire its fill in the Khandava forest, best of kings. With Keshava beside him it was no great burden for Partha, just as it is none for Vishnu, with resolve as his helper, when he kills his enemies. And Agni gave Partha the Gandiva, the finest of bows, and two quivers of arrows that never run out, and a chariot with the ape on its banner. There Bibhatsu set free the great asura Maya, and Maya built a heavenly hall, covered with every kind of jewel.

"Foolish Duryodhana, in his wicked mind, grew greedy for that hall. Then, with the son of Subala, he cheated Yudhishtira at dice, and sent him to the forest for seven years and five, and the thirteenth year to be spent unknown in a kingdom. Then, in the fourteenth year, they asked for their own wealth, and they did not get it, great king. Then the war began. They destroyed everything, and killed King Duryodhana, and took back the kingdom, most of it laid waste.

"This, then, is what happened long ago to those whose deeds were never mean: the quarrel, the ruin of the kingdom, and the victory, best of victors."

"Best of brahmins," said Janamejaya, "you have told me all of it in brief, the story of the Mahabharata, the great life of the Kurus. But as you tell this story, sinless one, so full of wonders, a great longing has come over me to hear it in full. So you should tell it again, in full. I never tire of hearing the great life of those who came before me.

"The Pandavas knew dharma. They killed all those who should not have been killed, and still men praise them. It can be no small reason that made them do it. Why did those tigers among men, strong as they were, and without fault, bear the torments the wicked put on them? How did Wolf-belly, with the strength of ten thousand elephants, and arms like weapons, hold back his anger when he was tormented, best of brahmins? How did Draupadi, dark Krishna, tormented by the wicked, not burn up the sons of Dhritarashtra with her terrible eyes, when she had the power? How did the two sons of Pritha, and the two sons of Madri, follow that tiger among men when he went wrong at the dice, cheated by the wicked? How did Yudhishtira, the best of those who uphold dharma, the son of Dharma, who knew dharma, bear such great suffering, when he did not deserve it? And how did the Pandava Dhananjaya, with Krishna as his charioteer, alone, shooting his arrows, send so many armies to the world of the dead? Tell me all of this, as it happened, rich in austerity: all that those great warriors did, at each place and time."

"I will tell you," said Vaishampayana, "the whole of the thought of the great seer Vyasa, great-souled, honoured in all the worlds, whose splendour has no measure. The son of Satyawati, whose power has no measure, has set out here this work of a hundred thousand verses of holy deeds. The wise man who recites it, and the man who hears it,

reach the world of Brahma and become equal to the gods. For this is the equal of the Vedas, and holy, and the highest. It is the best of all things to be heard, an ancient work praised by the seers. In this history of great holiness, the business of life and dharma are taught in full, and the understanding that leads to the final goal.

"The wise man who recites this Veda of Krishna to people who are not mean, who are generous, true and believing, wins his reward. A man who hears this history, even a very cruel man, will surely shed the sin even of killing an unborn child. This history is called Jaya, Victory. Whoever wants to win should hear it. He will win the whole earth and defeat his enemies. It is the best rite for the birth of a son, a great blessing. The queen and the crown prince should hear it often.

"Vyasa, whose understanding has no measure, has told it as a holy book of the business of life, a highest book of dharma, and a book of release. People tell it now, and others will tell it in time to come. Those who hear it have sons who serve them, and servants who please them. A man who always hears this is quickly freed of every sin he has done, by body, by speech and by mind. Those who hear the great birth of the Bharatas without envy have no fear of sickness. How much less do they fear the next world?

"Krishna Dvaipayana made this, wishing to do holy good. It brings wealth, fame, long life and heaven, and it is holy. It spreads through the world the glory of the great-souled Pandavas, and of the other kshatriyas, rich in wealth and splendour. As the blessed ocean and Himalaya, the mountain, are both famous as stores of jewels, so is the Bharata said to be.

"The wise man who recites it to brahmins at the holy days is cleansed of sin. He wins heaven, and he becomes one with Brahman. And whoever recites even a quarter of a verse of it to brahmins at a rite for the dead, that rite reaches his forefathers and never runs out. Whatever wrong a man does unknowing by day, as he goes about, is dissolved as soon as he hears the story of the Mahabharata.

"The great birth of the Bharatas is called the Mahabharata. Whoever knows the meaning of its name is freed from all sins. The sage Krishna Dvaipayana, rising early every day, made this finest story, the Mahabharata, in three years.

"On dharma and on wealth, on love and on release, full of the Bharatas, what is here is found elsewhere. What is not here is found nowhere."

Chapter 19

The Fish's Daughter

There was a king named Uparichara, Vasu, a lord of the earth who always kept to dharma, and he was strict in his vows. He was the joy of the Pauravas, and on Indra's advice he took the lovely country of Chedi, a land worth taking.

Once he laid down his weapons and went to live in a hermitage, given over to austerity. Then the god himself, the wielder of the thunderbolt, came to him. This king could win the rank of Indra by his austerity, thought Indra, and with gentle words he turned the king back from austerity himself.

"Lord of the earth," said Indra, "dharma on earth must not be thrown into disorder. Protect it, for when dharma is upheld, it upholds the whole world. Protect the dharma of the world, always watchful and steady, and you will win holy worlds that last for ever. I am in heaven and you are on earth, but be my dear friend. Live in the country that is the udder of the earth, lord of men. It is rich in cattle, holy, secure, full of wealth and grain, easy to guard and pleasant, with all the good things a land can give. This country is richer than any other in wealth and jewels and the like. The earth there is full of riches. Live among the Chedis, lord of Chedi.

"The people of that country love dharma. They are content and good. No one there tells a lie, even in jest. Sons do not divide their property from their fathers, and they delight in serving their elders. They do not yoke lean cattle to the plough; they feed them up. All the classes keep always to their own dharma among the Chedis, you who give honour to others. And nothing that happens in the three worlds will be hidden from you.

"A great chariot of crystal, fit for the gods, heavenly, that flies through the sky, will come to you as my gift. You alone of all mortals will ride in that finest of chariots, moving high above, like a god in bodily form. I give you the garland called Vaijayanti, whose lotuses never fade. In battle it will keep you unwounded by weapons. This will be your mark here, lord of men, famous as Indra's garland, blessed, matchless and great."

And the slayer of Vritra gave him a staff of bamboo, to grant what men wished and to protect the good. At the end of a year the lord of the earth had it set into the ground, to honour Shakra. And from that day to this, king, the best of kings set up the staff as he began it. The next day kings raise it, adorned with baskets, perfumes, garlands and ornaments, and it is wound with strings of garlands by the rules. And the blessed Shakra is worshipped there in the form of laughter, a form he took himself out of love for the great-souled Vasu.

When great Indra, the lord, saw the lovely worship that Vasu, the chief of kings, had made, he was pleased, and said, "Men and kings who worship at my festival and hold it joyfully, as the king of Chedi has done, will have fortune and victory, with their kingdoms. Their country will prosper and be glad."

So great Indra, the bountiful, honoured the great king Vasu with love, lord of men. Those who always hold Shakra's festival are made pure by it, as by gifts of land and other gifts, and by great sacrifices where boons are given. Honoured by the bountiful one, Vasu, lord of Chedi, ruled this earth by dharma from Chedi, and to please Indra, that lord of the earth held Indra's festival.

He had five sons of great courage and boundless power, and the emperor consecrated his sons as kings of many kingdoms. There was the great warrior Brihadratha, famous as king of Magadha; Pratyagraha; Kushamba, whom they call Manivahana; Macchilla; and Yadu, a prince never defeated. These were the sons of that royal seer of great splendour, king. They gave their own names to countries and cities, the five kings descended from Vasu, each with his own line that lasts for ever.

He lived in Indra's crystal palace in the sky, and gandharvas and apsaras waited on that great-souled king. So his name became famous: Uparichara, He Who Moves Above.

The river Shuktimati flowed past his city. The mountain Kolahala, a mountain with a mind, so they say, blocked the river out of desire. Vasu kicked the mountain Kolahala, and the river came out through the gap his blow had made. The mountain had fathered twins on the river. The river was glad to be set free, and gave the twins to the king. Vasu, the best of royal seers, who gave riches, made the boy the general of his army, the tamer of enemies. And the king made the girl his wife, his dear Girika.

One day Vasu's wife Girika, pure and bathed after her season, told him in her desire that her time had come. That same day the forefathers came to that best of kings, the wisest of the wise, and said to him, pleased, "Kill deer." The king would not disobey the forefathers' command. He went hunting, full of desire, thinking only of Girika, who was very beautiful, like a second Shri.

As he roamed the lovely forest, his seed fell. As soon as it fell, the lord of the earth caught it on a leaf of a tree. My seed must not fall in vain, he thought, and my wife's season must not be wasted. He thought it over again and again, the best of kings, and he knew his seed never failed. Seeing that it was the time to send the seed to his queen, he spoke mantras over it. The king knew the subtle truths of dharma and of life. He saw a swift hawk near him, and he said to the hawk, "Friend, for my sake, take this seed to my house. Give it to Girika quickly, for today is her season."

The hawk took it and flew up at once, fast. The bird went as fast as it could fly. Then another hawk saw it coming, and at once swooped on it, thinking it was carrying meat. The two of them fought with their beaks in the sky, and as they fought, the seed fell into the waters of the Yamuna.

There was a fine apsaras there named Adrika, who had become a fish by a brahmin's curse, and she lived in the Yamuna. In her fish form, Adrika rushed up and swallowed the seed of Vasu that had dropped from the hawk's claws.

Some time later, fishermen caught that fish. It was the tenth month, best of the Bharatas, and from her belly they took out a human boy and girl. They thought it a great wonder, and they told the king. "King, these two humans were born in a fish's body."

King Uparichara took the boy of the two. He became a king named Matsya, the Fish, righteous and true to his promises. And at once the apsaras was free of her curse. The blessed one had told her long before, "Fair one, you will be born as an animal. When you have borne two human children, you will be free of the curse." So when she had borne them and the fisherman had killed her, she left her fish form and took her heavenly form again, and that fine apsaras went away on the path of the perfected ones, the seers and the heavenly singers.

The girl, the fish's daughter, smelled of fish. The king gave her to a fisherman. "Let her be yours," he said. She had beauty and good character, and every virtue. Her name was Satyavati. But because she lived among the fishermen, that girl of the bright smile smelled of fish for a time.

To serve her father, she used to ferry a boat across the water. One day the seer Parashara, travelling from one holy ford to another, saw her. She was very beautiful, a girl even the perfected ones would long for. As soon as the wise man saw that lovely girl, he desired her. The bull among sages knew she was the daughter of Vasu, and he wanted her.

"Look, blessed one," she said, "there are seers standing on both banks. They are watching us. How can we be together?"

When she said this, the lord made a mist, and the whole place became as dark as night. When the girl saw the mist the great seer had made, she was amazed, and ashamed, for she had spirit. "Know, blessed one, that I am a maiden, and always under my father's rule. If I am joined with you, sinless one, my maidenhood will be spoiled. And if my maidenhood is spoiled, best of brahmins, how can I go home? I could not bear to stay at home. Think of this, blessed one, and then do what must be done."

The best of seers was pleased with her for saying this. "When you have done what pleases me," he said, "you will still be a maiden. And choose a boon, timid one, whatever you wish, proud girl. For my grace has never been given in vain before, you of the bright smile."

When he said this, she chose as her boon the finest fragrance for her body. And the blessed lord gave her what her heart desired. Then, glad, having won her boon, adorned with every quality of a woman, she lay with the seer of wonderful deeds. From then on her name was famous on earth as Gandhavati, She Who Is Fragrant. For men on earth could smell her fragrance a yojana away, and so she was also known as Yojanagandha, Fragrant for a Yojana. And the blessed Parashara went back to his own home.

So Satyavati was glad, for she had won a boon beyond compare. Joined with Parashara, she gave birth to a child at once. And on an island in the Yamuna the mighty son of Parashara was born. He stood before his mother, and he set his mind on austerity. "When you think of me," he said, "I will come to you, when there is something to be done."

So Dvaipayana was born to Satyavati by Parashara. Because he was left as a child on an island, a dvipa, he was called Dvaipayana.

In every age, the wise man saw dharma losing one of its feet, and he saw that the life and strength of mortals follow the ages. To favour Brahman and the brahmins he divided the Vedas, vi-vyasa, and so he is remembered as Vyasa. The lord, the greatest, the giver of boons, taught the Vedas, with the Mahabharata as the fifth, to Sumantu, to Jaimini, to Paila, to his own son Shuka, and to Vaishampayana. And each of them made known his own collection of the Bharata.

In the same way, Bhishma, son of Shantanu, of boundless splendour, great in courage and fame, was born to Ganga from the power of a Vasu.

There was an ancient seer, famous and great, named Animandavya, who was not a thief, but was impaled on a stake, suspected of theft. That great seer once called Dharma to him and said, "When I was a child I pierced a little bird with a reed. I remember that sin, Dharma. I remember no other. My austerity was a thousand times greater. Why did it not overcome that sin? Killing a brahmin is heavier than killing any other creature. So for this sin you will be born from a shudra womb."

By that curse, Dharma too was born from a shudra womb, as the learned Vidura, a righteous body without sin.

Sanjaya, like a sage, was born to the suta Gavalgana. And from the Sun, to Kunti while she was still a girl, was born the great warrior Karna, wearing armour that was born with him, his face lit by his earrings.

For the good of the worlds, Vishnu, whom the worlds bow to, was born of Vasudeva in Devaki, a god of great fame. They call him the god without beginning or end, the maker of the world, the lord, the unmanifest, the imperishable, Brahman, the first cause, the self beyond the qualities, the self that never wastes, nature, the source, the highest, the Person, the maker of all, joined to goodness, the lasting and imperishable, the endless, the unmoving, the god, the swan, Narayana, the lord, the creator, ageless and eternal, the highest, the imperishable. That Person, all-pervading, the maker, the grandfather of all beings, was born among the Andhakas and the Vrishnis to make dharma grow.

Two masters of weapons, very brave, skilled in every weapon, Satyaki and Kritavarma, devoted to Narayana, were born from Satyaka and Hridika.

The seed of the fierce ascetic, the great seer Bharadvaja, fell into a trough, a droni, and grew there. From it Drona was born. From Gautama Sharadvat, twins were born from a clump of reeds: the mother of Ashvatthama, and mighty Kripa. And Ashvatthama, the best of those who bear weapons, was born from Drona.

In the same way Dhrishtadyumna, as bright as fire itself, was born from the fire at a great sacrifice, a hero with a bow, mighty, born to destroy Drona. And in the same way Krishna, the daughter of Drupada, was born from the altar, full of splendour and lovely, shining in her body, and of the finest beauty.

Then Nagnajit, the pupil of Prahada, and Subala were born. Subala's offspring, a destroyer of dharma, was born from the anger of the gods. Shakuni, the son of Subala, the prince of Gandhara, was born, and so was Duryodhana's mother. Both of them knew the ways of the world.

Dhritarashtra, lord of men, was born from Krishna Dvaipayana in the field of Vichitravirya, and so was mighty Pandu.

Pandu had five sons, each like a god. Of his two wives' sons, Yudhishtira was the eldest in virtue. Yudhishtira was born of Dharma, Wolf-belly of the Wind, and glorious Dhananjaya, the best of all who bear weapons, of Indra. The twins, Nakula and Sahadeva, handsome, and devoted to serving their elders, were born of the two Ashvins.

A hundred sons were born to wise Dhritarashtra, with Duryodhana first among them, and Yuyutsu, the son of a vaishya woman.

Abhimanyu was born to Subhadra by Arjuna, the nephew of Vasudeva and the grandson of great Pandu. To the five Pandavas, five sons were born by Krishna, handsome princes, skilled in every weapon: Prativindhya of Yudhishtira, Sutasoma of Wolf-belly, Shrutakirti of Arjuna, Shatanika of Nakula, and mighty Shrutasena of Sahadeva. And Ghatotkacha was born in the forest to Bhima by Hidimba.

Shikhandi was born to Drupada, a girl who became a son. Sthuna, a yaksha, made her a man, out of kindness.

At that war of the Kurus, hundreds of thousands of kings came together to fight. Their names are beyond measure. It would be impossible to count them all even in ten thousand years. But these are the chief of them, through whom this story is told.

The Burden of the Earth

"Brahmin," said Janamejaya, "I want to hear properly about those you have named, and about the others you have not named, and about the other kings of great splendour. Tell me properly, fortunate one, why those great warriors, who were like gods, were born here on earth."

This, king, is a secret of the gods, or so we have heard. But I will tell it to you, bowing first to the Self-born.

Long ago, Jamadagni's son made the earth empty of kshatriyas three times over seven. Then he went to practise austerity on Mahendra, the best of mountains. When the son of Bhrigu had emptied the world of kshatriyas, king, the kshatriya women came to the brahmins, wanting children. The brahmins kept strict vows. They lay with them, tiger among men, only in their seasons. They never did it from desire, and never out of season.

The kshatriya women conceived by them in their thousands, king. They bore kshatriya sons of honoured courage, boys and girls, so that the kshatriya class would grow again. So the kshatriyas were born to the kshatriya women by the ascetic brahmins. They flourished in dharma, and they lived very long. And then all four classes had the brahmins at their head.

Men went to women in their season, not from desire, and never out of season. The other creatures did the same, even those born as animals. They went to their mates in their season, bull of the Bharatas. So the people grew in dharma, lord of the earth, devoted to dharma and their vows. They lived for a hundred thousand years. All men were free of cares and of sickness.

Then the kshatriyas ruled again over this earth, with its mountains, its woods and its forests. She was the cow whose edges are the oceans, where the great elephants roam. The kshatriyas ruled the earth again by dharma, and all the classes, the brahmins first, were filled with the greatest joy. The kings cast out the faults that are born of desire and anger. They protected their people, and brought the rod of punishment by dharma down on those who deserved it.

While the kshatriyas kept to dharma like this, Indra rained sweetly, the thousand-eyed god of the hundred sacrifices. He rained in the right place and at the right time, and the people flourished. No one died as a child then, lord of men. No one knew a woman before he was grown. So the earth, as far as the oceans, filled up with long-lived people, bull of the Bharatas.

The kshatriyas offered great sacrifices with rich gifts to the priests, and the brahmins studied the Vedas with their limbs and their Upanishads. The brahmins did not sell the sacred word then, king, nor recite the Vedas within hearing of shudras. The vaishyas worked the land here with oxen. They did not yoke weak cattle, and they kept even the lean ones alive. Men did not milk the cows while the calves were still sucking, and traders did not sell their wares with false measures.

People did their work, tiger among men, in keeping with dharma, looking only to dharma, devoted to dharma. All the classes kept to their own work, lord of men. So, tiger among

men, dharma did not decline anywhere then. Cows gave birth at their proper time, and so did women, bull of the Bharatas, and trees bore flowers and fruits in their seasons.

So, king, while the Krita age went on as it should, the whole earth filled up with a great many living beings.

Then, while the world of men was flourishing, bull of the Bharatas, asuras were born in the fields of kings, best of men. For the Adityas had defeated the daityas many times in battle. Thrown down from their power, they were born here on earth. Those proud asuras wanted to be gods here among men. So they were born on earth, lord, among all kinds of beings. They were born among cows and horses, king of kings, among donkeys, camels and buffaloes, among flesh-eating beasts, elephants and deer. So many had been born, and so many more were being born, lord of the earth, that the earth could no longer bear her own weight.

Some of the sons of Diti and of Danu fell from their world and were born here as mighty lords of the earth. They were brave and proud, and they took many forms. Those crushers of enemies overran this earth to the ocean's edge. They oppressed brahmins, kshatriyas, vaishyas and shudras, and by their strength they oppressed other creatures too. By the hundred thousand they roamed the earth on every side, terrifying and killing all kinds of creatures. They were hostile to brahmins, drunk with their own courage and maddened by the pride of their strength. They attacked the great seers in their hermitages everywhere.

Those great asuras were swollen with courage and strength, and they oppressed the Earth, lord of the earth. So the Earth went to Brahma. For neither the wind, king, nor the nagas, nor the mountains could hold up the earth then, overrun by the danavas' might.

Weighed down and stricken with fear, lord of the earth, the Earth went for refuge to the god who is the grandfather of all beings. She saw the god Brahma, the maker of the worlds, who never passes away. The blessed gods, the brahmins and the great seers were all around him. Gandharvas and apsaras praised him, glad in their work of praise. She came close and bowed to him.

Then the Earth, seeking refuge, told him her trouble, in the presence of all the guardians of the world, Bharata. But the Self-born, the highest, knew long before what the Earth had come to do, king. For how could the creator of the world not know, Bharata, all that is in the minds of the gods, the asuras and the worlds?

Then he spoke to the Earth, great king: the lord of the earth, the all-pervading, the source of all beings, the lord, the kindly one, the lord of creatures. "Earth, the reason you have come to me is the reason I will set all the dwellers of heaven to work."

When he had said this and sent the Earth away, king, the god Brahma, the maker of beings, gave his orders to all the gods himself. "To take the burden off this earth, be born on her, each of you, with a portion of yourselves, to make war on them." And in the same way the blessed one called together all the troops of gandharvas and apsaras, and said to them these excellent words: "Be born among men with your own portions, as you wish."

Shakra and all the others heard the words of the teacher of the gods. They were true and useful and wholesome, and the gods took them to heart. Then all of them, ready to go to

earth with their portions, went to Narayana, the slayer of enemies, in Vaikuntha. He holds the discus and the mace. He is dressed in yellow, dark and shining, with the lotus at his navel. He is the slayer of the gods' enemies, and his eyes are wide and beautiful and long.

Indra said to that highest of persons, "Go down with a portion of yourself, to make the earth clean."

And Hari said to him, "So be it."

Chapter 21

The Families of Beings

Then Indra made a pact with Narayana, to go down from heaven to earth in portions with the gods. Shakra himself gave his orders to all the dwellers of heaven, and then he left Narayana's home. So, one after another, the dwellers of heaven went down from heaven to this earth, to destroy the enemies of the immortals and for the good of all the worlds. They were born, tiger among kings, in the families of brahmin seers and of royal seers, as each of them wished. They killed danavas and rakshasas, gandharvas and snakes, and many other man-eating beings. And the danavas and rakshasas, the gandharvas and snakes, could not kill them, best of the Bharatas, even when they were children, so strong were they.

"I want to hear," said Janamejaya, "the truth about the origin of all the hosts of gods and danavas, of the gandharvas and apsaras, of all men, and of the yakshas and rakshasas, all of it from the beginning, and of every living being. For you know everything."

Then I will tell you, bowing first to the Self-born, the right account of the birth and the end of the gods and the other worlds.

Brahma had six sons born of his mind, as is known, six great seers: Marichi, Atri, Angiras, Pulastya, Pulaha and Kratu. Marichi's son was Kashyapa, and from Kashyapa these creatures were born.

There were thirteen daughters of Daksha, tiger among men, women of great fortune: Aditi, Diti, Danu, Kala, Anayu, Simhika, Muni, Krodha, Prava, Arishta, Vinata, Kapila and Kadru, Bharata, all daughters of Daksha. Their sons and grandsons, full of courage, are without end.

To Aditi were born the twelve Adityas, the lords of the world. I will tell you their names, king, Bharata. They are Dhatri, Mitra, Aryaman, Shakra, Varuna and Amsha, Bhaga, Vivasvat and Pushan, Savitri the tenth, Tvashtri the eleventh, and Vishnu, who is called the twelfth. He was the last-born of all the Adityas, and the greatest in virtue.

Diti had one son, remembered as Hiranyakashipu. That great-souled one had five sons, famous by name. Prahrada was the eldest of them, Samhrada came after him, Anuhrada was the third, and after him Shibi and Bashkala. Prahrada had three sons, famous everywhere, Bharata: Virochana, Kumbha and Nikumbha. Virochana had one son, the mighty Bali. And Bali's famous son was the great asura called Bana.

Danu had forty sons, famous everywhere, Bharata. The first-born of them was King Viprachitti, of great fame. Then Shambara, Namuchi and the famous Puloman, Asiloman, Keshin and the danava Durjaya, Ayahshiras, Ashvashiras and mighty Ayahshanku, Gaganamurdhan, Vegavat and Ketuman, Svarbhanu, Ashva, Ashvapati, Vrishaparvan and Ajaka, Ashvagriva, Sukshma and the great asura Tuhunda, Isripa, Ekachakra, Virupaksha, Hara and Ahara, Nichandra and Nikumbha, Kupatha and Kapatha, Sharabha and Shalabha, and Surya and Chandramas. These are the famous danavas named in the line of Danu. The Sun and the Moon of the gods, as is remembered, are others.

And these ten were famous in that line, sons of Danu, great king, bulls among the danavas, brave and very strong: Ekaksha, heroic Mritapa, Pralamba and Naraka, Vatapi,

Shatrutapana and the great asura Shatha, Gavishtha, Danayu and the danava Dirghajihva. Their sons and grandsons, as is remembered, cannot be counted, Bharata.

Simhika bore a son, Rahu, the tormentor of the moon and the sun, and Suchandra, Chandrahantri and Chandravimardana. The cruel Krodha had cruel sons and grandsons without end: the host called the Krodhavashas, cruel in deed, crushers of their enemies. Anayu had four sons, bulls among the asuras: Vikshara, Bala, Vira and the great asura Vritra. Kala's sons were famous, like Time itself, striking hard, known on earth as very brave among the danavas, scorchers of their enemies: Vinashana and Krodha, Krodhahantri, and another, Krodhashatru. They are known as the Kaleyas.

The teacher of the asuras was Shukra, the son of a seer. Ushanas had four famous sons, priests of the asuras: Tvashtavara and Atri, and two others, who performed the rites of the mantras. They were as bright as the sun, and they made the world of Brahma flourish.

This is the origin of the families of the mighty asuras and gods, as I heard it in the old lore. Their offspring, lord of the earth, cannot be counted in full. It is without end.

Tarkshya and Arishtanemi, Garuda and Aruna, Aruni and Varuni: these are remembered as the children of Vinata. Shesha, who is Ananta, Vasuki, the serpent Takshaka, Kurma and Kulika: these are the mighty children of Kadru.

Bhimasena and Ugrasena, Suparna and Varuna, Gopati and Dhritarashtra, and Suryavarchas the seventh, Patravat, Arkaparna and the famous Prayuta, Bhima and Chitraratha, famous, all-knowing and self-controlled, Shalishiras, king, and Pradyumna the fourteenth, Kali the fifteenth and Narada the sixteenth: these divine gandharvas are named as the sons of Muni.

Now I will name other beings, Bharata. Prava bore Anavadya, Anuvasha, Anuna, Aruna, Priya, Anupa, Subhaga and Bhasi. And Siddha, Purna, Barhin and the famous Purnasha, Brahmacharin, Ratiguna and Suparna the seventh, Vishvavasu, Bhanu and Suchandra the tenth: these divine gandharvas are named as the sons of Prava.

And this family of apsarases, known for its holy marks, the fortunate goddess Prava bore long ago by a divine seer: Alambusha, Mishrakeshi, Vidyutparna, Tula, Anagha, Aruna, Rakshita, Rambha and Manorama, Asita, Subahu, Suvrata and Subhaja, and Supriya. And Atibahu, the famous Haha and Huhu, and Tumburu: these four are remembered as the best of the gandharvas.

The nectar, the brahmins, the cows, the gandharvas and the apsarases: these are named in the old lore as the offspring of Kapila.

So I have told you the origin of all beings, and counted rightly the gandharvas and apsarases, the snakes, the birds, the Rudras and the Maruts, the cows and the glorious brahmins of holy deeds. This account brings long life. It is holy and blessed, and pleasant to hear. It should always be heard, and always told without envy. Whoever reads this lineage of great souls with care, in the presence of brahmins and gods, wins children in plenty, fortune and fame, and a good path after death.

Brahma's six sons born of his mind, the great seers, are known. And the eleven famous sons of Sthanu, born of his highest mind, are Mrigavyadha, Sharva and the famous

Nirriti, Ajaikapad, Ahirbudhnya and Pinakin, the scorcher of enemies, Dahana and Ishvara, Kapalin of great splendour, Sthanu and the blessed Bhava. These are remembered as the eleven Rudras.

Marichi, Angiras, Atri, Pulastya, Pulaha and Kratu: these six are the sons of Brahma, mighty great seers. Angiras had three sons, famous everywhere in the world, all firm in their vows: Brihaspati, Utathya and Samvarta. Atri had many sons, so we hear, lord of men, all knowers of the Veda, perfected great seers of calm spirit. The rakshasas are Pulastya's, and the monkeys and the kinnaras. Pulaha's are the deer, the lions, the tigers and the kimpurushas. Kratu's sons, like sacrifices themselves, are the companions of the sun, famous in the three worlds, devoted to truth and to their vows.

The blessed seer Daksha, the son of Brahma, lord of the earth, the best of those who have sons, was born from Brahma's right thumb. His wife was born from the left thumb of that great soul. On her the sage fathered fifty daughters. They were all faultless in body, with eyes like lotuses. Daksha, the lord of creatures, had lost his sons, and so he appointed his daughters to bear sons for him. He gave ten to Dharma, twenty-seven to the Moon, and thirteen to Kashyapa, by the divine rite, king.

Hear the names of Dharma's wives as I tell them: Kirti, Lakshmi, Dhriti, Medha, Pushti, Shraddha and Kriya, Buddhi, Lajja and Mati. These ten are the wives of Dharma, made by the Self-born to be the doors of Dharma. The Moon's twenty-seven wives are famous in the world. The Moon's wives, of good vows, are set to measure time. All of them are joined with the lunar mansions, and they keep the world's course in order.

The Grandfather is the sage and god. His son is the lord of creatures. His sons are the eight Vasus. I will tell of them in full. Dhara, Dhruva, Soma, Ahas, Anila, Anala, Pratyusha and Prabhasa: these are remembered as the eight Vasus. Dhara was the son of Dhumra, and so was Dhruva, the knower of Brahman. The Moon was the son of Manasvini, and Shvasana, the wind, of Shvasa. Ahas was the son of Rata, and Hutashana, the fire, of Shandili. Pratyusha and Prabhasa are remembered as the sons of Prabhata.

Dhara's sons were Dravina and Hutahavyavaha. Dhruva's son was the blessed Kala, Time, who drives the world on. Soma's son was Varchas, by whom one becomes bright. Manohara's sons were Shishira, Prana and Ramana. The sons of Ahas are remembered as Jyotis, Shrama, Shanta and Muni. Agni's son was the glorious Kumara, whose home was in the reed forest. After him came Shakha, Vishakha and Naigamesha. Because the Kritikas took him as their own, he is remembered as Karttikeya. Anila's wife was Shiva. Her sons were Purojava and Avijnatagati: these were the two sons of Anila. Pratyusha's son, they know, was the seer named Devala, and Devala too had two sons, patient and wise.

Brihaspati's sister, the finest of women, chaste, perfected in yoga, roams the whole world, free of attachment. She was the wife of Prabhasa, the eighth of the Vasus. And the fortunate Vishvakarman was born, the lord of the crafts, the maker of a thousand crafts, the builder of the thirty gods. He made all ornaments, the best of craftsmen. He made the gods' heavenly chariots. Men live by that great one's craft, and they always honour Vishvakarman, who never passes away.

The blessed Dharma, in human form, broke out of Brahma's right breast, bringing happiness to all the worlds. He had three fine sons who charm all beings: Shama, Kama and Harsha, Calm, Desire and Joy, who hold up the world with their splendour. Kama's wife is Rati, Shama's wife is Prapti, and Harsha's wife is Nandi, on whom the worlds

rest.

Marichi's son was Kashyapa, and Kashyapa's sons were the gods and the asuras, tiger among kings. He is the source of the worlds. Tvashtri's daughter, the wife of Savitri, took the form of a mare, and in the sky that fortunate woman bore the two Ashvins. Aditi's sons are twelve, with Shakra at their head, lord of men. The youngest of them is Vishnu, on whom the worlds rest.

These are the thirty-three gods. I will tell you their descent, and their hosts by their sides and families. The Rudras are one side, the Sadhyas and the Maruts another. Know that the Vasus are of Bhrigu's side, and the Vishvadevas too. Mighty Garuda, the son of Vinata, and Aruna, and the blessed Brihaspati are counted among the Adityas. Know that the guhyakas come from the Ashvins, and so do all the plants and animals. This is the host of the gods, king, named in order. A man who tells it is freed from all his sins.

The blessed Bhrigu broke out of Brahma's heart. Bhrigu's son was the wise Kavi, and Kavi's son was Shukra, the planet. By the command of the Self-born he runs round the world to keep the three worlds alive, bringing rain and drought, fear and safety. A teacher of yoga, of great understanding, he became the guru of the daityas, and of the gods too, that wise one, chaste and strict in his vows.

When the lord had set that son of Bhrigu to work for the welfare of the worlds, Bhrigu fathered another son, a blameless one: Chyavana, blazing with austerity, righteous and wise, who fell from his mother's womb in anger to set her free, Bharata. Arushi, the daughter of Manu, was that wise man's wife. On her was born Aurva, of great fame, who split her thigh. He was a great ascetic of great splendour, full of virtues while he was still a child. His son was Richika, and Richika's son was Jamadagni. Great Jamadagni had four sons. Rama was the youngest of them, but not the least in virtue, skilled in every weapon and every divine weapon, the destroyer of the kshatriyas, master of himself. Aurva had a hundred sons, with Jamadagni the first of them. They had sons by the thousand, and so the Bhrigus spread.

Brahma had two other sons, whose marks remain in the world, Dhatri and Vidhatri, who stay with Manu. Their sister is the goddess Lakshmi, fair, who lives in the lotus. Her sons, born of her mind, are the horses that roam the sky. Varuna's eldest wife, the goddess, was born of Shukra. Know that her son is Bala, and her daughter Sura, the joy of the gods.

When creatures hungry for food began to eat one another, Adharma was born there, the destroyer of all beings. His wife was Nirriti, from whom the rakshasas called Nairritas come. She had three terrible sons, always given to evil deeds: Bhaya, Mahabhaya and Mrityu, Fear, Great Fear and Death, the ender of beings.

The goddess Tamra bore five daughters, famous in the world: Kaki, Shyeni, Bhasi, Dhritarashtra and Shuki. Kaki bore the owls, and Shyeni the hawks. Bhasi bore the bhasa birds and the vultures, lord of men. Dhritarashtra, the lovely one, bore all the geese and swans and the chakravaka birds, bless you. And Shuki, of good spirit, full of fine qualities and honoured for every good mark, bore the parrots, you who know dharma.

Krodhavasha bore nine daughters from herself: Mrigi and Mrigamanda, Hari and Bhadramana, Matangi, Sharduli, Shveta and Surabhi, and the famous Surasa, with every good mark. All the deer, best of men, are the children of Mrigi. The bears, the srimaras and the yaks

are Mrigamanda's. Bhadramana bore Airavata, the great elephant of the gods. The horses and the swift monkeys are the children of Hari, bless you, and they call the long-tailed monkeys Hari's sons too. Sharduli bore the lions and the tigers, Bharata, and all the leopards, fortunate one, without doubt. The elephants are the children of Matangi, lord of men. And Shveta bore Shveta, the swift elephant of the quarter.

Surabhi bore two daughters, king, Rohini, bless you, and the famous Gandharvi. The cows were born of Rohini, and the horses of Gandharvi. Surasa bore the nagas, king, and Kadru the serpents. Anala bore the seven trees with round fruit. Anala's daughter was Shuki, and Kadru's daughter was Surasa.

Aruna's wife, Shyeni, bore two mighty sons, Sampati and Jatayus. Vinata's two sons were the famous Garuda and Aruna.

So, lord of men, best of the wise, I have told you rightly the origin of all the great beings. When a man hears it rightly, he is cleansed of his sins. He gains knowledge of all things and reaches the highest path.

Chapter 22

Gods and Demons Born as Men

"Blessed one," said Janamejaya, "I want to hear the truth about the gods, the danavas, the yakshas and the rakshasas, and all the other beings: the births and the deeds of these great ones among men, one after another."

Lord of men, I will tell you all of the dwellers of heaven who were born among men. First I will tell you of the danavas.

The bull among the danavas who was known as Viprachitti became the bull among men known as Jarasandha. The son of Diti who is remembered as Hiranyakashipu, king, was born in the world of men as Shishupala, a bull among men. The one known as Samhrada, Prahrada's younger brother, was born as the famous Shalya, the bull of the Bahliskas. Bright Anuhrada, who was known as the youngest, became the king known as Dhrishtaketu. The daitya named Shibi, king, became a lord of the earth famous as Druma. The one named Bashkala, the best of the asuras, became the lord of men known as Bhagadatta.

Ayahshiras, Ashvashiras, mighty Ayahshanku, Gaganamurdhan and Vegavat the fifth: these five brave great asuras, king, were born among the Kekayas as great princes, the best of the bulls among kings. Another, the mighty one known as Ketuman, became a king on earth known as Amitaujas. The glorious great asura known as Svarbhanu became the king of fierce deeds known as Ugrasena. The glorious great asura known as Ashva became a king named Ashoka, of great valour and courage. His younger brother, king, who is remembered as Ashvapati, a daitya, became a king, Hardikya, a bull among men.

The glorious great asura known as Vrishaparvan became a king on earth known as Dirghaprajna. Ajaka, king, the younger brother of Vrishaparvan, became a king on earth known as Malla. The strong great asura known as Ashvagriva became a king on earth known as Rochamana. Sukshma, king, who was called wise and famous, became a king on earth known as Brihanta. The best of the asuras known as Tuhunda became a lord of men known as Senabindu. The one named Isripa, the strongest of those asuras, became a king named Papajit, of famous courage on earth. The great asura known as Ekachakra became the famous Prativindhya on earth. Virupaksha, a daitya, a great asura of many ways of fighting, became a king on earth known as Chitravarman. The hero Hara, the best of the danavas, who took away his enemies, was born as a bull among men known as Suvastu. Ahara, of great splendour, who destroyed the side of his enemies, became a famous king on earth named Bahlika.

Nichandra, the best of the asuras, whose face was like the moon, became a glorious king known as Munjakesha. Nikumbha, unconquered in battle, was born on earth as a king of great mind, the best of kings, remembered as Devadhipa. The one named Sharabha, the great asura among those daityas, became a royal seer among men here named Paurava. The second, Shalabha, among those asuras, became a lord of men, a Bahlika named Prahrada. Chandra, the best of the sons of Diti, like the lord of the stars in the world, became a royal seer named Rishika, the best of kings.

The best of the asuras known as Mritapa, know him, best of kings, as the king Pashchimanupaka. The great asura of great splendour, known as Gavishta, became a king on earth known as Drumasena. The glorious great asura known as Mayura became a lord of the earth known as Vishva. His younger brother, known as Suparna, became a king on earth known as Kalakirti. The chief asura who was called Chandrahantri became a royal seer, a

lord of men, named Shunaka. The great asura called the Destroyer of the Moon became a royal seer, a lord of men, named Janaki. The bull among the danavas who was called Dirghajihva, Kauravya, became a lord of the earth known as the king of Kashi. The planet that Simhi bore, the tormentor of the moon and the sun, became a lord of men known as Kratha.

The eldest asura of the four sons of Anayu, bright Vikshara, became the king Vasumitra. The second, the great asura after Vikshara, lord of men, became a king famous as the lord of the Pamsu kingdom. The best of the asuras known as Balavira became a lord of men, Paundramatsyaka. The great asura known as Vritra, king, became a royal seer, a lord of men, named Maniman. His younger brother, the asura Krodhahantri, became a king on earth known as Danda. The other, called Krodhavardhana, became a lord of men known as Dandadhara.

Of the sons of Kalaka, eight became lords of men, tiger among kings, with the courage of tigers. In Magadha the glorious Jayatsena became king, the eldest of those eight Kaleyas, a great asura. The second of them, as glorious as Indra, became the lord of men named Aparajita. The third, great king, a strong-armed great asura, was born as the king of the Nishadas, of terrible valour on earth. Another of them, called the fourth, became famous on earth as Shreniman, the best of royal seers. The fifth, the best of them, a great asura, became famous here as Mahaujas, the scorcher of enemies. The sixth, a wise great asura among them, became famous on earth as Abhiru, the best of royal seers. And King Samudrasena came from that same host, famous on the earth that ends at the sea, who knew the truth of dharma and of wealth. The eighth of the Kaleyas, named Brihat, king, was a righteous scorcher of enemies, devoted to the good of all beings.

I named to you, king, the host called the Krodhavashas. From them heroic lords of men were born here on earth. They were Nandika, Karnaveshta, Siddhartha and Kitaka, Suvira and Subahu, and the great hero Bahlika. They were Krodha, Vichitya, Surasa and glorious King Nila, Viradhaman, Kauravya, and the one named Bhumipala. There was the one named Dantavakra, and the one named Durjaya. There was Rukmin, tiger among kings, and King Janamejaya. There were Ashadha, Vayuvega and Bhuritejas, Ekalavya, Sumitra, Vatadhana and Gomukha. There were the kings of the Karushas, and Kshemadhurti, Shrutayus, Uddhava and Brihatsena. There were Kshemogratirtha, and Kuhara, lord of men among the Kalingas, and Matimat, lord of men, and the one known as Ishvara. So a host of kings was born on earth long ago from the Krodhavashas, great king, of great fame and great strength.

The one called Devaka, as bright as the king of the gods, the chief lord of the gandharvas, was born on earth as a lord of men.

Know, Bharata, that Drona, the son of Bharadvaja, came from a portion of the famous divine seer Brihaspati. He was not born from a womb. Among archers, tiger among kings, he knew all weapons best. That famous man, of great splendour, was born here among men. Those who know the Veda know Drona as the best in the Veda and in the science of the bow. His deeds were like Indra's, and he made his own family great.

Mahadeva and Death, desire and anger, were joined together as one, Bharata. From them was born the hero Ashvatthama, the scorcher of enemies. He lived on earth, lord of men, a hero of great courage with eyes like lotus petals, a destroyer of the enemy's side.

The eight Vasus were born to Ganga as the sons of Shantanu, by the curse of Vasishtha and by the command of Vasava. The youngest of them was Bhishma, who made the Kurus safe.

He was wise and eloquent, he knew the Veda, and he destroyed the enemy's side. He was the best of all the wise, of great splendour. He fought with the great Rama Jamadagnya, the son of Bhrigu.

There was a brahmin seer on earth named Kripa, king, of great manhood. Know that he came from the host of the Rudras. There was a king named Shakuni, a great warrior in the world, the crusher of enemies. Know him, king, as Dvapara born. Truthful Satyaki carried on the line of the Vrishnis. That crusher of enemies was born from the side of the gods called the Maruts. And the royal seer Drupada came from that same host, in this world of men, king, the best of all who bear weapons. From there too, know, king, came King Kritavarma, the best of bulls among the kshatriyas. His deeds had no equal. And the royal seer named Virata, who scorched the kingdoms of his enemies, was born from the host of the Maruts.

The son of Arishta known as Hamsa was the lord of the gandharvas. He was born to make the Kuru line grow, as Dhritarashtra, the son of Krishna Dvaipayana. He was a long-armed lord of men of great splendour, whose eyes were his wisdom. Because of his mother's fault and the seer's anger, he was born blind.

Know that the very fortunate son of Atri, the best of those who have sons, was born in this world as Vidura, the best of the wise.

From a portion of Kali was born King Duryodhana on earth, of wicked mind and evil thoughts, the disgrace of the Kurus. That man of Kali was hated by the whole world. That lowest of men had the whole earth killed. By him the enmity was kindled that made an end of beings.

All the brothers born of Pulastya were born among men here: the hundred, with Duhshasana first, all of them cruel in their deeds. Durmukha and Duhsaha, and the others not named, were Duryodhana's helpers, the sons of Pulastya, bull of the Bharatas.

Know, king, that King Yudhishtira was a portion of Dharma, Bhimasena of the Wind, and Arjuna of the king of the gods. And in the same way Nakula and Sahadeva, of beauty without equal on earth, who charmed the whole world, were portions of the Ashvins.

The mighty son of Soma known as Suvarchas became Abhimanyu, of great fame, the son of Arjuna. Know that Dhristadyumna, the great warrior, was a portion of Agni, and know, king, that Shikhandi, both woman and man, was a rakshasa. The five sons of Draupadi, bull of the Bharatas, know them, king, as the hosts of the Vishvadevas.

Karna, the great warrior, who was born wearing his armour, know him as a portion of the god Divakara, the Sun, beyond compare.

He who is called Narayana, the god of gods, the eternal: his portion among men was mighty Vasudeva. Mighty Baladeva was a portion of the naga Shesha. And know, king, that powerful Pradyumna was Sanatkumara. So, lord of men, many other portions of the dwellers of heaven were born in the family of Vasudeva, making it grow.

I named to you, king, the host of the apsaras. A share of them was born on earth by Vasava's command. Those sixteen thousand goddesses, lord of men, were born in the world of men as the wives of Narayana.

A share of Shri was born on the surface of the earth for love, in Drupada's family, from the middle of the altar: a girl without fault. She was neither too short nor too tall, and she smelled of the blue lotus. Her eyes were long like lotuses, her hips were lovely, and her hair was black and long. She had every good mark, and she shone like beryl. In private she stirred the hearts of five lords among men.

The two goddesses Siddhi and Dhriti were born as Kunti and Madri, the mothers of the five. And Mati was born as the daughter of Subala.

So, king, I have told you how portions of the gods and the asuras came down to earth, and of the gandharvas, the apsaras and the rakshasas. I have told you of the kings born on earth, mad for battle, and of the great ones born in the wide family of the Yadus. This account of the descent of the portions should be heard without envy. It brings wealth, fame, sons, long life and victory. The wise man who has heard the descent of the portions of the gods, the gandharvas and the rakshasas knows the origin and the end of things, and he does not sink down in hard times.

Chapter 23

The King Who Went Hunting

"Brahmin," said Janamejaya, "I have heard from you, as it should be told, how the gods, the danavas and the rakshasas came down to earth in portions, and the gandharvas and apsaras too. Now I want to hear again the line of the Kurus, from the beginning, told by you in the presence of these brahmins and seers."

There was a mighty king named Dushyanta, bull of the Bharatas, who founded the line of the Pauravas and protected the earth to its four ends. That lord of men ruled a full quarter of the earth, and the lands girt by the sea. The winner of battles, the crusher of enemies, ruled all the lands as far as the barbarians and the forest tribes. He ruled to the edges of the ocean, the mine of jewels, where the four classes of people lived.

While that king ruled, no one caused the classes to be mixed, no one had to plough or dig mines, and no one did evil. Men took their pleasure in dharma, tiger among men, and so they gained both dharma and wealth, while that lord of the land ruled. There was no fear of thieves, my friend, and not the least fear of hunger. There was no fear of sickness while he ruled the land. The classes delighted in their own dharma, and they did not perform rites to gain what they desired. With that lord of the earth to shelter them, they had nothing to fear from any side.

The rain god rained at the right time, and the crops were full of fruit. The earth was rich in every jewel and full of wealth. The young king was of wonderful courage, and his body was as hard as a thunderbolt. He could have lifted Mandara in his two arms and carried it off, with its woods and its forests. He was a master of the bow and of fighting with the mace, of the sword and the other hand weapons, on elephant and on horseback. In strength he was like Vishnu, in splendour like the sun. He was as unshakeable as the ocean, and as patient as the earth. That lord of the earth was loved by all. His city and his kingdom were content, and he lived among people known for the love of dharma.

Once the strong-armed king went to a deep forest with a great army and many beasts of burden, surrounded by hundreds of horses and elephants. He went with hundreds of warriors around him, heroes carrying swords and spears, maces and clubs, lances and javelins. As the king went, a joyful din rose up. There were the lion roars of the warriors, the sound of conches and drums and the rumble of chariot wheels. The great elephants trumpeted, the horses neighed, and the men gave war cries and slapped their arms.

The women stood on the roofs of the finest palaces and watched the hero, who had won his own fame, in all his royal splendour. The crowds of women watched him, weapon in hand. He was like Shakra, the slayer of enemies, who could hold back the elephants of his foes. This is the tiger among men, they thought, *of wonderful valour in battle. Those who meet the strength of his arms are no longer enemies.* As they said this, the women praised the king with love. They let showers of flowers fall on his head.

On every side, the chief brahmins praised him. He set out gladly for the forest, wanting to hunt deer. The people of the city and the country followed him a long way, and then turned back when the king gave them leave.

The lord of the earth filled the earth and the heavens with the roar of his chariot,

which was like Garuda. As he went, the wise king saw a forest like Indra's garden of Nandana, full of bilva, arka and khadira trees, and crowded with kapittha and dhava trees. It was rough with mountain slopes and covered with stones. It had no water and no people, and it stretched for many yojanas. It was full of herds of deer and other fierce creatures of the forest.

Dushyanta, the tiger among men, with his servants, his army and his beasts of burden, stirred that forest up, killing deer of many kinds. When packs of tigers came within range of his arrows, Dushyanta brought them down and pierced them with his shafts. Some, the bull among men struck from far off with arrows. Others, which came close, he cut down with his sword. He killed some antelopes with his spear, the best of spearmen. He knew the art of whirling the mace, and he moved about with courage beyond measure. He went about killing the beasts and birds of the forest with lances and swords, with maces, clubs and heavy staves.

As the king of wonderful courage and his warriors, who loved to fight, stirred up the great forest, the great beasts fled it. Their herds were scattered and their leaders killed, and the herds of deer cried out in fear here and there. Some went to a dried-up river. Worn thin by the hope of water that failed them, their hearts spent with running, they fell down senseless. Some, overcome with hunger and thirst and weariness, fell to the ground, and hungry tigers among men ate them. Some of the forest people made a fire, lit it, and cut up the meat properly and ate it.

Some elephants there, mad with rut, strong, wounded by weapons, curled up the tips of their trunks and ran off fast in fear. Dropping dung and urine, and streaming with blood, the great wild elephants trampled many men there. The forest, full of buffaloes, covered by the cloud of the army with its rain of arrows, shone, its great beasts killed by the king.

When he had killed thousands of deer, the king, with his great train, went on into another forest, still hunting deer. He was alone now, the man of great strength, hungry and thirsty. He came to the end of that forest and reached a great barren plain. He crossed that too, and came to another great forest, with a fine hermitage in it. It gladdened the heart and was a delight to the eye, and cool winds blew there.

It was full of flowering trees, with soft, pleasant grass, wide, and ringing with the sweet songs of birds. Trees with spreading branches gave pleasant shade, and the creepers stirred with the humming of the bees. It was full of the greatest beauty. In that forest there was no tree without flowers or without fruit, no tree with thorns, and none without bees swarming on it. It rang with the songs of birds and was lovely with flowers, with trees that flowered in every season and soft, pleasant grass. The great archer entered that lovely, splendid forest.

Trees heavy with blossom, shaken by the wind, dropped showers of many-coloured flowers again and again. Trees that touched the sky, ringing with the sweet voices of birds, shone there, clothed in bright flowers. On their young shoots, bent low under their flowers, the birds sang softly, with the bees. He saw many spots adorned with heaps of flowers, ringed with bowers of creepers, that gladdened the heart, and the man of great splendour was full of joy.

The forest was beautiful with trees whose branches, covered in flowers, twined together, like the banners of great Indra. A cool, sweet-smelling breeze, carrying the pollen of

flowers, moved among the trees of the forest as if it wanted to play with them. The king saw that forest, with all these virtues, growing lovely on the bank of a river, like a raised banner.

As he looked at that forest, full of happy birds, he saw a fine hermitage, lovely and charming, full of trees of every kind, where fires were burning. It was full of ascetics and Valakhilyas and hosts of sages. It had many fire-houses, and it was spread with carpets of flowers, and great, wide groves made it shine.

It lay on both banks of the holy Malini river, king, a river with pleasant water, crowded with birds of many kinds, lovely with its ascetics' groves. There he saw beasts of prey that were gentle, and he was filled with joy.

The glorious warrior came to that hermitage, like the world of the gods, lovely on every side. He saw the river that flowed round the hermitage, its water holy, standing there like the mother of all living creatures. Its banks were full of chakravaka birds, and it carried a foam of flowers along. Kinnaras lived there, and monkeys and bears came to it. It rang with holy recitation, and its sandbanks made it beautiful. Elephants in rut, tigers and great snakes came to it.

When he saw the river that flowed round the hermitage, and the hermitage itself, the king made up his mind to go in. It was adorned by the Malini, with its islands and lovely banks, like the place of Nara and Narayana made beautiful by the Ganga. He entered the great forest, which rang with the cries of peacocks mad with joy.

The lord of men came to that place. It was like the garden of Chitraratha, full of every virtue and too bright for words. He had come to see the great seer Kanva, the Kashyapa, whose wealth was austerity. At the entrance to the forest he halted his army, crowded with chariots and horses and foot soldiers. "I will go to see the sage, the Kashyapa, who is free from passion and rich in austerity," he told it. "Wait here until I come back."

When the lord of men reached that forest, like Nandana, he forgot his hunger and thirst, and he was filled with joy. The lord of men put aside the signs of his rank. He went to that fine hermitage with his ministers and his family priest. He wanted to see the seer there, the heap of austerity who never passes away.

He looked at the hermitage, like the world of Brahma, ringing with the songs of the bees and full of birds of many kinds. As the rites went on, the tiger among men heard the chief of the Rig Veda priests chanting its verses, word by word and step by step. The hermitage shone with men who knew the science of sacrifice and its limbs, who chanted the steps, men of boundless spirit and strict discipline. The best of the Atharva Veda priests, honoured by the priests of the great sacrifices, recited the collections word by word and step by step. Other brahmins spoke with correct sounds, and the glorious hermitage, ringing with their voices, shone like the world of Brahma.

It rang on every side with learned men. Some knew how to prepare the sacrifice and were skilled in the rules of recitation. Some had mastered the Vedas and understood the truth of logic and its meaning. Some were skilled in joining many statements together, and some knew the special rites. Some were devoted to the dharma of release. Some knew how to set out a proposition, raise an objection, and reach a conclusion and the highest truth. And among them was the chief of the Lokayatikas, the materialists.

Here and there the slayer of enemy heroes saw lords among brahmins, self-controlled, strict in their vows, given to prayer and offerings, perfected. The lord of the earth was amazed to see the bright seats, spread with flowers, set out with care. When the best of kings saw the worship the brahmins paid at the shrines of the gods, he thought himself in the world of Brahma. He could not look enough at that fine and lovely hermitage, guarded by the austerity of the Kashyapa, and full of hosts of ascetics.

The slayer of enemies entered the Kashyapa's dwelling with his ministers and his family priest. It was secluded, lovely beyond words and blessed, and seers of great vows, rich in austerity, surrounded it on every side.

Shakuntala

Then the strong-armed king went on alone, sending his ministers away. He did not see the seer of strict vows in the hermitage. When he did not see the seer, and saw that the hermitage was empty, he called out loudly, as if to make the forest ring: "Who is here?"

When she heard his voice, a girl came out of the hermitage, like the goddess of fortune in bodily form, dressed as a woman ascetic. As soon as the dark-eyed girl saw King Dushyanta, she said at once, "Welcome." She honoured him with a seat, with water for his feet and the guest offering, and she asked after the king's health and welfare, king. When she had honoured him properly and asked after his health, she said, almost smiling, "What can I do for you?"

The king had been honoured as was right. He saw that the girl was faultless in every limb, and he said to her, as she spoke so sweetly, "I have come to wait on the fortunate seer Kanva. Where has the blessed one gone, good lady? Tell me, lovely one."

"My father, the blessed one, has gone out of the hermitage to fetch fruit," said Shakuntala. "Wait a moment, and you will see him when he comes."

The king did not see the seer, and she had told him this. He looked at her, lovely and glorious, with her charming smile, shining with beauty, austerity and self-control, full of youth and grace, and the lord of the earth said, "Who are you, and whose, you with the lovely hips? Why have you come to the forest? With such beauty and such virtue, where do you come from, lovely one? From the moment I saw you, you have stolen my heart. I want to know who you are. Tell me, lovely one."

When the king said this to her in the hermitage, the girl laughed, and answered in the sweetest words. "I am held to be the daughter of the blessed Kanva, Dushyanta: the famous ascetic, who is steadfast and knows dharma."

"The fortunate one, the blessed one honoured by the world, keeps his seed," said Dushyanta. "Dharma itself might stray from its course, but he of the strict vows would not stray. How could you, so beautiful, be his daughter? I have a great doubt about this. You must cut it away."

"Hear, king," said Shakuntala, "how I came to know this, and how it happened long ago, and how I am the sage's daughter. A seer came here once, and asked about my birth. Hear, lord of the earth, what the blessed one told him.

"Long ago, they say, Vishvamitra was practising great austerity, and he tormented Shakra, the lord of the hosts of the gods, very much. *His power is blazing with austerity, Indra, the breaker of cities, thought in fear. He may throw me from my place.* So he said to Menaka,

""Menaka, you are the first of the apsarases in heavenly gifts. Do me a kindness, lovely one. Hear what I have to tell you. Vishvamitra, a great ascetic, as bright as the sun, is practising terrible austerity, and he makes my heart shake. Vishvamitra is your task, Menaka, you of the slender waist. His spirit is sharpened, he is very hard to overcome, and he is deep in fierce austerity. So that he does not throw me from my place, go to him and tempt him. Break his austerity. Do me this great kindness. Tempt

him with your beauty and youth, your sweetness, your movements, your smiles and your words, lovely one, and turn him from his austerity."

""That blessed one is full of power," said Menaka, "and always a great ascetic, and quick to anger. You know him too, blessed one. You yourself are afraid of the splendour, the austerity and the anger of that great soul. How could I not be afraid? He is the one who took the fortunate Vasishtha's beloved sons from him. He was born a kshatriya, and he made himself a brahmin by force. For his bathing he made a river, hard to cross because of its many waters, the holiest in the world, which people know as the Kaushiki. There, long ago, in a hard time, the righteous royal seer Matanga, who had become a hunter, supported that great soul's wife. When the famine was over, the sage came back to his hermitage, and then the lord named the river Para. There, glad at heart, he himself made Matanga sacrifice, and you, lord of the gods, went to drink the soma out of fear of him. In his anger he made new lines of stars, a rival wealth of stars, beginning with Shravana.

""These are his deeds, and I am very much afraid of him. Tell me what to do, lord, so that he does not burn me in his anger. He could burn up the worlds with his splendour. He could shake the earth with his foot. He could shrink great Meru and spin it round in a moment. How could a girl like me touch a man like that, joined to austerity, blazing like fire, the master of his senses? His mouth is blazing fire, his eyes are the sun and the moon and the stars, his tongue is Time, best of the gods. How could a girl like me touch him? Yama, Soma, the great seers, the Sadhyas, the Vishvadevas and all the Valakhilyas fear his power. Why should a woman like me not fear him?

""But you have told me to go, lord of the gods. How could I not go near the seer? Only think of how to protect me, king of the gods, so that I can move about safely for your sake. Let the Wind lay bare my clothes as I play there, god. And by your grace, let Manmatha, the god of love, be my helper in the task. And let a sweet wind blow from the forest when I tempt the seer."

"Indra said, "So be it," and he arranged it. Then she went to the hermitage of the Kaushika.

"Shakra gave his orders to the wind, which is always moving, and Menaka set out, when the time came, with the Wind. The timid, lovely Menaka saw Vishvamitra in his hermitage, practising austerity, his sins burned away by it. She greeted him, and then she began to play near the seer. And the Wind carried off her garment, white as the moon. She ran to the ground quickly, reaching after the garment, smiling shyly, it seemed, at the Wind, that lovely woman.

"The best of sages saw Menaka bare, flustered, eager for her garment, her youth and beauty beyond words. When that bull among brahmins saw her beauty and her charm, he set his heart on lying with her, overcome by desire. He invited her, and the faultless woman was willing. The two of them spent a very long time there in the forest, taking their pleasure as they wished, and it seemed to them like a single day.

"The sage fathered Shakuntala on Menaka, on a lovely slope of the Himalaya, beside the river Malini. Menaka left the newborn child on the bank of the Malini, and, her task done, she went quickly back to Shakra's court.

"Birds saw the baby lying in the lonely forest, full of lions and tigers, and they

gathered round her on every side. So that the flesh-eaters, greedy for meat, would not harm the little girl in the forest, the birds, the shakuntas, guarded Menaka's daughter there.

"I went there to bathe, and I saw her lying in the lonely wild forest, with birds all around her. I brought her home and took her as my daughter. The one who makes the body, the one who gives life, and the one whose food we eat: these three, in that order, are called fathers in the rules of dharma. Because she was guarded by shakuntas in the lonely forest, I named her Shakuntala. Know, my friend, that Shakuntala is my daughter, and the faultless Shakuntala thinks of me as her father.'

"That is what he told the great seer when he was asked about my birth. So know that I am Kanva's daughter, lord of men. I think of Kanva as my father, for I do not know my own. That is what I have told you, king, as it happened and as I heard it."

"It is plain that you are a king's daughter, from what you say, lovely one," said Dushyanta. "Be my wife, you of the lovely hips. Tell me what I can do for you. Today I will bring you golden garlands, clothes, earrings of fine gold, bright jewels and gems from many cities, golden coins and skins. Let my whole kingdom be yours today. Be my wife, lovely one. Come to me, timid one, by the gandharva marriage, beautiful one. For of all marriages, you whose thighs are like the plantain, the gandharva is said to be the best."

"My father has gone out from this hermitage to gather fruit, king," said Shakuntala. "Wait a moment for him. He will give me to you."

"I want you, lovely one, faultless one, to be willing," said Dushyanta. "Know that I am here for your sake, for my heart has gone to you. The self is its own kin. The self is the only refuge of the self. You may give yourself, by dharma."

"In short, eight kinds of marriage are remembered as lawful: the brahma, the daiva, the arsha, the prajapatya, the asura, the gandharva, the rakshasa, and the paishacha is remembered as the eighth. Manu, the son of the Self-born, told the dharma of each in order. Know that the first four are praised for a brahmin, and, faultless one, that six in order are lawful for a kshatriya. For kings the rakshasa is also allowed, and the asura is remembered for vaishyas and shudras. Of the last five, three are lawful and two unlawful. The paishacha and the asura must never be done. This is the rule to follow. This is remembered as the way of dharma. The gandharva and the rakshasa are both lawful for a kshatriya. Do not fear it. They may be done singly or together. There is no doubt of it. So, lovely one, you desire me as I desire you, and you should become my wife by the gandharva marriage."

"If this is the path of dharma," said Shakuntala, "and if I am my own mistress to give myself, then hear my condition, best of the Pauravas, my lord. Promise me truly what I tell you here in private. The son born to me must be crown prince after you, great king. Tell me this truly. If this is so, Dushyanta, let me be joined with you."

"So be it," the king answered her, without stopping to think. "And I will take you to my own city, you of the bright smile, as you deserve, lovely one. I tell you this truly."

When he had said this, the royal seer took the hand of that girl, whose walk was graceful, by the rite, and he lay with her. He gave her his word, and then he went away,

saying again and again, "I will send an army of four divisions for you. With it I will bring you to my home, you of the bright smile."

So the king promised her, Janamejaya, and went away, thinking about the Kashyapa. *When the blessed one, so rich in austerity, hears of this, what will he do?* So he wondered as he entered his own city.

A moment after he had gone, Kanva came back to the hermitage. Shakuntala was ashamed, and she did not go to meet her father. But Kanva, the great ascetic with heavenly knowledge, knew. Seeing with his heavenly eye, the blessed one was pleased, and said, "What you did today, you who are of a royal line, joining with a man without asking me, does not harm dharma. For a kshatriya the gandharva marriage is said to be the best: a desiring woman with a desiring man, in private, without mantras. Dushyanta, the best of men, whom you went to, loving him, Shakuntala, is righteous and great-souled. A great-souled son will be born to you in the world, very strong. He will rule this whole earth, whose edges are the oceans. And when that great one marches against his enemies, the wheel of his chariot will roll on, never checked, for he will be an emperor."

Then she washed the feet of the sage when he had rested, took his load from him, and set out the fruit. And she said to him, "Dushyanta, the best of men, is the husband I have chosen. You should be gracious to him and to his ministers."

"I am gracious to him already, for your sake, lovely one," said Kanva. "And for his sake, choose from me whatever boon you wish."

Then Shakuntala, wanting good for Dushyanta, chose that the Pauravas should always be righteous and should never fall from their kingdom.

The Voice from the Sky

When Dushyanta had given his word and gone, Shakuntala, the lovely one, bore a boy of boundless power. It was when three full years had passed, Janamejaya: the son of Dushyanta, blazing like fire, full of beauty, generosity and virtue. Kanva, the best of those who do holy deeds, performed the rite of birth and the other rites for the wise boy as he grew.

His teeth were white and pointed, and his body was built like a lion's. His hands were marked with the wheel, his head was large, and he was glorious and very strong. The boy, shining like a child of the gods, grew quickly there. When he was only six years old, the strong child caught tigers, lions and boars, elephants and buffaloes, and tied them to the trees all round Kanva's hermitage. He rode them and tamed them, and ran about playing with them.

So the people who lived in Kanva's hermitage gave him a name. "Let him be Sarvadamana, the Tamer of All," they said, "for he tames everything." So the boy became Sarvadamana, full of courage, force and strength.

The seer saw the boy and his more than human deeds, and he said to Shakuntala, "It is time for him to be crown prince." Kanva knew the boy's strength, and he said to his pupils, "Take Shakuntala, with her son, from this hermitage to her husband quickly, today. She has every good mark and is honoured by all. It is not good for women to live long among their own kin. It destroys their good name, their conduct and their dharma. So take her without delay."

"So be it," they all said, and those men of boundless power set out for the city named for the elephant, with Shakuntala and her son ahead of them. The fair woman took her lotus-eyed son, who shone like a child of the immortals, and came from the forest where Dushyanta had known her. She came to the king and was announced, and she was brought in with her son, who was as bright as the rising sun.

She greeted him properly, and Shakuntala said to him, "This is your son, king. Let him be consecrated as crown prince. For this son, like a god, was born to me by you, king. Keep the agreement you made about him, best of men. Remember the agreement you made, fortunate one, when we came together in Kanva's hermitage."

When he heard her words, the king remembered. And yet he said, "I do not remember. Whose woman are you, wicked ascetic? I do not remember any bond with you, of dharma, love or wealth. Go or stay as you please. Do what you like."

When he said this, the lovely woman of spirit stood as if ashamed, as if stunned with pain, as still as a post. Her eyes grew red with fury and indignation, and her lips trembled. She looked at the king sideways, as if she would burn him with her glances. She hid what she felt, though anger drove her, and she held in the fire she had stored up by austerity. For a moment she thought, full of grief and indignation. Then she looked straight at her husband and spoke in anger.

"You know, great king. Why do you speak like this? 'I do not know', you say, freely, like any common man. Your heart knows what is true and what is false here. You are the witness, good sir. Do not despise yourself. A man who is one thing and makes himself out

to be another: what evil has that thief not done, who has robbed himself of himself?

"You think, I am alone. You do not know the ancient sage who lives in the heart. He knows the evil deed, and it is in front of him that you do wrong. A man who does evil thinks, No one knows me. But the gods know him, and so does the person within him. The sun and the moon, the wind and the fire, the sky, the earth and the waters, the heart and Yama, the day and the night and both twilights, and Dharma: they all know what a man does. Yama, the son of Vivasvat, takes away the evil deeds of the man with whom the knower of the field is pleased, the witness of deeds who lives in the heart. But the wicked man with whom he is not pleased, Yama makes that evildoer pay for his evil deeds. The gods do not favour a man who despises himself and makes himself out to be other than he is, for even his own self does not stand for him.

"Do not despise me because I came to you of my own accord. I am a faithful wife. You do not honour me, though I deserve the guest offering, your own wife who has come to you. Why do you look down on me in the assembly like a common woman? I am not crying in an empty place. Do you not hear me? If you will not do what I ask you, Dushyanta, your head will split into a hundred pieces today.

"A husband enters his wife, and he is born again from her. That is why the poets of old knew that a wife is called jaya, the one in whom a man is born. The child born to a man who knows the sacred tradition saves by its line his forefathers who have died before. Because a son saves his father from the hell called Put, the Self-born himself called him putra, the son.

"She is a wife who is skilled in the house. She is a wife who bears children. She is a wife whose husband is her life. She is a wife who is faithful to her husband. A wife is half a man. A wife is the best of friends. A wife is the root of dharma, wealth and love. A wife is a friend to the dying. Men with wives perform the rites. Men with wives are householders. Men with wives are glad. Men with wives have good fortune. Sweet-spoken wives are friends in lonely places. They are fathers in the duties of dharma, and mothers to the suffering. Even in the wilderness, a wife is a rest to a man on the road. A man with a wife is trusted. So wives are the highest refuge.

"When a husband has died and passes through the world, going alone through hard places, only his wife, if she is faithful, follows him always. If the wife dies first, she waits for her husband after death. If the husband dies first, the good wife follows him afterwards. For this reason, king, marriage is sought, so that the husband has his wife in this world and in the next.

"The wise say that a son is the self, born of the self. So a man should look on his wife, the mother of his son, as his mother. When the father sees the son born in his wife, like his own face in a mirror, he is glad, like a man of good deeds who has reached heaven. Men who burn with the pains of the mind, or suffer with sickness, are glad in their wives, as men who suffer from the heat are glad in water. A wise man should never say a harsh word to women, even when he is very angry, seeing that love, joy and dharma depend on them. Women are the eternal, holy field of a man's own birth. What power do even the seers have to make children without women?

"When a son runs up, covered in the dust of the earth, and hugs his father's limbs, what could be better than that? Here is your son, who has come to you of his own accord, looking at you longingly out of the corner of his eye. Why do you scorn him? Even ants

carry their own eggs and do not break them. How can you not support your own son, when you know dharma? The touch of clothes, of women, of water, is not as sweet as the touch of your own little son when you hold him in your arms. The brahmin is the best of two-footed beings, the cow the best of four-footed ones. The teacher is the best of those to be honoured, and a son the best of all things to touch. Let this lovely son hold you and touch you. There is no touch in the world sweeter than the touch of a son.

"I bore this boy, tamer of enemies, when three full years had passed, king of kings, to take away your sorrow. 'He will perform a hundred horse sacrifices, Paurava.' So a voice from the sky said to me long ago, when I was lying in after his birth.

"Surely men who go to another village take their sons on their laps with love, and smell their heads, and rejoice in them. The twice-born, as you know too, speak this verse from the Vedas at the birth rites of their sons: 'From limb after limb you come into being. From the heart you are born. You are the self that is called a son. Live a hundred autumns. My life depends on you, and my line that never ends. So live, my child, in great happiness, a hundred autumns.'

"This boy was born from your limbs, a second man from a man. Look at your son, like your second self in a clear pool. As the offering fire is carried from the household fire, so this boy was born from you. You were one, and you have become two.

"When you were hunting, king, led away by a deer, you came upon me, a girl in my father's hermitage. Urvashi, Purvachitti, Sahajanya and Menaka, Vishvachi and Ghritachi are the six finest apsaras. Of them the one called Menaka, sprung from Brahma, the finest of the apsaras, came down from heaven to earth and bore me to Vishvamitra. That apsaras Menaka bore me on a slope of the Himalaya, and she threw me away and went, the heartless woman, as if I were someone else's child. What evil did I do in a former life, that I was abandoned by my family as a child, and now by you? If you cast me off, I will go back to the hermitage. But you should not cast off this child, your own son."

"I do not know this son that was born to you, Shakuntala," said Dushyanta. "Women are liars. Who will believe what you say? Your mother Menaka is a heartless wanton, who threw you away on a slope of the Himalaya like a used garland. And your father, born of a kshatriya womb, the heartless Vishvamitra, greedy for the rank of a brahmin, is a slave to lust. Menaka is the finest of the apsaras, and your father one of the great seers. How can you, their child, talk like a wanton? Are you not ashamed to tell such an unbelievable story, and to me above all? Go away, wicked ascetic! Where is the great seer, always fierce, and where is that apsaras Menaka, and where are you, so poor, dressed as an ascetic woman? And your son is too big. He is a child, and yet so strong. How has he shot up in so short a time, like the trunk of a sal tree? Your birth is very low. You look like a wanton to me. Menaka bore you by chance, out of lust. All that you say is beyond my knowledge, ascetic. I do not know you. Go where you like."

"King," said Shakuntala, "you see the faults of others, though they are as small as mustard seeds. Your own, as big as bilva fruits, you see and do not see. Menaka is among the thirty gods, and the thirty gods follow Menaka. My birth is higher than yours, Dushyanta. You walk on the earth, king. I move through the sky. See the difference between us, like Meru and a mustard seed. I go to the palaces of great Indra, of Kubera, of Yama and of Varuna. See my power, king.

"There is a true saying I will tell you, sinless one, as an example, not out of hatred.

When you have heard it, you should forgive me. As long as an ugly man does not see his face in a mirror, he thinks himself more handsome than others. But when he sees his ugly face in the mirror, then he knows the difference between himself and others. A man who is very handsome despises no one. A man who talks too much, and speaks ill, becomes a nuisance here. A fool who hears men talking, of good things and bad, takes the bad words, as a pig takes dung. A wise man who hears men talking, of good things and bad, takes the good words, as a goose takes the milk from the water. As a good man grieves when he speaks ill of others, so a wicked man is glad when he speaks ill of others. As the good find happiness when they bow to their elders, so the fool is happy when he abuses the good. Those who do not look for faults live happily. The fools look for faults. Where the good should be spoken of by others, such men call others what they are themselves. And there is nothing more laughable in the world than when a wicked man calls a good man wicked.

"From a man who has fallen from truth and dharma, even an unbeliever shrinks, as from an angry snake. How much more does a believer? When a man has fathered a son like himself and then despises him, the gods destroy his fortune, and he does not reach the worlds he hoped for. The forefathers called a son the foundation of the family and the line, the highest of all dharmas. So one should not abandon a son. Manu named five kinds of son: those born of one's own wife, those received, those bought, those raised, and those fathered on other women. Sons bring men dharma and fame, they gladden the heart, and once born, they save their forefathers from hell, rafts of dharma. So, tiger among kings, you should not abandon your son. Guard yourself, and truth, and dharma, lord of the earth. Lion among kings, you should not carry deceit.

"One pond is better than a hundred wells. One sacrifice is better than a hundred ponds. One son is better than a hundred sacrifices. Truth is better than a hundred sons. A thousand horse sacrifices and truth were weighed in the balance, and truth outweighed the thousand horse sacrifices. The study of all the Vedas, and bathing at all the holy fords, may or may not be equal to speaking the truth, king. There is no dharma higher than truth, and nothing greater than truth. Nothing here is harsher than falsehood. Truth, king, is the highest Brahman. Truth is the highest promise. Do not abandon your promise, king. Let truth be your companion.

"If you cling to falsehood, and if you have no faith in yourself, then I will go. There can be no bond with a man like you. Even without you, Dushyanta, my son will rule this earth to its four ends, whose crown is the king of the mountains."

When she had said this much, Shakuntala turned to go. Then a voice without a body spoke from the sky to Dushyanta, as he sat surrounded by his priests, his family priest, his teachers and his ministers.

"The mother is only the bellows. The son belongs to the father. The one who fathers him, he is that one. Support your son, Dushyanta. Do not despise Shakuntala. The man who places the seed raises his son up from the house of Yama, god among men. You placed this child in the womb. Shakuntala speaks the truth. A wife bears the son, a part of oneself split in two. So support your son, Dushyanta, the son of Shakuntala, king. It is misfortune indeed for a living man to abandon his living son. Support the great-souled son of Shakuntala and Dushyanta, Paurava. Because you must support him, bhartavya, and at our word too, let this son of yours be named Bharata."

When the Paurava king heard what the dwellers of heaven had said, he was full of joy,

and he said to his family priest and his ministers, "Listen, all of you, to what this messenger of the gods has said. I myself know that he is my son. If I had taken this boy as my son on her word alone, people would have doubted, and he would not be pure."

Then the king was glad and joyful, now that the messenger of the gods had proved the boy pure, Bharata, and he took his son. He smelled his head and held him lovingly, honoured by the brahmins and praised by the bards, and he felt the great joy that comes from the touch of a son.

And the king, who knew dharma, honoured his wife as dharma required. He spoke gently to her. "Our union was made out of the sight of the world. So I thought this over, queen, to prove you pure. People would think that you came together with me only as a woman does, and this son has been chosen for the kingdom. So I thought it over. And the harsh things you said to me in your anger, my dear, loving me as you do, wide-eyed one, lovely one, I have forgiven you."

When he had said this to his dear queen, the royal seer Dushyanta honoured her with clothes, food and drink, Bharata. Then King Dushyanta named Shakuntala's son Bharata, and consecrated him as crown prince.

The famous wheel of that great soul began to roll, shining, heavenly, unconquered, great, and loud through the worlds. He conquered the kings of the earth and made them subject to him. He practised the dharma of the good and won unequalled fame. That mighty king was an emperor who ruled the whole earth, and he offered many sacrifices, like Shakra, the lord of the Maruts. Kanva was his priest, and he gave rich gifts, as Daksha did. The glorious king performed the horse sacrifice called Govitata, at which Bharata gave Kanva a thousand padmas.

From Bharata comes the fame of the Bharatas. By him this family is the Bharata family. Those who came after, and those who came before, are known as the Bharatas. In the line of Bharata there were many great kings, like gods and like Brahma, of great splendour. Their names cannot be counted. But I will tell you the chief of them, Bharata, those greatly fortunate ones, like gods, devoted to truth and honesty.

Chapter 26

Kacha

Now, sinless one, I will tell you the line of Daksha the lord of creatures, and of Manu the son of Vivasvat, of Bharata, Kuru, Puru and Ajamidha: the line of the Yadavas and of the Pauravas, all of it, and of the Bharatas. It is holy and brings great blessing, and it brings wealth, fame and long life.

The ten sons of Prachetas, all shining with splendour, as bright as great seers, are remembered as the good men of old. Long ago those mighty ones were burned by a fire born of the clouds. From them was born Daksha, son of the Prachetases, and from Daksha these creatures came, tiger among men, for he is the grandfather of the world. The sage Daksha lay with Virini and fathered a thousand sons like himself, of strict vows. Narada taught Daksha's thousand sons together the lore of release, the matchless knowledge of Samkhya. Then Daksha, the lord of creatures, wanting to make creatures, Janamejaya, appointed fifty daughters to bear sons for him. He gave ten to Dharma, thirteen to Kashyapa, and twenty-seven, who are set to measure time, to the Moon.

The finest of Kashyapa's thirteen wives was a daughter of Daksha, and on her Kashyapa, the son of Marichi, fathered the Adityas, Indra first among them, full of courage, and Vivasvat. Vivasvat's son was the lord Yama, son of Vivasvat. And Martanda was born as Yama's son, king. Martanda's son was the wise lord Manu, and from him came the line of Manu's people, the human race. From that Manu were born men, brahmins, kshatriyas and the rest. Then, king, the brahmin joined with the kshatriya, and the brahmins among Manu's people kept the Veda with its limbs.

They name Manu's mighty sons, devoted to the dharma of kshatriyas: Vena, Dhrishnu, Narishyanta, Nabhaga and Ikshvaku, Karusha and Sharyati, and Ila the eighth, Prishadhra the ninth, and Nabhagarishta the tenth. Manu had fifty other sons on earth as well. They all perished by quarrelling among themselves, so we have heard.

Then wise Pururavas was born of Ila. She was both his mother and his father, so we have heard. Pururavas enjoyed thirteen islands of the ocean, a man of great fame surrounded by beings who were not human. Drunk with his own courage, Pururavas quarrelled with the brahmins, and he carried off their jewels even as they cried out. Sanatkumara came from the world of Brahma, king, and gave him counsel, but he would not take it. Then the angry great seers cursed him, and he perished at once, a lord of men full of greed, his mind lost in the pride of his strength. It was he who, in the world of the gandharvas, with Urvashi, the lord, brought down the three fires set out for the rites.

Six sons were born to Aila by Urvashi: Ayus, Dhimat, Amavasus, Dridhayus, Vanayus and Shrutayus. Nahusha, Vriddhasharman, Raji, Rambha and Anenas: these they call the sons of Ayus by Svarbhanavi. Ayus's son Nahusha was wise and truly brave. That lord of the earth ruled a very great kingdom by dharma. Nahusha protected the forefathers, the gods, the seers and the brahmins, the gandharvas, snakes and rakshasas, the brahmins, kshatriyas and vaishyas. He killed the hordes of robbers and made the seers pay him tribute, and the mighty king made them carry him on their backs like beasts. He overcame the dwellers of heaven by his splendour, his austerity, his courage and his strength, and he made himself Indra.

Nahusha fathered six sons on Priyavasas: Yati, Yayati, Samyati, Ayati, Pancha and Uddhava. Yayati, the son of Nahusha, was an emperor of true courage. He protected the

earth and offered many kinds of sacrifice. Always devout, he honoured the forefathers and the gods with all his strength, and unconquered Yayati was kind to all his people. His sons, great archers with every virtue, were born to Devayani and Sharmishtha, great king. Yadu and Turvasu were born to Devayani, and Druhyu, Anu and Puru to Sharmishtha.

Yayati protected his people by dharma for years without end, king. Then the son of Nahusha came to old age, most terrible, the destroyer of beauty. Overcome by old age, the king spoke to his sons, Yadu, Puru, Turvasu, Druhyu and Anu, Bharata. "I want to be young, and take my pleasure with young women, enjoying life in my youth. Help me, my sons."

Yadu, his eldest son, the son of Devayani, said to him, "What must we do? What do you want with our youth?"

"Take my old age," Yayati said to him, "and with your youth I will enjoy the world. I was offering long sacrifices, and by the curse of the sage Ushanas I lost the enjoyment of my desires. It pains me, my sons. Let one of you rule the kingdom with my body, and let me be young, and have my desires, with a new body."

Yadu and the others would not take his old age. Then Puru, the youngest, true in his courage, said to him, "King, go about in a new body, as a young man. I will take your old age and stay in the kingdom at your command."

When he said this, the royal seer, by the power of his austerity, passed his old age to his great-souled son. With Puru's youth, the king became young again, and Puru ruled the kingdom with Yayati's age. After a thousand years, unconquered Yayati, still not satisfied in his desires, said to his son Puru, "Through you I have an heir. You are the son who will carry on my line. It will be famous in the world as the Paurava line, after you."

Then that tiger among kings consecrated Puru as king, and a long time afterwards he went the way of Time.

"Yayati was our forefather," said Janamejaya, "the tenth from the lord of creatures. How did he win Shukra's daughter, who was so very hard to win? I want to hear this in full, best of brahmins. And tell me one by one, in order, those who carried on Puru's line."

Yayati was a royal seer, as bright as the king of the gods. Shukra and Vrishaparvan both chose him, as happened long ago. I will tell you, Janamejaya, since you ask, how Yayati, the son of Nahusha, came to be joined with Devayani.

There was a struggle between the gods and the asuras for power over the three worlds, with all that moves and all that does not. To win, the gods chose the sage Angirasa, Brihaspati, as their priest, to perform their sacrifices, and the others chose Kavya Ushanas, Shukra. Those two brahmins were always fierce rivals.

The danavas that the gods killed when they met them in battle, Kavya brought back to life by the power of his knowledge, and they rose again and fought the gods. But the gods that the asuras killed at the front of the battle, Brihaspati, for all his great mind, did not bring back to life. For he did not know the knowledge that mighty Kavya knew, the knowledge of bringing back to life. The gods fell into deep despair.

Frightened of Kavya Ushanas, the gods went to Kacha, the eldest son of Brihaspati, and said to him, "We are devoted to you, so be devoted to us, and do us the greatest help. Fetch quickly the knowledge that lives in the brahmin Shukra, whose splendour has no measure, and you will have a share with us. You can see that brahmin near Vrishaparvan. There he protects the danavas. He does not protect those who are not danavas. You are young, and you can win over the seer, and his dear daughter, Devayani. You can win them over, and no one else, with your good character, your courtesy and sweetness, your conduct and your self-control. When Devayani is pleased, you will surely get that knowledge."

"So be it," said Kacha, the son of Brihaspati, and, honoured by the gods, he set out for Vrishaparvan's court. Sent by the gods, king, Kacha went quickly, and in the city of the king of the asuras he saw Shukra, and said, "I am the grandson of the seer Angiras and the son of Brihaspati himself. My name is Kacha. Take me as your pupil. I will live as a celibate student with you, my highest teacher. Allow me this, brahmin, for a thousand years."

"Kacha, you are most welcome," said Shukra. "I accept your words. I will honour you, for you deserve honour, and so Brihaspati will be honoured."

Kacha said, "So be it," and he took the vow that Shukra Ushanas, the son of Kavi, had set him. He took on the vow for the time it had to last, as it was said, and he served his teacher and Devayani, Bharata. Always meaning to please her, the young man in his youth sang and danced and played music, and he made Devayani glad. He waited on Devayani, a girl now grown to her youth, with flowers and fruit and errands, and he made her happy, Bharata. And Devayani, singing along with him, lovely girl, waited on that brahmin, who kept his rules and his vows, in private.

So five hundred years went by as Kacha kept his vow. Then the danavas found out about Kacha. They saw him alone, in a lonely place in the forest, guarding the cows, and in their anger they killed him, out of hatred for Brihaspati and to keep the knowledge safe. When they had killed him, they cut him up as small as sesame seeds and gave him to the jackals.

Then the cows came home without their herdsman. When Devayani saw the cows come back from the forest without Kacha, she spoke to her father, Bharata.

"Your evening fire offering has not been made, and the sun has set, my lord. The cows have come back without their herdsman. Kacha is nowhere to be seen, father. He must have been killed, father, or died. I cannot live without Kacha. I tell you truly."

"I will call out, 'Come here,'" said Shukra, "and bring the dead man back to life."

Then he used the knowledge of bringing back to life and called Kacha, and at the call Kacha appeared, whole, by the power of the knowledge. When the brahmin's daughter asked him, he told her, "I was killed."

Again, at Devayani's word, the brahmin went into the forest, as it happened, to gather flowers, and the danavas saw him. Then they killed him a second time, burned him and ground him to powder, and the asuras gave him to the brahmin himself, in wine.

Then Devayani spoke to her father again. "Kacha went to gather flowers for me, on an

errand, father. He is nowhere to be seen."

"Daughter," said Shukra, "Brihaspati's son Kacha has gone the way of the dead. Even when he is brought back to life by my knowledge, he is killed like this. What can I do? Do not grieve so, Devayani. Do not cry. A woman like you should not mourn for a mortal. The gods, all of them, and the whole world bow to the change that comes."

"His grandfather is Angiras, the most ancient," said Devayani, "and his father is Brihaspati, rich in austerity. He is the son and grandson of seers. How can I not grieve for him? How can I not cry? He was a celibate student, rich in austerity, always ready, and skilled in all his work. I will follow Kacha's path. I will not eat. For handsome Kacha is dear to me, father."

"Surely the asuras hate me," said Shukra, "when they kill my pupil, who has done no wrong. They are fierce, and they want to make me no brahmin at all, as the danavas have plainly set out to do. There must be an end to this evil. Whom would the killing of a brahmin not burn, even Indra?"

Urged on by Devayani, the great seer Kavya called again, in fury, to Kacha, the son of Brihaspati. Called by the knowledge, but afraid of his teacher, Kacha spoke softly from inside his belly.

"By what path were you brought here, to stand in my belly?" said Shukra. "Tell me, brahmin."

"By your grace my memory has not left me," said Kacha. "I remember everything, how it happened and as it happened. But my austerity must not be wasted, and so I bear this terrible pain. The asuras killed me, burned me and ground me to powder, and gave me to you in wine, Kavya. How could the magic of the asuras overcome the magic of a brahmin, while you are here?"

"My child," said Shukra, "what can I do to please you now? If Kacha lives, I die. Kacha, who is inside me, Devayani, cannot be seen except by splitting open my belly."

"Two griefs, like fire, will burn me," said Devayani: "Kacha's death, and your death. If Kacha dies, there is no peace for me. If you die, I cannot live."

"You have won what you sought, son of Brihaspati," said Shukra, "since Devayani loves you as you love her. Take this knowledge of bringing back to life, unless you are Indra in Kacha's form. No one else would come out of my belly alive, but only a brahmin. So take the knowledge. Become my son, you whom I have brought back to life, and bring me back to life when you have come out of this body, my child. Take the knowledge from your teacher, and then, with the knowledge, look on me with the eyes of dharma."

The brahmin took the knowledge from his teacher, split open his belly, and came out, handsome Kacha, from the right side of the brahmin, like the moon at the full moon at the end of the bright fortnight. And when Kacha saw that heap of holiness lying dead, he raised him up too, with the knowledge he had won. Kacha bowed to his teacher, and said, "The giver of the matchless truth, the treasure of the four treasures: those who do not honour such a teacher, who deserves honour, go to evil worlds where there is no footing."

Kavya Ushanas, the great one, had been deceived because he drank wine, and it had taken away his senses, which was most terrible. He saw handsome Kacha, whom he had drunk in the wine in his stupor. He rose in anger, wanting to do good to the brahmins, and suspicious now of drinking wine, he himself spoke these words.

"Any brahmin who, from this day on, drinks wine here out of folly, in his dullness, will have fallen from dharma, and will be a killer of brahmins. He will be scorned in this world and in the next. I have set this bound, this limit to the dharma of brahmins, in all the world. Let good brahmins, those who serve their teachers, hear it, and the gods and all the worlds."

When he had said this, that great one, the treasure of all the treasures of austerity, beyond all measure, called the danavas, their minds bewildered by fate, and said, "I tell you, danavas, you are fools. Kacha has won what he sought, and he will live with me. He has won the knowledge of bringing back to life, of such great worth. He is equal in power to Brahma, and he has become Brahman."

Kacha lived with his teacher a thousand years. Then, with his teacher's leave, he made ready to go back to the home of the thirty gods.

The Girl in the Well

When Kacha had finished his vow, and his teacher had let him go, and he was setting out for the home of the thirty gods, Devayani said to him,

"Grandson of the seer Angiras, you shine with good conduct and birth, with learning, austerity and self-control. As the famous seer Angiras is honoured by my father, so Brihaspati is honoured and revered by me even more. Knowing this, understand what I say, you who are rich in austerity. Remember how I behaved towards you while you kept your vows and your rules. Now that you have finished your learning, you should love me, for I love you. Take my hand by the rite, with the mantras before you."

"As the blessed one, your father, is to be honoured and revered by me," said Kacha, "so you, faultless one, are to be honoured by me still more. You are dearer than his own life to the great Bhargava, and by dharma you are always to be honoured by me as my teacher's daughter, good lady. As my teacher Shukra, your father, is always to be revered, Devayani, so are you. You should not speak to me like this."

"You are the son of my father's teacher's son," said Devayani, "but you are not my father's son. So I honour and revere you too, best of brahmins. When the asuras killed you again and again, Kacha, remember the love I showed you from that time on. You know my devotion, the highest, in friendship and in love. You know dharma. You should not abandon me, when I love you and have done no wrong."

"You are urging me to something I must not do, you of the good vows," said Kacha. "Be gracious to me, lovely one. You are more to be revered than my teacher, fair one. Where you once lived, wide-eyed one with the face like the moon, there I too have lived, good lady, in Kavya's belly, proud one. By dharma you are my sister. Do not speak so, lovely one. I have lived here happily, good lady, and I have no anger. I take my leave of you, and I will go. Wish me well on my way. Think of me when you talk, without going against dharma. And always serve my teacher, watchful and ready."

"If you refuse me," said Devayani, "when I ask you for the sake of dharma and love, then, Kacha, this knowledge of yours will not bear fruit."

"I refuse you because you are my teacher's daughter," said Kacha, "not for any fault of yours. And my teacher has given me leave to go. Curse me, then, if you will. I spoke to you of the dharma of the seers, Devayani, and you have cursed me. I did not deserve a curse. You cursed me out of desire today, not out of dharma. So your desire will not come true as you wish. No seer's son will ever take your hand. My knowledge will not bear fruit for me, since you have said so. But whoever I teach, for him that knowledge will bear fruit."

When he had said this to Devayani, Kacha, the best of brahmins, went quickly to the home of the lord of the thirty gods. The gods, with Indra at their head, saw that he had come. They honoured Brihaspati, and joyfully they said to Kacha, "You have done a most wonderful deed for our good. Your fame will never perish. You will have a share with us."

The dwellers of heaven were glad when Kacha came back having mastered the knowledge. They learned that knowledge from Kacha, and they had what they wanted, bull of the

Bharatas. They all came together and said to Indra of the hundred sacrifices, "Now is the time for your courage. Kill our enemies, breaker of cities."

When the thirty gods said this to him together, the bountiful Indra said, "So be it," and set out. In a forest he saw some women. The girls were playing in a forest like the garden of Chitraratha. Indra became the wind and mixed up all their clothes. Then the girls came out of the water together and took their clothes, whichever lay nearest. Then Sharmishtha, the daughter of Vrishaparvan, took Devayani's garment, not knowing they had been mixed up. And a quarrel broke out between the two of them, king of kings, Devayani and Sharmishtha, over it.

"Why are you taking my garment, asura girl," said Devayani, "when you are my pupil? You have no manners, and no good will come of it for you."

"When my father is sitting or lying down," said Sharmishtha, "your father praises my father and bows to him, standing low, like a humble man, again and again. You are the daughter of one who begs, and praises, and accepts gifts. I am the daughter of one who is praised, and gives, and does not accept. You have no weapon, and I have one. You are empty-handed, and you shake with rage, beggar girl. You will find someone to fight you. I do not count you as anything."

Devayani stood up to her, and held on to the garment. Sharmishtha threw her into a well, and then went back to her own city. Sharmishtha, set on evil, thought, She is dead, and in the rush of her anger she went home without looking back.

Then Yayati, the son of Nahusha, came to that place. His horses and his team were tired. He was hunting deer, and he was thirsty. Looking into the well, which had no water in it, the son of Nahusha saw the girl there, bright like a flame of fire. As soon as he saw the girl, as fair as an immortal, the best of kings spoke to her very gently, to comfort her.

"Who are you, dark young woman, with your copper-coloured nails and your polished jewelled earrings? You have been thinking for a long time, and you are sighing, in distress. Why? And how did you fall into this well, overgrown with creepers and grass? Whose daughter are you? Tell me everything, you of the slender waist."

"I am the daughter of Shukra," said Devayani, "who raises up with his knowledge the daityas the gods have killed. Surely he does not know what has happened to me. Here is my right hand, king, with its copper-nailed fingers. Take it and pull me out, for I think you are of good family. I know you are calm and brave and famous. So you should pull me out of this well I have fallen into."

The son of Nahusha knew she was a brahmin woman, and he took her by the right hand and lifted her out of the pit. When he had pulled her quickly out of the well, King Yayati took his leave of the lovely woman and went back to his own city.

"Go quickly, Ghurnika," said Devayani, "and tell my father everything. I will not set foot in Vrishaparvan's city now."

Ghurnika went quickly to the asura's palace. When she saw Kavya, she said, her mind in a whirl, "I tell you, great sage, Devayani has been killed in the forest by Sharmishtha, fortunate one, Vrishaparvan's daughter."

When Kavya heard that his daughter had been killed there by Sharmishtha, he went out in haste, in sorrow, to look for his daughter in the forest. When he saw his daughter Devayani in the forest, Kavya took her in his arms, and said in his grief, "All people bring sorrow and happiness on themselves by their own faults. I think you have done some wrong, and this has been your penance."

"Penance or no penance," said Devayani, "listen carefully to me. Hear what Sharmishtha, Vrishaparvan's daughter, said to me. She says it is true that you are the daityas' singer of praises. This is what Sharmishtha, the daughter of Vrishaparvan, says to me, in sharp and cruel words, her eyes red with anger: 'You are the daughter of one who praises, and begs, and accepts gifts. I am the daughter of one who is praised, and gives, and does not accept.' So Sharmishtha, the daughter of Vrishaparvan, told me again and again, her eyes red with anger, full of pride. If I am the daughter of one who praises and accepts gifts, father, then I will beg Sharmishtha's pardon. So I told my friend."

"You are not the daughter of one who praises, my dear," said Shukra, "nor of one who accepts gifts. You are the daughter of one who is praised and does not praise, Devayani. Vrishaparvan himself knows it, and Shakra, and King Yayati, the son of Nahusha. My power is Brahman, beyond thought, beyond all opposites, the power of a lord."

Sharmishtha's Price

"The man who always bears the harsh words of others," said Shukra, "know, Devayani, that he has conquered all this world. The man who holds back his anger when it rises, as a horse is held back, the good call a driver, not the one who only hangs on to the reins. The man who drives off his anger when it rises by not being angry, know, Devayani, that he has conquered all this world. The man who throws off his anger when it rises by forgiving, as a snake throws off its old skin, he is called a man. The man who holds in his wrath, who bears harsh words, who does not burn back when he is burned, he is truly a vessel of success. Of the man who sacrifices every month for a hundred years without tiring and the man who is never angry with anyone, the one who is not angry is the greater. When boys and girls make enmity in their thoughtlessness, a wise man should not follow them. They do not know strength from weakness."

"I know, father, young as I am," said Devayani, "what the difference is between the dharmas here. I know about not being angry and about harsh words, and I know strength from weakness. But one who wants to thrive should not forgive a pupil who does not behave like a pupil. So I do not want to live among people whose conduct is so mixed. A wise man who seeks his own good should not live among evil-minded men who scorn his conduct and his birth. One should live among good people who know him by his conduct and his birth. That is said to be the best place to live. The words that Vrishaparvan's daughter spoke were very terrible. I do not think there is anything harder in all three worlds than for a man who has lost his fortune to wait on his rival's blazing fortune."

Then Kavya, the best of the Bhrigus, went in anger to Vrishaparvan, where he sat, and spoke to him without stopping to think.

"Wrong that is done does not bear fruit at once, king, as the earth does not. But if he does not see it in himself, a man surely sees his wrong bear fruit in his sons or his grandsons, like heavy food in the belly. You had the brahmin Kacha killed, the son of Angiras, who did no evil and knew dharma, who served me and was happy in my house. Because of the killing of one who did not deserve to be killed, and the killing of my daughter, understand this, Vrishaparvan: I will leave you and your kin. I cannot stay in your kingdom with you, king. Ah, daitya, you think I am one who talks nonsense, since you do not check this fault of yours, but let it pass."

"I know of no wrong in you, Bhargava, and no lie," said Vrishaparvan. "Dharma and truth are in you. So be gracious to us. If you leave us and go away from here, Bhargava, we will go into the ocean. We have no other refuge."

"Go into the ocean, asuras, or run to the ends of the earth," said Shukra. "I cannot bear my daughter's pain, for she is dear to me. Make peace with Devayani, for my life depends on her. Then I will see to your welfare, as Brihaspati does for Indra."

"Whatever wealth the lords of the asuras have on earth, Bhargava," said Vrishaparvan, "elephants, cattle or horses, you are lord of it all, and of me."

"Whatever wealth the lords of the daityas have, great asura," said Shukra, "I am lord of it, if you make peace with Devayani."

"If you are lord of the king's wealth, father, Bhargava," said Devayani, "I do not

accept it from you. Let the king speak for himself."

"Whatever you wish for, Devayani, you of the bright smile," said Vrishaparvan, "I will give it to you, however hard it is to give."

"I want Sharmishtha as my slave, with a thousand girls," said Devayani. "Let her follow me wherever my father gives me in marriage."

"Get up, nurse," said Vrishaparvan, "and bring Sharmishtha quickly. Whatever Devayani wishes, let her have it."

Then the nurse went and said to Sharmishtha, "Get up, good Sharmishtha, and bring happiness to your kin. The brahmin is leaving his pupils, urged on by Devayani. Whatever she wishes, sinless one, you must do it today."

"Whatever she wishes, I will do it today," said Sharmishtha. "Only let Shukra not go away, and Devayani, because of me."

Then, at her father's command, she came out quickly from the fine city in a litter, with a thousand girls around her.

"I, with a thousand girls, am your slave and your servant," said Sharmishtha. "I will follow you wherever your father gives you."

"I am the daughter of one who praises you," said Devayani, "a bard who accepts gifts. How will you, the daughter of one who is praised, be a slave?"

"Anyone should bring happiness to her kin when they are in trouble, in whatever way she can," said Sharmishtha. "So I will follow you wherever your father gives you."

When Vrishaparvan's daughter had promised to be her slave, best of kings, Devayani said to her father, "I will go into the city, father. I am satisfied, best of brahmins. Your knowledge never fails, and the power of your learning is real."

When his daughter said this, the famous best of brahmins went into the city, glad, honoured by all the danavas.

Then, after a long time, best of kings, the lovely Devayani went out to that same forest to play. She came to the same place with Sharmishtha and the thousand slave girls, and wandered there as she pleased, very happy, with all her companions. They all played there happily, drinking the honey wine of spring, eating all kinds of food and biting into fruit.

And again, by chance, King Yayati, the son of Nahusha, hunting deer, came to that same place, tired and wanting water. He saw Devayani and Sharmishtha and the women, drinking and playing, adorned with heavenly ornaments. He saw Devayani of the bright smile sitting among the women, a lovely woman of beauty beyond compare, with Sharmishtha waiting on her, rubbing her feet and so on.

"Two girls, surrounded by two thousand girls," said Yayati. "I ask you both your families and your names."

"I will tell you," said Devayani. "Listen to me, lord of men. Know that I am the daughter of Shukra, the teacher of the asuras. And this is my friend and my slave, who goes wherever I go: Sharmishtha, the daughter of Vrishaparvan, the king of the danavas."

"How can this girl, so lovely, a daughter of the king of the asuras, be your friend and your slave, fair one?" said Yayati. "I am very curious."

"Everything follows what is ordained, tiger among men," said Devayani. "Take it as ordained by fate, and do not tell wondering tales about it. You look and dress like a king, and you speak the words of the Veda. What is your name, where are you from, and whose son are you? Tell me."

"I have heard the whole Veda in my years as a student," said Yayati. "I am a king, and a king's son, known as Yayati."

"Why have you come to this place, king?" said Devayani. "To pick lotuses, or to hunt?"

"I was hunting, good lady, and I came for water," said Yayati. "And I have been questioned a great deal. Give me leave to go."

"With two thousand girls, and my slave Sharmishtha, I am yours," said Devayani. "Bless you, be my friend and my husband."

"Know, daughter of Ushanas, bless you, that I am not worthy of you, proud one," said Yayati. "Kings may not marry your father's daughters, Devayani."

"The kshatriya is joined with the brahmin, and the brahmin bound to the kshatriya," said Devayani. "You are a seer, and a seer's son. Marry me, son of Nahusha."

"The four classes were all born from one body, fair lady," said Yayati. "But their dharmas are separate, and their rules of purity are separate, and the brahmin is the highest of them."

"No man has ever taken this hand of mine, son of Nahusha," said Devayani. "You took it first. So I choose you. How could another man touch the hand of a proud woman like me, when it has been taken by you, a seer's son, or a seer yourself?"

"A man who knows," said Yayati, "knows that a brahmin is harder to face than an angry snake full of poison, or a fire blazing on every side."

"How can you say, bull among men," said Devayani, "that a brahmin is harder to face than an angry snake full of poison, or a fire blazing on every side?"

"A snake kills one," said Yayati, "and a weapon kills one. But an angry brahmin kills cities and kingdoms too. That is why I think a brahmin is harder to face, timid one. So I will not marry you, good lady, unless your father gives you."

"Then marry me when my father gives me to you," said Devayani, "for I have chosen you, king. There is no danger for a man who does not ask, but takes what is given."

Then Devayani quickly sent word to her own father. As soon as he heard, the Bhargava came to see the king. As soon as he saw Shukra come, Yayati, lord of the earth, bowed to

the brahmin Kavya and stood with his palms joined, bending low.

"Father, this is King Yayati, the son of Nahusha," said Devayani. "He took my hand when I was in trouble. I bow to you. Give me to him. I will choose no other husband in the world."

"My dear daughter has chosen you as her husband, hero," said Shukra. "Take her, son of Nahusha. I give her to you as your queen."

"Then let no great wrong touch me here, Bhargava," said Yayati, "born of the mixing of the classes, brahmin. That is what I ask of you."

"I free you from the wrong," said Shukra. "Choose what you wish. Do not be troubled about this marriage. I drive away your sin. Take Devayani of the slender waist as your wife, by dharma. With her you will find joy beyond compare. And this girl, Sharmishtha, Vrishaparvan's daughter, must always be honoured, king. But do not call her to your bed."

When Shukra had said this, Yayati walked round him keeping him on his right, and with the great one's leave, he went back to his city, glad.

Chapter 29

Old Age

When Yayati came to his city, which was like the city of great Indra, he went into the women's quarters and settled Devayani there. With Devayani's consent he had a house built near the ashoka grove for Vrishaparvan's daughter, and he settled Sharmishtha, the asura's daughter, there, with her thousand slave girls, well cared for, giving her clothes, food and drink. With Devayani, the king, the son of Nahusha, took his pleasure for many years, very happy, like a god. When her season came, the lovely Devayani conceived, and she bore a son, the first.

When a thousand years had passed, Sharmishtha, Vrishaparvan's daughter, saw that she had come to her youth, and that her season had come, and she thought, *My season has come, and I have not chosen a husband. What has happened to me? What should I do? What can I do to make it right? Devayani has had a child. I have come to my youth for nothing. As she chose a husband, so I will choose him. The king should give me the fruit of a son. That is what I have decided. Will that righteous man come to see me now, alone?*

Then the king came out at that time, by chance, and came to the ashoka grove, and stood there, having found Sharmishtha. When Sharmishtha of the lovely smile saw him alone, in a lonely place, she went to meet the king, joined her palms, and said, "In the house of Soma, or Indra, or Vishnu, or Yama, or Varuna, or in yours, son of Nahusha, who would dare to touch a woman? You know me always, king, for my beauty, my family and my character. I beg you to be kind to me. Give me my season, lord of men."

"I know you are a daitya's daughter of good character, and without fault," said Yayati.

"I do not see a fault in your beauty the size of a needle's point. But when I married Devayani, Kavya Ushanas said to me, 'You must not call Vrishaparvan's daughter to your bed.'"

"A word spoken in jest does no harm, king," said Sharmishtha, "nor one spoken to women, nor at the time of marriage, nor when life is in danger, nor when all one's wealth is being taken. They say these five lies are not sins. But when a man is asked as a witness and speaks otherwise, they call that a lie, lord of men. When the matter concerns one and the same purpose, the lie destroys the man who speaks it."

"The king is the measure for all beings," said Yayati. "He would perish if he lied. Even if I were in great need, I would not dare to act falsely."

"These two are held to be the same, king," said Sharmishtha: "one's own husband and one's friend's husband. They call it the same marriage. My friend chose you as her husband."

"I have taken a vow that I must give to those who ask," said Yayati. "And you ask me for what you desire. Tell me, what shall I do for you?"

"Save me from adharma, king," said Sharmishtha, "and bring me to dharma. If I have a child by you, I will walk the highest dharma in the world. Three have no wealth of their own, king: a wife, a slave and a son. Whatever they come by belongs to the one they belong to. I am Devayani's servant, and the daughter of Bhrigu's line is in your power. She and I are both yours to support, king. Love me."

When she said this, the king knew that it was true. He honoured Sharmishtha and brought her to dharma. He lay with Sharmishtha and had what he wished, and they honoured each other and went back the way they had come. From that union, lovely Sharmishtha of the charming smile conceived her first child by that best of kings. In time, king, the lotus-eyed woman bore a boy like a child of the gods, with eyes like lotuses.

When Devayani of the bright smile heard that a boy had been born, she was hurt, and she thought about Sharmishtha, Bharata. She went to Sharmishtha and said, "What is this wrong you have done, fair one, in your greed for love?"

"A seer came here," said Sharmishtha, "a righteous man, a master of the Vedas. He gave boons, and I asked him for what I desired, as dharma allows. I do not take my pleasure against the rules, you of the bright smile. So my child is from that seer. I tell you the truth."

"That is well, timid one, if it is true," said Devayani, "and if the brahmin is known. I want to know that brahmin, his family, his name and his birth."

"He blazed with power and splendour, like the sun," said Sharmishtha. "When I saw him, I did not have the strength to ask, you of the bright smile."

"If this is so, Sharmishtha," said Devayani, "then I have no anger, if you have had a child from an elder and a better brahmin."

When they had said this to each other, and laughed together, the daughter of Bhṛigu's line went home, believing it was true.

King Yayati fathered two sons on Devayani, Yadu and Turvasu, like a second Shakra and Vishnu. And from that same royal seer, Sharmishtha, Vṛishaparvan's daughter, bore three boys: Druhyu, Anu and Puru.

Then one day, king, Devayani of the bright smile went out into the great forest with Yayati. There she saw boys like gods, playing without a care. She was amazed, and said, "Whose are these children, king? They are like the sons of gods, and lovely. In splendour and in looks they seem to me like you." And when she had asked the king, she asked the boys, "What are your names and your family, my children? Who is your father? Tell me the truth. I want to hear."

The children pointed with their forefingers at that best of kings, and told her their mother was Sharmishtha. When they had said this, they went to the king together. But in front of Devayani the king did not greet them, and the little boys went crying to Sharmishtha.

When the queen saw the boys' love for the king, and understood the truth, she said to Sharmishtha, "You are in my power. Why have you done what displeases me? You have gone back to the ways of the asuras. Are you not afraid?"

"What I told you, that he was a seer, was true, you of the charming smile," said Sharmishtha. "I act by right and by dharma, and I am not afraid of you. When you chose the king, I chose him too. By dharma, a friend's husband becomes a husband, lovely one. You are to be honoured and respected by me, for you are the eldest and the best, a brahmin woman. But the royal seer is to be honoured by me more than you. Do you not know

that?"

When she heard her, Devayani said, "King, I will not live here now. You have done what displeases me."

She rose up suddenly, the dark young woman, her eyes full of tears, and set out in haste for Kavya. The king was troubled when he saw her go, and he followed her in alarm, trying to calm her. But she did not turn back, her eyes red with anger. The lovely-eyed woman said not a word to the king, and soon she came to Kavya Ushanas. As soon as she saw her father, she bowed to him and stood before him, and after her Yayati honoured the Bhargava.

"Dharma has been beaten by adharma," said Devayani. "The low has risen above the high. I have been wronged by Sharmishtha, Vrishaparvan's daughter. This king, Yayati, has fathered three sons on her, and on me, unlucky that I am, only two, I tell you, father. This king is famous for knowing dharma, best of the Bhrigus, and he has broken the bounds. I tell you this, Kavya."

"Great king," said Shukra, "since you know dharma, and yet you did adharma as if it were dear to you, old age, which is hard to conquer, will soon overpower you."

"She asked me for her season, blessed one," said Yayati, "and I did not do it with any other thought. What I did for the daughter of the king of the danavas was lawful. A man who is asked for her season by a woman, and does not give it, the knowers of Brahman here call a killer of an unborn child, brahmin. A man who is asked in private by a willing woman who is lawful to him, and does not go to her, the wise call a killer of an unborn child in matters of dharma. I considered these reasons, best of the Bhrigus, and in fear of adharma I went to Sharmishtha."

"Should you not have looked to me?" said Shukra. "You are in my care, king. In matters of dharma, false conduct is theft, son of Nahusha."

So Yayati, the son of Nahusha, was cursed by Ushanas in his anger, and at once he lost his youth and took on old age.

"I have not had my fill of youth with Devayani, best of the Bhrigus," said Yayati. "Be gracious to me, brahmin. Let this old age not enter me."

"I do not speak falsely," said Shukra. "You have come to old age, lord of the earth. But if you wish, pass this old age on to someone else."

"Let the son who gives me his youth," said Yayati, "have the kingdom, and the merit, and the fame, brahmin. Give me your consent to this."

"You will pass on your old age as you wish, son of Nahusha," said Shukra. "Think of me with love, and you will not fall into sin. The son who gives you his youth will be king. He will be long-lived and famous, and he will have many children."

When Yayati had come to old age and reached his own city, he spoke to his eldest and best son, Yadu. "Old age, wrinkles and grey hair have come over me, my son, by the curse of Kavya Ushanas, and I have not had my fill of youth. Take my wrong, Yadu, together with my old age. Let me enjoy the world with your youth. When a thousand years are over,

I will give you back your youth, and take my wrong back again, with my old age."

"With a white beard and white hair, wretched, made slack by old age," said Yadu, "his body covered in wrinkles, ugly, weak and thin, unable to do his work, scorned by the young and by those who live off him: I do not want that old age."

"You were born from my heart," said Yayati, "and you will not give me your youth. So your children, my son, will have no share in kingship. Turvasu, take my wrong, with my old age. Let me enjoy the world with your youth, my son. When a thousand years are over, I will give you back your youth, and take my wrong back again, with my old age."

"I do not want old age, father," said Turvasu. "It destroys desire and pleasure. It puts an end to strength and beauty. It destroys the mind and the breath."

"You were born from my heart," said Yayati, "and you will not give me your youth. So your line, Turvasu, will be cut off. You fool, you will be king among people of mixed conduct and dharma, who live against the grain, eaters of raw flesh, outcasts. You will be lord among the sinful barbarians who lie with their teachers' wives, who are born as beasts and live the dharma of beasts."

When Yayati had cursed his own son Turvasu like this, he said to Sharmishtha's son, Druhyu, "Druhyu, take my old age, which destroys colour and beauty, for a thousand years, and give me your youth. When a thousand years are over, I will give you back your youth, and take back again my own wrong, with my old age."

"An old man cannot enjoy an elephant, a chariot, a horse, or a woman," said Druhyu, "and his speech fails him. I do not want that old age."

"You were born from my heart," said Yayati, "and you will not give me your youth. So, Druhyu, the love you desire will never come to you anywhere. You and your line will live where men cross the water always by raft and boat, and there, no king, you will have the name of Bhoja. Anu, take my wrong, with my old age. Let me enjoy the world with your youth for one thousand years."

"An old man takes his food at the wrong times, like a child, and unclean," said Anu, "and he does not make his offering in the fire at the proper time. I do not want that old age."

"You were born from my heart," said Yayati, "and you will not give me your youth. You have told the faults of old age, and so you will come to them. And your children, Anu, will die as soon as they reach their youth. And you too will be one who lets the sacred fire go out."

"Puru, you are my dear son. You will be the best. Old age, wrinkles and grey hair have come over me, my son, by the curse of Kavya Ushanas, and I have not had my fill of youth. Puru, take my wrong, with my old age. Let me enjoy the world for a while with your youth. When a thousand years are over, I will give you back your youth, and take my wrong back again, with my old age."

When he said this, Puru answered his father at once, "I will do as you say, great king. I will take your wrong, king, with your old age. Take my youth from me, and enjoy your desires as you wish. Covered with old age, taking on your age and your looks, I will

give you my youth and live as you tell me."

"Puru, my child, I am pleased with you," said Yayati. "And because I am pleased, I give you this: your children will be rich in all they desire in your kingdom."

Chapter 30

Yayati's Fall

With Puru's youth, Yayati, the son of Nahusha, the best of kings, enjoyed the pleasures he loved, full of joy. He enjoyed them as he wished and as his spirit moved him, at the right times and happily, never against dharma, as was fitting for him. He satisfied the gods with sacrifices and the forefathers with the rites for the dead. He satisfied the poor with kindness and the best of brahmins with the gifts they wanted, and guests with food and drink. He cared for the vaishyas by protecting them and for the shudras by gentleness, and he held robbers in check. Pleasing all his people rightly by dharma, Yayati protected them like a second Indra in the flesh. That king, with the courage of a lion, young, enjoying the world, took the highest happiness, without going against dharma.

When he had enjoyed those fine pleasures, the lord of the earth was satisfied, and weary, and he remembered the term of a thousand years. He knew how to reckon time, and he counted the moments and the instants. When he saw that the time was full, he spoke to his son Puru. "As I wished, as my spirit moved me, at the right times, tamer of enemies, I have enjoyed the world with your youth, my son. Puru, I am pleased with you, bless you. Take back your youth, and take this kingdom too, for you are the son who has done what I love."

Then King Yayati, the son of Nahusha, took back his old age, and Puru took back his own youth again.

The king wanted to consecrate his youngest son, Puru. But the classes, with the brahmins at their head, said to him, "Lord, how can you pass over the eldest, Yadu, Shukra's grandson, Devayani's son, and give the kingdom to Puru? Yadu is your eldest son. After him Turvasu was born. Sharmishtha's son is Druhyu, then Anu, and then Puru. How can the youngest have the kingdom over the heads of the elder ones? We remind you of this. Keep to dharma."

"Let all the classes, with the brahmins at their head, hear what I have to say," said Yayati, "why the kingdom must not be given to the eldest, in any way. My eldest, Yadu, did not do what I asked. A son who goes against his father is not counted a son by the good. The son who does what his mother and father tell him, who is good and helpful to them, who behaves like a son to his father and mother, is a son. Yadu scorned me, and so did Turvasu, and Druhyu and Anu scorned me deeply. Puru did what I said, and honoured me above all. The youngest is my heir, for he carried my old age. Puru, in the form of a son, did what I desired. And Shukra himself, Kavya Ushanas, gave me a boon: 'The son who follows you will be king, lord of the earth.' So I ask you: let Puru be consecrated as king."

"The son who has every virtue," said the people, "and is always good to his mother and father, deserves every blessing, lord, even if he is the youngest. Puru deserves this kingdom, since he is the son who has done what you love. And because of Shukra's boon, nothing can be said against it."

When the people of the city and the country, content, had said this, the son of Nahusha consecrated his own son Puru in his kingdom. When he had given the kingdom to Puru, the king was consecrated for life in the forest, and he left the city with brahmins and ascetics.

From Yadu came the Yadavas, and from Turvasu the Yavanas. Druhyu's sons were the Bhojas, and from Anu came the barbarian tribes. From Puru came the Paurava line, in which you were born, king, to rule this kingdom, master of yourself, for a thousand years.

So King Yayati, the son of Nahusha, consecrated the son he wanted as king, and, glad, he became a sage who lived in the forest. He lived in the forest with brahmins, eating fruit and roots, and he held himself in check. From here he went to heaven. He went to that home of the gods and lived there happily, content. And not very long after, Shakra threw him down again. As he fell from heaven, he did not reach the surface of the earth. He stayed in the air. So I have heard. And then, it is told, he went to heaven again from there, the mighty one, with King Vasumat, with Ashtaka, Pratardana and Shibi, meeting them, it is said, in an assembly.

"By what deed did that lord of the earth reach heaven again?" said Janamejaya. "I want to hear all of this, truly, in full, told by you, brahmin, in the presence of these brahmins and seers. Yayati, the lord of the earth, was like the king of the gods, the one who made the Kuru line grow, as bright as fire. I want to hear all the life of that great one, of wide fame and true glory, both in heaven and here."

Then I will tell you the later story of Yayati, in heaven and here, which is holy and destroys all sins.

King Yayati, the son of Nahusha, consecrated his youngest son Puru as king, and went off gladly to the forest. He placed his sons, with Yadu first, in the lands at the borders, and the king lived a long time in the forest, eating fruit and roots. Master of himself, his anger conquered, he satisfied the forefathers and the gods and poured offerings into the fires by the rule, as the rules for a forest dweller lay down. The lord honoured his guests with the offerings of the forest, living by gleanings grain, and he ate only what was left.

The king lived like this for a full thousand years. For thirty years he lived on water, his speech and his mind held in check. Then, tireless, he lived on air for a year. For a year the king practised austerity in the middle of five fires. For six months he stood on one foot, living on air. Then, his fame holy, he went to heaven, filling heaven and earth.

The king of kings lived in heaven, in the home of the gods, honoured by the thirty gods, the Sadhyas, the Maruts and the Vasus. He went from the world of the gods to the world of Brahma, a man of holy deeds, master of himself. The lord of the earth lived there a long time, so it is told.

Once Yayati, the best of kings, went to Shakra. At the end of their talk Shakra asked the lord of the earth a question. "When Puru took your old age and went about the earth in your form, king, and you gave him the kingdom, what did you tell him? Tell me truly."

"I told him," said Yayati, "All the land between the Ganga and the Yamuna is yours. You are king of the middle of the earth. Your brothers are lords of the lands at the edges. The man without anger is better than the angry. The patient man is better than the impatient. Men are better than beings who are not men, and the learned better than the unlearned."

"When he is abused, a man should not abuse back. The anger of the patient man burns up the one who abuses him, and he takes the other's merit. He should not wound, nor speak cruelly. He should not take the highest knowledge from a low man. He should not speak the harsh words that make others tremble, words that lead to evil worlds. Know that the man who wounds, who speaks roughly and stings men with the thorns of his words, is the unluckiest of men. He carries destruction bound in his mouth.

"Let him be honoured by the good in front of him, and guarded by the good behind him. Let him always bear the insults of the bad, and let him take on the conduct of the good, for his own conduct is noble. The arrows of words fly from the mouth, and the man they strike grieves night and day. They fall on the tender places of others, so a wise man should not loose them at anyone. There is no charm in all three worlds like kindness to all beings, and giving, and sweet speech. So always speak gently, and never harshly anywhere. Honour those who should be honoured. Give, and never beg."

"You finished all your works, king," said Indra, "and left your home and went to the forest. So I ask you, son of Nahusha: to whom are you equal in austerity, Yayati?"

"Among gods and men," said Yayati, "among gandharvas and great seers, I see no one equal to me in austerity, Vasava."

"Because you have despised your equals, your betters and your inferiors," said Indra, "not knowing their power, these worlds of yours have an end. Your merit is spent, and today you will fall, king."

"If my worlds are spent, Shakra, because I despised the gods, the seers, the gandharvas and men," said Yayati, "then let me fall among the good, king of the gods, when I am cast out of the world of the gods."

"You will fall near the good, king," said Indra, "and when you have fallen, you will find a footing again. But know this, Yayati, and never again despise your equals or your betters."

Then Yayati left the holy worlds loved by the king of the immortals. As he was falling, Ashtaka saw him, the best of royal seers, the guardian of the rules of true dharma, and he said,

"Who are you, young, as handsome as Vasava, blazing with your own splendour like a fire? You are falling from the sky, from the darkness of the rising clouds, like the sun, the best of all that move in the sky. When we saw you falling from the path of the sun, as bright as fire and the sun, beyond measure, we all wondered, What is this that falls? and we were bewildered. Then we saw you standing on the path of the gods, with the power of Shakra, the sun or Vishnu. So we all came up to you today, wanting to know the truth of your fall.

"We do not dare to be the first to ask you, and you do not ask us who we are. So we ask you, whose form is so lovely: whose are you, and why have you come? Let your fear go, and your sorrow and bewilderment. Let them go quickly, you who are like the king of the gods. For while you are near the good, not even Shakra, the slayer of Bala, can overpower you. The good are always the refuge of those who have fallen from happiness, you who are like the king of the immortals. They have come together here, the lords of all that moves and all that does not. You stand among the good, your equals. Fire is

master in burning, and the earth in sowing. The sun is master in shining, and a guest is master among the good."

"I am Yayati, the son of Nahusha," he said, "Puru's father. Because I despised all beings, I was thrown out of the world of the gods, the perfected ones and the seers. My merit is small, and I am falling. I am older than you in years, and so I do not greet you first. Among the twice-born, the one who is older in knowledge, in austerity or in birth is honoured."

"You said that the one who is older in years is the elder, king," said Ashtaka. "That is not so at all. The one who is learned, and old in years as well, is the one the twice-born honour."

"They say that wrong goes against good deeds," said Yayati, "and that it lives in the proud and leads to evil worlds. The good do not follow the bad in this, for their own hearts speak for the good. I had great wealth. However I strive, I will not win it back. The man who understands this, and lives set on his own good, knows how to live."

"There are many kinds of beings in the world of the living. They depend on fate. Their efforts and their rights are lost. Whatever comes to him, the steady man should not be shaken by it, knowing in his own mind that fate is the stronger. A creature finds happiness or sorrow by fate, not by his own power. So, thinking fate the stronger, he should never burn with grief, and never exult. He should not burn in sorrow nor exult in happiness, but should always live evenly, steady, thinking fate the stronger, never burning with grief and never exulting."

"I am never bewildered by fear, Ashtaka. I have no pain in my mind. For I think: As the Maker shapes me in the world, so I will surely be. Think of the creatures born of sweat, of eggs and of sprouts, the creeping things, the worms and the fish in the water, and the stones, grass and wood. When their fate is spent, all of them go back to their own nature. Knowing that happiness and sorrow do not last, why should I be in pain, Ashtaka? What should I do, and what can I do to escape pain? So I keep pain away, and stay watchful."

"Tell me the chief worlds you have enjoyed, lord of kings," said Ashtaka, "and how long, and how. Tell me all of it, as it was, king. You speak of dharma like one who knows the field."

"I was a king here," said Yayati, "ruling the whole earth. Then I won great worlds, and I lived there for a thousand years. Then I went on to a higher world. Then I lived in the lovely city of Indra of many invocations, with its thousand gates, a hundred yojanas wide, for a thousand years. Then I went on to a higher world. Then I reached the heavenly, ageless world of the lord of creatures, the lord of the world, which is hard to reach. I lived there a thousand years. Then I went on to a higher world."

"I lived in the home of the god of gods as I wished, having won those worlds, honoured by all the thirty gods, equal in power and splendour to the lords. And I lived in Nandana, taking any form I wished, for a million years, playing with the apsarases, seeing the lovely trees in flower, with their holy scents."

"I stayed there, attached to the pleasures of the gods. When a very long time had passed, a messenger of the gods, terrible to look at, cried out to me. Three times he

cried it, with a long, drawn-out voice: 'Fall!'

"That is all I know, lion among kings. Then I fell from Nandana, my merit spent. And I heard the voices of the gods in the air, grieving for me in pity, lord of men: 'Alas, Yayati's merit is spent. He falls, though he did holy deeds and his fame was holy.' As I fell, I said to them, 'How may I fall among the good?' They showed me your place of sacrifice. When I saw it, I came here quickly. I took the scent of the offerings of the place of sacrifice as my guide, and the trail of the smoke, and I was glad."

Chapter 31

The Grandsons

"When you lived in Nandana, taking any form you wished, for a million years," said Ashtaka, "why, first among the men of the golden age, did you leave it and come down to the earth?"

"As a kinsman, a friend or one of his own people is abandoned by men here when his wealth is gone," said Yayati, "so there the hosts of the gods, with their lords, at once abandon a man whose merit is spent."

"How do they come to have their merit spent there?" said Ashtaka. "My mind is very much confused about this. Where do they go, with what marks, and to whose home? Tell me, for I think you know the field."

"They all fall into this earthly hell, lord of men, crying out," said Yayati. "They are spent, and in many ways they grow again, to be food for herons, jackals and crows. So a man should avoid wicked deeds, blamed in the world. I have told you all of it, king. Now tell me, what else shall I tell you?"

"When birds peck at them," said Ashtaka, "and vultures, and blue-throated birds and winged things, how do they come to be, and how do they come into being again? I have not heard of any other earthly hell."

"After the body," said Yayati, "as their deeds swell, they plainly wander over the earth. They fall into this earthly hell, and they do not count the many years. For sixty thousand years they fall through the sky, and for eighty thousand, and as they fall, fierce earthly rakshasas with sharp teeth tear at them."

"If the fierce earthly rakshasas with sharp teeth tear at them for their sins as they fall," said Ashtaka, "how do they come to be? How do they come into being? How do they become embryos?"

"Seed, joined with the essence of flowers and fruit, follows the blood," said Yayati. "When the man lets it go, it goes into the woman's flow, and there it becomes an embryo. They enter trees and plants, water, wind, earth and sky, and all four-footed and two-footed beings. So they come to be, and so they become embryos."

"Does the embryo make another body here," said Ashtaka, "or does it go by its own desire as it comes into the human womb? Tell me, for I ask in doubt. How does it get its body and its growth, its eyes and ears and its awareness? Tell me the truth of it all, since I ask, for we all think you know the field, my friend."

"In the season," said Yayati, "the wind carries the seed, joined with the juice of flowers, up into the womb. There the subtle elements take charge, and little by little they make the embryo grow. When he is born, with his limbs formed, a man is the seat of the six ways of knowing. He knows sound with his ears. He sees all forms with his eyes, smells with his nose, tastes with his tongue, feels touch with his skin, and knows what he feels with his mind. So know, Ashtaka, how the great self that bears the breath gathers in the body."

"When a man dies," said Ashtaka, "and is burned, or buried, or ground away, he comes to

nothing and is destroyed. How does he become aware of himself afterwards?"

"He lets go of his breath, groaning like a sleeper, lion among kings," said Yayati, "and puts his good and bad deeds in front of him. Following the lead of the wind, he leaves the body and takes another womb. Those who do good go to a good womb. Those who do evil go to an evil womb. The evil become worms and insects. I do not wish to say more, great one. Four-footed, two-footed and six-footed, so they come to be, so they become embryos. I have told you all of it. What more do you ask, lion among kings?"

"What must a mortal do, my friend," said Ashtaka, "to win the best worlds, by austerity or by learning? Since I ask, tell me all of it, as it is: by what he may go, one step after another, to the fair worlds."

"Austerity and giving, calm and self-control, modesty, honesty and pity for all beings," said Yayati, "are always destroyed by pride, when a man is overcome by darkness. So the good say. The man who studies and thinks himself learned, and with his learning destroys the fame of others, has worlds that come to an end, and that sacred learning gives him no fruit.

"Four acts give safety, and they give danger when they are done wrongly: the fire offering made in pride, silence kept in pride, study done in pride, and sacrifice made in pride. A man should not be glad when he is honoured, nor pained when he is scorned. The good honour the good in this world, and the bad do not win a good mind. 'I will give this, I will sacrifice this, I will study this: that is my vow.' They say such things bring danger, and they must always be avoided. The wise who know the ancient refuge, which the mind worships, reach the highest good, the shining form, and the highest peace, after death and here."

"How does a householder reach the gods?" said Ashtaka. "How does a wandering beggar, or one who does a teacher's work, or a forest-dweller set on the good path? Many people say many things about this now."

"The student," said Yayati, "studies when he is called, and needs no urging for his teacher's work. He rises first and sleeps last. He is gentle, self-controlled, steady and careful, and given to study. Such a student succeeds.

"The householder gains wealth by dharma, and sacrifices with it. He always gives, and feeds his guests, and he never takes what others have not given. That is the ancient secret teaching for the householder.

"The sage in the forest lives by his own strength, and he has turned from wrong. He gives to others, and he harms no one. Living in the forest, sparing in his food and his movements, such a sage reaches the highest success.

"The beggar does not live by a craft, and he has no home. He has always conquered his senses, and he is free on every side. He stays in no house, he carries little, he moves little, and he wanders the lands alone. He is the true beggar.

"The night by which worlds are won, and desires become conquered and happy, the wise man should strive for that very night, to stand in the forest, master of himself. The forest-dweller who gives up the elements of his body in the forest raises ten forefathers before him, ten after him, and himself the twenty-first, to the worlds of

merit."

"How many kinds of sage are there," said Ashtaka, "and how many kinds of silence? Tell us. We want to hear."

"The man who lives in the forest, and the village is behind him," said Yayati, "or who lives in the village, and the forest is behind him, he is a sage, lord of men."

"How is the village behind a man who lives in the forest?" said Ashtaka. "And how is the forest behind a man who lives in the village?"

"The sage who lives in the forest should use nothing from the village," said Yayati.

"Then, as he lives in the forest, the village is behind him. Without a fire, without a home, without a family or a school, the sage should want only as much cloth as covers him, and only as much food as keeps him alive. Then, as he lives in the village, the forest is behind him.

"The sage who gives up desires, gives up works, conquers his senses and keeps the sage's silence wins success in the world. His teeth are clean, his nails cut, he is always bathed and cared for. Dark he may be, but he stands firm in bright deeds. Who would not honour him? When the sage, worn thin by austerity, wasted, his flesh and bones and blood all spent, has gone beyond the pairs of opposites and keeps the sage's silence, he wins this world and then the next. When the sage seeks his food with his mouth, like a cow, then the world he had before is ready for immortality."

"Of these two, which reaches oneness with the gods first," said Ashtaka, "as they both run, like the sun and the moon?"

"The homeless beggar," said Yayati, "who holds himself in check while he lives in the village among householders who follow their desires, reaches it first. If a man who has not lived a long life falls into wrong, and grieves when he has done it, let him then take up another austerity. What is cruel, they call unwholesome. The man who follows dharma without thought of gain, having nothing and ruling nothing, that is honesty, king, that is concentration, that is noble."

"Who sent you here today as a messenger, king," said Ashtaka, "young, garlanded, handsome and shining? Where have you come from, and from which direction? Or is there a place on earth for you?"

"My merit spent," said Yayati, "I am thrown down from the sky to enter this earthly hell. When I have spoken to you, I will fall at once. The brahmins, the guardians of the world, are hurrying me. I chose to fall near the good, and they are all gathered here, full of virtue. I won this boon from Shakra as I was about to fall to the surface of the earth, lord of men."

"I ask you: do not fall," said Ashtaka, "if I have worlds of my own here, lord of the earth, whether in the air or in heaven. I think you know the field of that dharma."

"As many cattle and horses as there are on the earth," said Yayati, "with the wild beasts and the mountains, so many worlds you have in heaven. Know this, lion among kings."

"I give them to you. Do not fall," said Ashtaka. "The worlds I have in heaven, king of kings, in the air or in heaven, take them quickly, conqueror of enemies."

"No one like me, not a brahmin but a knower of Brahman, lives by taking gifts, chief of kings," said Yayati. "As one should always give to brahmins, so I gave before, lord of men. No one who is not a brahmin should live like a beggar, nor a brahmin woman who is a hero's wife. How could I do now what I have never done before, seeking to know what is good?"

"I ask you, you whose form is so lovely," said Pratardana, "if I, Pratardana, have worlds of my own, whether in the air or in heaven. I think you know the field of that dharma."

"You have many worlds, lord of men," said Yayati, "each one of them seven times seven days, flowing with honey, rich with ghee, free of sorrow. They are endless, and they wait for you."

"I give them to you. Do not fall," said Pratardana. "The worlds that are mine, let them be yours, whether in the air or in heaven. Take them quickly, and be free of your confusion."

"A king of equal splendour should not want another's merit as his safety, king, since he is a king," said Yayati. "A wise king, brought into trouble by the order of fate, should never do anything base. A king should think of the path of dharma that brings fame, and act with his eyes on dharma. A man like me, who knows dharma, should not do the mean thing you say. How could I do what I have never done, what others have not done, seeking to know what is good?"

As King Yayati said this, Vasumanas, the best of kings, spoke to him.

"I, Vasumanas, son of Rushadashva, ask you," said Vasumanas, "if I have a world in heaven, lord of men, or a famous one in the air, great one. I think you know the field of that dharma."

"As much as the air, the earth and the quarters of the sky," said Yayati, "and all that the sun warms with his heat: so many worlds you have in heaven. They are endless, and they wait for you."

"I give them to you. Do not fall," said Vasumanas. "The worlds that are mine, let them be yours. Buy them, king, even for a blade of grass, if taking a gift is wrong for you."

"I do not remember ever making a false sale," said Yayati, "or taking anything for nothing, fearing it as I would from a child. I would not do what others have never done, seeking to know what is good."

"Take those worlds, king, as my gift," said Vasumanas, "if a sale does not please you. I will not take them back, lord of men. Let all those worlds be yours."

"I am Shibi, son of Ushinara," said Shibi, "and I ask you if I too have worlds here, my friend, whether in the air or in heaven. I think you know the field of that dharma."

"You have never scorned, in word or in heart, learned king, those who came to you

wanting something," said Yayati. "So you have endless worlds in heaven, like lightning, full of sound, and great."

"Take those worlds, king, as my gift," said Shibi, "if a sale does not please you. I will not take them back once I have given them, the worlds you would go to and enjoy."

"As you have power like Indra's, lord of men, and those worlds are endless," said Yayati, "so I take no joy in a world given by another. That is why, Shibi, I do not welcome the gift."

"If you will not accept our worlds one by one, king," said Ashtaka, "we will give them all to you and go to hell."

"Give to the worthy what is due to them, good men, in truth and kindness," said Yayati. "But I will not dare to do what I have never done before."

"Whose are these five golden chariots that we see," said Ashtaka, "standing high and shining, blazing like tongues of fire?"

"These five golden chariots, standing high and shining, blazing like tongues of fire," said Yayati, "will carry you."

"Mount the chariot, king," said Ashtaka, "and stride through the sky. We will follow when the time comes."

"We must all go now together," said Yayati, "for we have won heaven. There is our path to the home of the gods, free of dust. We can see it."

Then all those best of kings mounted the chariots and set out, striding up to heaven, filling heaven and earth with the light of their dharma.

"I thought that I would go first, alone," said Ashtaka, "for Indra, the great one, is my friend in every way. How is it that Shibi, son of Ushinara, has gone ahead of us all, driving his horses at full speed?"

"This son of Ushinara gave all the wealth he found for the path of the gods," said Yayati. "That is why Shibi is the best of us. Giving, austerity, truth and dharma, modesty, fortune, forgiveness, gentleness and patience, king: these all live in King Shibi, who has no equal, through his kind understanding. Because he lives like this, and is held back by modesty, Shibi has gone ahead in his chariot."

Then Ashtaka, out of curiosity, asked again his mother's father, who was like Indra, "I ask you, lord of men, tell me truly: where are you from, and whose son are you? What you have done, no other kshatriya or brahmin in the world has done."

"I am Yayati, the son of Nahusha, the father of Puru," he said, "and I was an emperor here. I tell a secret to my own people: I am your mother's father, and now you know it. I conquered this whole earth. I tethered fine, one-hoofed horses fit for sacrifice and gave them to the brahmins, and so the gods had their share of merit. I gave this whole earth to the brahmins, full of beasts of burden, with cattle and gold and the finest wealth. There were a hundred arbudas of cows. By my truth heaven and earth stand, and fire blazes among men. I have never spoken a word in vain, for the good honour truth."

All the gods, the sages and the worlds are to be honoured by truth. That is what is in my heart. Whoever tells the story of all of us who have won heaven, as it happened, without envy, to the best of brahmins, will reach the same world as we."

So that great king, the crusher of enemies, was saved by his daughter's sons. His deeds were most generous, and he left the earth and went to heaven, filling the earth with the fame of his deeds.

Chapter 32

The Line of Puru

"Blessed one," said Janamejaya, "I want to hear about the kings who carried on Puru's line: how brave they were, what kind of men, how many, and how valiant. For in this line there has never been a king without good character, or without courage, or without children. I want to hear in full, rich in austerity, the lives of those famous kings, so rich in wisdom."

Then I will tell you, since you ask, of the heroes who carried on Puru's line, as bright as Shakra.

Three sons were born to Puru by Paushti, all great warriors: Pravira, Ishvara and Raudrashva. Of them, Pravira carried on the line. From him was born the lord Manasyu, the son of Shyeni, a hero with lotus eyes, who protected the earth to its four ends. Manasyu had three sons by Sauviri, all heroes and great warriors: Subhru, Samhanana and Vagmin.

Raudrashva had ten sons by an apsaras. They were great archers, heroes, men who offered sacrifices, with many children and much learning, all of them skilled in every weapon and all devoted to dharma: Richepu, Kakshepu and mighty Krikanepu, Sthandilepu, Vanepu and the great warrior Sthalepu, strong and wise Tejepu, Satyepu with the courage of Indra, Dharmepu, and Samnatepu, the tenth, with the courage of a god. These sons of Anadhrishti, my friend, performed the royal consecration and the horse sacrifice.

Then the learned King Matinara was born, the son of Richepu. Matinara had four sons, king, of boundless courage: Tamsu, Mahat, Atiratha and Druhyu of matchless splendour. Of them, mighty Tamsu carried on the Paurava line, won blazing fame and conquered the earth. Mighty Tamsu fathered a son, Ilina, and he too, the best of conquerors, conquered this whole earth. Then Ilina fathered five sons on Rathantari, like the five elements, king, with Dushyanta the first: Dushyanta, Shura and Bhima, Prapurva and Vasu. The eldest of them, Dushyanta, became king, Janamejaya.

From Dushyanta was born the learned King Bharata, the son of Shakuntala. From him the great fame of the Bharata line spread. Bharata fathered nine sons on three wives. The king did not welcome them. "They are not like me," he said. Then Bharata offered great sacrifices, and he won a son, named Bhumanyu, from Bharadvaja, Bharata. Then, knowing that he had a son, the joy of the Pauravas consecrated Bhumanyu as crown prince, best of the Bharatas.

Then that great king had a son, Vitatha. Then Vitatha was born as the son of Bhumanyu. Bhumanyu had sons by Pushkarini: Suhotra and Suhotri, Suhavis and Suyajus. The eldest of them, Suhotra, won the kingdom of the lords of the earth. He sacrificed with many offerings, the royal consecration, the horse sacrifice and others. Suhotra enjoyed the whole earth, clothed by the ocean, full of elephants, cattle and horses, and crowded with jewels. The earth almost sank under him, weighed down by its great load, full of elephants, horses and chariots, and crowded with people. While King Suhotra ruled his people by dharma, the land was marked by shrines and sacrificial posts by the hundred thousand. With her people and her crops thriving, and her gods with her, the earth shone.

Aikshvaki bore to Suhotra, the lord of the earth, Ajamidha, Sumidha and Purumidha,

Bharata. Ajamidha was the best of them, and the line rested on him. He too fathered six sons, on three wives, Bharata. Dhumini bore Riksha. Nili bore Dushyanta and Parameshthin. Keshini bore Jahnu, and the two, Jana and Rupina. All these Panchalas come from Dushyanta and Parameshthin, and the Kushikas come from Jahnu of boundless splendour, king. They call Riksha the eldest, the lord of the people, older than Jana and Rupina. From Riksha was born Samvarana, king, who carried on your line.

While Samvarana, the son of Riksha, ruled the earth, king, there was a very great destruction of his people. So we have heard. Then the kingdom broke apart, struck by ruin of many kinds, by hunger and death, by drought and by sickness. The armies of enemies struck at the Bharatas. Shaking the earth with his army of four divisions, the king of the Panchalas, who had conquered the earth by force, marched against him, and defeated him in battle with ten akshauhinis.

Then King Samvarana fled from that great danger, with his wives, his ministers, his sons and his friends. He lived then in a thicket by the great river Sindhu, near a mountain at the edge of the river country. The Bharatas lived there for a long time, sheltered in a stronghold.

When they had lived there a thousand years, the blessed seer Vasishtha came to the Bharatas. They all went out eagerly to meet him and bowed to him, and the Bharatas brought him the guest offering. They offered everything to the bright seer with honour. When he had lived there eight years, the king himself chose him. "Be our family priest. We are striving for our kingdom."

"Om," said Vasishtha, and he agreed to serve the Bharatas. Then, so we have heard, he consecrated the Paurava as emperor over all the kshatriyas, the horn of the whole earth. He took again the fine city where Bharata had lived before, and he made all the kings of the earth pay him tribute once more. Then the mighty descendant of Ajamidha, having won back the earth, sacrificed again with many great sacrifices, with rich gifts to the priests.

Then Tapati, the daughter of the sun, bore Kuru to Samvarana. All his people chose him as king, for he knew dharma. The land of Kurujangala on earth is famous by his name. That great ascetic made Kurukshetra holy by his austerity. We have heard that his clever wife Vahini bore him five sons: Ashvavat, Abhishvat, Chitraratha, Muni and the famous Janamejaya.

Abhishvat's sons were Parikshit and mighty Shabalashva, Abhiraja and Viraja, and mighty Shalmala, Uccaihsravas, Bhadrakara, and Jitari, remembered as the eighth. In their line there were men famous for the virtues their deeds brought them. Parikshit's sons were Janamejaya and six more, mighty men, all of them skilled in dharma and in wealth: Kakshasena and Ugrasena, mighty Chitrasena, Indrasena, Sushena, and the one named Bhimasena.

Janamejaya's sons were mighty and famous on earth: Dhritarashtra, the first-born, Pandu and Bahlika, Nishadha of great splendour, and mighty Jambunada, Kundodara, Padati, and Vasati, remembered as the eighth. All of them were skilled in dharma and in wealth, and all of them delighted in the good of all beings. Then Dhritarashtra became king. His sons were Kundika, Hastin, Vitarka, Kratha and Kundala the fifth, Havishravas, Indrabha, and Sumanyu the unconquered.

Pratipa had three sons, bull of the Bharatas: Devapi, Shantanu, and Bahlika, the great warrior. Devapi went forth from the world, seeking dharma. Shantanu and the great warrior Bahlika won the earth.

Many strong and great warriors were born in the line of Bharata, king, many of the best of kings, like divine seers. And there were others like them, like gods, great warriors, born in the line of Manu, who made the line of Ila grow.

Chapter 33

The Line Told Again

"I have heard from you, brahmin," said Janamejaya, "the great story of how my forebears came to be, and I have heard of the noble kings in this line. But a lovely tale told briefly does not satisfy me. So tell it again, in full. Who would not delight in this heavenly story of their holy births, from the lord of creatures and from Manu? Their fame stands, wide and great, holding up the three worlds, grown by the greatness of their true dharma and their virtues. They had virtue and power, courage and strength, goodness and spirit, and as I hear their story, which tastes like the nectar of immortality, I cannot have enough of it."

Listen, king, to the whole of this fine account of your own line, as I heard it rightly long ago from Dvaipayana.

From Daksha came Aditi. From Aditi came Vivasvat. From Vivasvat came Manu. From Manu came Ila. From Ila came Pururavas. From Pururavas came Ayus. From Ayus came Nahusha. From Nahusha came Yayati.

Yayati had two wives, Devayani, the daughter of Ushanas, and Sharmishtha, the daughter of Vrishaparvan. Here there is a verse of the line:

Devayani bore Yadu and Turvasu. Sharmishtha, daughter of Vrishaparvan, bore Druhyu, Anu and Puru.

From Yadu came the Yadavas. From Puru came the Pauravas.

Puru's wife was named Kausalya. On her he fathered Janamejaya, who performed three horse sacrifices, and after he had offered the sacrifice called Vishvajit, went into the forest.

Janamejaya married Ananta, a woman of the Madhavas. On her he fathered Prachinvat, who conquered the eastern quarter as far as the place where the sun rises. That is why he is called Prachinvat, the Conqueror of the East.

Prachinvat married a woman of the Ashmakas. On her he fathered Samyati.

Samyati married Varangi, the daughter of Drishadvat. On her he fathered Ahampati.

Ahampati married Bhanumati, the daughter of Kritavirya. On her he fathered Sarvabhauma.

Sarvabhauma won Sunanda, a Kaikeyi princess, by conquest and carried her off. On her he fathered Jayatsena.

Jayatsena married Sushuva, a princess of Vidarbha. On her he fathered Arachina.

Arachina too married a princess of Vidarbha, another, named Maryada. On her he fathered Mahabhauma.

Mahabhauma married Suyajna, the daughter of Prasenajit. On her he fathered Ayutanayin, who performed ten thousand human sacrifices. That is why he is called Ayutanayin, the Bringer of Ten Thousand.

Ayutanayin married Bhasa, the daughter of Prithushravas. On her he fathered Akrodhana.

Akrodhana married Karandu, a princess of Kalinga. On her he fathered Devatithi.

Devatithi married Maryada, a princess of Videha. On her he fathered Richa.

Richa married Sudeva, a princess of Anga. On her he fathered a son, Riksha.

Riksha married Jvala, the daughter of Takshaka. On her he fathered a son named Matinara.

Matinara held a twelve-year sacrifice on the Sarasvati. When the sacrifice was over, the river Sarasvati came to him and chose him as her husband. On her he fathered a son named Tamsu. Here there is a verse of the line:

Sarasvati bore Tamsu, the son of Matinara. Tamsu fathered a son, Ilina, on Kalindi.

Ilina fathered five sons on Rathantari, with Dushyanta the first.

Dushyanta married Shakuntala, the daughter of Vishvamitra. On her he fathered Bharata. Here there are two verses:

The mother is only the bellows. The son belongs to the father. The one who fathers him, he is that one. Support your son, Dushyanta. Do not despise Shakuntala. The man who places the seed raises his son up from the house of Yama, god among men. You placed this child in the womb. Shakuntala speaks the truth.

That is why he was called Bharata.

Bharata married Sunanda, the daughter of Sarvasena of Kashi. On her he fathered Bhumanyu.

Bhumanyu married Jaya, a woman of the Dasharhas. On her he fathered Suhotra.

Suhotra married Suvarna, a princess of the Ikshvakus. On her he fathered Hastin, who laid out this city of Hastinapura. That is why it is called Hastinapura.

Hastin married Yashodhara, a princess of Trigarta. On her he fathered Vikunthana.

Vikunthana married Sudeva, a woman of the Dasharhas. On her he fathered Ajamidha.

Ajamidha had a hundred and twenty-four sons, by Kaikeyi, Naga, Gandhari, Vimala and Riksha. They were kings who each founded a line of his own. Of them, Samvarana carried on this line.

Samvarana married Tapati, the daughter of Vivasvat. On her he fathered Kuru.

Kuru married Shubhangi, a woman of the Dasharhas. On her he fathered Viduratha.

Viduratha married Samprija, a princess of Magadha. On her he fathered a son named Arugvat.

Arugvat married Amrita, a princess of Magadha. On her he fathered Parikshit.

Parikshit married Suyasha, a woman of the Bahudas. On her he fathered Bhimasena.

Bhimasena married Sukumari, a Kaikeyi princess. On her he fathered Paryashravas, whom they call Pratipa.

Pratipa married Sunanda, a princess of the Shibis. On her he fathered sons: Devapi, Shantanu and Bahlika.

Devapi went into the forest while he was still a boy, and Shantanu became king. Here there is a verse of the line:

Whatever old man he touches with his hands is made happy and becomes young again. That is why they know him as Shantanu.

That is why he was called Shantanu.

Shantanu married Ganga, the river Bhagirathi. On her he fathered Devavrata, whom they call Bhishma.

Bhishma, to do what would please his father, brought Satyawati to be his mother, whom they call Gandhakali. She had a son born to her as a maiden, Dvaipayana, by Parashara. And she had two sons by Shantanu, Chitrangada and Vichitravirya. Of them, Chitrangada was killed by a gandharva before he reached his youth, and Vichitravirya became king.

Vichitravirya married Ambika and Ambalika, the daughters of the king of Kashi by a princess of Kosala. But Vichitravirya died without children.

Then Satyawati thought, The line of Dushyanta is being cut off. She called Dvaipayana, the seer, to mind. He stood before her. "What shall I do?" he said.

She said to him, "Your brother Vichitravirya has gone to heaven without children. Father children for him, as is right."

"Very well," he said, and he fathered three sons: Dhritarashtra, Pandu and Vidura.

King Dhritarashtra had a hundred sons by Gandhari, through a boon from Dvaipayana. Four of Dhritarashtra's sons were the chief: Duryodhana, Duhshasana, Vikarna and Chitrasena.

Pandu had two wives, Kunti and Madri, both of them jewels among women.

Once, when Pandu was hunting, he saw a seer mating with a doe. The seer was in the midst of it and had not yet tasted the pleasure of love, and Pandu shot him with an arrow. Pierced by the arrow, the seer said to Pandu, "You know dharma, and yet you struck me down when I had not yet tasted the pleasure of love. So you too, when you come to this state, before you have tasted the pleasure of love, will quickly die."

Pandu went pale, and to escape the curse he did not go near his wives. And he said, "I have brought this on myself by my own rashness. And I hear that there are no worlds for a man without children." So he said to Kunti, "Bear sons for me."

She bore sons there: Yudhishtira by Dharma, Bhimasena by the Wind, and Arjuna by Shakra. Pandu was glad, and he said to her, "Your fellow wife has no children. Let her have children too, as is right."

"So be it," said Kunti. Then Nakula and Sahadeva were born to Madri by the two Ashvins.

One day Pandu saw Madri adorned, and desire rose in him. As soon as he touched her, he died. Madri climbed onto his funeral pyre with him. She said to Kunti, "Noble one, watch carefully over the twins."

Then the ascetics brought the five Pandavas, with Kunti, to Hastinapura, and presented them to Bhishma and Vidura. There too, when an attempt was made to burn them in the house of lac, it failed, through Vidura's counsel. Then, on the way, they killed Hidimba and went to Ekachakra. In Ekachakra too they killed a rakshasa named Baka, and then they went to the city of the Panchalas. There they won Draupadi as their wife, and came home to their own country safely.

And they fathered sons. Yudhishtira fathered Prativindhya, Wolf-belly Sutasoma, Arjuna Shrutakirti, Nakula Shatanika, and Sahadeva Shrutakarman.

Yudhishtira won Devika, the daughter of Govasana the Shaibya, at her own choosing of a husband. On her he fathered a son named Yaudheya. Bhimasena married Baladhara, a princess of Kashi, whom he won as the prize for his strength. On her he fathered a son named Sarvaga. Arjuna went to Dvaravati and married Subhadra, the sister of Vasudeva. On her he fathered a son named Abhimanyu. Nakula married Karenumati, a princess of Chedi. On her he fathered a son named Niramitra. Sahadeva married Vijaya, a Madra princess, at her own choosing of a husband. On her he fathered a son named Suhotra. And Bhimasena, before all this, had fathered a son named Ghatotkacha on the rakshasi Hidimba. These are the eleven sons of the Pandavas.

Abhimanyu married Uttara, the daughter of Virata. She bore a child that was dead. At the command of Vasudeva, the best of men, Pritha took him in her lap. "I will bring this six-month child back to life," Vasudeva said. And when he had brought him back to life, he said, "He was born when the line was wasted away. Let him be named Parikshit."

Parikshit married Madravati. On her he fathered Janamejaya. Janamejaya had two sons by Vapushtama, Shatanika and Shanku. Shatanika married a princess of Videha. On her he fathered a son, Ashvamedhadatta.

This is the line of Puru, and of the Pandavas. Whoever hears this line of Puru is freed from all his sins.

Chapter 34

Ganga

There was a king born in the line of Ikshvaku, a lord of the earth named Mahabhisha, true in his word and true in his courage. He pleased the king of the gods with a thousand horse sacrifices and a hundred Vajapeya rites, and so the lord won heaven.

Once the gods were waiting upon Brahma, and the royal seers were there, and King Mahabhisha among them. Then Ganga, the best of rivers, came to the Grandfather. The wind lifted her garment, bright as the moon, and at once the hosts of the gods lowered their faces. But the royal seer Mahabhisha looked at the river without fear. The blessed Brahma thought ill of Mahabhisha, and said to him, "You will be born among mortals, and then you will win back these worlds."

The king thought about all the kings who were rich in austerity, and he chose Pratipa, of great splendour, to be his father.

The river, the best of rivers, saw King Mahabhisha lose his composure, and she went away thinking of him in her heart. On her way she saw the Vasus, the gods who live in heaven, their forms ruined, their power struck down by faintness. When the best of rivers saw them like that, she asked them, "Why have you lost your forms? Is all well with the dwellers of heaven?"

"We have been cursed, great river," said the Vasu gods, "by the great Vasishtha, in his anger, for a small offence. Long ago, in our folly, we all passed by the best of seers, Vasishtha, as he sat hidden at his twilight prayers. In his anger he cursed us: 'Be born from a womb.' What a man who speaks the sacred word has said cannot be made otherwise. So you must become a woman and bear us, the Vasus, as your sons on earth. We do not want to enter the unclean belly of a human woman."

When they said this, Ganga said to the Vasus, "So be it," and she asked them, "Who among mortals, the best of men, will be your father?"

"The son of Pratipa," said the Vasus, "a righteous king named Shantanu, will be born in the world of men. He will be our father."

"I think so too, sinless gods, as you say," said Ganga. "I will do what pleases him, and what you want."

"You must throw your sons into the water as soon as they are born," said the Vasus, "so that our release, you who go through the three worlds, comes before long."

"I will do this," said Ganga. "But let one son be kept for him, so that his union with me for the sake of a son is not in vain."

"Each of us will give a quarter of half his strength," said the Vasus. "With that strength your son will be the son he wants. But he will not have children of his own among mortals. So your son will be mighty, and have no son."

When they had made this agreement with Ganga, the Vasus went away gladly, as they had planned.

Then King Pratipa, who delighted in the good of all creatures, sat for many years on the bank of the Ganga, praying. Ganga rose from the water, full of beauty and grace, like Shri in bodily form, most desirable to see. The lovely-faced woman of heavenly form and high spirit came and sat on the right thigh of the royal seer as he prayed, a thigh like the trunk of a sal tree.

"What can I do for you, lovely one?" said Pratipa, lord of the earth, to the proud woman. "What do you desire?"

"I desire you, king, best of the Kurus," said the woman. "Love me. The good condemn turning away women who desire them."

"I will not go to another man's wife out of desire, fair one," said Pratipa, "nor to a woman not of my class. Know that this is my vow, and it is lawful."

"I am not unlucky," said the woman, "nor forbidden to you, nor one to be spoken ill of, ever. Love me, king, for I love you. I am a maiden, and a fine woman."

"I have set aside what you urge me to," said Pratipa, "dear as it would be. If I did otherwise, the wreck of dharma would destroy me. You came and sat on my right thigh, lovely woman. Know, timid one, that this is the seat of children and daughters-in-law. The left side is the place of a lover, and you avoided it. So I will not love you with desire, fine woman. Be my daughter-in-law, lovely one. I choose you for my son, for you came and sat on the side of the daughter-in-law, you of the lovely thighs."

"So be it, you who know dharma," said the woman. "Let me be joined with your son. Out of devotion to you I will serve the famous Bharata line. You are the refuge of all the kings on earth. I could not tell your virtues in a hundred years. The goodness of those who have gone before in your line is beyond compare. But your son must not know my family, my lord, and whatever I do, your son must never question it. Living with your son like this, I will make his joy grow. By holy and dear sons your son will reach heaven."

"So be it," she said, king, and she vanished there and then. And the king kept it in mind, waiting for the birth of a son.

At this very time, Pratipa, the bull among kshatriyas, practised austerity with his wife for the sake of a son, joy of the Kurus. To them, when they were old, that Mahabhisha was born as their son. He was born the child of one who was calm, shanta, and so he was Shantanu. Remembering the worlds that never pass away, which he had won by his own deeds, Shantanu did only holy deeds, best of the Kurus.

When Shantanu was a young man, Pratipa instructed him. "Long ago a woman came to me, Shantanu, for your good. If that lovely woman comes to you in private, my son, full of desire, beautiful, a heavenly woman wanting a son, you must not question her. Do not ask her, 'Who are you, lovely one, and whose?' Whatever she does, you must not ask her about it, sinless one. At my command, love her, for she loves you." So he told him.

When Pratipa had instructed his son Shantanu like this, the king consecrated him in his own kingdom and went into the forest.

King Shantanu was wise, and famous on earth as a bowman. He loved to hunt, and he was

always in the forest. The best of kings killed deer and buffalo, and he roamed alone along the Ganga, where the perfected ones and the heavenly singers go.

One day, great king, he saw a wonderful woman, blazing with beauty, like Shri herself, the lotus goddess. She was flawless in every part, with lovely teeth, adorned with heavenly ornaments, wearing fine clothes, alone, and she shone like the heart of a lotus. When he saw her, the hair on his body stood up. He was amazed at her beauty, and though he drank her in with his eyes, the lord of men could not have enough. And when she saw the king of great splendour wandering there, her heart went out to him in love, and the graceful woman could not have enough of him either.

Then the king spoke to her gently, in a soft voice. "Whether you are a goddess or a danava woman, a gandharva woman or an apsaras, a yaksha woman or a snake woman, or a human woman, you of the slender waist, whoever you are, you who shine like the child of a god, be my wife, lovely one."

When she heard the king's gentle, sweet words, spoken with a smile, the faultless woman remembered the Vasus' agreement, and she came to him. She spoke, delighting the king's heart with her words. "I will be your queen, lord of the earth, and I will obey you. But whatever I do, king, good or bad, you must not stop me, nor say anything unkind to me. As long as you behave like this, I will live with you, king. If I am stopped, or spoken to unkindly, I will surely leave you."

"So be it," the king said to her, best of the Bharatas, and she was filled with joy beyond compare to have won that best of kings.

Shantanu, master of himself, won her and enjoyed her as he wished. Thinking, She must not be questioned, he said nothing to her at all. The lord of the earth was delighted with her character and her conduct, her beauty and generosity and her virtues, and the care she gave him in private. For she was the goddess Ganga, the river that flows in three worlds, who had taken on a lovely human body, of heavenly beauty, the fair one. She had come as a wife to Shantanu, the lion among kings, as bright as the king of the gods, whose desire had been granted by his good fortune. With her skill in love and tenderness, with her charming ways and her dancing, she delighted the king, as he delighted in her. The king was so lost in love, so captured by the virtues of that finest of women, that he did not notice the many years, seasons and months go by.

Taking his pleasure with her as he wished, the lord of men fathered eight sons on her, as fair as the immortals. And as each son was born, Bharata, she threw him into the water. "I am doing you good," she would say, and she would drown him in the stream of the Ganga.

King Shantanu did not like this. But the lord of the earth said nothing to her, afraid she would leave him.

Then, when the eighth son was born, and she seemed to be smiling, the king, in pain, wanting to save his son, said to her, "Do not kill him! Who are you, and whose? Why do you kill your sons? Killer of your sons, do not bring this great sin on yourself. Stop, you whom all will condemn."

"You want a son," said the woman. "I will not kill your son, best of those who have sons. But my time with you is worn out, as we agreed. I am Ganga, the daughter of Jahnu,

served by the hosts of great seers. I have lived with you to bring about a purpose of the gods. These eight are the Vasus, gods of great fortune and great power, who became men through the fault of Vasishtha's curse. There was no one on earth but you to father them, and no human woman like me to bear them. So I became a woman to be their mother. By fathering the eight Vasus you have won worlds that never pass away. This was the gods' agreement with the Vasus, which I promised: 'I will set each one free from his human birth as soon as he is born.' So they are freed from the curse of the great Apava. Good fortune to you. I will go. Protect this son of great vows. This was my time of dwelling with you, made for the sake of the Vasus. Know that this son was born of me, given by Ganga."

"Who is this Apava?" said Shantanu. "What wrong did the Vasus do, that by his curse they all came into human bodies? And what has this boy, given by Ganga, done, that because of it he will live among men? How did the Vasus, the lords of the whole world, come to be born among men? Tell me, daughter of Jahnu."

When he asked her this, the goddess Ganga, the daughter of Jahnu, said to her husband Shantanu, the bull among men,

"The son whom Varuna had long ago, best of the Bharatas, is the sage named Vasishtha, also known as Apava. His holy hermitage, full of deer and birds, is on the side of Meru, the king of mountains, and flowers of every season cover it. There the son of Varuna practised austerity, best of the Bharatas, in a forest with sweet roots, fruit and water, the best of those who do holy deeds.

"Surabhi, the daughter of Daksha, very proud, bore a cow to Kashyapa, bull of the Bharatas. For the good of the world, the righteous son of Varuna won that fine cow, who gave everything desired, as the cow for his fire offerings. She lived in that ascetics' forest, where sages came, and wandered there without fear, in that lovely and holy place.

"Then one day, bull of the Bharatas, the Vasus, Prithu and all the others, came to that forest, where the gods and the divine seers came. They wandered all over that forest with their wives, and played among the lovely mountains and woods. There the wife of one of the Vasus, you with the courage of Indra, as she wandered in that forest, saw the cow, the sage Vasishtha's finest cow, who gave everything desired. The slender woman was amazed at the cow's wealth of good qualities, and she showed her to Dyaus, you whose eyes are like a bull's: full-uddered, a good milker, with a fine tail and a fine face, lovely, with every virtue and a matchless nature. Long ago, joy of the Pauravas, the Vasu's wife showed the Vasu that cow with all those virtues.

"As soon as Dyaus saw the cow, king, you with the courage of the king of elephants, he told the goddess about her beauty and her virtues. 'This fine cow, goddess, dark-eyed one, belongs to the son of Varuna, the seer whose forest this is, lovely one. A mortal who drinks her sweet milk, slender one, will live ten thousand years in lasting youth.'

"When the slender, faultless goddess heard this, best of kings, she said to her husband, who blazed with splendour, 'I have a friend in the world of men, the daughter of a king, named Jinavati, rich in beauty and youth, the daughter of Ushinara, the wise royal seer, true to his word, famous in the world of men for her beauty. For her sake, fortunate one, best of immortals, bring me that cow and her calf, which I want. Be quick, you who make merit grow. When my friend has drunk her milk, you who give honour, let her alone

among men be free from old age and sickness. You should do this for me, fortunate and faultless one. There is nothing dearer to me, nothing at all.'

"When he heard the goddess's words, Dyaus, wanting to please her, stole that cow, with his brothers, Prithu and the others. Sent by his lotus-eyed wife, king, Dyaus could not see the seer's fierce austerity. He stole the cow, and did not think of the fall.

"Then the son of Varuna came back to his hermitage with the fruit he had gathered, and he did not see the cow and her calf in that fine forest. The ascetic searched for her in the forest, and the sage of great mind, searching, did not find the cow. With his heavenly sight he knew that the Vasus had taken her, and at once he fell into a rage and cursed the Vasus. 'Since the Vasus have taken my cow, my good milker with her fine tail, they will all be born among men. There is no doubt of it.'

"So the blessed Apava, the best of sages, cursed the Vasus, bull of the Bharatas, in the power of his anger. And when he had cursed them, the fortunate one set his mind on austerity again. So, king, the ascetic, the brahmin seer of great power, cursed the eight Vasu gods, in anger.

"Then, knowing that they had been cursed, the Vasus came again to the great one's hermitage and approached the seer. They tried to win the seer's favour, bull among kings, but they did not win it from Apava, the best of seers, tiger among men, who knew all dharma. But the righteous one said, 'You seven, Dhara and the rest, will be free of the curse within a year. But this one, for whose deed I cursed you, Dyaus, will live a long time in the world of men, through his own deed. I will not make false what I said in anger. And this great-minded one will not have children among men. He will be righteous and skilled in all the sciences. He will be devoted to what is good and dear to his father, and he will give up the pleasures of women.' When he had said this to all the Vasus, the blessed seer went away.

"Then the Vasus all came to me together, king, and asked me for a boon, and I granted it: 'As soon as we are born, Ganga, throw us into the water yourself.' So, best of kings, I have done rightly what was needed to free them from the world of men, cursed as they were. By that seer's curse, best of kings, this one alone, Dyaus, will live long in the world of men, Bharata."

When she had told him this, the goddess vanished there and then, and she took the boy with her and went where she wished. He was named Devavrata, and also Gangeya: the son of Shantanu had two names, and in virtue he surpassed Shantanu.

And Shantanu, stricken with grief, went back to his city. Now I will tell you the boundless virtues of Shantanu, and the great fortune of that famous Bharata king, whose bright history is called the Mahabharata.

Chapter 35

Bhishma

So wise Shantanu, honoured by gods, royal seers and seers, was famous in all the worlds as a righteous man who spoke the truth. Self-control, generosity, patience, understanding, modesty, steadiness and the highest splendour were always in Shantanu, that great-spirited bull among men. Such was the king, full of virtues, skilled in dharma and in wealth, the protector of the Bharata line and of good people.

His neck was lined like a conch shell, his shoulders were broad, and he moved like an elephant in rut. He was settled in his mind that dharma is higher than desire and than wealth. These were in the great-spirited Shantanu, bull of the Bharatas, and there was no kshatriya like him in dharma. He kept to his own dharma, the best of all who know dharma, and the kings of the earth consecrated him as king of kings. With the protector of the Bharatas over them, the kings were free of grief, fear and harm, and they slept and woke in comfort.

While the world was guarded by kings with Shantanu at their head, all the classes kept to their rules, and the brahmins stood first. The kshatriyas served the brahmins, the vaishyas were loyal to the kshatriyas, and the shudras, devoted to brahmins and kshatriyas, served the vaishyas.

He lived in lovely Hastinapura, the capital of the Kurus, and ruled the earth to the ocean's edge. He was like the king of the gods, knowing dharma, truthful and honest, and through his giving, his dharma and his austerity he had the highest fortune. He was free of passion and hatred, as good to look at as the moon, as bright as the sun, as swift as the wind, like Death in his anger, and like the earth in his patience. While Shantanu ruled the earth, king, no cattle, boars, deer or birds were ever killed for nothing. In a kingdom where dharma and the brahmins came first, Shantanu, humble and self-disciplined, ruled all creatures alike, free from desire and passion. Rites were begun then for the gods, the seers and the forefathers, and no living creature was killed against dharma. For the unhappy, the unprotected, and those born as animals, the king was a father to all.

While that best of Kuru kings was king of kings, speech rested on truth, and the mind rested on giving and dharma. For sixteen years, and eight, and four, and eight more, he found no delight in women, and he lived in the forest.

His son, Gangeya, named Devavrata, a Vasu, was like him in form, in conduct, in behaviour and in learning. He was master of all weapons, those of kings and all the others, of great strength, great spirit and great courage, a great warrior.

Once, when he had shot a deer and was following the river Ganga, King Shantanu saw that the Bhagirathi had only a little water in it. When he saw it, Shantanu, the bull among men, wondered, *Why is this best of rivers not flowing today as it did before?*

Then the great-minded king looked for the cause, and he saw a boy, handsome, tall and lovely to look at, using a divine weapon like the god Indra himself. He stood there, having dammed the whole Ganga with his sharp arrows. When the king saw the river Ganga held back by arrows near the boy, he was amazed at the deed, which was more than human.

Shantanu had seen his son only at birth, long ago, and the wise king did not remember

him well enough to know him as his own. But when the boy saw his father, he bewildered him by magic. And when he had bewildered him, he quickly vanished there and then.

When King Shantanu saw that wonder, he suspected that it was his son, and he said to Ganga, "Show him to me."

Ganga, taking on a lovely form, showed him the boy, adorned, holding him by the right hand. Shantanu did not know her, though he had seen her before, adorned with jewels and wearing spotless clothes.

"This is the eighth son you fathered on me long ago, king," said Ganga. "Here he is, tiger among men. Take him home. The mighty one learned the Vedas and their limbs from Vasishtha himself. He is skilled in weapons, a great archer, like the king of the gods in battle, always honoured by the gods and the asuras, Bharata. Whatever science Ushanas knows, this one knows it all. And the whole science that the son of Angiras knows, whom the gods and asuras bow to, is established in him too, in your strong-armed, great-souled son, with all its limbs and branches. And whatever weapon the mighty seer Rama Jamadagnya knows, whom others cannot overcome, is established in him too. This great archer, king, skilled in the dharma and the business of kings, your own son, I have given back to you. Take the hero home, hero."

Given leave by her, Shantanu took his son, who shone like the sun, and went to his city. When the Paurava came to his city, which was like the city of Indra, he thought himself rich in everything he could desire. Then he consecrated his son as crown prince among the Pauravas. Shantanu's famous son delighted the Pauravas, his father and the kingdom by his conduct, bull of the Bharatas. So the king of boundless courage lived happily with his son for four years.

Once the lord of the earth went into a forest by the river Yamuna, and he smelled a wonderful fragrance, too fine for words. Looking for where it came from, he wandered everywhere, and then he saw a girl, of the fisher people, as lovely as a goddess. As soon as he saw the dark-eyed girl, he asked her, "Whose are you, who are you, and what are you doing, timid one?"

"I am a fisherman's daughter," she said. "I ferry a boat, for the sake of dharma, at the command of my father, the great king of the fishermen. Bless you."

King Shantanu looked at the fisher girl, lovely as a goddess, with her beauty, her sweetness and her fragrance, and he desired her. He went to her father and asked for her, and asked her father to give her to him.

The king of the fishermen answered the lord of the earth, "As soon as she was born, this lovely girl was to be given to a fine husband. But I have a wish in my heart. Hear it, lord of men. If you ask me for her as your lawful wife, sinless one, then make me a promise by your truth, for you speak the truth. If you promise, I will give you this girl, king. For I will never find a husband for her equal to you."

"When I have heard your condition, fisherman," said Shantanu, "I will decide. If it can be given, I will give it. But I will never give what should not be given."

"The son who is born of her," said the fisherman, "must be consecrated as king, lord of the earth, after you, and no one else, king."

Shantanu did not want to grant the fisherman this, though he burned with a fierce desire of the body, Bharata. The lord of the earth went back to Hastinapura, still thinking of the fisher girl, his mind struck down by grief.

Then one day, when Shantanu sat grieving, deep in thought, his son Devavrata came to his father and said, "All is well with you on every side. All the kings obey you. Why, then, do you grieve here so often, in pain? Why are you so deep in thought, king, and never speak?"

When his son said this, Shantanu answered, "It is true, as you say, that I am deep in thought. You are my only child in our great family, Bharata, and mortals do not last. That is why I grieve, my son. If some misfortune came to you, Gangeya, we would have no family left. You alone are surely better than a hundred sons. And I do not want to marry again for nothing. I want it only so that our line will not be destroyed. Bless you. Those who speak of dharma say that to have one son is to have no son. The daily fire offering, the three Vedas, and sacrifices with their gifts are not worth a sixteenth part of a child. It is so among men, and among all creatures too, great and wise one: there is no doubt in my mind about children. This is the lasting teaching of the three Vedas and of the best of the ancients. And you are a hero, always quick to anger, always with your weapons, Bharata. Your death can come from nothing but a weapon, sinless one. So I am in doubt. If you were gone, what would happen? That is the whole reason for my sorrow, my son."

When he had understood the whole reason, the wise Devavrata went away to think it over. He went at once to an old minister, who wished his father well, and asked him the cause of his father's grief. And when the chief of the Kurus asked him properly, bull of the Bharatas, the minister told him of the condition about the girl.

Then Devavrata went with old kshatriyas to the king of the fishermen, and asked for the girl himself, for his father. The fisherman received him properly and honoured him, and when he was seated in the royal assembly, Bharata, he said to him,

"You alone are protector enough for Shantanu, bull among men, the best son of those who have sons. What can I say to you? Who, even Indra of the hundred sacrifices himself, would not regret passing over a marriage alliance so worthy and so much to be wished for? This girl is the child of a noble man equal to you in virtues, from whose seed the famous Satyawati was born. He praised your father to me many times, my son, as the one among all kings worthy to marry Satyawati, Bharata. I even turned away the divine seer Asita before. That best of seers wanted Satyawati very much. But as the girl's father, I will say one thing, bull of the Bharatas. I see only one fault here: a mighty rival. Whoever has you as his rival, gandharva or asura, would never live happily if you were angry, scorcher of enemies. That is the only fault here, lord of the earth, no other. Know this, bless you, in giving and in not giving, scorcher of enemies."

When he said this, Gangeya answered fittingly, in the hearing of the kings, for his father's sake, Bharata. "Take this as my true resolve, best of those who keep the truth. No one born, and no one yet unborn, would dare to say this. I will do as you say. The son born of her will be our king."

When he said this, the fisherman spoke to him again, wishing to do something very hard for the kingdom's sake, bull of the Bharatas. "You alone are protector enough for

Shantanu, whose splendour has no measure, and you are the lord who can give the girl, righteous one. But hear this word of mine, my friend, and what must be done. I speak as girls' fathers do, tamer of enemies. What you have promised among the kings for Satyawati's sake, you who are devoted to truth and dharma, is worthy of you. It will not be otherwise, strong-armed one. There is no doubt of that. But about the children you may have, we have a great doubt."

When he understood what the fisherman meant, the prince, devoted to truth and dharma, made a promise then, king, wishing to do what would please his father.

"King of the fishermen," said Devavrata, "best of kings, hear what I say for my father's sake, in the hearing of these kings. I gave up the kingdom already, lord of men. Now, for the sake of children, I make this resolve. From this day on, fisherman, I will live a celibate life. Though I have no son, I will have worlds in heaven that never pass away."

When he heard his words, the hair on the righteous fisherman's body stood up, and he answered, "I give her."

Then in the air the apsaras, the gods and the hosts of seers rained down flowers and said, "This is Bhishma, the terrible one."

Then, for his father's sake, he said to the famous woman, "Mount the chariot, mother. Let us go home." When Bhishma had said this, he lifted the proud woman onto the chariot, came to Hastinapura, and told Shantanu everything.

The kings praised his deed, which was so hard to do, together and one by one, and they said, "This is Bhishma."

When Shantanu saw the hard deed that Bhishma had done, his father, well pleased, himself gave him the boon of dying when he chose.

The Three Princesses

When the wedding was over, King Shantanu settled the lovely girl in his house. Then a wise son of Shantanu was born to Satyawati, the hero named Chitrangada, who surpassed all men in courage. And the mighty lord fathered on Satyawati another son, a great archer, King Vichitravirya. Before the boy had reached his youth, bull of the Bharatas, wise King Shantanu went the way of Time.

When Shantanu had gone to heaven, Bhishma, keeping to Satyawati's wishes, set Chitrangada, the tamer of enemies, on the throne. In his pride of courage Chitrangada insulted all the kings, for he thought no man his equal. As he insulted gods, men and asuras alike, the mighty king of the gandharvas, who had the same name, came against him. A very great battle took place between them at Kurukshetra. Those two mighty ones, the chief of the gandharvas and the chief of the Kurus, fought on the bank of the river Hiranvati. The fight went on for three years. The struggle was wild, thick with the rain of weapons. In the end the gandharva, who was the stronger in magic, killed the hero, the best of the Kurus. He brought to his end Chitrangada, the best of the Kurus, with his many arrows and his bow. Then the gandharva went up to heaven.

That tiger among kings, of great splendour, was dead. Bhishma, the son of Shantanu, had the funeral rites performed. Then the strong-armed one consecrated Vichitravirya, still a boy and not yet grown, as king of the Kurus. Vichitravirya, keeping to Bhishma's word, ruled from the seat of his father and grandfather. Skilled in the books of dharma, the king honoured Bhishma, son of Shantanu, by dharma, and Bhishma protected him.

With Chitrangada dead and his brother still a boy, Bhishma ruled the kingdom, keeping to Satyawati's wishes. When he saw that his brother, the wisest of the wise, had come to his youth, Bhishma set his mind on Vichitravirya's marriage.

Then Bhishma heard that the three daughters of the king of Kashi, as lovely as apsaras, were all choosing husbands together at a bridegroom choice. So with his mother's leave, the best of chariot fighters put on his armour. He went in a single chariot to the city of Varanasi. There Bhishma, the joy of Shantanu, saw the kings who had come together from every side, and he saw the girls.

The names of the kings were being called out by the thousand. Then the lord Bhishma himself chose the girls. Bhishma, the best of fighters, lifted them onto his chariot. And he spoke to the kings, with a voice like the thunder of the clouds.

"The wise say that a girl may be given to a worthy man by invitation. She is adorned as well as one can, and wealth is given with her. Others give a girl for a pair of cattle. Others give her for an agreed sum of wealth. Some take her by force, and some by winning consent. Some approach a girl who is off her guard, and some find a husband for themselves. The poets remember this as the eighth kind of marriage, as you know. Kshatriyas praise the bridegroom choice, and they go to it. But those who speak of dharma say that a bride carried off by force is the best. These girls, kings of the earth, I mean to carry off by force. Strive with all your strength, to win or to lose. Here I stand, kings of the earth, resolved to fight."

So the mighty Kaurava spoke to the kings and to the king of Kashi. He set all the girls on his own chariot and bade the kings farewell. Then he drove quickly away, taking the

girls with him.

Then all the kings leaped up in fury, touching their own arms and biting their lips. There was a great commotion as they hurried to throw off their ornaments and put on their armour. With the bright ornaments and armour on every side, Janamejaya, it was like a falling of stars. Their armour and ornaments flashed here and there. Their brows were knitted in anger and indignation, and their eyes were red. The heroes mounted the fine chariots their drivers had made ready, with good horses yoked to them. Carrying every kind of weapon, with their weapons raised, they followed the lone Kaurava as he went.

Then the battle began between them and him, the one against the many. It was wild and terrible, Bharata. They shot ten thousand arrows at him all at once. Before they reached him, Bhishma quickly cut them all down. Then all the kings surrounded him on every side, and they rained arrows on him as clouds rain on a mountain. He held off that rain of arrows on every side with his own arrows, and then he pierced every one of the kings, three arrows each. As a chariot fighter he was quicker than any other man, and he guarded himself well in battle. Even his enemies honoured him for it.

So the master of every weapon conquered them in battle. Then the Bharata set off back towards the Bharatas with the girls. But the great warrior, the king of the Shalvas, of boundless spirit, struck at Bhishma, son of Shantanu, from behind. He was like a bull elephant, the leader of a herd, who follows a cow in heat and strikes another elephant from behind with his tusks.

"You who lust after women, stop! Stop!" said the strong-armed king of the Shalvas to Bhishma, driven by his fury.

Then that tiger among men, Bhishma, the destroyer of enemy armies, was stung by those words. He blazed in anger like a fire without smoke. Keeping to the dharma of a kshatriya, free of fear and alarm, the great warrior turned his chariot to face Shalva. When they saw him turn, all the kings became onlookers at the meeting of Bhishma and Shalva. Like two bulls bellowing over a cow in heat, those two, strong and brave, went at each other.

Then the king of the Shalvas, the best of men, covered Bhishma, son of Shantanu, with swift arrows by the hundred thousand. When the kings saw Bhishma struck first by Shalva, they were amazed, and cried, "Well done! Well done!" All the kings, seeing his speed in battle, praised Shalva gladly.

When he heard the kshatriyas' words, Bhishma, son of Shantanu, conqueror of enemy cities, was angry, and he said, "Stop! Stop!" And he said to his driver in anger, "Drive to where that king is, so that I may kill him today, as the king of birds kills a snake."

Then the Kaurava fitted the weapon of Varuna rightly, and with it he crushed the four horses of the king of the Shalvas. He held off the Shalva king's weapons with his own. Then the Kaurava Bhishma killed his driver, and with one weapon he killed his fine horses. For the sake of the girls, Bhishma, son of Shantanu, conquered that best of kings and let him go alive. Then Shalva went back to his own city, bull of the Bharatas. And the kings who had come to see the bridegroom choice went back to their own kingdoms too.

So Bhishma, the best of fighters, won those girls. He set out for Hastinapura, where the Kaurava king was. Before long he had passed forests, rivers, mountains and trees of many kinds. He had destroyed his enemies in battle and was unwounded. So the son of the river that runs to the sea, of courage beyond counting, brought home the daughters of the king of Kashi. The righteous man went to the Kurus, holding them as his daughters-in-law, or his younger sisters, or his daughters. All three were full of virtues, and his courage had won them. Bhishma, the elder brother, gave them to his younger brother, Vichitravirya.

By the dharma of the good he had done a deed more than human. Now Bhishma, who knew dharma and was master of himself, made up his mind together with Satyawati. He began to prepare for his brother Vichitravirya's wedding.

As Bhishma was about to hold the wedding, the eldest of the Kashi king's daughters, a good woman, said to him, "I had already chosen the lord of Saubha as my husband, in my heart. And he had chosen me. This was my father's wish too. I was to choose Shalva at that bridegroom choice. Now that you know this, you who know dharma, do what dharma requires."

When the girl said this to him in the assembly of brahmins, the hero Bhishma thought over what was right to do. He made his decision with brahmins who had mastered the Vedas. Then Bhishma, who knew dharma, gave leave to Amba, the eldest daughter of the king of Kashi, to go.

Bhishma gave Ambika and Ambalika as wives to his younger brother, Vichitravirya, by the rites the scriptures lay down. When he had taken their hands, righteous Vichitravirya, proud of his beauty and youth, gave himself up to desire. The two were tall and dark, with dark curling hair, raised red nails, and full hips and breasts. We have won a husband worthy of us, they thought, and they honoured the fine Vichitravirya. He was like the Ashvins in beauty, with the courage and strength of a god, and he stirred the hearts of all women.

The lord of the earth took his pleasure with them for seven years, and then the young Vichitravirya fell ill with consumption. His friends and trusted physicians tried to save him. But the Kaurava went to the house of Yama, like the setting sun. Keeping to Satyawati's wishes, Bhishma had all the funeral rites performed rightly for King Vichitravirya. The priests and all the bulls of the Kurus were with him.

The Vow and the Line

Satyavati was wretched and grieving, longing for sons. With her two daughters-in-law she performed the rites for her son. Then the proud and noble lady thought about dharma, and about the line of the fathers and the line of the mothers. And she spoke to Ganga's son.

"The funeral offerings, the fame and the line of Shantanu rest on you now. He was a Kaurava, famous and always devoted to dharma. A good deed surely leads to heaven, and truth surely leads to long life. In the same way, dharma is sure in you. You know dharma, both in brief and in full, you who know dharma. You know the many sacred teachings, and you know all the Vedas. I see how firm you are in dharma and in the customs of the family. In hard times you know what to do, like Shukra and Angiras. So I trust you completely, best of those who uphold dharma. I will give you a task. Hear it, and you should do it.

"My son, your brother, was brave and very dear to you. He has gone to heaven while still a boy, bull among men, and he had no son. Here are your brother's queens, the lovely daughters of the king of Kashi. They are young and beautiful, and they long for sons, Bharata. Father children on them, to carry on our line. At my bidding, noble one, you should do this dharma. Be consecrated king and rule the Bharatas. Take a wife by dharma. Do not let your forefathers sink."

His mother said this to him, and so did his friends. But the righteous tamer of enemies answered with words true to dharma.

"Mother, there is no doubt that what you speak of is the highest dharma. But you know the great vow I made about children. You know what happened when the bride price was set for you. Satyavati, I promise you again the truth I promised then. I would give up the three worlds, or the kingdom of the gods, or anything greater than either. But I would never give up the truth.

"The earth might give up its smell, and water its taste. Light might give up its form, and wind its touch. The sun might let go of its brightness, and fire its heat. Space might give up its sound, and the moon its coolness. The slayer of Vritra might give up his courage, and the king of dharma his dharma. But I could never bring myself to give up the truth."

When her son, rich in wealth and splendour, had said this, his mother Satyavati answered him.

"I know how firmly you stand by the truth, you whose courage is truth. If you wished, you could make three other worlds by your own power. I know the truth you spoke for my sake. But think of the dharma for times of trouble. Carry the burden of your fathers. Act so that the thread of the family and its dharma do not fail, tamer of enemies, and so that our friends may be glad."

She was wretched, longing for sons, and she went on pleading. She was speaking against dharma. So Bhishma spoke to her again.

"Queen, look to dharma. Do not destroy us all. For a kshatriya, to fall from the truth is never praised in the books of dharma. But there is a way for Shantanu's line to live

on unbroken on the earth. I will tell you the kshatriya dharma for this, queen. It is age-old. Hear it, and then decide, with wise family priests who are skilled in the dharma for times of trouble. And look to the way of the world."

"Rama, the son of Jamadagni, could not bear his father's death," Bhishma said, "and in his anger he killed the lord of the Haihayas. He cut off the thousand arms of Arjuna, the Haihaya king. Then he took up his bow again and let loose great weapons. Conquering the earth in his chariot, he burned up the kshatriyas again and again. So in the old days, with weapons high and low, the great Bhargava emptied the earth of kshatriyas thrice seven times.

"Then brahmins of great self-control lay with kshatriya women everywhere and fathered children on them. It is laid down in the Vedas that the son belongs to the man who took the mother's hand in marriage. Keeping that dharma in mind, the women went to the brahmins. In the world too, kshatriyas have been seen born again in this way.

"Long ago there was a wise seer named Utathya. He had a wife named Mamata, whom he loved dearly. Utathya's younger brother was Brihaspati, of great splendour, the family priest of the gods. And Brihaspati approached Mamata.

"Mamata said to her husband's brother, the best of speakers, 'I am with child by your elder brother. Stop! And this child of Utathya's, here in my womb, great one, has already learned the Veda with its six limbs. Your seed is surely never wasted either. So as things are, you should hold back.'

"She spoke rightly. But Brihaspati, for all his splendour, could not master himself. He was ruled by desire. So he lay with her, against her will. As he was releasing his seed, the child in the womb spoke to him.

"'Sir, father's younger brother, stop! There is no room for two here. Your seed is never wasted, and I came here first.'

"When he was spoken to like this, the blessed seer Brihaspati was angry. He cursed Utathya's son in the womb and reviled him. 'At such a time, which all beings long for, you speak to me like this! So you will enter a long darkness.'

"So by the curse of famous Brihaspati the seer was born, and he was named Dirghatamas, Long Darkness. In power he was like Brihaspati himself. Famous in his turn, he fathered sons, Gautama and others, to make the line of the seer Utathya grow. But those sons, Gautama and the rest, were overcome by greed and folly. They put him on a raft of wood and set him adrift on the Ganga. 'Why should we keep a blind old man?' they thought. Then those cruel men went home.

"The blind seer floated downstream on that raft and passed through many lands. A king named Bali, who knew every dharma, had gone to bathe, and he saw him carried close by the current. Righteous Bali, whose courage was truth, took hold of him. And when he learned who he was, he chose him to give him sons.

"'Great one,' he said, 'giver of honour, you should father sons on my wives, to carry on my line, sons skilled in dharma and in wealth.'

"The splendid seer said, 'So be it.' Then the king sent his own wife, Sudeshna, to him.

But the queen thought him blind and old, and she did not go. She sent him her nurse's daughter instead, to the old man. On her, a shudra woman, the righteous seer, master of himself, fathered eleven sons, Kakshivat and the others.

"The mighty king saw Kakshivat and the others all learning the Veda. 'They are mine,' he said to the seer.

"'No,' said the great seer. 'They are mine. I fathered Kakshivat and the others on a shudra woman. Your queen, Sudeshna, thought me blind and old. The foolish woman despised me, and she gave me a shudra, her nurse's daughter.'

"Then Bali won the best of seers over again, and he sent his wife Sudeshna to him once more. Dirghatamas touched the queen on her limbs, and said to her, 'You will have a splendid son who speaks the truth.' So the royal seer named Anga was born to Sudeshna.

"In this way other kshatriyas too were born on the earth to brahmins: great archers, who knew dharma well, brave and very strong. You have heard this, mother. Now do here as you wish."

Chapter 38

Vyasa Comes

"Mother," said Bhishma, "I will tell you again the sure way to make the line of Bharata live on. Hear me as I tell it. Let some brahmin of good qualities be invited, with wealth, to father children in Vichitravirya's fields."

Then Satyavati spoke to Bhishma. Her voice faltered, and she was half laughing and ashamed.

"What you say is true, strong-armed Bharata. Because I trust you, I will tell you something, for the sake of our line. I cannot keep it from you, when we are in such trouble. You are the dharma of our family. You are its truth, and its last refuge. So listen to what I say, and then do what comes next.

"My father was a righteous man, and he kept a ferry boat. One day, when I was in my first youth, I went to the boat. Then the great seer Parashara, the wise, the best of those who uphold dharma, came to the boat to cross the Yamuna. As I was taking him across the river, the best of sages came up to me. He was tormented by desire, and he spoke to me gently and sweetly, at length. I was afraid of a curse, and I was afraid of my father. He offered me boons that are hard to win. I did not dare refuse him, Bharata. I was only a girl, and he overpowered me with his power and brought me under his control. He covered the world in darkness, and it happened there in the boat.

"Before that I had a strong smell of fish, which people found disgusting. The sage took it away and gave me this fine scent instead. Then he said to me, 'When you have given birth to my child on an island in this river, you will still be a virgin.'

"So Parashara's son was born to me when I was a girl, long ago. He became a great seer and a great yogi. He is remembered as Dvaipayana. The blessed seer divided the four Vedas by his austerity, and so in the world he came to be Vyasa, the Divider. And because he is dark, he is Krishna. He speaks the truth, and he is devoted to calm. He is an ascetic whose sins are burned away. If you and I appoint him, you of boundless splendour, he will surely father good children in his brother's fields. He said to me then, 'Think of me when there is something to be done.' I will think of him, strong-armed Bhishma, if you wish it. With your consent, Bhishma, that great ascetic will surely father sons in Vichitravirya's fields."

When the great seer's name was spoken, Bhishma joined his hands.

"A wise man looks at the three, dharma, wealth and desire," he said. "He sees how wealth leads to more wealth, dharma to more dharma, and desire to more desire, and how each can also lead the other way, each on its own. He thinks it all through carefully with his mind, and then he makes up his mind. What you have said is in keeping with dharma, and it is good for our family. It is the best way, and it pleases me very much."

When Bhishma had agreed, joy of the Kurus, Kali called to mind the sage Krishna Dvaipayana. The wise one was reciting the Vedas, and he knew his mother's thought. In an instant, unseen by anyone, he was there, joy of the Kurus.

His mother honoured her son with the proper rites. She put her arms round him, and her breasts flowed with milk over him. The fisherman's daughter wept to see her son after so

long. The great seer sprinkled his grieving mother with water and bowed to her. Then Vyasa, her first-born son, spoke to her.

"I have come to do what you want. You know the truth of dharma. Tell me what to do, and I will do what pleases you."

Then the family priest honoured the great seer, and he accepted it, with mantras, as the rules require. When he was seated, his mother asked after his health. Then Satyavati looked at him and spoke.

"Sons are born to a mother and a father alike, poet. The father is their master, and so, without doubt, is the mother. By the Ordainer's will you are my first son, brahmin seer, and Vichitravirya was my youngest. As Bhishma is his brother on his father's side, so you are his brother on your mother's side. Or so I hope you see it, son. This son of Shantanu keeps to the truth, and his courage is truth. He will not set his mind on having children, nor on ruling the kingdom.

"So, out of regard for your brother, for the sake of the line, at Bhishma's word and at my bidding, sinless one, out of pity for all beings and to protect them, and out of kindness, hear what I say and do it. Your younger brother's wives are like daughters of the gods. They are young and beautiful, and they long for sons by dharma. Father children on them, son, for you can. Give them children worthy of this family, to carry on its line."

"Satyavati," said Vyasa, "you know dharma, both the higher and the lower. Your mind, you who know dharma, is set on dharma. So at your bidding, and for the sake of dharma, I will do what you wish. This has been seen from of old. I will give my brother sons like Mitra and Varuna. But the two queens must keep the vow I lay down for them, for a year, as is right. Then they will be pure. No woman may come to me who has not kept the vow."

"Let the queen conceive at once," said Satyavati. "Do what you must to make it so. When a kingdom has no king, there is no rain and there are no gods. How can a kingdom without a king be held together, lord? So give her a child. Bhishma will bring him up."

"If I must give a son at once, out of season," said Vyasa, "then let her bear my ugliness. That will be her highest vow. If Kausalya can bear my smell, my looks, my clothes and my body, let her conceive a fine child this very day."

When he had said this, the sage vanished, to wait for the meeting.

Then the queen went to her daughter-in-law and found her alone. She spoke to her words of dharma, sensible and kind.

"Kausalya, listen to the dharma I tell you. It is plain that the Bharatas are dying out, because my luck has run out. Bhishma saw my distress, and the trouble of his father's line, and gave me an idea, to make dharma grow. But that idea depends on you, daughter. I know it. Raise up the lost line of Bharata again. Bear a son as bright as the king of the gods, you of the lovely hips. He will carry the heavy burden of our family's kingdom."

So, somehow, by dharma, she won over her daughter-in-law, who kept to dharma. Then she fed brahmins, divine seers and guests.

Then, in time, when her daughter-in-law had bathed after her season, Satyawati settled her on the bed. And she said to her softly, "Kausalya, you have a husband's brother. He will come to you tonight. Be watchful and wait for him. He will come at midnight."

When she heard her mother-in-law's words, as she lay on the fine bed, she thought of Bhishma and of the other bulls of the Kurus.

Then the truthful seer, appointed first to Ambika, came into her bed while the lamps were burning. When the queen saw how dark he was, with his tawny matted hair, his blazing eyes and his brown beard, she shut her eyes. He lay with her that night, to please his mother. But the princess of Kashi was so afraid that she could not look at him.

When he came out, his mother met her son and said, "Will she have a prince with good qualities, son?"

Vyasa, who knew what lies beyond the senses, and whom fate was driving, heard his mother's words. He said, "He will have the strength of ten thousand elephants. He will be learned and the best of royal seers, very fortunate, very brave and very wise. He will have a hundred mighty sons. But because of his mother's fault, he will be blind."

When she heard this, his mother said to her son, "A blind man is not a fit king for the Kurus, rich in austerity. You should give the Kuru line a second king, to protect his kin and make his fathers' line grow."

He promised, "So be it," and the great ascetic went out. And in time Kausalya gave birth to that son, and he was blind.

Again the blameless queen Satya spoke to her daughter-in-law, and she called the seer as before. The great seer went to Ambalika in the same way. When she saw the seer, she too was dismayed, Bharata, and she turned pale.

When Vyasa, Satyawati's son, saw her frightened, pale and dismayed, he said to her, "Because you turned pale when you saw how ugly I am, this son of yours will be pale. He will be Pandu, the Pale One. And that will be his name here, lovely one." With that the blessed one, the best of seers, went out.

When he came out, Satya saw her son and spoke to him. And he told his mother again that the boy would be pale. His mother asked him for one more son, and the great seer said to her, "So be it."

Then the queen, in time, gave birth to a boy, Pandu, who had every lucky mark and seemed to blaze with glory. His sons were the five Pandavas, great archers.

Then, when her season came, Satyawati appointed her elder daughter-in-law to Vyasa again. But the girl, who was like a daughter of the gods, thought of the great seer's looks and his smell, and she was afraid. So she did not do as the queen told her. The princess of Kashi dressed a slave woman, as lovely as an apsaras, in her own ornaments, and sent her to Krishna.

When the seer came, the slave woman rose to meet him and bowed to him. When he gave her

leave, she lay down, and she served him with respect. The seer was pleased with her in the joy of love, and he spent the night with her, and she was glad. As he rose, he said to her, "You will be a slave no longer. A glorious child has come into your womb, lovely one. He will be righteous in the world, the best of all the wise."

He was born, and his name was Vidura, the son of Krishna Dvaipayana, the brother of Dhritarashtra and of Pandu, of boundless understanding. He was Dharma, in the form of Vidura, because of the curse of the great Mandavya. He knew the truth of things, and he was free of desire and anger.

Then Vyasa, free of his debt to dharma, met his mother again. He told her of the child that had been conceived, and he vanished there and then.

So in Vichitravirya's field, from Dvaipayana, were born those sons like children of the gods, who made the Kuru line grow.

The Seer on the Stake

"What had Dharma done, that he was cursed?" asked Janamejaya. "And by whose curse, brahmin seer, was he born from a shudra woman?"

There was a brahmin called Mandavya, a famous man. He was steadfast and knew every dharma, and he held to truth and austerity. At the gate of his hermitage, at the foot of a tree, the great ascetic stood with his arms raised, a great yogi keeping a vow of silence.

He had stood a long time in his austerity when some robbers came to the hermitage carrying stolen goods, bull of the Bharatas. Many guards were on their trail. The robbers hid the loot in his dwelling, best of the Kurus. Then, when the troop came after them, they hid there too in their fear.

They had just hidden themselves when the troop of guards arrived in haste. The men chasing the thieves saw the seer. The ascetic was standing there as he always stood, and they asked him, "Which way did the robbers go, best of brahmins? Tell us, brahmin, so that we can follow them as fast as we can."

But though the guards said this to him, the ascetic said nothing, king, good or bad.

Then the king's men searched the hermitage, and they found the thieves hiding there, and the goods as well. So the guards grew suspicious of the sage. They bound him and brought him before the king with the robbers. The king ordered him to be put to death along with the thieves. The executioners did not know who he was, and they impaled the great ascetic on a stake. When they had set the sage on the stake, the guards took the goods and went back to the king.

The righteous brahmin seer stayed on the stake for a long time. He ate nothing, but he did not die. He kept himself alive, and he called the seers to him. The great man went on with his austerity on the point of the stake, and the sages were deeply troubled, tamer of enemies. They took the form of birds and came to him at night from every side. They showed themselves as well as they could, and asked the best of brahmins, "We want to hear, brahmin, what sin you have done."

The tiger among sages said to the ascetics, "Whom shall I blame? No one else has wronged me."

When the king heard about the seer, he came out with his ministers and tried to win over the best of seers, where he sat on the stake. "Whatever wrong I did you, best of seers, I did in folly and ignorance. I beg your forgiveness for it. You should not be angry with me."

When the king said this, the sage forgave him. And once he was forgiven, the king had him taken down. When he had taken him down from the point of the stake, he tried to pull the stake out of him. He could not pull it out, so he cut it off at the base. So the sage went about with the stake still inside him. By that austerity he won worlds that others can hardly win. And from then on he was known in the worlds as Animandavya, Mandavya of the Point.

The brahmin, who knew the highest truth, went to the house of Dharma. There he saw Dharma seated on his throne, and the lord reproached him.

"What wrong did I do without knowing it," he said, "that I should reap a fruit like this? Tell me the truth at once. See the power of my austerity."

"You pushed a reed into the tails of little flying insects," said Dharma. "This is the fruit of that deed, rich in austerity."

"For a small offence you have given me a huge punishment," said Animandavya. "So, Dharma, you will be born as a man, from a shudra woman. Today I lay down a limit in the world for the fruit of dharma. Up to the fourteenth year, nothing done will be a sin. But for those who do such things after that, it will be a fault."

So by the curse of that great man, for that offence, Dharma was born from a shudra woman in the form of Vidura. He was skilled in dharma and in wealth, and free of greed and anger. He saw far ahead, he was devoted to calm, and he delighted in the good of the Kurus.

When those three princes were born, the three grew and flourished: Kurujangala, the Kurus and Kurukshetra.

The earth gave tall crops, and the crops bore fruit. The rain god rained in season, and the trees were full of flowers and fruit. The beasts of burden were well and happy, and the beasts and birds rejoiced. The garlands were fragrant and the fruits were full of juice. The cities were crowded with merchants and craftsmen. Brave men, learned men and good men were happy. There were no robbers, and no one delighted in wrongdoing. Even in the far corners of the kingdom the golden age had come.

The people were given to gifts, to rites and to dharma, and they were devoted to sacrifices and vows. They loved one another, and they prospered. They had no pride or anger, and they were free of greed. They helped each other to prosper, and dharma was the highest thing.

The city was full, like the great ocean, and it shone. It had gates, arches and turrets like banks of clouds, and it was crowded with a hundred palaces, like the city of great Indra. The people amused themselves happily by rivers and in stretches of woodland, by pools, ponds and hillsides, and in lovely groves. The southern Kurus roamed about with the northern Kurus, vying with them, and with the siddhas, the seers and the charanas. No one was poor, and no woman was a widow.

In that lovely country the Kurus made many wells, gardens, halls and pools, and houses for brahmins. Bhishma protected it on every side according to the books of law, king. It was lovely, marked with hundreds of shrines and sacrificial posts. The land grew, taking in other kingdoms, and the wheel of dharma that Bhishma set going turned in the kingdom.

As the rites of the noble princes were performed, the people of the city and the country kept a festival without end. In the houses of the Kuru chiefs and the townsmen, lord of men, the cry was heard everywhere: "Give! Eat!"

From their birth Bhishma looked after Dhritarashtra, Pandu and wise Vidura as if they were his own sons. They went through the rites of passage, and they kept their vows and

studied. They grew skilled in hard work and exercise, and they came to their youth. They mastered archery, riding, fighting with the mace and with sword and shield, the training of elephants, and statecraft. They learned the old stories and the Puranas, and many other kinds of learning, lord. They knew the truth of the Vedas and their limbs, and they worked hard at everything.

Pandu was bold with the bow, and he outdid all men. King Dhritarashtra was stronger than anyone else. And in the three worlds there was no one equal to Vidura, king, who was always devoted to dharma and went furthest in it.

The line of Shantanu had been lost, and people saw it raised up again. Then a saying went round the world, in every kingdom: "Of mothers of heroes, the Kashi princesses. Of countries, Kurujangala. Of all who know dharma, Bhishma. Of cities, the City of the Elephant."

Dhritarashtra did not come to the throne, because he was blind, and Vidura did not, because of his mixed birth. So Pandu became king.

Chapter 40

The Blindfold and the Mantra

"This famous family of ours is rich in every virtue," said Bhishma. "It has held rule over the earth, above all other kings. It was protected by kings before us, great men who knew dharma, and it has never died out here. Satyawati and I and the great Krishna have set it up again in you, the threads of the family. It must grow like the ocean, son. I must see to that, and you above all.

"I hear of a Yadava girl who would suit our family, and of a daughter of Subala, and one of the lord of Madra. They are all well born and beautiful, and they have protectors. Those bulls among kshatriyas are fit to be joined to us. I think we should ask for them, wisest of the wise, for the sake of this family's line. Or what do you think, Vidura?"

"You are our father," said Vidura, "and our mother, and our highest teacher. So think it over yourself, and do what is good for this family."

Then Bhishma heard from brahmins about Gandhari, Subala's daughter. She had worshipped Hara, the giver of boons, who took away Bhaga's eyes. And the lovely Gandhari, so they said, had won the boon of a hundred sons. When Bhishma, grandfather of the Kurus, had heard this for certain, he sent messengers to the king of Gandhara, Bharata.

Subala hesitated, because Dhritarashtra was blind. But he weighed the family, its fame and its conduct in his mind, and he gave Gandhari, who kept to dharma, to Dhritarashtra.

Gandhari heard that Dhritarashtra was blind, and that her father and mother meant to give her to him, Bharata. Then the lovely girl took a cloth, folded it many times, and bound it over her own eyes, king. She was wholly devoted to her husband. She had made up her mind: I will not have more than my husband has.

Then the king of Gandhara's son, Shakuni, came to the Kauravas, bringing his sister, who was richly adorned. The hero gave his sister away with a fitting train of servants, and then, honoured by Bhishma, he went back to his own city.

Gandhari of the lovely hips pleased all the Kurus by her character, her conduct and her ways, Bharata. She won them all by her behaviour, and she was wholly devoted to her husband. She kept her vows so well that she would not even speak of other men.

There was a chief of the Yadus named Shura, the father of Vasudeva. He had a daughter named Pritha, whose beauty had no equal on earth. Shura had promised his first child to his cousin, his father's sister's son, who had no children. So the mighty man gave the girl, as his first-born, to the great Kuntibhoja, a friend to a friend, for Kuntibhoja had longed for the favour of that first child.

In her father's house she was given the task of honouring the gods and the guests. There she waited on a fierce and terrible brahmin of strict vows, whose purposes in dharma were hidden. People know him as Durvasas. She pleased that fierce, disciplined man with every effort. Looking to the dharma for times of trouble, the sage gave her a mantra, joined with the power of a spell. And he said to her, "Whatever god you call with this mantra, by his grace you will have a son."

When the brahmin had said this, the famous girl was curious. While she was still a

virgin, she called the god, the Sun. She saw him coming, the Sun who makes the world come to be. And the girl of flawless limbs was amazed to see that great wonder.

The Sun, the Heater, whose work is light, put a child in her. Then she bore a hero, the best of all who bear weapons. He was a god's child, glorious and wrapped in splendour, and he wore armour. It was armour he was born with, and his face was lit by earrings. That son was Karna, famous in all the worlds.

Then the Sun, of the highest brilliance, gave her back her virginity. And when he had given it, the best of givers went up to heaven.

For fear of her family, Kunti hid what she had done. She let the boy, with all his lucky marks, go on the water. The famous husband of Radha, a son of the sutas, took the abandoned child, and he and his wife made him their son. The two of them named the boy. "He was born with wealth, vasu," they said. "Let him be Vasushena."

As he grew he became strong, and he gave himself to every weapon. The mighty youth worshipped the Sun until it burned his back. And at the time when that hero, true to his word, sat reciting his prayers, there was nothing the great man would not give to a brahmin.

Indra, who makes all beings, took the form of a brahmin, and came to beg of him. The splendid god asked for the earrings and the armour. Karna, dismayed, cut the armour from his own body, streaming with blood. He cut off the earrings too, and he gave them with joined hands.

Shakra was amazed. He gave him a spear, and said, "Whoever you throw this at in anger, god, asura or man, gandharva, snake or rakshasa, he will not live."

Before, his name had been Vasushena, as we have heard. Then, because of that deed, he became Vaikartana, the Cutter: Karna.

Pandu's Conquests

Kuntibhoja's daughter had beauty, strength of spirit and every good quality. She delighted in dharma, and she kept great vows. Her father held a bridegroom choice for her. And there, among thousands of kings, she found Pandu, with teeth like a lion's, shoulders like an elephant's and eyes like a bull's, a man of great strength. The joy of the Kurus, whose good fortune had no measure, was joined with Kuntibhoja's daughter as Indra, the generous, was joined with Paulomi.

Then Bhishma, the keeper of the god's vow, went to the capital of the Madras. Madri, the daughter of the lord of Madra, was famous in the three worlds and renowned among all kings, and her beauty had no equal on earth. She was bought for Pandu with a great deal of wealth, and Bhishma had her married to the great Pandu. When they saw Pandu, that tiger among men, with his lion's chest, his elephant's shoulders, his bull's eyes and his proud spirit, men on earth were amazed.

When he was married, Pandu, full of strength and energy, set out to conquer the earth, against many enemies. First that lion among men, who carried the fame of the Kauravas, went against the Dasharnas, who had wronged the Kurus before, and he beat them in battle.

Then Pandu took his army, with its banners of every kind, crowded with elephants, horses and chariots and thick with companies of foot soldiers. Darva, the protector of the kingdom of Magadha, was killed in Rajagriha. He had wronged all the heroes and was the enemy of every king.

Then Pandu took his treasure, his beasts and his troops and went to Mithila, and he beat the Videhas in battle. So too among the Kashis, the Suhmas and the Pundras, bull of the Bharatas, he won fame for the Kurus by the strength of his own arms.

Pandu was a fire. His flood of arrows was its great flame, and his weapons were its rays. The kings who came against that tamer of enemies were burned up. He shattered their armies with his own. He brought the kings and their armies under his control and set them to paying tribute. All the kings on earth were beaten by him, and they thought him the one hero, like Indra among the gods.

All the lords of the earth came to him with joined hands, bowing, bringing wealth and jewels of every kind. They brought gems, pearls and coral, gold and silver, the finest cattle, the finest horses, the finest chariots, and elephants. They brought donkeys, camels and buffaloes, and all the goats and sheep they had. The king of the City of the Elephant accepted it all.

Pandu took it and went home again, his beasts glad. He wanted to delight his own kingdom and the City of the Elephant. "The fame of Shantanu, that lion among kings, and of wise Bharata had been lost," said the kings and the royal ministers when they came together, "and Pandu has raised it up again. Those who once took the Kurus' kingdoms and the Kurus' wealth have been made to pay tribute by Pandu, the lion of the City of the Elephant."

They were glad and confident, and so were the people of the city and the country. All of them, with Bhishma at their head, went out to meet him when he came. They had not gone

far from the City of the Elephant when they saw the whole world before them filled with happy people of every kind. And the Kauravas, with Bhishma, could see no end to the jewels, high and low, brought on vehicles of every kind, and the finest elephants, horses and chariots, the cattle, camels and sheep.

Pandu, who swelled the joy of Kausalya, bowed at the feet of Bhishma, who had been a father to him. And he honoured the people of the city and the country, each as they deserved. Bhishma met the son who had crushed the kingdoms of others and come home with his purpose achieved, and he wept for joy. Then, to the great sound of hundreds of trumpets and drums, Pandu entered the City of the Elephant, delighting the townspeople everywhere.

With Dhritarashtra's leave, Pandu presented the wealth he had won by his own arms to Bhishma, to Satyawati and to his mother. The righteous man sent some of that wealth to Vidura too, and he satisfied his friends with wealth as well. Then Bhishma gladdened Satyawati and famous Kausalya with the fine jewels Pandu had won, Bharata. His mother Kausalya rejoiced in her son of matchless splendour. She put her arms round that bull among men as Paulomi embraced Jayanta.

With the wealth that the hero's courage had won, Dhritarashtra offered a hundred great horse sacrifices, with a hundred thousand gifts to the priests at each.

Then Pandu, bull of the Bharatas, with Kunti and Madri, shook off all idleness and went to live in the forest. He left his palace and its fine beds, and lived always in the wilds, given up to hunting. He roamed the lovely southern slopes of the Himalaya mountains, and lived on the mountain heights and in forests of great sal trees.

Living in the forest with Kunti and Madri, Pandu shone like a splendid elephant of Indra's between two cow elephants. The forest people saw the Bharata king roaming with his two wives, a hero carrying arrows, sword and bow, in bright armour, a master of the great weapons. "He is a god," they thought. At Dhritarashtra's command, men tirelessly brought him everything he wanted and enjoyed, to the edges of the forest.

Then Bhishma, the son of the river, heard of a daughter of King Devaka, born of a brahmin father and a shudra mother. She was young and beautiful. That bull among men asked for her and had her brought, and he married her to the wise Vidura. On her Vidura, the joy of the Kurus, fathered sons who were well disciplined and like him in their virtues.

The Hundred Sons

Then a hundred sons were born to Dhritarashtra by Gandhari, Janamejaya, and one more besides the hundred by a vaishya woman. And five sons, great warriors, were born to Pandu's wives, Kunti and Madri, from the gods, to carry on the line.

"How were a hundred sons born to Gandhari, best of brahmins?" asked Janamejaya. "How long did it take, and how long did they live? How did Dhritarashtra come to have a son by a vaishya woman? How could he pass over Gandhari, a wife worthy of him, who kept to dharma and did all he wished? And how were five sons, great warriors, born to Pandu from the gods, when that great seer had cursed him? You know it all, rich in austerity. Tell it to me as it happened, and in full. I never have enough of hearing about my family."

Once Dvaipayana came to Gandhari worn out with hunger and toil. She made him welcome, and Vyasa gave her a boon. She chose a hundred sons, each like her husband. In time she conceived by Dhritarashtra.

Gandhari carried that child in her womb for two years, and still she did not give birth. Then sorrow came over her. She heard that Kunti's son had been born, as bright as the rising sun. She felt how hard and unmoving her own belly was, and she brooded. Then, without Dhritarashtra knowing, Gandhari, faint with grief, struck her own womb with great force until it gave up what it held. Out came a lump of flesh, hard as a ball of iron. She had carried it in her belly for two years, and now she began to throw it away.

But Dvaipayana knew of it, and he came in haste. The best of those who pray saw that lump of flesh. "What is this you mean to do?" he said to Subala's daughter.

She told the great seer the truth of what she had in mind. "I heard that Kunti's son was born first, as bright as the sun," she said, "and in my great sorrow I struck down my womb. You granted me a hundred sons, did you not? And this lump of flesh is what has been born to me, for a hundred sons!"

"It is so, daughter of Subala," said Vyasa, "and it cannot be otherwise. I have never said anything untrue, even in jest. Why would I now? Have a hundred pots filled with ghee made ready at once. And sprinkle this lump with cold water."

As the lump was sprinkled, it split into a hundred pieces. Each part was a separate embryo, the size of the top joint of a thumb. A full hundred and one were formed from the lump of flesh, lord of the people, one after another, as time went by, king. Then he put those embryos in the pots, in places well guarded, and set a watch over them. And the blessed one told Subala's daughter that the pots should be opened only after the same length of time again. When the blessed Vyasa had said this and made all these arrangements, the wise one went to the Himalaya, the mountain of rock, to practise austerity.

In the order in which they had been placed, King Duryodhana was born first of them. But by the reckoning of birth, King Yudhishtira was the eldest.

As soon as that son was born, Dhritarashtra called many brahmins, and Bhishma and Vidura too. "Prince Yudhishtira is the eldest, the one who makes our line grow," he said. "He has won the kingdom by his own merit, and we have nothing to say against it. But will

this one, born next after him, be king too? Tell me the truth of this, what will surely come to pass."

As he finished speaking, Bharata, fierce beasts of prey howled in every direction, and jackals cried out, foretelling evil. When the brahmins and wise Vidura saw these dread signs on every side, they said, "It is plain, king, that this son of yours will be the end of the family. Peace lies in giving him up. There is great harm in rearing him. Let there be a hundred sons less one, lord of the earth. By giving up one, bring safety to the world and to the family. For the family, give up one. For the village, give up a family. For the country, give up a village. For yourself, give up the whole earth."

So Vidura and all those fine brahmins told him. But the king did not do it, for he loved his son.

Then within a month all Dhritarashtra's hundred sons were born, king, and one daughter over the hundred.

While Gandhari was suffering, with her belly growing, a vaishya woman waited on strong-armed Dhritarashtra, so they say. In that year, king, the wise and famous Yuyutsu was born to her by Dhritarashtra, a son of mixed birth.

So a hundred sons were born to wise Dhritarashtra, great warriors and heroes, and one daughter, Duhshala.

"Tell me the names of Dhritarashtra's sons in order, lord," said Janamejaya, "from the eldest down."

Duryodhana and Yuyutsu, king, and Duhshasana, Duhsaha and Duhshala, Jalasandha, Sama and Saha. Vinda and Anuvinda, Durdharsha, Subahu, Dushpradharshana, Durmarshana, Durmukha, Dushkarna and Karna. Vivimshati and Vikarna, Jalasandha, Sulochana, Chitra and Upachitra, Chitraksha, Charuchitra and Sharasana. Durmada and Dushpragaha, Vivitsu, Vikata and Sama, Urnanabha and Sunabha, Nanda and Upanandaka. Senapati and Sushena, Kundodara and Mahodara, Chitrabana and Chitravarma, Suvarma and Durvimochana.

Ayobahu and Mahabahu, Chitranga and Chitrakundala, Bhimavega and Bhimabala, Balaki and Balavardhana. Ugrayudha and Bhimakarma, Kanakayu and Dridhayudha, Dridhavarma and Dridhakshatra, Somakirti and Anudara. Dridhasandha and Jarasandha, Satyasandha and Sadahsuvak, Ugrashravas and Ashvasena, Senani and Dushparajaya. Aparajita and Panditaka, Vishalaksha and Duravara, Dridhahasta and Suhasta, Vatavega and Suvarchas.

Adityaketu and Bahvashi, Nagadanta and Ugrayayi, Kavachi, Nishangi and Pashi, Dandadhara and Dhanurgraha. Ugra and Bhimaratha, Vira and Virabahu, Alolupa and Abhaya, Raudrakarma and Dridharatha. Anadhrishya and Kundabhedhi, Viravi and Dirghalochana, Dirghabahu and Mahabahu, Vyudhoru and Kanakadhvaja. Kundashi and Virajas. And Duhshala, over the hundred.

These are the hundred and one, king, and the one daughter, as they are told. Know that the order of their names is the order of their birth, lord of men. All of them were great warriors and heroes, all skilled in war. All knew the Vedas, and all were learned in the books of kingship. All were skilled in the arts of company, and splendid in their learning and their birth. When the time came, Dhritarashtra looked into it carefully and found fitting wives for them all, as the rules require. And when the time came, Bharata,

the king gave Duhshala to Jayadratha, king of Sindhu, with Subala's son's consent.

Chapter 43

The Deer

"You have told me the birth of Dhritarashtra's sons," said Janamejaya, "which was beyond the human, and came from a seer, best of those who know the Veda. And I have heard their names from you, one by one. Now tell me of the Pandavas. You said yourself, when you told of the parts of the gods coming down to earth, that all of them, great men with the courage of the king of the gods, were portions of the gods. So I want to hear the whole story of the births of those men whose deeds were more than human. Tell it, Vaishampayana."

King Pandu was in a great forest, full of deer and beasts of prey. There he saw the leader of a herd of deer, mating. Then Pandu shot the doe and the stag with five sharp, swift arrows, with golden shafts and fine feathers.

That stag, king, was the son of a seer, a man of great splendour, rich in austerity. He had been coupling with his wife in the form of a deer. Still joined to the doe, he fell at once to the ground. His senses reeling, he cried out in a human voice.

"Even men who are ruled by desire and anger," he said, "who have lost their reason and delight in wrongdoing, keep away from cruelty. Wisdom does not swallow fate. Fate swallows wisdom. Wisdom cannot understand what fate brings about. You were born, Bharata, in the first of families, whose men always kept to dharma. How did your mind go astray, overcome by desire and greed?"

"The way kings behave in killing enemies," said Pandu, "is the way laid down for killing deer. You should not blame me, deer, out of folly. Kings are allowed to kill deer openly, without trickery. That is the dharma of kings. You know it, so why do you blame me? The seer Agastya, while he was holding a sacrifice, went hunting. He consecrated the wild deer of the great forest to all the gods. Why do you blame us for a dharma proven by that authority? By Agastya's spell your fat was offered into the fire."

"Men did not let fly their arrows at enemies beforehand," said the deer. "It is when enemies are open to attack that the time for killing them is most praised."

"Men kill with force, by every means, with sharp arrows," said Pandu, "whether the beast is heedless or watchful, in the open. Why do you blame me, deer?"

"I do not blame you, king, for killing deer for my own sake," said the deer. "But you should have been kind, and waited for me to finish mating. What wise man would kill a deer mating in the forest, at a time that is good for all beings, and that all beings long for? You have made fruitless the lovely fruit of a man's purpose. It does not become you, Kaurava, born in the line of the Pauravas and of the seers, whose deeds were never harsh. This was a cruel act, a very great one, blamed by all the world. It does not lead to heaven or to fame, and it is utterly against dharma, Bharata. You know the delights of women very well, and you know the truth of the books of dharma and wealth. You are like a god. You should not do a thing like this, which does not lead to heaven. It is you, best of kings, who should restrain men who do cruel deeds and act wickedly, men who have forsaken the three aims of life.

"What have you gained, best of men, by killing me, who did you no wrong? I am a sage who lives on roots and fruit, wearing the form of a deer. I live always in the forest, and I

am devoted to calm. You have harmed me, so the same will surely happen to you. You have been cruel to a pair of lovers, helpless and blinded by desire. The moment of love will bring the end of your life in the same way.

"I am a sage named Kindama, unmatched in austerity. I was ashamed to do this before men, so I was mating with a doe. I roam the deep forest as a deer among deer. It will not be the killing of a brahmin for you, because you did not know. You killed me in a deer's form, when I was blinded by desire. But for this, fool, you will reap the same fruit. When you lie with the woman you love, blinded by desire, you too will go to the world of the dead in that state. And the woman you lie with at the end, best of the wise, she will follow you out of love, when you have fallen into the power of the king of the dead, whom no being can escape. I was happy, and you brought me grief. In the same way, when you are happy, grief will come to you."

When he had said this, in great pain, the deer parted from life. And at once Pandu was stricken with grief.

The king and his wives stepped away from the dead deer, and he mourned for him as if he had been one of his own kin. In his pain and sorrow he lamented.

"Men born even into families of good people come to grief by what they do, when they have not mastered themselves and are trapped in the net of desire. My father was born of a man who always kept to dharma, and he died while still a boy, a slave of desire, so we have heard. In the field of that king, the slave of desire, the blessed Krishna Dvaipayana himself, a seer who governs his speech, fathered me. And now this low thought has come to me in my trouble. I have been wicked, lost in hunting, and the gods have forsaken me for my folly.

"I will set my mind on freedom, for bondage is a great calamity. I will follow the lasting way of my father. I will give myself up wholly to austerity. So I will wander this earth alone, spending each day under a single tree, a shaven sage, living on alms. I will be covered in dust. I will shelter in empty houses or live at the foot of a tree. I will give up everything, loved and unloved. I will neither grieve nor rejoice. Blame and praise will be the same to me. I will have no hopes, bow to no one, be free of the pairs of opposites, and own nothing. I will laugh at no one, and frown at no one. My face will always be calm, and I will delight in the good of all beings. I will harm nothing of the four kinds, moving or still. I will be the same to all living things, as if they were my own children.

"I will beg once a day at seven houses. If there are no alms, I will go without food. I will take a little at a time, as much as is fit to eat, and sometimes only from the first house. When I am given something I will go no further, and when I am given nothing I will finish the round of seven. If one man hacks at one of my arms with an adze, and another anoints the other with sandal paste, I will wish neither of them ill or well. I will not act like one who wants to live, nor like one who wants to die. I will neither welcome death nor hate life. I will pass beyond every rite a living man may perform to prosper, and stay in the blink of an eye and the moments like it. In every state I will give up the work of all my senses. I will let go of dharma itself, and wash my soul clean of its stain. I will be free of every sin, and past every snare. I will be in no one's power, like the wind. Living always in this way, I will keep my body alive, set on the road without fear.

"I will not delight in the way of a dog, without courage, fit only for the wretched, always cut off from my own dharma. The man who, honoured or dishonoured, looks wretchedly for another way of life, a slave to desire, walks the way of dogs."

When the king had said this, in great pain, sighing deeply, he looked at Kunti and at Madri and spoke to them. "Kausalya, Vidura the steward, the king with our kin, noble Satyawati, Bhishma, the royal family priests, the great brahmins who drink soma and keep strict vows, and the elders of the city who live there under our protection: make your peace with them all and tell them that Pandu has gone to the forest as a wandering ascetic."

Kunti and Madri heard the words of their husband, whose mind was made up to live in the forest. And they answered him with words to match.

"There are other stages of life, bull of the Bharatas, that you can live in, with the two of us, your wives by dharma, practising great austerity. You yourself will surely be the guide even to heaven. We will master our senses, set on our husband's world, and give up desire and pleasure, and we too will practise great austerity. If you leave us, great and wise lord of the people, we will give up our lives this very day. There is no doubt of it."

"If this is your firm resolve, and it is in keeping with dharma," said Pandu, "then I will follow my father's own lasting way. I will give up the comforts and ways of the village. I will practise great austerity, wear bark and live on fruit and roots, and wander the great forest. I will offer to the fire at dawn and at dusk, and bathe at both times. I will grow thin, eating little, wearing rags, skins and matted hair. I will bear cold, wind and sun, hunger, thirst and weariness, and wither this body with austerity that is hard to bear. I will live alone and reflect, living on what is ripe and what is unripe. I will satisfy the ancestors and the gods with the food of the forest, with words and with water. I will never do anything unkind to a forest-dweller, let alone to a village-dweller, or even to one who lives with his family. So I will stay, seeking out the fiercest and fiercer rule of the forest books, until this body comes to its end."

When the king, born in the Kaurava line, had said this to his two wives, Pandu gave away to brahmins his crest jewel, his gold necklace, his armlets and earrings, his costly clothes and his wives' ornaments, everything. And he said again, "Go to the City of the Elephant and tell them: Pandu has gone to the forest as a wandering ascetic."

Then the bull of the Kurus set out with his wives, giving up everything: wealth, desire, pleasure, and the highest delight. His followers and servants heard the lion of the Bharatas' many pitiful words. They raised a terrible cry of grief and wailed, "Alas! Alas!" Shedding hot tears, they left the king, and went quickly to the City of the Elephant with all his message. When Dhritarashtra, best of men, heard from them all that had happened in the great forest, he grieved for Pandu.

But the Kaurava prince Pandu, living on roots and fruit, went with his two wives to the mountain Nagasabha. He reached Chaitraratha, passed beyond Varishena, crossed the Himalaya, and went on to Gandhamadana. Guarded by great beings, siddhas and great seers, the king lived there, on level ground and rough. He came to the lake of Indradyumna, passed beyond Hamsakuta, and on Shatashringa, great king, he became an ascetic.

The Debt to the Fathers

There on Shataashringa, living in the best of austerities, the mighty Pandu became dear to the companies of siddhas and charanas. He served others, did not boast, held himself in check and mastered his senses. By his own strength, Bharata, he set out to win heaven. To some of them he became a brother, and to some a friend. Other seers looked after him as if he were their son. After a long time, bull of the Bharatas, Pandu reached an austerity without stain, and he became like a brahmin seer.

Longing to cross over to the far shore of heaven, he set out north from Shataashringa with his two wives. But the ascetics there said to him, "As we have gone higher and higher, northwards on the king of mountains, we have seen many hard places on it. There are playgrounds of the gods, the gandharvas and the apsaras, and Kubera's gardens, level and rough. There are the slopes of great rivers, and hard mountain caves. There are places of everlasting snow, with no trees, beasts or birds. Some places have great rains. Some are hard to cross, and some cannot be reached at all. No bird could fly over them, let alone any other creature. Only the wind goes there, and the siddhas and the great seers. How could these two princesses travel on this king of mountains and not break down? They have not deserved such hardship. Do not go, bull of the Bharatas."

"Great ones," said Pandu, "they say the door of heaven is not open to a man without children. I have no children, and that is why I burn with grief. I tell you this plainly. Men are born on the earth with four debts, owed by the hundred thousand, to the ancestors, the gods, the seers and men. Those who know dharma have laid it down that there are no worlds for the man who does not see to these in their time. A man satisfies the gods with sacrifices, the sages with study and austerity, the ancestors with sons and funeral offerings, and men with kindness. I am freed by dharma from my debts to the seers, the gods and men. But I am not freed from the debt to the ancestors, and that is why I burn, rich in austerity. When a man's body dies, the ancestors surely die with it. That is certain. So the best of men are born here to have children. That great man begot me in my father's field. How can children be born in my field in the same way?"

"You have children, righteous king," said the ascetics. "We know it with the eyes of the gods: fine, sinless offspring, like the gods. Tiger among men, bring about by your own action what the gods have ordained. A wise man who does not waver gets his fruit without pain. Now that you see the fruit, son, you should make the effort. When you have children with good qualities, you will be happy."

When he heard the ascetics' words, Pandu was lost in thought. He knew that the deer's curse had spoiled his own power to beget.

He spoke in private to Kunti, his famous wife by dharma, urging her towards a way to get children in time of need.

"The wise know, Kunti, that offspring is the foundation of the worlds, bound up with dharma. That is the eternal dharma, from the beginning. Sacrifices offered, gifts given, austerities practised, rules well kept: none of it purifies a man here who has no children, so it is said. I know this, you of the bright smile, and I see it. I have no children, I think, *so I will not reach the fair worlds.* Because of the deer's curse, my power to beget is destroyed, for I had no mastery of myself and did a cruel thing, timid one.

"In the teaching of dharma, Pritha, there are six kinds of sons who are heirs and kin, and six kinds who are not. Hear them from me. The son born to a man himself; the son begotten on his wife by another; the son acquired; the son of a remarried woman; the son of an unmarried girl; and the son born of an unchaste wife. And the son given; the son bought; the son adopted; the son who comes of his own accord; the son the bride brings with her to the wedding; the son of another's seed; and the son born of a woman of low birth. When one kind fails, a man should seek the next. In time of need men want a son from a better man than themselves. Good men get offspring that bring the fruit of dharma, better even than from their own seed, Pritha. So Manu, son of the Self-born, said.

"So, since I have lost the power to beget, I will send you today. Get children from a man my equal or my better, famous one.

"Hear this story too, Kunti, about Sharadandayani. She was a hero's wife, and her elders appointed her to bear children. In her season, pure and bathed, Kunti, she went out at night to a crossroads. She chose a brahmin who had reached perfection, and offered into the fire in the rite for a son. When that rite was over, she lived with him. And there she bore three great warriors, Durjaya and his brothers. You too, lovely one, at my bidding, lose no time in getting children from a brahmin great in austerity."

When he said this to her, great king, Kunti answered Pandu, her husband, the hero, the bull of the Kurus, the lord of the earth.

"You know dharma. You should never say such a thing to me, your wife by dharma, who loves you, lotus-eyed one. You yourself, strong-armed Bharata, will beget children on me by dharma, heroes full of courage. Tiger among men, I would go to heaven with you. Come to me for children yourself, joy of the Kurus. I would not go to any other man even in my mind, only to you. And what other man on earth is better than you?

"But first hear from me this old story, in keeping with dharma, which I heard and will tell you, wide-eyed one.

"There was once a king, so they say, named Vyushitashva. He was deeply devoted to dharma, and he made the line of Puru grow. When that righteous, great-souled king offered sacrifice, the gods came to him with Indra and the great seers. Indra was drunk with soma, and the brahmins with their fees, at the sacrifice of the great royal seer Vyushitashva. Then Vyushitashva shone out above all mortals, king, as the sun outshines all beings at the end of winter. The best of kings conquered and seized the kings of the east, the north, the middle and the south, and drove them before him. At the great horse sacrifice the mighty Vyushitashva became the lord of kings, with the strength of ten elephants. And those who know the old stories sing a verse about it: *Vyushitashva conquered this earth to the ocean's edge, and he protected all the classes as a father protects the sons of his body.*

"He offered great sacrifices and gave wealth to the brahmins. He gathered jewels without end and brought the great rites to pass. He pressed much soma and performed the soma sacrifices. He had a wife he loved dearly, lord of men, named Bhadra, the daughter of Kakshivat, whose beauty had no equal on earth. We have heard that the two of them desired each other. Wild with desire for her, he fell ill of consumption. Before long he went down like the setting sun.

"When that lord of men was dead, his wife was in deep grief. She had no son, tiger among men, and she lamented, so we have heard. Hear it, lord of men. Bhadra was in the utmost pain.

"Any woman without a son, you who know dharma best, who lives without her husband, does not live. She only grieves. It is better for a woman to die than to be without her husband, bull of the kshatriyas. I want to go where you have gone. Be kind, and take me. Without you I cannot bear to live a moment. Be kind to me, king, and take me from here quickly. I will follow behind you, tiger among men, on level ground and rough, as you go and never come back. I will be like your shadow, king, never leaving you, always obedient, always delighting in what is dear and good to you. From today, king, without you, lotus-eyed one, cruel sorrows will overwhelm me and wither my heart. Surely I was unlucky. In my former bodies I must have parted companions, or separated lovers who had come together, king. So this grief of parting from you has come to me, stored up by wicked deeds in former bodies. From today, king, I will lie on a bed of kusha grass, lost in misery, longing only to see you. Show yourself to me, tiger among men. I am wretched, helpless and pitiful, and I am weeping, lord of men.'

"As she lamented like this, again and again, with her arms around the dead body, a voice spoke from the air, so they say. 'Rise, Bhadra, and go. I give you a boon here. I will beget children on you, you of the lovely smile. When you have bathed after your season, on the eighth or the fourteenth night of the moon, lie down with me on your own bed, lovely one.'

"When she was told this, the queen, true to her husband, did exactly as the voice had said, for she longed for sons. And from that dead body, lord of men, the queen bore sons: three Shalvas and four Madras, best of the Bharatas.

"In the same way, bull of the Bharatas, you too can beget sons on me by the power of your mind, by your austerity and your yoga."

Chapter 45

Shvetaketu's Rule

When she had said this, the king, who knew dharma, spoke again to the queen, with these fine words full of dharma.

"It is as you say, Kunti. Vyushitashva did this long ago, lovely one, for he was like an immortal. But now I will tell you about dharma. Listen to me. It is the ancient dharma, seen by the seers, great men who knew dharma.

"In the old days, so they say, women were not kept shut away, lovely one. They went where they pleased and enjoyed themselves as they liked. They were free, you of the lovely eyes. From girlhood they went from their husbands to other men, fortunate one, and it was not against dharma. That was dharma in those days. Even now, creatures born as animals follow that ancient dharma, free of desire and hatred. This dharma, seen in ancient times, is honoured by the great seers. And among the northern Kurus it is still the way, you whose thighs are like plantain stems. For that eternal dharma favours women.

"But the present rule was set up in this world not long ago. Hear from me in full who set it up, and why.

"There was a great seer named Uddalaka, so we have heard. He had a son, a sage, named Shvetaketu. It was he who made this rule among men, so we have heard, out of anger, lotus-eyed one. Hear why.

"Once, in front of Shvetaketu's father, a brahmin took his mother by the hand, and said, 'Let us go.' The seer's son was furious and could not bear it, when he saw his mother being led away as if by force. When his father saw that Shvetaketu was angry, he said to him, 'Do not be angry, son. This is the eternal dharma. The women of all classes on earth are unconfined. As cows are, son, so are all creatures, each in its own kind.'

"But the seer's son, Shvetaketu, would not accept that dharma. And he made this rule for men and women on earth, noble lady, for human beings, but not for other creatures. From that time on this rule has stood, so we have heard.

"From today, a woman who strays from her husband will commit a sin, the same evil as killing an unborn child, and it will bring her misery. A man who strays from his wife, when she has been chaste since girlhood and true to him, will commit the same sin on earth. And a wife who is appointed by her husband to bear a child, and will not do it, will commit the same sin.'

"So Uddalaka's son, Shvetaketu, set up this rule of dharma by force long ago, timid one. And we have heard, lovely one, that when Saudasa appointed his wife Madayanti to bear a child, she went to the seer Vasishta. From him the lovely woman got a son named Ashmaka. She was Kalmashapada's wife, and she did it to please her husband. And you know how we ourselves were born, lotus-eyed one, from Krishna Dvaipayana, timid one, to make the Kuru line grow.

"So, looking at all these reasons, you should do what I tell you. It is in keeping with dharma, blameless one. Those who know dharma know this as dharma, princess: at each of her seasons, a woman must not pass over her husband, you of firm vows. At all the other

times, so they say, a woman is entitled to her freedom. Good people call this the ancient dharma. Those who know dharma know that whatever a husband tells his wife, princess, whether it is in keeping with dharma or not, she should do it. And all the more when he longs for a son and cannot beget one himself, as I long to see a son, you of flawless limbs.

"So, lovely one, to win your favour, I raise my joined hands to my head. My palms are red, and my fingers are like lotus petals. At my bidding, you of the lovely hair, you should bear sons with good qualities by a brahmin great in austerity. Through you, you of the full hips, I may go the way of those who have sons."

When he said this, the lovely Kunti, who delighted in what was dear and good to her husband, answered Pandu, the conqueror of enemy cities.

"When I was a girl in my father's house, I was given the task of honouring the guests. There I waited on a fierce brahmin of strict vows, whose purposes in dharma were hidden. People know him as Durvasas. I pleased that disciplined man with every effort. The blessed one gave me a boon joined with the power of a spell. He gave me a set of mantras and said to me, 'Whatever god you call with this mantra, willing or unwilling, he will come into your power.'

"That is what the brahmin told me in my father's house, Bharata, and it is true. Now its time has come. With your leave, king, I can call a god with that mantra, royal seer, so that we may have children, lord. Tell me which god I should call, you who know the truth best. Know that I am ready for this work, waiting only for your leave."

"Try this very day, lovely one, as the rules require," said Pandu. "Call Dharma, lovely one, for among the gods he has the greatest share of merit. Dharma could never be joined with what is against dharma. And the world will think, lovely one, This is dharma. He will surely be the most righteous of the Kurus. And a son given by Dharma will never set his mind on what is against dharma. So put dharma first, you of the bright smile. Restrain yourself, and win Dharma over with worship and with the spell."

When her husband said this, the lovely woman said, "So be it." She bowed to him, and with his leave she walked round him, keeping him on her right.

Three Sons from the Gods

When Gandhari had been with child for a year, Janamejaya, Kunti called on Dharma, the unfailing, to give her a child. The queen quickly brought an offering to Dharma, and she recited as the rules required the prayer that Durvasas had given her long before. She lay with Dharma, who had taken on a body by his yogic power, and the lovely woman won a son, the best of all living beings.

It was the eighth hour of the day, the one called Abhijit, when the sun stands at noon. The moon was in Indra's constellation, and it was a holy day, held in honour. Then Kunti bore a son of abundant fame. As soon as that son was born, a voice without a body spoke.

"This one will be the best of those who uphold dharma. There is no doubt of it. Pandu's first-born son will be called Yudhishtira. He will be a famous king, known in the three worlds, full of glory, splendour and good conduct."

When he had won that righteous son, Pandu spoke to her again. "They say a kshatriya is greatest in strength. Choose a son who is greatest in strength."

So when her husband told her this, she called on Vayu, the Wind. From him was born the strong-armed Bhima, of terrible courage. When he was born, so very strong, the voice spoke of him too, Bharata. "This one is born the strongest of all the strong."

And there was a great wonder as soon as Wolf-belly was born. He fell from his mother's lap and smashed a rock with his body. Kunti, so they say, had leaped up suddenly in fear of a tiger. She did not notice Wolf-belly asleep in her lap. The boy, as hard as a thunderbolt, fell on the mountain. As he fell, his body broke the rock into a hundred pieces. When Pandu saw the rock broken to powder, he was amazed.

On the very day that Bhima was born, best of the Bharatas, Duryodhana too was born, lord of the earth.

When Wolf-belly was born, Pandu thought again. *How can I have a son who is excellent, the best in the world? This world rests on fate and on human effort. And fate is won by rites performed in their proper time. Indra is the king of the gods, the first of them, so we have heard. His strength and energy cannot be measured. He is mighty, and his splendour has no end. I will win him over with austerity and get a son of great strength. The son he gives me will be the best. So I will practise great austerity, in deed, in mind and in word.*

Then the splendid Pandu, the Kaurava, took counsel with the great seers. He told Kunti to keep an auspicious vow for a year. And the strong-armed king himself stood on one foot. He practised fierce austerity in deep concentration. To win over the lord of the thirty gods, the righteous man turned with the sun from its rising to its setting, Bharata.

After a long time Vasava, Indra, spoke to him. "I will give you a son famous in the three worlds, who will bring about what gods, brahmins and friends want. I will give you a son who is the best, and who will destroy all his enemies."

When great Vasava had said this to him, the righteous Kaurava king remembered the words

of the king of the gods and spoke to Kunti. "Bear a son, you of the lovely hips, wise in policy, great, as bright as the sun, hard to overcome, active and wonderful to see, the home of a kshatriya's splendour. We have won the favour of the lord of the gods. Call him, you of the bright smile."

When he said this, the famous woman called on Shakra. The king of the gods came, and he fathered Arjuna.

As soon as the boy was born, a voice without a body spoke, filling the sky with its deep, great roar. "Kunti, this one will be the equal of Kartavirya and of Shibi in courage. He will be as unconquerable as Shakra, and he will spread your fame. As Aditi's joy grew because of Vishnu, so Arjuna, the equal of Vishnu, will make your joy grow. He will bring the Madras under his power, and the Kurus with the Kekayas, the Chedis, the Kashis and the Karushas, and he will uphold the fortune of the Kurus. By the strength of his arms the Fire at Khandava will be utterly sated with the fat of all creatures. This mighty leader will conquer the kings of the earth, and with his brothers he will offer three great sacrifices. Kunti, he will be the equal of Jamadagni's son, and as brave as Vishnu, the best of the brave, unconquered. He will win every divine weapon. This bull among men will bring back lost fortune."

The Wind spoke these wonderful words in the sky at the birth of Kunti's son, and Kunti heard them. When the ascetics who lived on Shatashringa heard that voice speaking aloud, they were filled with the greatest joy. And there was a mighty sound of drums in the sky from the divine seers and the dwellers in heaven with Indra. A great roar rose up, with showers of flowers. The companies of the gods gathered and honoured Partha.

Kadru's sons and Vinata's sons were there, the gandharvas and the apsaras, all the lords of creatures and the seven great seers. Bharadvaja, Kashyapa and Gautama came, and Vishvamitra, Jamadagni and Vasishtha. The blessed Atri, who rose when the sun was lost, came too. Marichi and Angiras, Pulastya, Pulaha and Kratu came, and Daksha the lord of creatures, and the gandharvas and the apsaras. They wore heavenly garlands and clothes and were decked with every ornament. They sang to Bibhatsu, and the apsaras danced around him.

Glorious Tumburu sang with the gandharvas. There were Bhimasena and Ugrasena, Urdayu and Anagha, Gopati, Dhritarashtra and Suryavarchas the seventh. There were Yugapa, Trinapa, Karshni, Nandi and Chitraratha, Shalishiras the thirteenth, Parjanya the fourteenth, Kali the fifteenth and Narada the sixteenth. There were Brihatta, Brihaka and famous Karala, Brahmacharin, Bahuguna and the famous Suparna, Vishvasu, Bhumanyu and Suchandra the tenth. And there were the two famous for the sweetness of their song, Haha and Huhu. These divine gandharvas sang to that bull among men.

The apsaras too, happy and decked with every ornament, danced and sang, great ladies with long eyes. Anuna and Anavadya, Priyamukhya and Gunavara, Adrika and Sachi, Mishrakeshi and Alambusha danced. Marichi and Shichuka, Vidyutparna and Tilottama, Agnika, Lakshana, Kshema, Devi, Rambha and Manorama danced. Asita and Subahu, Supriya and Suvapu, Pundarika and Sugandha, Suratha and Pramathini, Kamya and Sharadvati all danced there in troupes. Menaka, Sahajanya, Parnika and Punjikasthala, Kratusthala and Ghrithachi, Vishvachi and Purvachitti, the famous Umlocha and Pramlocha, these ten, sang. And Urvashi the eleventh sang with them, long-eyed like the rest.

The Adityas stood in the sky, blazing like fire, and made the greatness of Pandu's son

grow: Dhatri and Aryaman, Mitra and Varuna, Amsha and Bhaga, Indra, Vivasvat and Pushan, Tvashti and Savitri, Parjanya and Vishnu. The Rudras stood there: Mrigavyadha and Sharva and famous Nirriti, Ajaikapad, Ahirbudhnya and Pinakin the scorcher of enemies. Dahana and Ishvara and Kapalin were there, lord of the people, and Sthanu and the blessed Bhava. The two Ashvins, the eight Vasus, the mighty Maruts, the All-gods and the Sadhyas stood round about. Karkotaka and Shesha came, and the serpent Vasuki, Kacchapa and Apakunda, and the great snake Takshaka. They were full of splendour, great in anger and great in strength. These and many other nagas stood there. Tarkshya and Arishtanemi, Garuda and Asitadhvaja, Aruna and Aruni, the sons of Vinata, stood there.

When they saw that great wonder, the best of sages were amazed. And from then on they treated the Pandavas with even more care.

But famous Pandu, greedy for sons, urged his lovely wife again. Kunti said to him, "They do not speak of a fourth birth even in time of trouble. A woman who goes beyond that is loose, and with a fifth she is a whore. You know this dharma, and you understand it. So how can you pass it over for the sake of children, and speak to me as if you had forgotten it?"

Chapter 47

Spring

When Kunti's sons and Dhritarashtra's sons had been born, the daughter of the king of Madra spoke to Pandu in private.

"I have no quarrel with you, tamer of enemies, even though you cannot beget, and even though I, who deserve the best, am always placed below. I did not grieve so much when I heard that Gandhari had a hundred sons, king, joy of the Kurus. But this is my great grief: that I, Kunti's equal, have no son. By good fortune my husband now has children by Kunti. If Kuntibhoja's daughter would give me children too, it would be a kindness to me, and good for you as well. My pride holds me back from speaking to Kunti, because she is my co-wife. But if you are pleased with me, urge her yourself."

"This is always in my heart too, Madri," said Pandu, "but I did not dare say it to you, for I did not know whether you would welcome it or not. Now that I know your mind, I will try. I am sure that if I speak to her, she will do what I say."

Then Pandu spoke to Kunti again, alone. "Give my family children, lovely one, and do the world a kindness. So that the funeral offerings to me and my forefathers do not come to an end, and for love of me, do this highest good, lovely one. For the sake of fame, do a very hard thing. Indra won the rule of the gods, and still, wanting fame, he offered sacrifices. So too brahmins who know the mantras practise the hardest austerities and still go to their teachers, for the sake of fame, spirited one. So too all the royal seers and the brahmins rich in austerity have done hard deeds, high and low, for the sake of fame. Carry Madri across, as if on a raft, blameless one. Share your children with her, and win the highest glory."

When he said this, Kunti said to Madri, "Think of a god once. You will surely have a child worthy of you by him."

Then Madri thought for a moment, and turned her mind to the two Ashvins. They came, and they fathered twin sons on her, Nakula and Sahadeva, whose beauty had no equal on earth. For the twins too a voice without a body spoke. "These two will have beauty, strength of spirit and every good quality beyond all other men. They will shine with splendour, rich in beauty and in wealth."

The dwellers on Shatashringa named them, lord of the people, with devotion, with rites and with blessings. The eldest of Kunti's sons they called Yudhishtira, the middle one Bhimasena, and the third Arjuna. The brahmins, glad at heart, named Madri's sons: the first-born Nakula, the other Sahadeva. And those best of the Kurus were born a year apart.

Then Pandu urged Kunti again, for Madri's sake. But Pritha, when he spoke to her in private, king, said to him, "I told her to call once, and she won two. She has cheated me. I am afraid she will get the better of me. That is the way of women. I was a fool. I did not know that calling two gods at once would bear two fruits. So do not ask me again. Let that be my boon from you."

So the five sons of Pandu were born, given by the gods, mighty and famous, to make the Kuru line grow. They had every lucky mark, and they were as lovely to look at as the moon. They were proud as lions, great archers, and they walked with a lion's stride.

With necks like lions, those lords of men grew up with the courage of gods. As they grew there on the holy Himalayan mountain, they filled the gathered great seers with wonder. And the five and the hundred, who made the Kuru line grow, all grew up in a short time, like lotuses in water.

Pandu looked at his five handsome sons in the great forest, growing up under the protection of his own strong arms, and he was happy on the mountain.

Once, in the season of Madhu and Madhava, when the forest was in full flower, the time that bewilders all creatures, the king was roaming the forest with his wife. The forest was full of palasha, tilaka, mango, champaka and paribhadraka trees, and many others rich in fruit and flowers. It was lovely with ponds of every kind and with lotus pools. When Pandu looked at the forest, love was born in his heart.

He was wandering there glad at heart, like an immortal, and Madri followed him alone, wearing a fine dress. He looked at her, young and thinly clad, and his desire grew like a fire that springs up in a thicket. The lotus-eyed king saw her alone, his equal, and he could not hold back that desire. He was overpowered by it. Then the king seized her by force, alone as they were. The queen tried to stop him, struggling as hard as she could. But his whole being was swept up in desire, and he did not think of the curse. He went to Madri by force, as a man goes to a woman. Fallen into the power of love, to the end of his life, the Kaurava threw off his fear of the curse and took his beloved by force. Time itself had clouded the mind of the man who was ruled by desire. It churned up his senses and was lost with his reason.

When he had lain with his wife, joy of the Kurus, Pandu, the righteous man, met with the law of Time.

Then Madri held the lifeless king in her arms and cried out in grief, again and again. Kunti came with her sons and the two sons of Madri, the Pandavas, to where the king lay in that state.

"Come here alone, Kunti," Madri cried out in her pain. "Let the children stay there."

When she heard this, Kunti held the children back where they were. She cried out, "I am lost!" and ran to her. When she saw Pandu and Madri lying on the ground, Kunti's whole body was seized with grief, and she wept in her anguish.

"I always guarded this hero," she said, "and he was always master of himself. How could he break through the curse, when he knew what the forest-dweller had said? Surely you should have guarded the king, Madri. How could you tempt him, here where no one was? He was always so wretched, brooding on the curse. How did joy come to him when he found you alone? You are blessed, daughter of the Bahlikas, luckier than I am, for you saw the king's face when he was happy."

"He was lured on," said Madri, "and I held him back again and again. But he would not hold himself back. He wanted to make what was fated come true."

"I am the elder," said Kunti, "his first wife by dharma. The first fruit of dharma is mine. Do not stop me from what must be, Madri. I will follow my husband, who has gone into the power of the dead. Get up, let him go, and look after these children."

"I will follow our husband," said Madri, "who never turned back. I have not had my fill of love. Let my elder sister allow it. This best of the Bharatas came to me and perished with his desire unspent. How could I cut off his desire in the house of Yama? And if I lived, noble lady, I could not treat your sons just as I treat my own. That sin would touch me. So, Kunti, treat my two sons as your own. The king has gone into the power of the dead desiring me. Let my body be burned with the king's body, well covered. Do this kindness for me, noble lady. Watch over the children, and think of my good. I see nothing else I need to ask of you."

When she had said this, the famous daughter of the king of Madra, his wife by dharma, quickly followed that bull among men onto the fire of his pyre.

Chapter 48

The Return to the City

When they had performed the last rites for Pandu, the great seers, who were like gods, met together and took counsel.

"That great man, great in austerity, gave up his kingdom and his country," they said, "and came here to practise austerity and take refuge with the ascetics. King Pandu has gone from here to heaven. He has left in our keeping his sons, just born, and his wife."

So those generous siddhas, who delighted in the good of all beings, talked it over among themselves. They decided to go to the city named after the elephant, taking Pandu's sons with them, to give the Pandavas to Bhishma and to Dhritarashtra. At that very moment the ascetics all set out, taking with them Pandu's wife and sons, and his body.

Kunti had always lived in comfort, and she loved her sons dearly. But now, on the road, the long way seemed short to her. Before long the famous woman reached Kurujangala and came to the Vardhamana gate of the city.

When the people in the City of the Elephant heard that thousands of charanas and sages had come, they were amazed. When the sun had been up a little while, all the townsfolk came out with their wives to see the ascetics, with dharma in their minds. Crowds of women and crowds of kshatriyas came out in crowds of carriages, and brahmins with their wives. There was a great press of vaishyas and shudras too. No one felt envy. All had their minds on dharma.

Bhishma, son of Shantanu, came out, and Somadatta the Bahlika, and the royal seer whose eyes were his wisdom, and Vidura the steward himself. Queen Satyawati came out, and famous Kausalya, and Gandhari, surrounded by the royal ladies. Dhritarashtra's sons came out, all hundred of them, led by Duryodhana, decked in bright ornaments.

All the Kauravas and their family priests bowed their heads to the companies of great seers, and sat down near them. The people of the city and the country also bowed their heads to the ground, and sat down near them too. When Bhishma saw that the whole crowd had fallen silent, he offered the kingdom and the country to the great seers.

Then the eldest of them, a great seer with matted hair and a deerskin, rose. He knew what the great seers had decided, and he spoke.

"The heir of the Kauravas, the king named Pandu, gave up the pleasures of desire and went from here to Shatashringa. He was keeping a vow of celibacy, and by a divine cause this son, Yudhishtira, was born to him from Dharma himself. And the Wind gave that great king this son, Bhima, the mighty, the strongest of the strong. This one, whose courage is truth, was born to Kunti from Indra, who is called on by many. His crown will outshine all great archers. And these two, the best of the Kurus, great archers, tigers among men, whom Madri bore from the Ashvins, stand here too.

"Pandur, the famous, always devoted to dharma, living in the forest, raised up again this line of his grandfathers. As he watched the birth of his sons, and their growing, and their study of the Veda, Pandu's joy grew without end. He kept to the way of the good, and he won sons. And Pandu went to the world of the ancestors seventeen days ago. When she saw him laid on the pyre and offered into the mouth of the fire, Madri gave up her

life and entered the fire. She has gone with him to her husband's world, true to her vow. Now let the rites for her and for him be done. Here are the bodies of the two of them, and here are their fine sons. Let the tamers of enemies and their mother be received with honour. When the funeral rites are over, let Pandu, the famous upholder of the Kuru line, who knew every dharma, have the rite for the ancestors."

When they had said this to all the Kurus, the charanas and the guhyakas all vanished in a moment, while the Kurus watched. The companies of seers and siddhas vanished there like a city of the gandharvas, and the Kurus were utterly amazed.

"Vidura," said Dhritarashtra, "have all the funeral rites performed for Pandu, that lion among kings, as for a king, and above all for Madri too. Give cattle, clothes, jewels and wealth of every kind for Pandu and Madri, to whoever wants it and as much as they want. And see that Madri is honoured as Kunti would honour her. Let her be so well covered that neither the wind nor the sun can see her. Pandu, the sinless king, is not to be grieved for. He is to be praised. Five heroic sons were born to him, like the sons of gods."

Vidura said, "So be it," Bharata, and with Bhishma he had Pandu's rites performed in a place well shut in. Then the royal family priests quickly brought blazing fires out of the city, with offerings of ghee going before them. They decked a litter with the flowers of the season, with fragrances and with fine garlands of every kind, and covered it all over with cloth. When it was decked with garlands and costly cloths, the ministers, the kinsmen and the friends gathered round it. They carried that lion among men, well covered, with Madri, on a splendid carriage drawn by men and richly adorned. They decked it with a white parasol and a yak-tail fan and the sound of every kind of music. And men took jewels by the hundred and gave them to all who asked, for Pandu's last rites. They brought fine white parasols, great ones, and beautiful clothes, for the Kaurava's sake. Priests in white robes went ahead of him with the sacred fires, blazing and well adorned, pouring offerings into them.

Brahmins, kshatriyas, vaishyas and shudras by the thousand followed the king, weeping and burning with grief. "Where is our king going," they cried, "leaving us and giving us endless sorrow, the best of protectors, leaving us without a protector?"

All the Pandavas were weeping aloud, and Bhishma and Vidura. In a lovely stretch of woodland on the bank of the Ganga, on smooth, fair ground, those truthful men set down the litter of Pandu, the lion among men, whose deeds were never harsh, and his wife.

Then they quickly sprinkled his body with water from golden pots. It had been treated with every fragrance, smeared with pure kaliyaka paste and scented with the finest bathing oils. They anointed him with the best white sandal, mixed with black aloe and tunga juice. Then they dressed him in white cloths of the country. Wrapped in the cloths, the tiger among men shone as though he were alive, fit for a costly bed. When the priests who performed the rites for the dead gave leave, they sprinkled the king with ghee, adorned him with Madri beside him, and burned them with fragrant sandal mixed with tunga and padmaka, and with many other perfumes in plenty.

When she saw the two bodies, Kausalya was overcome. "Alas, my son!" she cried, and she fell suddenly to the ground. When the people of the city and the country saw her fallen in her grief, they all wept aloud, full of pity and of love for their king. All creatures cried out, as if worn out with the noise of grief, the animals with the men.

Bhishma, son of Shantanu, wise Vidura and all the Kauravas cried aloud in deep sorrow.

Then Bhishma, Vidura and the king with his kinsmen offered water to him, and so did all the Kuru women. When they had offered water, all the subjects, grieving, took the Pandavas, worn thin with sorrow, and stood round them, king. As the Pandavas lay on the ground with their kinsmen, so the townsfolk, brahmins and all, lay on the ground too, king. For twelve nights, down to the children, the city and the Pandavas were joyless, unwell and without cheer.

Chapter 49

Poison

Then the steward, the king and Bhishma, with their kinsmen, gave the funeral feast for Pandu, with the offerings to the dead that are like nectar. They fed the Kurus and the leading brahmins by the thousand, and gave heaps of jewels and fine villages to the best of the brahmins. When the Pandavas, bulls of the Bharatas, had been purified, the townsfolk took them and entered the city named after the elephant. All the people of the city and the country grieved for that bull of the Bharatas without end, as if one of their own kin had died.

When the funeral feast was over, Vyasa saw that the people were in sorrow. His mother was dazed and stricken with grief and pain, and he spoke to her.

"The times of happiness are past, and cruel times are at hand. Each day will be worse than the last. The earth's youth is gone. A terrible time is coming, full of deceit and thick with every kind of wrong, when the ways of dharma and its rites are lost. Go. Give up the world, and live in the forest of austerity, disciplined. Do not stay to see the terrible destruction of your own family."

"So be it," said Satyawati. She went in to her daughter-in-law and said to her, "Ambika, we have heard that through your son's bad policy the Bharatas will perish, with all who follow them, and their grandsons too. So, if you agree, bless you, let us take Kausalya, who is stricken with grief for her son, and go to the forest."

"So be it," said Ambika. And Satyawati, who kept good vows, said farewell to Bhishma and went to the forest with her two daughters-in-law, Bharata. There the queens practised very fierce austerity, best of the Bharatas. Then they gave up their bodies, great king, and went the way they longed for.

The Pandavas received the rites of passage laid down in the Veda. They grew up in their father's house, enjoying its pleasures. Playing with Dhritarashtra's sons in their father's house, the Pandavas excelled in every children's game.

In racing, in hitting the mark, in eating and in scattering the dust, Bhimasena trounced all Dhritarashtra's sons. When they were playing gleefully, he would catch them at hide-and-seek, grab them by the head and make them fight one another. Wolf-belly alone crushed all those hundred and one mighty boys without much trouble. The strong boy would seize them by the feet, throw them down with force, and drag them along the ground, screaming, till their knees, heads and eyes were scraped raw. When he played in the water, he would grab ten boys in his arms, stay under the water, and let them go only when they were half dead. When they climbed a tree to pick fruit, Bhima would shake the tree with a kick. Struck by the force of the blow, the tree swayed, and the little boys came tumbling down fast, fruit and all.

In wrestling, in racing, in the exercises, the boys never got the better of Wolf-belly, though they strove with him. So Wolf-belly, rivalling Dhritarashtra's sons, made himself deeply hated by them. But he did it out of childishness, not out of malice.

Then Dhritarashtra's mighty son, knowing Bhimasena's famous strength, showed his evil heart. He had turned from dharma and he had his eyes on wicked things. Out of folly and greed for power, a wicked thought came to him.

This Wolf-belly, Kunti's son, the middle one of Pandu's sons, is the strongest of the strong. He must be killed by treachery. Then I will take his younger brother and the eldest, Yudhishtira, by force and put them in chains, and I will rule the earth.

When the wicked Duryodhana had made up his mind to this, he was always looking for a weak spot in great-hearted Bhima.

He had large, splendid tents built of cloth and blankets, Bharata, for playing in the water, and he chose a spot of ground at Pramanakoti. When the games were over, they all put on clean clothes and ornaments, and slowly ate the food, rich in everything they could want. At the end of the day, tired from their games, the heroes, the leaders of the Kurus, chose to spend the night in the pleasure tents.

The mighty Bhima was worn out. He had exercised more than the others, carrying the boys who had come to play in the water on his back. Wanting a place to sleep, he climbed up on to the ground at Pramanakoti and fell asleep. He had found a cool place to rest, and he was tired and dazed with drink. The Pandava slept without moving, king, like a dead man.

Then Duryodhana quietly bound Bhima with ropes of creeper, and threw him from the bank into the deep water, where the current was terrible. But Kunti's son woke. He broke all his bonds, and Bhima, the best of fighters, rose up out of the water again.

Another time, while he slept, Duryodhana had angry snakes with sharp fangs and deadly poison bite him all over his body, in all his vital places. But though the fangs of those fanged creatures struck his vital places, they could not break the skin of the broad-chested boy, so hard was he. Bhima woke, and he crushed all the snakes. And with a backhand blow he killed Duryodhana's favourite charioteer.

Again Duryodhana had poison thrown into Bhimasena's food, fresh kalakuta, sharp and strong, enough to make the hair stand on end. The son of the vaishya woman told the Parthas, for he wished them well. But Wolf-belly ate it and digested it without any change in him. That very sharp poison did not affect him at all. Bhima, whose frame was terrible, digested even that.

So Duryodhana, Karna and Shakuni, Subala's son, tried to kill the Pandavas by many means. And the Pandavas, tamers of enemies, knew all about it. But they kept to Vidura's advice, and did not bring it out into the open.

Born of Reeds and a Pot

"Great brahmin," said Janamejaya, "tell me about Kripa's birth too. How was he born from a clump of reeds, and how did he win his weapons?"

The great seer Gautama had a son named Sharadvat, great king, who was born, so they say, with arrows. His mind did not turn to the study of the Vedas so much, tamer of enemies, as it turned to archery. As those who speak of Brahman master the Vedas by austerity, so he, rich in austerity, won all the weapons. By his devotion to archery and his great austerity, Gautama greatly troubled the king of the gods.

So the lord of the gods sent a divine girl named Jalapadi. "Put an obstacle in the way of his austerity," he said, Kaurava. She came to Sharadvat's lovely hermitage, and the young girl tempted Gautama, who held a bow and arrows. When Gautama saw the apsaras in the forest, wearing a single cloth, with a figure unmatched in the world, his eyes opened wide. His bow and arrows fell from his hands to the ground, and a trembling came over his body at the sight of her.

But his knowledge was so great, and his austerity so strong, that the wise man held firm with the utmost steadiness. Yet from that sudden stirring, king, his seed flowed, and he did not notice it. The sage left the hermitage and the apsaras, and went away. His seed fell on a clump of reeds. Falling on the reeds, it split in two, king, and from it twins were born to Gautama Sharadvat.

By chance, while King Shantanu was out hunting, one of his soldiers saw the twins in the forest. He saw the bow and arrows, and the black antelope skins, and decided they were the children of a brahmin who had mastered archery. So he showed the twins, with the arrows, to the king. The king took the twins, full of pity, and went home, saying, "They are my children."

So the king brought them up and gave them the rites of passage. And Gautama, having gone away, gave himself to archery. "I have brought these two children up out of pity, kripa," said the lord of the earth, so he gave them names from that very word. Gautama learned by his austerity that they had been left there, and he came and told Kripa everything, his family and his lineage. He taught him in full all the fourfold science of archery and every kind of weapon, and all their secrets. Before long Kripa became a great teacher. Then all the great warriors learned archery from him: Dhritarashtra's sons and the mighty Pandavas, the Vrishnis, and other kings who came from many lands.

Wanting something better, Bhishma looked for teachers of arrows and weapons, men respected for their courage, to train his grandsons. *No one of little wit, no one who is not great and not skilled in many weapons, no one without a god's strength of spirit, could train the mighty Kurus in weapons*, he thought.

Long ago the great seer Bharadvaja was performing a rite, and he saw the apsaras Ghritachi herself, who had just bathed. The wind blew up and pulled her garment away. Then his seed fell, and the seer put it in a pot, a drona. In that pot of the wise man, Drona was born. He studied the Vedas and all their limbs.

The mighty Bharadvaja, the best of those who uphold dharma, handed on the weapon of Fire to the noble Agniveshya. Then the sage who was born of Fire, best of the Bharatas,

handed on that great weapon of Fire to Bharadvaja's son.

Bharadvaja had a friend, a king named Prishata. At that time a son named Drupada was born to him. Every day Prishata's son, the bull of the kshatriyas, went to the hermitage and played and studied with Drona. When Prishata died, strong-armed Drupada became king, the lord of men among the northern Panchalas. And the blessed Bharadvaja went up to heaven.

Then, at his father's bidding and wanting a son, the famous Drona married Kripa, Sharadvat's daughter. Gautama's daughter, who always delighted in the fire rite, in dharma and in self-control, bore a son, Ashvatthama. As soon as he was born he whinnied like the horse Uchchaihshravas. When it heard this, an unseen being in the sky spoke. "Since the strength of this child's cry has reached every quarter like a horse's, this boy will be called Ashvatthama, Horse-strength."

Bharadvaja's son was delighted with his son. Living there, the wise man gave himself to archery. He heard, king, that the great Rama, the son of Jamadagni, the tamer of enemies, was giving away all his wealth to brahmins. Rama was setting out for the forest when Bharadvaja's son came and said to him, "Know that I am Drona, a bull among brahmins. I have come for wealth."

"All the gold I had, and whatever other wealth, I have given to brahmins, rich in austerity," said Rama. "And this goddess, the earth, to the ocean's edge, with her towns and her garland of cities, I have given whole to Kashyapa. Now I have only my body left, and my precious weapons, and arms of every kind. Choose, Drona. What shall I give you? Tell me quickly."

"Give me all your weapons, Bhargava," said Drona, "every one, with the art of calling them back, and with the secrets of their use."

"So be it," said the Bhargava, and he gave him the weapons, and the whole science of archery with its secrets and its vows. When he had received it all and mastered the weapons, the best of brahmins was delighted, and he went to his dear friend Drupada.

Chapter 51

The Ball in the Well

Then the mighty son of Bharadvaja came to Drupada and said to Prishata's son, "Know that I am your friend, king."

"Brahmin," said Drupada, "your understanding is unformed, and hardly fitting, when you boldly tell me, 'I am your friend.' Kings in high places never make friends, fool, with men like you, who have no fortune and have lost their wealth. Friendships too wear out with time, as men wear out. There was friendship between us once, but it was bound by our being equals. No friendship is ever seen in the world that does not grow old. Desire pulls it apart, and anger cuts it down. Do not cling to a friendship that has worn out. Make a new one. Our friendship, best of brahmins, was tied to what each of us needed.

"A poor man is no friend of a rich man, nor an unlearned man of a learned one, nor a coward of a hero. Why do you want a friendship that is past? Friendship and marriage are between two whose wealth is equal and whose family is equal, not between the well-fed and the starving. A man who does not know the Veda is no friend of one who does, nor a man without a chariot of a chariot fighter. A man who is not a king is no friend of a king. Why do you want a friendship that is past?"

When Drupada said this to him, the mighty son of Bharadvaja thought for a moment, flooded with anger. He made up his mind about the Panchala, and the wise man went to the city of the Kuru chiefs, named after the elephant.

The princes had come out of the City of the Elephant together, and the heroes were wandering about happily, playing with a ball. As they played, the ball fell into a well. They could find no way to get it back.

Then Drona saw the princes at a loss. The mighty man smiled a little, and spoke to them with a clever smile. "Shame on your kshatriya strength! Shame on your skill with weapons! You are born in the line of Bharata, and you cannot get your ball back. Here is a handful of reeds. I have charged it with the power of a weapon. See its power, which nothing else has. I will pierce the ball with one reed, and that reed with another, and that one with another. By joining them together I will get hold of the ball."

The princes watched, their eyes wide with wonder. And when they saw the ball drawn out, they said to the man who had pierced it, "We bow to you, brahmin. No one else can do this. Who are you? How should we know you? What can we do for you?"

"Describe me to Bhishma," said Drona, "my looks and my qualities. He is very wise. He will know me at once."

"So be it," they all said, and they told Bhishma, their grandfather, the brahmin's words, and what he had done, so out of the ordinary. When Bhishma heard the princes, he knew it was Drona. He is a fitting teacher, he thought.

So Bhishma, the best of those who bear arms, brought him in himself, and honoured him well. Then he asked him carefully why he had come, and Drona told him everything.

"Long ago, Bhishma, I went to the great seer Agniveshya for weapons, to learn archery, unfailing one. I lived there a very long time, a humble student with matted hair,

keeping the vow of celibacy, for many years, to master archery. The son of the king of the Panchalas, the mighty Yajnasena, studied with me, working hard for our teacher and paying close attention. He was my friend there. He helped me, and I loved him. I spent a long time with him and was happy, alas. We studied together from childhood, Kaurava.

"He came to me there, doing me kindnesses and speaking kind words, and said something to me that made my love grow, Bhishma. 'Drona, I am my great father's dearest son. When the king of the Panchalas consecrates me as king, the kingdom will be yours to enjoy, friend. I swear it to you on the truth. My pleasures, my wealth and my happiness will be yours to command.'

"When he had said this, I went away, having mastered the weapons, wanting wealth. When I heard that he had been consecrated, I thought, *I have got what I wanted.* I went back to my dear friend on his throne, full of joy, remembering our time together and what he had said. I came to Drupada, lord, and, as an old friend, I said to him, 'Know that I am your friend, tiger among men.'

"When I came up to him like a friend, Drupada laughed at me as if I were nothing, and he said, 'Brahmin, your understanding is unformed, and hardly fitting, when you boldly tell me, "I am your friend." Kings in high places never make friends, fool, with men like you, who have no fortune and have lost their wealth. A man who does not know the Veda is no friend of one who does, nor a man without a chariot of a chariot fighter. A man who is not a king is no friend of a king. Why do you want a friendship that is past?'

"When Drupada said this to me, I was flooded with anger. So I came to the Kurus, Bhishma, looking for pupils of good quality."

Bhishma accepted him as teacher, together with Pandu's sons. He brought all his grandsons, and wealth of many kinds, and gave them to Drona as his pupils, king, with the proper rites. And the great archer accepted the Kauravas as his pupils.

When he had accepted them all, and they had come to him as pupils, Drona spoke to them alone, in private, with confidence. "There is a task I long for in my heart. When you have mastered your weapons, you must do it for me. Promise me this truly, sinless ones."

When they heard this, the Kauravas fell silent, lord of the people. But Arjuna, the tamer of enemies, promised it all. Then Drona kissed Arjuna on the head, again and again. He embraced him lovingly and wept for joy.

Then mighty Drona taught Pandu's sons weapons of many kinds, divine and human. Other princes too came together to Drona, the best of brahmins, to learn weapons, bull of the Bharatas: the Vrishnis and the Andhakas, and kings from many lands. And Radha's son, the son of the suta, came to Drona as his teacher. But the suta's son was very resentful, and he rivalled Partha. He took shelter with Duryodhana, and he looked down on the Pandavas.

Chapter 52

The Bird's Head

Arjuna took the greatest pains in honouring his teacher, and the greatest care with his weapons, and he became Drona's favourite. Drona called the cook aside and told him, "You must never serve Arjuna his food in the dark."

Then one day, while Arjuna was eating, a wind blew up, and it put out the lamp that was burning there. Arjuna went on eating his food, and his hand did not miss his mouth, for the hand of a strong man always knows its way to his food from habit. The Pandava understood that it came from practice, and he began to practise at night.

Drona heard the twang of his bowstring, Bharata. He got up, came to him, embraced him, and said, "I will do all I can to see that there is no other archer like you in the world. I tell you truly."

Then Drona taught Arjuna more, how to fight from chariots, on elephants and horses, and on the ground. He taught the Pandava to fight with the mace, with the sword, with the lance, the spear and the javelin, and to fight in the melee. When they saw his skill, kings and princes came by the thousand, eager to learn archery.

Then, great king, Ekalavya, the son of Hiranyadhanus, king of the Nishadas, came to Drona. But Drona, who knew dharma, would not take him as a pupil in archery, thinking, He is a Nishada, out of regard for the others. The tamer of enemies touched Drona's feet with his head and went into the forest. There he made a Drona out of clay. He treated it with the utmost respect, as his teacher, and he set himself to practise with arrows and weapons under the strictest discipline. With the greatest faith and the greatest effort, he became very quick in drawing, aiming and loosing.

Then one day, with Drona's leave, the Kurus and the Pandavas all drove out in their chariots to hunt, tamers of enemies. A man followed the Pandavas by chance, king, alone, carrying their gear and leading a dog. While they wandered about, each busy with his own affairs, the dog strayed off in the forest and came upon the Nishada. When it saw the Nishada in the forest, dark, his body smeared with dirt, wearing a black deerskin, it stood near him and barked. Then, as it barked, he loosed seven arrows into its mouth, all as if at once, showing how quick he was with his weapon. The dog came back to the Pandavas with its mouth full of arrows. When the heroic Pandavas saw it, they were amazed. They saw how quick he was, and how he could shoot by sound, and they were ashamed. They praised him in every way.

Then the Pandavas searched for the forest dweller, king, and found him in the forest, shooting arrows without stopping. He looked so strange that they did not know him. So they asked him, "Who are you? Whose son are you?"

"Heroes," said Ekalavya, "know that I am the son of Hiranyadhanus, king of the Nishadas, and a pupil of Drona. I have worked hard at archery."

When they had learned the truth about him, the Pandavas went back and told Drona everything that had happened, and the wonder of it. But Arjuna, Kunti's son, kept thinking of Ekalavya, king. He went to Drona in private and said to him, with the freedom of affection, "You embraced me, when I was alone, and told me lovingly, 'No pupil of mine will be better than you.' Then how is it that you have another pupil,

better than me, better than anyone in the world, a mighty man, the son of the king of the Nishadas?"

Drona thought for a moment and made up his mind. He took Savyasachin with him and went to the Nishada. He saw Ekalavya, his body smeared with dirt, his hair matted, wearing rags, bow in hand, shooting arrows without stopping. When Ekalavya saw Drona coming near, he went to meet him, clasped his feet, and touched the ground with his head. The Nishada honoured Drona as the rules require. He told him he was his pupil, and stood before him with joined hands.

Then Drona said to Ekalavya, king, "If you are my pupil, then give me my fee at once."

When he heard this, Ekalavya was delighted. "What shall I give, lord? Let my teacher command me. There is nothing I would not give to my teacher, best of those who know Brahman."

"Give me your right thumb," said Drona.

Ekalavya heard Drona's cruel words. But he kept his promise, for he was always devoted to truth. His face was just as happy, and his heart just as cheerful. Without a moment's thought, he cut off his thumb and gave it to Drona.

After that the Nishada drew the bowstring with his fingers. But he was never as quick as he had been before, lord of men. Then Arjuna was glad, and the fever left his heart. And Drona's word came true: no one else surpassed Arjuna.

Two of Drona's pupils among the Kurus, Duryodhana and Bhima, were outstanding at the mace. Ashvatthama excelled in all the secret arts. The twins were better with the sword than any other men. Yudhishtira was the best chariot fighter. But Dhananjaya was the best in everything. He was famous to the ocean's edge as the leader of the leaders of chariot bands. In intelligence, in concentration, in strength and in energy, and in all the weapons, the Pandava excelled. In his weapons and in his love for his teacher, Arjuna stood out. The teaching was the same for all, but in skill and in courage Arjuna alone was a great warrior beyond all the princes. The wicked sons of Dhritarashtra could not bear Bhimasena's strength or Dhananjaya's learning, lord of men.

When they had all mastered every branch of learning, Drona brought them together to test their knowledge of arms, bull among men. He had craftsmen make an artificial bird, a vulture, and set it on top of a tree without the princes knowing, and he pointed it out as the target.

"All of you, take up your bows quickly," said Drona, "and stand with your arrows fitted, aiming at this bird. As soon as I speak, cut off its head. I will call on you one at a time, boys. Do as I say."

Then the best of the Angirasas spoke first to Yudhishtira. "Fit your arrow, unconquerable one, and let it go when I have finished speaking."

So Yudhishtira took up his loud bow first, and stood aiming at the bird, as his teacher had told him. When the joy of the Kurus had drawn his bow, after a moment Drona said to him, "Do you see the bird on top of the tree, prince?"

"I see it," Yudhishtira answered his teacher.

After another moment Drona spoke to him again. "Now do you see this tree, or me, or your brothers?"

"I see this tree," said Kunti's son, "and you, and my brothers, and the bird," again and again.

"Step back," said Drona, as if displeased. "You cannot hit this target," he said scornfully.

Then, in the same way, the famous teacher tested Duryodhana and the rest of Dhritarashtra's sons, and his other pupils, Bhima and the others, and the kings from other lands. "We see everything," they all said, and he scorned them all.

Then Drona smiled and spoke to Dhananjaya. "Now you must shoot at this target. Listen. You must let go your arrow as soon as I speak. Draw your bow, son, and wait a moment."

Savyasachin bent his bow into a circle and stood aiming at the target, as his teacher had told him. After a moment Drona spoke to him in the same way. "Do you see the bird sitting there, and the tree, and me?"

"I see the bird," Partha said to Drona. "I do not see the tree, or you, Bharata."

Then Drona was pleased. After a moment the unconquerable one spoke again to the best of the Pandava chariot fighters. "If you see the bird, then tell me again."

"I see the bird's head," he said, "not its body."

When Arjuna said this, the hair on Drona's body stood on end with joy. "Shoot," he said to Partha, and Partha shot without a thought. With a sharp, razor-headed arrow the Pandava cut the head off the bird on the tree, and brought it down with force. When that was done, Drona embraced Phalguna. And he thought Drupada already beaten in battle, with all his followers.

Some time later, bull of the Bharatas, the best of the Angirasas went with his pupils to bathe in the Ganga. When Drona had waded into the water, a strong crocodile that lived there, driven by Time, seized him by the calf. Though he could have freed himself, he urged all his pupils on, as if in haste. "Kill the crocodile and save me!"

At the very moment he spoke, Bibhatsu struck the crocodile under the water with five sharp arrows. The others stood there bewildered. When Drona saw the Pandava act, he thought him the best of all his pupils, and he was pleased. Cut to pieces by Partha's arrows, the crocodile let go of the great man's leg and died.

Then Bharadvaja's son said to the great warrior, "Take this weapon, strong-armed one. It is the best of weapons, very hard to withstand, the weapon called Brahmashiras, with the art of using it and of calling it back. You must never use it against men. If it is loosed at anyone of little power, it could burn up the world. This weapon, son, is said to be without equal in the worlds. Keep it with care, and hear what I say. If ever an enemy who is not human attacks you, hero, then use this weapon in battle to kill him."

"So be it," Bibhatsu promised, with joined hands, and he received that supreme weapon. And his teacher said to him again, "No other man in the world will be an archer equal to you."

The Tournament

When Drona saw that Dhritarashtra's sons and Pandu's sons had mastered their weapons, Bharata, he spoke to King Dhritarashtra, lord of the people, in the presence of Kripa, Somadatta, wise Bahlika, Ganga's son, Vyasa and Vidura.

"King, best of the Kurus, the princes have completed their training. With your leave, king, let them show what they have learned."

The great king was glad at heart. "Son of Bharadvaja," he said, "you have done a great thing, best of brahmins. Whenever you think the time is right, and wherever, and however, command me yourself to arrange it. Today, in my despair, I envy men who have eyes, who will see my sons show their courage in arms. Steward, do exactly what the teacher says. I do not think anything could please me more, you who love dharma."

Then Bharadvaja's son, very wise, took his leave of the king. He went out with Vidura and had the ground measured. It was level, without trees or bushes, sloping to the north. On a day when the stars were favourable he made an offering on that ground, and it was proclaimed in the city, best of speakers. On the arena, craftsmen built a very large hall for the spectators, well made, as the books of building require. It was for the king, with every kind of weapon, and for the women, bull among men. The people of the country built platforms there, large and high, and costly litters.

When the day came, the king went with his ministers, putting Bhishma and Kripa, the best of teachers, at the front. He came to the splendid golden hall, hung with nets of pearls and decked with beryl. Noble Gandhari and Kunti, best of conquerors, and all the king's women climbed happily onto the platforms with their maids and their trains. They were like the wives of the gods climbing Meru. The four classes, brahmins, kshatriyas and the rest, came hurrying from the city, eager to see the princes' skill in arms. With music playing and the people's excitement, the gathering became like a great ocean churned up.

Then the teacher entered the middle of the arena with his son, wearing white, with a white sacred thread, white hair and a white beard, white garlands and white paste. He was like the sun with Mars in a cloudless sky. The strongest of the strong made an offering as the time required, and had brahmins who knew the mantras recite the blessing.

After the sound of the holy blessing, men came in carrying weapons and equipment of every kind. Then the bulls of the Bharatas came in, the mighty princes, with their armour on, their belts tied, their quivers fastened and their bows in hand. There, in order of age, with Yudhishtira at their head, the princes of great courage showed their most wonderful skill in arms. Some of the people ducked their heads for fear of the arrows flying. Others watched boldly, amazed. Riding their horses fast, the princes struck the targets with arrows of every kind, beautiful with their names marked on them, loosed with speed. The people saw that company of princes with their bows and arrows, like a city of the gandharvas, and they were amazed. Suddenly men by the hundred thousand shouted, "Well done! Well done!", Bharata, their eyes wide with wonder.

The mighty princes showed the ways of the bow again and again, in the chariot drills, on elephants and on horses, and in wrestling. Then, taking sword and shield, the fighters went through the sword drills as they had been taught, all over the ground. The people

saw how quick they all were, how well they moved, how handsome, how steady and how firm of grip, in the use of sword and shield.

Then those two who always delighted in it, Suyodhana and Wolf-belly, came down into the ring, maces in hand, like two mountains, each with a single peak. With their belts tied, strong-armed, standing on their manhood, they roared like two rutting elephants over a cow. The mighty pair circled left and right with their shining maces, like two bulls in rut.

Vidura told Dhritarashtra everything the princes did, and Kunti, the fire-stick that kindled the Pandavas, told Gandhari.

With the king of the Kurus and Bhima, the strongest of the strong, in the ring, the crowd was split in two, as their loyalties took them. "Ah, the hero, the king of the Kurus!" some roared. "Ah, Bhima!" roared others. And suddenly huge shouts went up from the men.

When wise Bharadvaja saw the arena heaving like a stormy sea, he said to his dear son Ashvatthama, "Stop these two mighty men. They have both trained well. Do not let the arena break out in fury because of Bhima and Duryodhana."

So the teacher's son held them back, with their maces raised, like two oceans lashed by the winds at the end of an age.

Then Drona went into the courtyard of the arena. He silenced the band, whose noise was like a great cloud, and said, "Now see Partha, dearer to me than my son, the best of all masters of weapons, Indra's son, the equal of Indra's younger brother!"

At the teacher's word, after the blessings had been said, the young man appeared. It was Phalguna, with his lizard-skin finger guard tied on, his quiver full and his bow in hand, wearing golden armour. He was like a cloud at dusk, with the sun, the rainbow and the lightning.

Then a great cry went up from the whole arena, and music played everywhere, with conches. "This is Kunti's glorious son! This is the middle Pandava! This is great Indra's son! This is the protector of the Kurus! This is the best of the masters of weapons, the best of those who uphold dharma! This is the highest treasure of good conduct and knowledge among men of good conduct!"

As Kunti heard these matchless words from the spectators, her breast grew wet with tears mixed with milk.

Dhritarashtra, best of men, with his ears full of that great noise, said happily to Vidura, "Steward, what is this huge noise, like a stormy sea, that has suddenly risen in the arena, as if to split the sky?"

"Great king," said Vidura, "it is Partha, Phalguna, Pandu's son, who has come down in his armour. That is the great noise."

"I am blessed," said Dhritarashtra, "and favoured, and protected, wise one, by the three Pandava fires sprung from Pritha's fire-stick."

When the excited arena had somehow grown calm, Bibhatsu showed the speed with weapons he had learned from his teacher. With the weapon of Fire he made fire. With the weapon of Varuna he made water. With the weapon of Wind he made wind, and with the weapon of the Rain-cloud he made clouds. With the weapon of Earth he went into the ground, and with the weapon of the Mountain he made mountains. With the weapon of Vanishing he vanished again. In a moment he was tall, in a moment short. In a moment he was at the yoke of his chariot, in a moment in the middle of it, and in a moment he leaped down to the ground. His teacher's favourite struck targets delicate, small and heavy with arrows of every kind, with perfect grace. Into the mouth of an iron boar as it swung round he shot five arrows, not touching one another, as if they were a single arrow. Into the hollow of a cow's horn hanging from a rope and swaying, the mighty man drove twenty-one arrows. These and other great feats he showed with the sword and the bow, and he showed his skill with the mace, a master of every weapon.

When that display was almost over, Bharata, and the crowd was growing quiet and the music was dying down, a sound was heard from the gate. It told of greatness and strength. It was the slapping of arms, like the crash of a thunderbolt. *Are the mountains splitting?* the whole arena thought for a moment, lord of the earth. *Is the earth cracking open? Is the sky filling with clouds heavy with rain?* And all the spectators turned to face the gate.

Drona stood there surrounded by the five Partha brothers, like the moon with the five stars of the constellation Savitra. And the proud hundred brothers, with Ashvatthama, gathered round Duryodhana, the killer of enemies, as he rose. He stood there with his mace in his hand, surrounded by his brothers with their weapons raised. He shone like Indra long ago among the companies of the gods, when the danavas were destroyed.

Chapter 54

King of Anga

The people made way for him, their eyes wide with wonder, and Karna, the conqueror of enemy cities, came into the great arena. He wore the armour he was born with, and his face was lit by his earrings. He carried his bow and had his sword belted on, and he moved like a mountain on foot. He was the child Pritha had borne as a girl, famous and wide-eyed, a part of the hot-rayed Sun. Karna, the destroyer of hosts of enemies, had the strength and courage of a lion, a bull and a lord of elephants. In brilliance, in beauty and in splendour he was like the sun, the moon and fire. He was tall, like a golden palm tree, young, with a lion's frame, glorious, with virtues beyond counting, the Sun's own son.

The strong-armed man looked all round the ring. Then he bowed to Drona and Kripa, but without much respect. The whole gathering stood still, staring. *Who is this?* they thought, shaken and very curious.

Then, in a voice as deep as a cloud, the best of speakers, the son of the Sun, spoke to his brother, Indra's son, whom he did not know as his brother.

"Partha, I will do every feat you have done, and better, while the people watch. Do not be so amazed at yourself."

Before he had finished speaking, best of speakers, the people everywhere leaped up at once, as if thrown up by a machine. Joy touched Duryodhana, tiger among men. Shame and anger filled Bibhatsu in a moment.

Then, with Drona's leave, the mighty Karna, who always loved a fight, did all that Partha had done there. Then Duryodhana and his brothers embraced Karna gladly, Bharata, and said, "Welcome, strong-armed one! You have come by good fortune, giver of honour. Enjoy me and the kingdom of the Kurus as you wish."

"I have done all I set out to do," said Karna. "I choose your friendship. And I want to fight Partha in single combat, Bharata."

"Enjoy the pleasures of life with me," said Duryodhana. "Do your kinsmen good, and put your foot on the heads of all your enemies, tamer of enemies."

Then Partha, feeling himself insulted, spoke to Karna, who stood among the crowd of brothers like a mountain. "Karna, the worlds that go to men who come uninvited and speak uninvited, you will go to, when I have killed you."

"This arena is open to everyone," said Karna. "What is it to you, Phalguna? Kshatriyas are best by courage, and dharma follows strength. Why these insults, the comfort of the weak? Speak with arrows, Bharata, till today, in front of your teacher, I take your head with my arrows."

Then, with Drona's leave, Partha, the conqueror of enemy cities, quickly embraced by his brothers, went forward to fight him. And Karna, embraced by Duryodhana and his brothers, stood ready for battle, gripping his bow and arrow.

Then the sky was covered with clouds, with lightning and thunder, with rainbows racing

before them, and with lines of white cranes like laughter. Then the Sun, seeing Indra looking down lovingly on the arena, drove away the clouds that had come near. So the Pandava was seen hidden in the shadow of the cloud, and Karna was seen bathed in sunlight.

Dhritarashtra's sons stood on the side where Karna was. Bharadvaja's son, Kripa and Bhishma stood where Partha was. The arena was divided in two, and so were the women. Kuntibhoja's daughter understood what was happening, and she fainted. Vidura, who knew every dharma, revived Kunti as she lay in a faint, sprinkling her with water mixed with sandal. When her breath came back to her, she saw her two sons in their armour, and she was in anguish. She could do nothing at all.

As the two stood with their great bows raised, Kripa, the son of Sharadvat, spoke. He knew the rules of single combat and every dharma.

"This is Pritha's younger son, the son of Pandu, a Kaurava. He will fight you in single combat. You too, strong-armed one, must tell us your mother and your father, and the family of kings you are the pride of. When he knows who you are, Partha will fight you, or not."

When Karna was told this, his face bowed down with shame, like a lotus bruised and drooping under the rain.

"Teacher," said Duryodhana, "the books lay down three sources of kingship: to be born of a royal family, to be a hero, and to lead an army. If Phalguna will not fight in battle with one who is not a king, then I will consecrate this man king of the land of Anga."

Then and there, at that very moment, the great warrior Karna, glorious and mighty, was consecrated king of Anga by men who knew the mantras, on a golden throne, with golden pots of water, parched grain and flowers. With a parasol and a yak-tail fan, amid cries of victory, the king, the bull among men, said to the Kaurava king, "What can I give you, tiger among kings, to match this gift of a kingdom? Tell me, king, and I will do it."

"I want your friendship for ever," said Suyodhana.

"So be it," Karna answered. And the two of them embraced in their joy, and were very happy.

Then Adhiratha came into the arena. His upper cloth had slipped, he was sweating and trembling, and he leaned on his staff, as if calling out. When Karna saw him, he put down his bow. Bound by reverence for his father, he bowed his head to him, his head still wet from the consecration. The charioteer hurriedly covered his feet with the end of his cloth and said, "My son!", as if that said everything. Trembling with love, he embraced him, and wet his head again, still wet from the consecration as king of Anga, with his tears.

When he saw him, the Pandava Bhimasena decided that Karna was a suta's son. He said to him, as if laughing, "Suta's son, you do not deserve to die in battle at Partha's hands. Quickly, pick up a whip, as suits your family. And you do not deserve to enjoy the kingdom of Anga, lowest of men, any more than a dog deserves the sacrificial cake that lies near the fire at a sacrifice."

When Karna heard this, his lower lip trembled a little. He sighed, and looked up at the Sun in the sky.

Then mighty Duryodhana leaped up in anger from among his brothers, like a rutting elephant from a bed of lotuses. He said to Bhimasena, of terrible deeds, as he stood there, "Wolf-belly, you should not say such things. Strength is the chief thing for kshatriyas. Even a low-born kshatriya must be fought. The sources of heroes, like the sources of rivers, are hard to know, so they say. The fire that fills all that moves and all that stands rose from water. The thunderbolt that kills the danavas was made from Dadhicha's bones. The blessed god Guha, who holds all secrets, is said to be the son of Fire, the son of the Kritikas, the son of Rudra and the son of Ganga. There are famous brahmins born of kshatriya women. Our teacher was born from a pot, and Kripa, our master, from a clump of reeds. And how you yourselves were born, kings have heard too.

"How could a doe give birth to a tiger like the sun, with earrings and armour, marked with divine signs? This lord of men deserves to rule the whole earth, not just Anga, by the strength of his arms and with me to follow his orders. If there is any man who cannot bear what I have done, let him get into his chariot, or on foot, and bend his bow."

Then a great uproar went up from the whole arena, mixed with cries of approval. And the sun set.

Then Duryodhana took Karna by the hand, king, and went out of the arena, lit by torchlight. And the Pandavas, with Drona and Kripa and Bhishma, all went to their own homes, lord of the people. As the people left, some cried "Arjuna!", some "Karna!", and some "Duryodhana!", Bharata.

Kunti had recognised her son, the lord of Anga, from the divine signs on him, and in her love a hidden joy grew in her. And Duryodhana's fear of Arjuna quickly vanished, king, now that he had Karna. The hero, who had worked so hard at arms, spoke to Duryodhana in the friendliest way. And even Yudhishtira came to think that there was no archer on earth equal to Karna.

The Teacher's Fee

Then Drona called together all his pupils, every one of them, lord of the earth, and asked them for his teacher's fee. "Capture Drupada, the king of the Panchalas, at the head of his army, and bring him to me. Bless you. That will be my highest fee."

"So be it," they all said. And those fighters quickly set off in their chariots with Drona to pay their teacher's fee. The bulls among men marched on the Panchalas, killing as they went, and they crushed the city of mighty Drupada. Those bulls of the Bharatas captured Yajnasena Drupada at the head of his army, with his ministers, and brought him to Drona.

His pride was broken, his wealth taken, and he was in Drona's power. Drona, thinking of their old quarrel, said to Drupada, "I have crushed your kingdom by force and trampled your city. Your life is in your enemy's hands. Do you want our old friendship now?"

When he had said this, he laughed at him. Then he made up his mind and spoke again. "Do not be afraid for your life, king. We brahmins are forgiving. When we were boys, you played with me in the hermitage, and that made my love for you grow, bull of the kshatriyas. I ask again for your friendship, bull among men. I give you a gift, king. Take half the kingdom. A man who is not a king, it seems, cannot be the friend of a king. So I have made an effort for your kingdom, Yajnasena. You are king on the south bank of the Bhagirathi, and I am king on the north. Know that I am your friend, Panchala, if you think fit."

"This is no wonder, brahmin," said Drupada, "in great men who are brave. I am pleased with you, and I want your affection for ever."

When he said this, Drona set him free, Bharata. With a glad heart, he honoured him and gave him half the kingdom. Drupada, cast down in spirit, lived in Makandi, on the bank of the Ganga, a land full of people, and in Kampilya, the finest of cities, and ruled the southern Panchalas as far as the river Charmanvati.

But Drupada never forgot his quarrel with Drona, and it gave him no peace. He could not see how to beat him with a kshatriya's strength. He knew he was weaker than the brahmin in strength, and he longed for the birth of a son, and he held to that. And Drona took the country of Ahicchatra. So, king, the city of Ahicchatra, with its lands, was conquered in battle by Partha and handed over to Drona.

When Duryodhana saw how strong Bhimasena was, and how learned Dhananjaya, the wicked man burned with jealousy. Then Karna, the son of Vikartana, and Shakuni, Subala's son, tried to kill the Pandavas by many means. And the Pandavas, tamers of enemies, knew all about it. But they kept to Vidura's advice, and did not bring it out into the open.

When the townspeople saw how the sons of Pandu shone with every good quality, they gathered in the squares and the halls and talked about them. "Dhritarashtra, whose eyes are his wisdom, did not get the kingdom before, because he was blind. How can he be king now? And Bhishma, son of Shantanu, true to his word and his great vow, gave up the kingdom long ago. He will never take it now. So let us consecrate the eldest Pandava today, and rightly. He is young, but he has the ways of the old. He is truthful, and he knows pity. He knows dharma, and he will honour Bhishma, son of Shantanu, and

Dhritarashtra and his sons, and give them every comfort."

The wicked Duryodhana heard what they said, those people devoted to Yudhishtira, and he was sick at heart. The evil man burned and could not bear their words. Burning with jealousy, he went to Dhritarashtra. He found his father alone, bowed to him, and then, burning with the people's love for the Pandavas, he said:

"Father, I have heard the people of the city talking, and what they say bodes ill. They pass over you, and Bhishma, and want the Pandava for their lord. Bhishma agrees, for he does not want to be king. But the people in the city mean to do us the greatest harm. Pandu won the kingdom from his father by his own merits, long ago. You did not get the kingdom that came to you, because of a defect. If the Pandava gets Pandu's inheritance, his son will surely get it after him, and then that son's son, and so on. Then we and our sons will be cut out of the royal line, lord of the earth, and despised by the world. Act quickly, king, so that we do not fall for ever into hell, living on others' food. If you had held the kingdom firmly before, king, we would surely have got it, even if the people did not want us."

When he heard his son speak like this, Dhritarashtra, whose eyes were his wisdom, thought for a moment. Then he said to Duryodhana:

"Pandu always kept to dharma. He was always kind to me, and good to me, as he was to all his kinsmen, and to me above all. He hid nothing from me. I knew everything he meant to do, down to his meals. Firm in his vows, he always reported the kingdom to me. His son keeps to dharma just as Pandu did. He has every good quality, he is famous in the world, and the townspeople think well of him. How can we drive him out of his father's and grandfather's kingdom by force, when he has so many to help him? Pandu always supported the ministers and the army, and their sons and grandsons too. The people of the city were treated well by Pandu, son. Why would they not kill us and all our kin for Yudhishtira's sake?"

"I have thought of this danger myself, father," said Duryodhana. "I have seen to it that all the subjects have been won over with money and honours. They will surely be on our side, the leading men above all. The treasury and the ministers are in my hands today, lord of the earth. So you should send the Pandavas away quickly, by some gentle means, to the town of Varanavata. When the kingdom is secure in my hands, king, then Kunti will come back with her children, Bharata."

"Duryodhana," said Dhritarashtra, "this is in my heart too. But because it is wicked, I do not speak it aloud. And neither Bhishma, nor Drona, nor the steward, nor Gautama will ever allow the Kaunteyas to be sent away. To the Kauravas, son, we and they are equal. Those wise men, who keep to dharma, would not want it to be unequal. So why would the Kauravas and these great men, and the whole world, not want to put us to death, son?"

"Bhishma is always in the middle," said Duryodhana. "Drona's son is on my side. Where the son is, there Drona will be, without doubt. And Kripa, Sharadvat's son, will go where these three go. He will never leave Drona and his sister's son. The steward is bound to us by money, though secretly he is with the others. And alone he cannot stop us for the Pandavas' sake. Have no fears. Send Pandu's sons away to Varanavata with their mother, this very day. No harm will come of it. This sorrow is like a dagger planted in my heart. It is terrible, it keeps me from sleeping, and it has lit a fire of grief in me. Put it out with this deed."

Purochana

Then King Duryodhana and his brothers slowly won over all the people with gifts of money and honours. And some clever counsellors, set on by Dhritarashtra, began to talk about the lovely town of Varanavata. "A great festival of Pashupati has begun in the town of Varanavata, the loveliest on earth. It is full of every kind of jewel, a place that delights men's hearts." So they talked, at Dhritarashtra's bidding.

As they talked about lovely Varanavata, the sons of Pandu began to think of going there, king. When the king saw that their curiosity was roused, Ambika's son spoke to the Pandavas.

"My men keep telling me, again and again, that Varanavata is the loveliest town in the world. If you would like to go to the festival at Varanavata, my sons, go with your followers and your trains, and enjoy yourselves like immortals. Give jewels to the brahmins and to the singers, as many as you like, shining like gods. When you have enjoyed yourselves for a while and had your fill of pleasure, you will come back happy to this Hastinapura."

Yudhishtira understood what Dhritarashtra wanted, and he knew that he himself had no one to help him. "So be it," he answered.

Then, sadly, Yudhishtira spoke quietly to wise Bhishma and very wise Vidura, to Drona, to Bahluka, to Somadatta the Kaurava, to Kripa, to the teacher's son, and to famous Gandhari. "At Dhritarashtra's command, we are going to live with our followers in the lovely, crowded town of Varanavata. Let all of you, with kind hearts, speak words of blessing over us. Made strong by your blessings, no evil will overcome us."

When the son of Pandu said this, all the Kauravas turned to the Pandavas with kindly faces. "May you always be safe on the road, sons of Pandu, from all creatures. May no harm come to you from anywhere."

Then, when the blessings had been said, the Pandavas did all they had to do, and set out for Varanavata, for the sake of the kingdom.

When the king had spoken to the great Pandavas like this, the wicked Duryodhana was overjoyed. He took Purochana aside, bull of the Bharatas, and grasping his minister by the right hand, he said to him:

"Purochana, this earth, full of wealth, is mine. As it is mine, so it is yours. You must guard it. I have no one I trust more than you, no ally to plan with as I plan with you. Keep my counsel, friend, and root out my rivals. Do what I tell you, by some clever means.

"Dhritarashtra has sent the Pandavas to Varanavata. At his command they will enjoy the festival. You must go to Varanavata today, in a swift chariot drawn by donkeys. When you get there, have a large, costly house built, with four halls and well enclosed, backing onto the armoury. Have every kind of thing that burns brought there, hemp, resin and the rest. Mix earth with ghee, oil and plenty of lac, and have the walls plastered with it. Put hemp, bamboo, ghee, wood and all kinds of contraptions all through that house. Do it so that the Pandavas do not suspect you, even when they look closely, nor anyone else

think *This house is made to burn.*

"When the house is built, honour the Pandavas greatly and settle them there, and Kunti, with their friends. Have fine seats, carriages and beds made ready for the Pandavas, so that my father is pleased. See to everything so that they enjoy themselves in the town of Varanavata without suspicion, until the time has come round. Then, when you know that they trust you completely and are sleeping without fear, set fire to the house at its door. When they have been burned in their own house, people will say they were burned, and their kinsmen will never be able to blame us for the Pandavas."

"So be it," Purochana promised the Kaurava. And he set off for the town of Varanavata in a chariot drawn by donkeys. He went quickly, king, and keeping to Duryodhana's plan, Purochana did everything the prince had told him.

Vidura's Riddle

The Pandavas yoked their chariots with fine horses as swift as the wind. As they mounted, they clasped Bhishma's feet in sorrow, and the feet of King Dhritarashtra, of great Drona, of the other elders, of Vidura and of Kripa. So those men of strict vows bowed to all the Kuru elders. They embraced their equals, and the children bowed to them. They took leave of all the mothers, walked round them with respect, and took leave of all the people. Then they set out for Varanavata.

Wise Vidura, the other bulls of the Kurus and the townspeople followed the tigers among men, worn thin with grief. There some of the brahmins spoke out fearlessly, deeply grieved for the sons of Pandu, bull of the Bharatas.

"The king does not see straight," they said. "He is lost in darkness. Dhritarashtra's mind is wicked, and he has no eye for dharma. The sinless Pandava will never take to wrongdoing, nor Bhima, the strongest of the strong, nor Kunti's son Dhananjaya. How much less would Madri's two wise sons? Dhritarashtra cannot bear that they should have the kingdom that came to them from their father. How can Bhishma allow such a wrong, when the Kaunteyas, bulls of the Bharatas, are sent away for no reason? Shantanu's son Vichitravirya, the royal seer, was like a father to us, and so was Pandu, the joy of the Kurus. Now that tiger among men has gone the way of fate, and Dhritarashtra cannot bear these young princes. We cannot bear it either. Let us all leave our homes in this finest of cities and go where Yudhishtira goes."

Yudhishtira, the king of dharma, was worn thin with grief himself. But he was deeply moved, and he said to the grieving townspeople, "The king, the lord of the earth, is our father, to be honoured, our teacher and our elder. Whatever he says, we must do without suspicion. That is our vow. You are our friends. Walk round us, bless us, and go back to your homes. When there is something we need from you, then you will do what is dear and good to me."

"So be it," they promised. They walked round them, blessed them, and went back to the city.

When the townspeople had turned back, Vidura, who knew every dharma, spoke to the eldest Pandava to warn him. The wise man, who knew the talk of riddles, spoke to the wise one, seeing clearly what dharma and prudence required.

"A man who understands this should act so as to escape danger. There is a sharp weapon, not made of iron, that cuts the body. Enemies cannot kill the man who knows it, for he knows how to ward it off. The eater of dry grass and the destroyer of cold does not burn the creature that lives in a hole in the great thicket. The man who protects himself like that lives. A man without eyes does not know the road. A man without eyes does not find the directions. A man without steadiness does not win good fortune. You have been warned. Understand. A man may take a weapon not made of iron from those he cannot trust. The porcupine escapes the fire by going into its burrow. By wandering, a man comes to know the paths. By the stars he finds his directions. He who masters his five by himself is not overcome."

When he had instructed them and gone some way with them, Vidura walked round them, gave the Pandavas leave to go, and went home.

When Vidura, Bhishma and the townspeople had turned back, Kunti spoke to Ajatashatru. "The steward said something in the middle of the crowd, as if he were not saying it, and you answered 'So be it.' We did not understand it. If we may hear it, and there is no harm in it, I want to hear all that passed between you and him."

"Vidura told me to beware of poison and of fire," said Yudhishtira. "He said that no road should be unknown to us. And he said that if I master my senses I will win the earth. I told Vidura that I had understood it all."

They set out on the eighth day of Phalguna, under the constellation Rohini. And when they reached Varanavata, they saw the people of the town.

When they heard that the Pandavas had come, all the people of the town of Varanavata, with every lucky sign, as the books lay down, eagerly came out to meet the best of men, in thousands, in every kind of carriage, full of joy. The people of Varanavata came up to the Kaunteyas, cried blessings of victory over them, and stood round them. Surrounded by them, Yudhishtira, the king of dharma, the tiger among men, shone like a god, like Indra with the thunderbolt in his hand among the immortals.

The sinless ones were honoured by the townspeople, and they honoured them in turn. Then they entered crowded Varanavata, decked out for them. When the heroes had entered the town, they went quickly to the houses of the brahmins who were devoted to their duties, lord of the earth. The best of men visited the houses of the town's officers, and of the chariot fighters, and the houses of the vaishyas and shudras too.

When the townsfolk had honoured them, the Pandavas, bulls of the Bharatas, went to their lodging, with Purochana leading the way. Purochana gave them food, drink and delicacies, fine beds and the best seats. They stayed there, honoured by him, with very costly furnishings, waited on by the people of the town.

When they had stayed there ten nights, Purochana told them about the house called Auspicious, which was not auspicious. At Purochana's word the tigers among men went into it with their household, like guhyakas going into Kailasa.

But Yudhishtira, who knew every dharma, looked the house over, and said to Bhimasena, "It is made to burn. I can smell fat, gentle brother, and ghee mixed with lac. This house has clearly been built to burn, tamer of enemies. Hemp and resin have plainly been brought in to build it. The grass, the rushes, the bamboo and everything are soaked in ghee. It has been built well by trusted craftsmen, skilled in building. This wicked Purochana wants to burn me when I trust him. Vidura, the wise, saw this danger then, Partha, and that is why he warned me before. We have been warned by him, and we know the house is evil. It has been built by skilled men in secret, obeying Duryodhana."

"If you think this house is made to burn," said Bhima, "let us go back to where we were staying before."

"I think we should stay here," said Yudhishtira, "on our guard, showing nothing, as if we were lost, while we look for a sure way to get out. If Purochana sees any sign in us, he will act quickly and burn us even by force. Purochana has no fear of blame or of wrongdoing. That is how the fool behaves, keeping to Suyodhana's plan."

"And if we were burned here, would our grandfather Bhishma be angry? Why would he anger the Kauravas? Perhaps he and the other bulls of the Kurus would be angry for dharma's sake. But if we ran away for fear of burning, Suyodhana, greedy for the kingdom, would have us all killed by his spies. He is in power and we are not. He has allies and we have none. He has a great treasury and we have nothing. He would surely have us killed by his schemes.

"So we must deceive this wicked man, and wicked Suyodhana too, and live in hiding here and there. We will go about the earth as hunters. Then, if we have to flee, we will know the paths. And today we will dig a tunnel in the ground, well hidden. If we keep our breathing hidden there, the fire will not burn us. We must work tirelessly, so that neither Purochana nor any of the townspeople knows that we are living here like this."

Chapter 58

The Fire

A friend of Vidura's, a skilled miner, came to the Pandavas in private, king, and said, "Vidura has sent me. I am a very skilled miner. He said, 'Do the Pandavas a service.' What can I do for you? Vidura told me in secret, 'Win the Pandavas' trust, and do them good there.' What can I do for you?"

"On the fourteenth night of the dark fortnight, Purochana will set fire to the door of your house. The Pandavas, the bulls among men, are to be burned with their mother. That is what Dhritarashtra's son has decided, Partha. I have heard it. And Vidura said something to you in mleccha speech, Pandava, and you said to him, 'So be it.' Let that be the sign by which you trust me."

Kunti's son Yudhishtira, steadfast in truth, answered him. "I know you, gentle friend, for a friend of Vidura's, honest and trusted and dear to him, always firm in your loyalty. The wise man has no need of a sign. As he is to us, so are you to us. We make no difference between you. We are yours as we are his. Protect us, as the wise man would.

"I believe this refuge is made to burn, and made for me. Purochana built it at the command of Dhritarashtra's son. That wicked, evil-minded man has a treasury and allies, and the villain troubles us all the time. So save us from this fire, with all your skill. If we are burned here, Suyodhana will have what he wants. This is the well-stocked armoury of that wicked man. This great house has been built up against it, at the edge of the rampart, so that there is no escape. This is surely the evil deed he meant to do. Vidura knew of it from the start, and so he warned us. This is the danger the steward saw long ago. Get us out without Purochana knowing."

"So be it," the miner promised, and he set to work. Clearing out a moat, he made a very large tunnel. In the middle of the house he made its mouth, not very wide, fitted with a door, hidden and level with the ground, Bharata. For fear of Purochana he kept the mouth covered, for that evil-minded man always lived at the door of the house.

The Pandavas spent their nights there with their weapons, king, and by day they went hunting from forest to forest. They trusted no one, but they seemed to trust. They were deeply unhappy, but they seemed content, king, deceiving Purochana. The people of the town knew nothing of them, except that best of miners, Vidura's friend.

When Purochana saw them living there happily for a whole year, seeming to trust him, he was delighted. And when he saw Purochana so pleased, Kunti's son Yudhishtira, who knew dharma, said to Bhimasena, Arjuna and the twins:

"This wicked Purochana thinks we trust him completely. The cruel man has been deceived. I think it is time to run. Let us set fire to the armoury, burn Purochana, leave six living beings here, and escape without being seen."

Then Kunti, on the pretext of giving gifts, gave a great feast for brahmins one night, king, and women came to it. When they had enjoyed themselves, eaten and drunk as they liked, Bharata, they took leave of the lady of the Madhavas and went home that night. But by chance a Nishada woman with five sons came to the feast looking for food, driven by Time, with her sons. She drank wine and was drunk, and with all her sons, king,

reeling from drink, she fell asleep in that very house, senseless, like the dead, lord of men.

Then, when everyone was asleep and a strong wind was blowing in the night, Bhima set fire to the place where Purochana was sleeping. A great heat and the roar of the fire rose up, and with it the crowd of people woke.

"This house was built by that wicked, witless man at Duryodhana's bidding," cried the townspeople, "and he has burned it, to his own destruction. Shame on Dhritarashtra, whose mind is so crooked! He has had the pure young Pandavas burned by his minister. But by good fortune the wicked, evil-minded man has been burned too, who burned these innocent best of men when they trusted him."

So the people of Varanavata lamented. And they stood round the house on every side all night.

But the Pandavas and their mother, in deep distress, came out through the tunnel, king, and went away in secret, unseen. They were held back by lack of sleep and by fear, and the tamers of enemies could not move fast with their mother. But Bhimasena, lord of kings, whose speed and courage were terrible, went on, carrying all his brothers and his mother. The mighty man put his mother on his shoulder and the twins on his hips, and took the two strong Parthas by the hands. Breaking the trees with his speed and splitting the earth with his feet, splendid Wolf-belly went on fast, as swift as the wind.

Bhima Keeps Watch

When the night was over, all the people of the town came hurrying to see the sons of Pandu. As they put out the fire, they saw that the house of lac had burned down, and the minister Purochana with it. "This was surely done by the wicked Duryodhana to destroy the Pandavas," the people cried. "There is no doubt Dhritarashtra's son burned Pandu's heirs with Dhritarashtra's knowledge, for he did not stop him. Surely Bhishma, son of Shantanu, does not follow dharma, nor Drona, nor Vidura, nor Kripa, nor the other Kauravas. Let us send word to the wicked Dhritarashtra: 'Your great wish has come true. You have burned the Pandavas.'"

Then, as they cleared away the fire looking for the Pandavas, they saw the innocent Nishada woman burned, with her five sons. And the same miner, while cleaning the house, had covered the tunnel with earth, so that those men did not see it.

Then the townspeople sent word to Dhritarashtra that the Pandavas had been burned in the fire, and the minister Purochana. When King Dhritarashtra heard that terrible news, the death of Pandu's sons, he wept in deep grief. "Today King Pandu has died, my brother, so hard to find, now that those heroes have been burned, and their mother with them. Let men go quickly to the town of Varanavata. Let them give due honour to those heroes and to the daughter of King Kuntibhoja. Let them build fine large pools for them. And let the friends of those who died there honour them too. Whatever good I can have done, now that this has happened, for the Pandavas and for Kunti, let all of it be done, with wealth."

When he had said this, Dhritarashtra, Ambika's son, surrounded by his kinsmen, offered water to the sons of Pandu. All the Kauravas cried aloud, lost in grief. But Vidura grieved only a little, for he knew better.

The Pandavas, meanwhile, came out of the town of Varanavata and went fast, king, heading south. They found their way by the stars in the night, facing south, and with great effort, king, they reached a deep forest. Then, tired, thirsty and blind with sleep, the sons of Pandu spoke again to mighty Bhimasena.

"What could be harder than this? We are in a deep forest, we do not know which way to go, and we cannot go on. And we do not know whether that wicked Purochana was burned. How can we escape this danger without being seen? Carry us again, Bharata, as before. You alone are strong, like the ever-moving wind."

When the king of dharma said this to him, mighty Bhimasena took up Kunti and his brothers and went on quickly. As he strode on fast, the wind stirred by the force of his thighs blew, king, as it blows at the start of the hot months. He crushed the trees in flower and in fruit, and tore up the wooded thickets near his path. So, breaking the trees, he went on with boundless strength, and at his speed the Pandavas nearly fainted. Many times he crossed rivers with far banks, using his arms as rafts, and on the way they went in hiding, for fear of Dhritarashtra's sons. With difficulty he carried his mother alone, delicate and famous, on his back, over rough river banks.

In the evening the bulls of the Bharatas came to a stretch of forest with few roots, fruits or water, full of cruel birds and beasts, a terrible place. A fearful dusk came on. The beasts and birds were fierce. The directions were dark, and unseasonable winds

blew. The Kuru princes were worn out with weariness and thirst, and overcome with sleep, and they could go no further.

Then Bhima went into the vast, terrible, empty forest and came to a lovely banyan tree with wide shade. There he set them all down, and the bull of the Bharatas said, "I will look for water here. Rest. These water birds, the cranes, are calling sweetly. I am sure there is a great lake here."

"Go," said his eldest brother, Bharata, and he went where the water birds were calling. He drank water there, and bathed, bull of the Bharatas, and he brought water back in his upper cloth, king. He came quickly back to his mother from a distance of two miles. When he saw his mother and his brothers asleep on the ground, Wolf-belly was stricken with grief and wept.

"They could not sleep before on costly beds in Varanavata, and now they sleep on the ground. Look at Kunti, lying on the earth today, the sister of Vasudeva, the crusher of hosts of enemies, the daughter of Kuntibhoja, honoured for every lucky mark, the daughter-in-law of Vichitravirya, the wife of great Pandu. She was always used to a bed in a palace, as radiant as the inside of a lotus. She is the most delicate of women, fit for the costliest bed. Look at her lying here on the ground, where she does not belong. She bore these sons to Dharma, to Indra and to the Wind, and she lies here on the ground, worn out, where she does not belong. What sadder sight could I see than this, when I see these tigers among men sleeping on the ground today?

"The king, who knows dharma, deserves to rule the three worlds. How can he lie here on the ground, worn out, like a common man? This one, dark as a rain cloud, has no equal among men on earth, and he sleeps on the ground like a common man. What could be sadder than this? These two, who are like the Ashvins among the gods for beauty, are asleep today on the earth like common men.

"The man who has no crooked kinsmen to shame his family lives happily in the world, like a single tree in a village. A single tree in a village, with leaves and fruit, becomes a shrine, and since it has no kin, it is worshipped and honoured. And those who have many brave kinsmen who keep to dharma live happily in the world, free from sickness. Strong and prosperous, delighting their friends and kin, they live leaning on one another, like trees that grow in a forest. But we have been driven out by wicked Dhritarashtra and his son, and only just escaped burning at his command. We have escaped the fire and taken shelter under this tree. We have come to the utmost hardship. Which way shall we go?

"I can see a town not far from this forest. They are asleep, and someone must keep awake. I will keep awake myself. They will drink the water afterwards, when they wake and their weariness has gone."

So Bhima made up his mind, and he kept watch himself.

Hidimba

While they slept there, a rakshasa named Hidimba was sitting in a sal tree not far from the forest. He was cruel, an eater of human flesh, of great courage and great strength, ugly in shape, with yellow eyes, fanged and fearful to look at. Hungry, and longing for meat, he saw them by chance. With his fingers raised, scratching and shaking his rough hair, yawning with his huge mouth, he looked at them again and again. The wicked man-eater, huge and mighty, smelled the smell of men, and said to his sister:

"At last, after so long, food I love has come to me. My mouth is running with juices, and my tongue is licking round it. I will sink my eight sharp fangs, which nothing can withstand for long, into their bodies and their soft flesh. I will spring on a man's throat and tear open the artery and drink his blood, hot, fresh and frothing, in plenty. Go and find out who these are, sleeping here in the forest. The strong smell of men is filling my nose. Kill all these men and bring them to me. They are asleep in our country, and you have nothing to fear from them. We will cook the flesh of these men as we like and eat it together. Do as I say, quickly."

At her brother's words the rakshasi went quickly, bull of the Bharatas, to where the Pandavas were. When she got there she saw the Pandavas asleep with Pritha, and unconquerable Bhimasena awake. As soon as the rakshasi saw Bhimasena, towering like a young sal tree, beautiful beyond anyone on earth, she desired him.

This dark, strong-armed man with shoulders like a lion's, shining, with a neck like a conch and eyes like lotuses, would make me a fitting husband. I will never do my brother's cruel bidding. A woman's love for her husband is far stronger than her bond with her brother. If I killed these men, my brother and I would be satisfied for a moment. If I do not, I will be happy for years without end.

She could take any shape she liked. So she took on the finest human form and came slowly up to strong-armed Bhimasena. Like a shy creeper, decked in heavenly ornaments, she smiled and said to Bhimasena:

"Where have you come from, bull among men, and who are you? Who are these men sleeping here, who look like gods? And who is this tall, dark, delicate lady of yours, sinless one, sleeping as safely in this forest as if she were in her own house? She does not know that this deep forest is the haunt of rakshasas. A wicked rakshasa named Hidimba lives here. My brother, the rakshasa, meaning you harm, sent me, for he wants to eat your flesh, you who are like an immortal. But when I saw you, shining like a child of the gods, I wanted no other husband. I tell you the truth. Now that you know this, you who know dharma, do right by me. My heart and body are struck with love. I love you. Love me. I will save you from the man-eating rakshasa, strong-armed one. We will live in the mountain strongholds. Be my husband, sinless one. I can travel through the sky and go wherever I wish. Find joy without equal with me, here and there."

"Rakshasi," said Bhima, "who would leave his mother, his elder brother and these younger ones here, even if he had the power? What man like me would go off, sick with desire, and leave his sleeping brothers and his mother as food for a rakshasa?"

"I will do whatever pleases you," said the rakshasi. "Wake them all. I will save you all, if you like, from the man-eating rakshasa."

"I will not wake my brothers and my mother, rakshasi," said Bhima, "while they sleep peacefully in the forest, for fear of your wicked brother. Timid one, no rakshasas can stand up to my courage, nor men, nor gandharvas, nor yakshas, lovely-eyed one. Go or stay, good lady, or do whatever you like. Or send your brother the man-eater, slender one."

When Hidimba, lord of the rakshasas, saw that his sister had been gone a long time, he came down from the tree and went to the Pandavas. His eyes were red, his arms strong, his hair on end. He was mighty, his body like a mass of clouds, his face blazing with sharp fangs.

As soon as she saw him coming, so hideous to look at, Hidimba said to Bhimasena in fear, "Here comes the wicked man-eater, in a rage. Do what I tell you, with your brothers. I can go where I will, hero, and I have a rakshasa's strength. Climb up on my hips and I will carry you through the sky. Wake these sleepers and your mother, tamer of enemies. I will take you all and go through the sky."

"Do not be afraid, you of the wide hips," said Bhima. "He is nothing while I am here. I will kill him before your eyes, slender-waisted one. This low rakshasa is no match for me in battle, timid one, nor are all the rakshasas together. Look at my arms, well rounded, like elephants' trunks. Look at my thighs, like iron bars, and my broad, solid chest. Today you will see my courage, which is like Indra's, lovely one. Do not despise me, you of the wide hips, thinking I am only a man."

"I do not despise you, tiger among men," said Hidimba. "You look like a god. But I have seen what the rakshasa does to men."

As Bhimasena was talking like this, Bharata, the angry man-eating rakshasa heard his words. And Hidimba looked at his sister's human body: her hair wreathed with garlands, her face like the full moon, her fine brows, nose, eyes and hairline, her delicate nails and skin, decked with every ornament, dressed in the finest cloth. When he saw her wearing that lovely human form, the man-eater suspected that she wanted a man, and he was furious. In his rage against his sister, best of the Kurus, the rakshasa opened his wide eyes and said to her:

"What fool is standing in my way when I want to eat? Are you so bewildered, Hidimba, that you are not afraid of my anger? Shame on you, you faithless, man-hungry woman, doing me this harm, disgracing all the rakshasa lords before us. You have taken the side of these men and done me a great wrong. I will kill them all today, and you with them."

When the red-eyed rakshasa had said this to his sister, he sprang at her to kill her, gnashing his teeth. As he rushed at her, Bhima, the best of fighters, saw him. The splendid man shouted at him, "Stop! Stop!"

Bhimasena looked at the rakshasa, furious with his sister, and said, as if laughing, "What will you gain, Hidimba, by waking these people who are sleeping so sweetly? Come at me, fool, man-eater, as hard as you can. Strike at me. You should not kill a woman, least of all when she has done no wrong, when it is someone else who has wronged you. This girl is not in her own power, loving me here. She is driven by the bodiless god of love, who moves inside the body, your sister, fool, you disgrace to the rakshasas. She saw my looks when you sent her, and now the timid girl loves me. She does not disgrace

your family. Love is to blame, rakshasa. While I stand here, wicked one, you should not kill a woman. Come, man-eater, one against one. I will send you to the house of Yama today. Today let your head be crushed by the force of my hand, rakshasa, as if trampled by the foot of a mighty elephant. Today let the eaters of flesh, hawks and jackals, drag your limbs gladly over the ground, when I have killed you in battle. In a moment I will clear this forest of the thorn that has always spoiled it, eating men. Today, wicked one, your sister will see you dragged along the ground by me, big as a mountain, like a great elephant dragged by a lion. When I have killed you, you disgrace to the rakshasas, the men who roam the forest will go about this forest unharmed."

"What use is your roaring and your boasting, man?" said Hidimba. "Do it all, then boast. Do not waste time. You think yourself strong and brave. When you meet me today, you will know I am the stronger. I will not hurt these others yet. Let them sleep in peace. I will kill you first, you fool with your hateful tongue. I will drink the blood from your limbs, and after that I will kill them too, and then this girl who has wronged me."

With that the man-eater raised his arm and ran at Bhimasena in a rage. As he rushed in, Bhima, of terrible courage, caught the arm he struck with, laughing. Holding him by force as he writhed, Bhima dragged him eight bow-lengths from that place, as a lion drags a small deer. Then the rakshasa, caught by force by the Pandava, flew into a rage. He threw his arms round Bhimasena and roared a terrible roar. Again mighty Bhima dragged him away by force, so that the noise would not reach his sleeping brothers. They grappled each other and dragged each other with great force, the rakshasa and Bhimasena, and they showed the greatest courage. They broke great trees and tore down creepers, like two sixty-year-old elephants in rut, full of fury.

At the great noise they made, those bulls among men woke up with their mother. And they saw Hidimba standing in front of them.

Ghatotkacha

When they woke and saw Hidimba's more than human beauty, the tigers among men were amazed, and so was Pritha. Kunti looked at her, marvelling at her beauty, and spoke to her gently, sweetly and kindly. "Whose are you, you who shine like a child of the gods, and who are you, lovely one? Why have you come, and from where? If you are the goddess of this forest, or an apsaras, tell me all of it, and why you are standing here."

"This great forest you see, dark as a blue cloud," said Hidimba, "is the home of the rakshasa Hidimba, and my home. Know that I am the sister of that lord of the rakshasas, noble lady. My brother sent me here, for he wanted to kill you and your sons. I came here at the word of that cruel-minded one, and I saw your mighty son, who shines like gold. Then love, which moves within all beings, drove me, good lady, and I came under the power of your son. So I chose your mighty son for my husband. I tried to carry him off, but I could not. When he saw that I was taking a long time, the man-eater came himself to kill all your sons. And your son, my beloved, the wise, great-hearted one, crushed him by force and dragged him away from here. Look at them, man and rakshasa, dragging each other, roaring at each other, showing their courage in battle."

As soon as they heard her words, Yudhishtira leaped up, and Arjuna, Nakula and mighty Sahadeva. They saw the two locked together, dragging each other, each longing for victory, like two lions mad for battle. Hugging each other and dragging each other, they raised a cloud of dust from the earth like the smoke of a forest fire. Covered in the dust of the earth, like mountains, they shone like two peaks wrapped in mist.

When Partha saw Bhima being hard pressed by the rakshasa, he said to him quietly, as if smiling, "Bhima, do not be afraid, strong-armed one. We did not know you were fighting this terrible creature. We were asleep, worn out. I am here to help you, Partha. I will fight the rakshasa. Nakula and Sahadeva will guard our mother."

"Stand aside and watch," said Bhima. "There is no need for you to rush in. Now that he has come between my arms, he will not live."

"Why let this wicked rakshasa live so long, Bhima?" said Arjuna. "We must go. We cannot stay here long, tamer of enemies. Kill him before the east grows red, before the twilight comes. In that cruel hour the rakshasas grow strong. Hurry, Bhima. Stop playing. Kill this terrible rakshasa before he works his magic. Put all the strength of your arms into it."

At Arjuna's words, Bhima lifted up the body of the terrible rakshasa and quickly whirled it round a hundred times. "You were fattened for nothing on flesh got for nothing," said Bhima. "You grew for nothing, and your mind was for nothing. You deserve a death for nothing, and today you will be nothing."

"Or, if you find this rakshasa a burden in battle," said Arjuna, "I will help you. Let him be killed quickly. Or let me kill him myself, Wolf-belly. You have done your work and you are tired. Rest a while."

When Bhimasena heard this, he flew into a rage. He crushed the rakshasa to the ground by force and killed him as one kills a beast for sacrifice. As Bhima killed him, he roared a huge roar that filled the whole forest, like a drum wet with water. The mighty son of

Pandu locked him in his arms, broke him in the middle, and gladdened the Pandavas.

When they saw Hidimba dead, the fierce brothers were delighted, and they honoured Bhimasena, the tiger among men, the tamer of enemies. When they had honoured great Bhima of the terrible courage, Arjuna spoke to Wolf-belly again. "I think there is a town not far from this forest, lord. Let us go quickly, bless you, so that Suyodhana does not find us."

"So be it," they all said. And the tigers among men, the tamers of enemies, set off with their mother, and Hidimba the rakshasi went too.

"Rakshasas remember a quarrel," said Bhima, "and use their bewildering magic. Hidimba, go the way your brother went."

"Even in anger, tiger among men," said Yudhishtira, "do not kill a woman, Bhima. Guard dharma, Pandava, above guarding your life. You killed the mighty one who came meaning to kill. What can his sister do to us, even if she is angry?"

Then Hidimba bowed to Kunti with joined hands, and said to her and to Yudhishtira, Kunti's son, "Noble lady, you know the pain that love brings to women in this world. That pain has come to me, good lady, because of Bhimasena. I have borne that terrible pain, waiting for my time. Now my time has come, and it will bring me happiness. I have left my friends, my own dharma and my own people, and chosen your son, this tiger among men, as my husband, good lady. Yet when I spoke as I did, I was refused by this fine man, and by you too, famous lady. Think me a fool, or think me devoted and faithful, great lady, but join me with this husband, your son. Let me take him, who looks like a god, and go where I will. And I will come back. Trust me, good lady. When you think of me, I will come and carry you all wherever you want. I will bring you, bulls among men, through dangers and hard places. I will carry you on my back when you want to go fast. Be kind to me, and let Bhimasena love me.

"To come through a danger, a man should keep himself alive by every means. Whoever follows dharma must do all he can to that end. He who holds to dharma in times of danger is the best of those who know dharma. For those who keep dharma, a danger is a trial of their dharma. Merit keeps a man alive. Merit, they say, is the giver of life. There is no blame in the means by which a man practises dharma."

"It is as you say, Hidimba," said Yudhishtira. "There is no doubt of it. But you must keep to dharma as I tell you, slender-waisted one. Every day, good lady, when he has bathed, said his prayers and been blessed, you may have Bhimasena, until the sun sets. Enjoy yourself with him by day as you like, swift as thought. But you must always bring Bhimasena back at night."

"So be it," promised Hidimba the rakshasi. And she took Bhimasena and rose into the sky.

On lovely mountain peaks and in the shrines of the gods, ringing with the calls of beasts and birds, always delightful, she took on the most beautiful form, decked with every ornament. Talking sweetly, she gave the Pandava pleasure. So too in forest thickets, on slopes of flowering trees, by lovely lakes with lotuses and water lilies, on river islands and beaches of beryl sand, by forest pools with fine bathing places and by mountain streams, on the shores of the ocean strewn with gems and gold, in lovely towns and great forests of sal, in the holy groves of the gods and on the mountain

slopes, in the homes of the guhyakas and the retreats of ascetics, by the Manasa lakes, with the fruits and flowers of every season, she wore her most beautiful form and gave the Pandava pleasure.

Giving Bhima pleasure here and there, swift as thought, the rakshasi bore a mighty son to Bhimasena. He had strange eyes, a huge mouth and ears like arrowheads. He was terrible to look at, with coppery lips and sharp fangs, very strong. He was a great archer, very brave, of great spirit and great arms, very swift, huge in body, and a master of great magic, a tamer of enemies. He was not human, though born of a human, of terrible speed and great strength. He surpassed the pishachas and all other beings, and men too. Though a child, he reached his youth among men at once, lord of the people. The mighty hero became supreme in all weapons. For rakshasa women conceive and give birth on the same day, and they take any shape they like, and many shapes.

The great archer, bald, bowed and clasped his father's feet and his mother's, and they named him. He said to his mother, "My pot is bare," and so his name became Ghatotkacha, Pot-bare. And Ghatotkacha was devoted to the Pandavas, and they always loved him, and he became one of them.

"Our time together is over," Hidimba said to Bhima. And, having made an agreement, she went her own way. "When there is work to be done, I will come to my fathers," said Ghatotkacha, the best of rakshasas. Then he took his leave and set out for the north. He had been created by great Indra for the sake of the spear, to destroy Karna, whose courage was matchless.

From forest to forest the heroes went, killing many herds of deer, hurrying away, king, the great warriors. Passing through the lands of the Matsyas, the Trigartas, the Panchalas and the Kichakas, looking at lovely stretches of forest and lakes, they all wore their hair matted and dressed in bark and deerskin. With Kunti, the great men took on the look of ascetics. Sometimes they carried their mother, hurrying, the great warriors, and sometimes they walked at their ease, and then pressed on again. Reciting the Veda of Brahman, all the limbs of the Veda and the books of statecraft, those men who knew dharma saw their grandfather.

They bowed to great Krishna Dvaipayana, and stood before him with joined hands, the tamers of enemies, with their mother.

"I knew of this beforehand in my mind, bulls of the Bharatas," said Vyasa, "how you were driven out, wrongly, by Dhritarashtra's sons. Knowing it, I have come to do you the greatest good. Do not despair at this. All of it is for your happiness. They and you are all the same to me, without doubt. But kinsmen show more love to those who are in need and to those who are young. So my love for you is greater now. Out of love I want to do you good. Listen. Here, near by, is a lovely, healthy town. Live here in hiding, and wait for me to come."

When he had comforted the Parthas, the tamers of enemies, like this, Vyasa went with them to Ekachakra, and the lord comforted Kunti. "Mother of living sons, this son of yours, Yudhishtira, the son of Dharma, the king of dharma, will rule all the kings of the earth. He knows dharma and is master of himself. He will win the whole earth by dharma, and enjoy it through the strength of Bhimasena and Arjuna, without doubt. Your sons and Madri's, all great warriors, will enjoy themselves in their own kingdom, happy at heart. When they have conquered this earth, the tigers among men will offer the royal

consecration, the horse sacrifice and other rites, with rich gifts. Favouring their friends with wealth and comfort, your sons will enjoy their fathers' and grandfathers' kingdom here."

When he had said this and settled them in a brahmin's house, the seer Dvaipayana said to the best of kings, "Wait for me here. I will come back. When you know the time and place, you will find great joy."

"So be it," they all said to him, with joined hands, lord of men. And the blessed seer Vyasa went where he wished.

The Brahmin's House

"When the sons of Kunti, those great warriors, had come to Ekachakra," asked Janamejaya, "what did the Pandavas do next, best of brahmins?"

When the sons of Kunti, the great warriors, had come to Ekachakra, they lived for a while in a brahmin's house. They went about seeing lovely forests of many kinds, and royal lands, rivers and lakes. They all went out begging for alms, lord of the people, and the townspeople grew fond of them for their good qualities. Every night they brought their alms to Kunti, and they each ate the portion she divided out for them. The heroes ate half with their mother, the tamers of enemies, and mighty Bhima ate the other half of all the alms.

So the great men lived there, king, and a long time went by, till of the Bharatas. Then one day, when the bulls of the Bharatas had gone begging, Bhimasena happened to stay there with Pritha. Then Kunti heard a great, terrible cry of pain rise up in the brahmin's house, Bharata. As she heard them all weeping and lamenting, the queen could not bear it, king, for she was kind and good. With her heart churned up by grief, gentle Pritha spoke to Bhima full of pity.

"We live very happily in this brahmin's house, son, unknown to Dhritarashtra's sons, honoured and free from care. I am always thinking, son, what I could do for this brahmin that would please him, as people do when they have lived happily in someone's house. A man is worth as much as the good done to him is not lost on him. However much another does for him, he should do more in return. Surely some grief has come upon this brahmin. If we could help him in it, it would be a good deed."

"Find out what his grief is," said Bhima, "and where it comes from. When I know, I will set about it, however hard it may be."

As they were talking, lord of the people, they heard again the cry of pain from the brahmin and his wife. Then Kunti hurried into the inner rooms of that good brahmin, like a cow whose calf is tied up. There she saw the brahmin with his wife, his son and his daughter, his face twisted with grief.

"Shame on this life in the world," said the brahmin. "It has no pith and no point. Its root is sorrow. It belongs to others, and it is full of what we hate. Life is the greatest sorrow. Life is the greatest fever. For anyone living, the pairs of opposites are sure to come. A single man cannot pursue dharma, wealth and desire together, and to be parted from them is thought the greatest sorrow. Some say that freedom is the highest thing, but it is not to be had at all. When wealth is won, the whole of hell comes with it. Longing for wealth is great sorrow. Having it is greater. And when a man has grown fond of his wealth, losing it is greater still."

"I see no way to escape this danger, or to flee with my son and wife to safety. I tried before, as you know, brahmin wife, to go where it was safe. But you would not listen to me. 'I was born here and grew up here, and my father lived here,' you said, you foolish woman, when I begged you again and again. Your old father went to heaven long ago, and your mother too, and the kin you had are gone. What joy was there in living here? You wanted your kin, and would not listen to me, and now the loss of our kin has come, which grieves me terribly. Or rather, it is my own death, for I could never give up any of my

kin and live on myself, like a cruel man.

"You are my partner in dharma, self-controlled, always like a mother to me. The gods made you my friend and my highest refuge. My mother and father chose you, and you share my householder's life. I chose you rightly and married you with mantras. You are of good family and good character, the mother of my children, a good woman who has never harmed me, always devoted to me. I could never give you up, my wife, to save my life.

"How then could I give up my daughter myself, a child not yet grown, whose body has not yet shown the signs of womanhood? The great Ordainer placed her in my keeping for her husband. Through her I hope for the worlds that come through a daughter's sons, with my ancestors. I fathered her myself. How could I give up this child? Some men think a father loves his son more, but not his daughter. To me they are equal. In her the worlds, our line and our happiness rest for ever. How could I give up this innocent child?

"If I gave up my own life and went into the power of the dead, I would still grieve. For if I leave these, they will surely not be able to live here. To give up any one of them would be cruel, and the wise condemn it. And if I give up myself, they will die without me. I have fallen into great trouble and cannot cross this danger. Alas! Where shall I turn today with my family? It would be better to die with them all. I cannot bear to live."

"You must not grieve at all," said the brahmin's wife, "like a common man. This is no time for grief, for a learned man like you. All men must die in this world. Where something must be, there is no place for grief. A wife, a son, a daughter: all are wanted for one's own sake. Put away your distress with your good sense. I will go there myself.

"This is a woman's highest duty in the world, the eternal one: to give up even her life and do what is good for her husband. What I do there will bring you happiness here, and it will be undying for me in the other world, and bring me fame in this one. And this is the weighty dharma I will tell you. There is more gain for you in it, and more dharma. The purpose for which a man wants a wife you have gained through me: a daughter and a son. You have freed me of my debt. You can feed and protect the children. I could not feed and protect them as you can.

"Without you, every hope I have would turn to disaster. How would our two little children live, and how would I? How could I, a widow with no protector and small children, keep the two of them alive without you, and stay on the path the good walk? How could I guard this daughter of yours, when proud, arrogant men who are not fit to be your kin come asking for her? As birds go after a piece of meat thrown on the ground, so all men go after a woman who has lost her husband. Harassed and pestered by wicked men, I could not keep to the path that good people love, best of brahmins.

"How could I set this one girl of your family, still unmarried, on the path of her fathers and grandfathers? How could I give this boy the qualities we want, with no protector and everything lost, as you would, who see dharma so clearly? Unworthy men will despise me, having no protector, and ask for your daughter too, as shudras ask to hear the Veda. If I did not want to give her, when she has your qualities, they would seize her by force, like crows snatching the offering from a sacrifice. Seeing your son unlike yourself, and your daughter in the power of unworthy men, despised by the world,

not knowing myself, I would surely die at the hands of proud men, brahmin. And without me and without you, my two children would surely perish, like fish when the water dries up. Without you, all three of us will surely perish. So you should let me go.

"For women, the highest blessing is to go before their husband, brahmin, not to live on under their sons. I have given up this son, and this daughter, and my kin, and my life, for you. For a woman, always standing by what is dear and good to her husband is better than sacrifices, austerities, vows and gifts of every kind. What I want to do is in keeping with dharma and highly thought of, dear and good for you and for the family.

"Good people hold that children, wealth, dear friends and a wife too are there to free a man from danger. The whole family on one side and a man himself on the other are not equal. That is the settled view of the wise. So do your work through me. Save yourself by me. Give me leave, noble one, and look after my children.

"Those who know dharma say that women must not be killed, when they settle questions of dharma. They say the rakshasas know dharma. Perhaps he will not kill me either. For men, death is certain. For women it is uncertain. So you should send me, you who know dharma. I have enjoyed life. I have had what I loved. I have practised dharma. I have had your children, whom I love. Death will not grieve me. I have borne children, I am old, and I have always wanted to please you. I have thought all this through, and so I have made up my mind. When you have given me up, noble one, you will find another wife. Then your dharma will be established again. It is no wrong for a man to have many wives, good man. But for a woman it is a great wrong to pass over her first husband. Think of all this, and of how giving up your own life is condemned. Save yourself, the family and these two children, through me."

When his wife said this to him, Bharata, her husband embraced her. And he and his wife wept quietly, in deep distress.

Kunti's Offer

When she heard her grieving parents' words, so full of pain, their daughter, her whole body stricken with grief, spoke to them.

"Why are you weeping so bitterly, like people with no one to protect them? Listen to me, and when you have heard me, do what is right. By dharma, there is no doubt that you should give me up. Give up the one who has to be given up, and save everyone by losing me alone. People want children for this reason, thinking, She will carry me across. Now that the time has come, cross over by me, as if on a raft. A son carries his father across, here out of trouble or after death. He carries him across in every way, and so the wise call him a son, putra. And grandfathers always long for their daughters' sons too. I will save them myself, by saving my father's life.

"This brother of mine is a child. If you go to the other world, he will surely die before long. And if my father has gone to heaven and my little brother has died, the offerings to the ancestors will stop, and that would displease them. Left by my father, my mother and my brother, I would surely pass from sorrow to greater sorrow and die, where I do not belong. But if you are safe and well, my mother and my little brother, the family line and the offerings will surely stand.

"A son is one's own self, a wife is a friend, but a daughter, they say, is a trouble. Free yourself from trouble, then, and join me to dharma. Without you, father, I will be a helpless, pitiful girl with no protector, going anywhere at all. Or else I will set this family free. I will do a very hard deed and win its fruit. Or if you go there, best of brahmins, and leave me, I will suffer. Think of me too. So, for our sake, for dharma's sake and for the sake of your children, save yourself, good father, and give me up, for I am the one to be given up. Do not let the time pass for what must be done. The water you offer for me will do me good.

"What could be worse than this, that when you have gone to heaven we should run about like dogs, begging food from strangers? But if you and your kin are saved from this trouble, safe and well, I shall live happily in the world of the immortals."

When they heard her lament like this in so many ways, her father, her mother and the girl herself all wept, the three of them.

Then, hearing them all weeping, their son, a little boy, opened his eyes wide and said in his babbling voice, "Don't cry, father. Don't cry, mother. Don't cry, sister." And he went up to each of them in turn, almost laughing. Then he picked up a blade of grass and said happily, "I will kill the man-eating rakshasa with this!"

Though they were overcome with grief, when they heard the child's babbling words a great joy came over them.

Now is the time, Kunti thought. She came up to them and spoke, bringing the dying back to life, as if with nectar.

"What is the root of this sorrow?" said Kunti. "I want to know the truth of it. When I know, I will take it away, if it can be taken away."

"What you say is worthy of the good, rich in austerity," said the brahmin. "But no human being can take this sorrow away. Near this town lives a rakshasa, Baka, the mighty lord of this country and this town. He is fattened on human flesh, the evil-minded man-eater. The mighty lord of the asuras always protects this land. With a rakshasa's strength he guards the town and the country. Because of him we have no fear of enemy armies or of other creatures.

"His wage is fixed: a cartload of rice as his food, two buffaloes, and one man who takes them to him. Each man in turn gives him that meal. The turn comes round after many years, and men cannot escape it. And any who ever try to get free of it, the rakshasa kills and eats, with their sons and wives. The king lives in Vetrakiyagriha. He does not follow the policy that would keep his people safe for ever. We surely deserve this, living always in fear in the country of a weak king, sheltering under a bad king. Whom should brahmins obey? In whose country should they live as they like? They go where good qualities draw them, like birds that fly where they please. A man should first find a king, then a wife, then wealth. When he has gathered those three, he should support his kin and his sons. I gathered all three the wrong way round, and now that we have fallen into this danger, we suffer terribly.

"Now that turn, which will destroy my family, has come to us. I must give his wage: the food, and one man. I have no money to buy a man anywhere. And I cannot give up my friends or kin. I see no way to escape the rakshasa. I am drowning in a great sea of sorrow that cannot be crossed. So today I will go to the rakshasa with all these, my family, and then the wretch will eat us all together."

"You must not despair at all because of this danger," said Kunti. "I see a way to free you from the rakshasa. You have only one son, a little boy, and one daughter, poor girl. I do not think they should go there, nor your wife. I have five sons, brahmin. One of them will go, taking the offering for that wicked rakshasa for your sake."

"I will never do this to save my life," said the brahmin. "I will never let a brahmin, a guest, lose his life for my sake. This is not done even among the low-born and the wicked, that one should give up oneself and even one's son for a brahmin's sake. I think I must look to my own good. Between killing a brahmin and killing myself, it is better for me to kill myself. Killing a brahmin is the worst of sins. There is no atonement for it. Even if I did it without meaning to, it would be better for me to kill myself. I do not want death for myself, good lady. But if others kill me, no sin will touch me. If I consented to the death of a brahmin, I see no atonement for it. It would be cruel and base. To abandon one who has come to one's house, one who has come for shelter, or to kill one who asks for help, is held to be the cruellest thing. The great men of old, who knew the dharma for times of danger, knew that one should never do a deed that is condemned, never a cruel one. It is better that I myself should die today with my wife. I will never consent to the death of a brahmin."

"I too hold firmly that brahmins must be protected, brahmin," said Kunti. "And no son of mine is unloved, even if I had a hundred. But that rakshasa cannot kill my son. My son is mighty, perfected in mantras, and full of splendour. He will take all that food to the rakshasa, and he will free himself. I am sure of it. The hero has met rakshasas before, mighty and huge, and has killed many of them. But you must not tell anyone about this, brahmin, at all. People who want learning would pester my sons out of curiosity. And the good hold that if my son taught this knowledge to anyone without his teacher's leave, it would do that man no good."

When Pritha said this, the brahmin and his wife were overjoyed, and they honoured her words, which were like nectar. Then Kunti and the brahmin together said to the son of the Wind, "Do it." And he said to them, "So be it."

Chapter 64

Baka

When Bhima had promised, "I will do it," Bharata, the Pandavas all came back with the alms. Yudhishtira, Pandu's son, knew from his brother's face alone what was afoot. He sat down alone with his mother and asked her in private, "What is this deed that Bhima, of terrible courage, means to do? Does he want to do it with your consent?"

"He will do it at my word," said Kunti, "this tamer of enemies. It is a great deed, for a brahmin's sake, and to free the town."

"What rash, harsh, ill-done thing is this you have done?" said Yudhishtira. "Good people do not praise giving up a son. How can you want to give up your own son for someone else's? By giving up your son you have done what goes against the ways of the world. We all sleep safely, sheltered by his arms. We hope to win back the kingdom the wretches stole from us. Duryodhana cannot sleep a single night, he and Shakuni, for grief when they think of his boundless strength. By that hero's strength we were freed from the house of lac and other evils, and Purochana was killed. Relying on his strength we think of this earth, full of wealth, as already won, with Dhritarashtra's sons killed. What were you thinking, to decide to give him up? Has your mind been swept away by troubles? Have you lost your senses?"

"Yudhishtira," said Kunti, "do not worry about Wolf-belly. I have not made this decision from weakness of mind. We have lived here happily, son, in the brahmin's house. I have thought of this, son, as a way of repaying him. A man is worth as much as the good done to him is not lost on him. I saw Bhima's great courage then, at the house of lac, and in the killing of Hidimba, and I trust Wolf-belly. The strength of Bhima's arms is great, equal to ten thousand elephants. By it you, who are like elephants yourselves, were carried out of Varanavata. No one has been or will be as strong as Wolf-belly. He could stand up in battle to the best of them all, even to the wielder of the thunderbolt himself. As soon as he was born, long ago, he fell from my lap onto the mountain, and his body was so heavy that his limbs broke the rock to pieces. I remembered Bhima's strength with good sense, Pandava, and so I made up my mind to repay the brahmin."

"I have not decided this out of greed, nor ignorance, nor folly. I have made this decision for dharma, knowing what I do. Two aims will be achieved, Yudhishtira: we will repay our lodging, and a great act of dharma will be done. A kshatriya who helps a brahmin in any of his affairs wins the fair worlds, so I have heard. A kshatriya who saves a kshatriya from death wins great fame in this world and the next. A kshatriya who helps a vaishya in battle will surely please the people in all the worlds. And a king who saves a shudra who comes to him for shelter is born here into a rich family, honoured by kings. So the blessed Vyasa told me long ago, joy of the Kauravas, very wise as he is. That is why I want to do this."

"What you have done, mother, is right," said Yudhishtira, "for you have thought it out, and done it out of pity for a brahmin in distress. Bhima will surely come back when he has killed the man-eater. But the brahmin must be told, and made to take care, that the townspeople do not find out."

When the night was over, the Pandava, Bhimasena, took the food and went to where the man-eater lived. When he reached the rakshasa's forest, the mighty Pandava called out his name, and began to eat the food himself.

When the rakshasa heard Bhimasena's words, he came in a fury to where Bhima stood. He was huge and fast, as if he would split the earth. He frowned so that three lines stood on his brow, and bit his lip. When the rakshasa saw Bhimasena eating the food, he opened his eyes wide in anger and said, "Who is this fool eating the food meant for me, before my eyes? He wants to go to the house of Yama!"

When Bhimasena heard this, he almost laughed, Bharata. He ignored the rakshasa and went on eating, with his back turned. Then the man-eater gave a terrible yell, raised both his arms and ran at Bhimasena to kill him. Even so, Wolf-belly, the Pandava, the killer of enemy heroes, took no notice of the rakshasa. He did not even look at him, and went on eating. Then the rakshasa, full of fury, stood behind Kunti's son and struck him on the back with both hands. But though the mighty one struck him hard with both hands, Bhima did not even look at the rakshasa. He went on eating.

Then the mighty rakshasa, angrier than ever, took up a tree and ran at Bhima again to strike him. Then Bhima, the bull among men, slowly finished the food, rinsed his mouth with water, and stood up, pleased, ready for battle. When the angry rakshasa threw the tree, mighty Bhima caught it with his left hand, almost laughing, Bharata. Then the mighty rakshasa tore up trees of every kind again and hurled them at Bhimasena, and the Pandava Bhima hurled them back. That battle of trees between Baka and the Pandava was terrible, great king, and it destroyed the forest.

Then Baka shouted his name, ran at the Pandava, and seized mighty Bhimasena in his arms. Strong-armed Bhimasena threw his arms round the rakshasa too, and though he writhed with all his great force, the mighty man dragged him along by main strength. Dragged by Bhima and dragging the Pandava, the man-eater grew terribly tired. The earth shook with their great force, and they smashed huge trees to pieces.

When Wolf-belly saw the rakshasa weakening, bull of the Bharatas, he threw him to the ground and beat him with his hands. Then he pressed his knee hard into his back, and seized him by the neck with his right arm. With his left hand he took hold of his clothes at the waist, and the Pandava doubled the rakshasa up, while he bellowed terrible bellows. Then blood came out of his mouth, lord of the people, as Bhima broke that terrible rakshasa.

Terrified by that noise, the rakshasa's people came running out of his house with their servants, king. They were frightened and out of their wits, and Bhima, the best of fighters, calmed them and made them agree to terms. "You must never again harm men here. Those who do will be killed quickly, just like this." When they heard him, Bharata, those rakshasas said to him, "So be it," and accepted his terms. From then on the people of the town saw the rakshasas there as gentle, Bharata.

Then Bhima took the lifeless man-eater, left him at the city gate, and went away unseen. When he had killed him, Bhima went to the brahmin's house and told the king everything that had happened, from beginning to end.

Early in the morning, people coming out of the town saw the rakshasa lying dead on the ground, soaked in blood. He looked like a mountain peak, sprawled there, terrifying. Others went to Ekachakra and gave the news. Then the townspeople came by the thousand, king, with their women, their old people and their children, to see Baka. They were all amazed at the more than human deed, and they all worshipped their gods, lord of the

people.

Then they worked out whose turn it had been that day to give the meal. When they knew, they all came to the brahmin and asked him about it. When they asked him again and again, that bull among brahmins, protecting the Pandavas, said to all the townspeople:

"When I was ordered to give the food, and was weeping with my family, a brahmin saw me, a mighty man, perfected in mantras. He asked me first about the town's trouble. Then that best of brahmins comforted me, almost laughing, and said, 'I will take this food to the wicked one. Do not be afraid for my sake.' That strong man took the food and went to Baka's forest. It must have been he who did this deed, for the good of the world."

Then all the brahmins and kshatriyas were amazed, and the vaishyas and shudras rejoiced, and they held a festival to Brahman. Then all the country people came to the town to see that great wonder. And the Parthas went on living there.

Born of the Fire

"When those tigers among men had killed the rakshasa Baka," asked Janamejaya, "what did the Pandavas do next, brahmin?"

They went on living there, king, after they had killed the rakshasa Baka, studying the highest Veda in the brahmin's house. Then, a few days later, a brahmin of strict vows came to the brahmin's house looking for lodging. The learned and excellent brahmin, who had vowed always to welcome every guest, honoured him properly and gave him a place to stay. Then all the Pandavas, the bulls among men, with Kunti, sat with the brahmin as he told his stories. He told of countries and of holy places of many kinds, of the doings of kings and of many cities. When his stories were done, Janamejaya, the brahmin told them there of the wonderful bridegroom choice of Yajnasena's daughter among the Panchalas: of the birth of Dhrishtadyumna and the birth of Shikhandi, and of how Krishna was born, not from a womb, at Drupada's great sacrifice.

When the bulls among men heard of that great man's deeds, the most wonderful in the world, they asked him to tell the whole story. "How was Dhrishtadyumna, Drupada's son, born from the fire? How did Krishna's wonderful birth from the middle of the altar come about? How did he learn all the weapons from Drona, the great archer? And how did those dear friends fall out, and through whose doing?"

When the bulls among men urged him like this, king, the brahmin told them the whole story of Draupadi's birth.

"There was a great seer at Gangadvara," said the brahmin, "Bharadvaja, very wise, always strict in his vows. He went to bathe in the Ganga, and there he saw the apsaras Ghrithachi, who had come before him and was bathing. By the river bank the wind blew her garment away. When the seer saw her with her garment pulled away, he desired her. He had been celibate since boyhood, and as his heart went out to her, his seed fell, and the seer put it in a pot, a drona. From it the wise man's son Drona was born, and he studied the Vedas and all their limbs.

"Bharadvaja had a friend, a king named Prishata, and at that time a son named Drupada was born to him. Every day Prishata's son, that bull of the kshatriyas, went to the hermitage, and played and studied with Drona. When Prishata died, Drupada became king. Drona heard that Rama was giving away all his wealth. When Rama had set out for the forest, the son of Bharadvaja said to him, 'Know that I am Drona, best of brahmins, and I have come for wealth.'

"I have only my body left,' said Rama. 'Choose one of the two, brahmin, my weapons or my body.'

"You should give me all your weapons,' said Drona, 'and the art of calling them back, and of using them all.'

"So be it,' said the joy of the Bhrigus, and gave them to him. When he had received them, Drona had what he wanted. He was overjoyed, and when he had won from Rama the Brahma weapon, most highly prized, he was above all men.

"Then the mighty son of Bharadvaja went to Drupada, and the tiger among men said, 'Know

that I am your friend.'

"A man who does not know the Veda is no friend of one who does,' said Drupada, 'nor a man without a chariot of a chariot fighter. A man who is not a king is no friend of a king. Why do you want a friendship that is past?'

"The wise man made up his mind about the Panchala, and went to the city of the Kuru chiefs, named after the elephant. When he came, Bhishma took his grandsons and wealth of many kinds and gave them to wise Drona as his pupils. Then Drona, the learned, called all his pupils together and said to them, meaning trouble for Drupada, 'There is a fee for your teacher turning over in my heart. When you have mastered your weapons you must give it. Tell me truly, sinless ones.'

"And when all the Pandavas had mastered their weapons, and worked hard at them, Drona spoke again about his fee. 'Prishata's son Drupada is king in Chhatravati. Take his kingdom from him and give it to me quickly.' Then the five sons of Pandu beat Drupada in battle, bound him with his ministers, and showed him to Drona.

"I ask again for your friendship, lord of men,' said Drona. 'A man who is not a king, it seems, cannot be a king's friend. So I have made an effort for your kingdom, Yajnasena. You are king on the south bank of the Bhagirathi, and I on the north.'

"That great insult never left the king's heart for a moment. He was sick at heart, and he grew thin.

"King Drupada could not bear it. He wandered from one brahmin settlement to another, looking for brahmins of great power who could bring about what he wanted. Longing for the birth of a son, his mind struck down with grief, he thought all the time, I have no child good enough. In his despair he said of the sons he had, 'Shame on such kin!' He sighed constantly, wanting to pay Drona back. He thought of Drona's power, his discipline, his training and his deeds. The best of kings tried, but he could find no way to repay him with a kshatriya's strength, Bharata.

"Wandering about near Kalmashi on the bank of the Ganga, the king came to a holy settlement of brahmins. There was no brahmin there who had not finished his studies, none without a vow, and none who was not a great man. There Prishata's son saw two brahmin seers of strict vows, Yaja and Upayaya, living in calm, devoted to the study of the Veda, both of the Kashyapa line. Those two best of seers were fit to carry him across. He invited them tirelessly, offering them all they could desire.

"He weighed their strength and their wisdom, and went in private to the younger, Upayaya, of firm vows, tempting him with gifts. He served at his feet, spoke kindly and gave him all he could want. When he had honoured Upayaya properly, he said to him, 'By what rite, brahmin, could I have a son who will be Drona's death? If you do it, Upayaya, I will give you a hundred million cows, or anything else your heart desires, best of brahmins. I will give it all, without doubt.'

"No,' said the seer. But Drupada went on serving him, trying to win him over. Then at the end of a year Upayaya, best of brahmins, spoke to Drupada in a sweet voice, king, when the time had come.

"My elder brother, wandering by a forest stream, picked up a fruit that had fallen on

ground whose purity he did not know. I was following my brother, and I saw that it was not fitting. He would not stop to think about taking what was unclean. He saw the fruit, and did not see the faults that go with it. A man who does not tell clean from unclean in one thing, how will he in others? When he was studying the Veda and living in his teacher's house, he always ate the alms that others had left, and praised the taste of the food again and again, without disgust. I reason from this that my brother wants gain. Go to him, king. He will perform the sacrifice for you.'

"When he heard Upayaja's words, the king, who knew every dharma, felt disgust and thought it over in his mind. But he honoured the seer Yaja, who deserved honour, and said to him, 'I will give you eighty thousand cows. Perform the sacrifice for me, lord. I burn with my enmity against Drona, and you should bring me relief. He is the best of those who know Brahman, and unmatched in the Brahma weapon. That is why Drona defeated me in our quarrel as friends. There is no kshatriya on earth to equal Bharadvaja's wise son, the chief teacher of the Kauravas. Drona's nets of arrows take the lives of living things. His bow, six cubits long, looks huge and without equal. The great-spirited archer, Bharadvaja's son, beats back a kshatriya's force with a brahmin's force, without doubt. He stands there like Jamadagni's son, made to cut down the kshatriyas. The terrible power of his weapons cannot be withstood by men on earth. Speaking out his brahmin power, like a fire fed with offerings, he meets the kshatriyas in battle and burns them up, with Brahman going before him. Of brahmin and kshatriya, brahmin power is the greater. I am weaker in kshatriya strength, and I have turned to brahmin power, finding you, better than Drona, the best of those who know Brahman. Let me have a son who will be Drona's end, unconquerable in battle. Perform that rite for me, Yaja, and I will give you a hundred million cows.'

"So be it,' said Yaja, and he began to prepare the sacrifice. And though Upayaja wanted none of it, he urged him on, saying, 'It is for your elder.' Yaja promised to bring about Drona's destruction. Then great Upayaja told the king the rite of the sacred fires for the fruit of a son. 'The son will be of great courage, great splendour and great strength, just as you want him, king.'

"Fixing his mind on a son who would kill Bharadvaja's son, the king gathered everything for the rite to succeed. At the end of the offering, Yaja called the queen. 'Come to me, Queen Prishati. A pair of children has come to you.'

"My mouth is not yet cleansed, brahmin,' said the queen, 'and I am wearing holy scents. I am held back, though it is for a son. Wait, Yaja, for my sake.'

"Yaja has cooked the offering and Upayaja has spoken the mantras over it,' said Yaja. 'How could it fail to fulfil the wish? Come, or stay.'

"When Yaja had said this, and the prepared offering had been poured in, a boy like a god rose out of the fire. He was the colour of flame, terrible to look at, with a crown on his head and the finest armour, with a sword, arrows and a bow, roaring again and again. He climbed into a fine chariot and drove off in it. Then the Panchalas cried out in joy, 'Well done! Well done!' And a great unseen being moving in the sky said, 'This prince, who takes away the Panchalas' fear and brings them fame, who takes away the king's grief, is born to kill Drona.'

"And a girl too, the Panchali, rose from the middle of the altar, fortunate, lovely in every limb, slim-waisted, charming. She was dark, with eyes like lotus petals and dark

curling hair, a goddess who had taken a human body. The scent of blue lotuses came from her a mile away. She had the greatest beauty, and there was none like her on earth. When the girl of the lovely hips was born, a voice without a body said, 'This dark girl, the best of all women, will lead the kshatriyas to destruction. In time this slender-waisted one will do the work of the gods. Because of her a great terror will come upon the kshatriyas.'

"When they heard this, all the Panchalas roared like a pride of lions, and the earth could not bear them in their joy. When she saw the two, Prishati went to Yaja, wanting children. 'Let these two know no other mother but me,' she said. 'So be it,' said Yaja, to please the king. And the brahmins, their hearts full, gave the two their names. 'Because he is bold, dhrishta, and very daring, and because he was born from dharma and with splendour, dyumna, let Drupada's son be Dhrishtadyumna.' And they called the dark girl Krishna, for she was dark in colour. So those twins were born at Drupada's great sacrifice.

"Then mighty Bharadvaja brought Dhrishtadyumna the Panchala to his own house and taught him weapons. The very wise Drona thought that fate cannot be escaped, and that what will be must be, and so, to guard his own fame, he did it."

When they heard this, the sons of Kunti felt as if they had been pierced by a dart, and the great warriors were all uneasy at heart. When Kunti saw her sons bewildered and lost, she spoke to Yudhishtira, she who always spoke the truth.

"We have lived a long time here in the brahmin's house, Yudhishtira, enjoying this lovely town and getting alms. All the lovely forests and groves here we have seen, again and again, tamer of enemies. Seen again, they do not please us as they did. And alms are not so easy to get now, hero, joy of the Kurus. Let us go to the Panchalas, if you think fit. It will be pleasant to see something new, son. The Panchalas are said to have plenty of food, tamer of enemies, and we have heard that King Yajnasena is good to brahmins. I do not think it is right to live in one place too long. Let us go there, if you think fit, son."

"What you think best is best for us," said Yudhishtira. "But I do not know whether my younger brothers want to go or not."

Then Kunti spoke to Bhimasena, Arjuna and the twins about going, and they said, "So be it." Then Kunti and her sons took leave of the brahmin, king, and set out for the lovely city of great Drupada.

Angaraparna

While the great Pandavas were living in hiding, Vyasa, Satyawati's son, came to see them. When they saw him coming, the tamers of enemies went to meet him, bowed down and greeted him, and stood before him with joined hands. The sage told them all to be seated. Pleased at being honoured by the Parthas, he spoke to them kindly.

"Are you living by dharma and by the books, tamers of enemies? Do you honour brahmins who deserve honour?"

When the blessed seer had spoken words full of dharma and good sense, and told them many wonderful stories, he spoke again.

"There was once, in a forest of austerities, the daughter of a great seer. She was slender-waisted, with lovely hips and fine brows, and she had every good quality. But because of her own deeds she was unlucky. Though she was beautiful and good, she found no husband. So, unhappy, she began to practise austerity to win a husband. By her fierce austerity, so they say, she pleased Shankara.

"The blessed god was pleased with her, and said to the ascetic girl, 'Choose a boon, bless you, lovely one. I am the giver of boons.' Then she said to the lord what she thought was good for her: 'I want a husband with every good quality.' And she said it again and again.

"Then Ishana, the best of speakers, answered her, 'You will have five husbands, good lady.' She answered Shankara, 'Give me one husband.' But the god spoke again, with these fine words: 'Five times you said to me, "Give me a husband." When you have gone into another body, it will be as you said.'

"That girl, lovely as a goddess, has been born in Drupada's family. Krishna, Prishata's blameless daughter, is appointed to be your wife. So go into the city of the Panchalas, mighty ones. When you have won her, you will surely be happy."

When he had said this, the great and fortunate grandfather of the Pandavas took leave of the Parthas and of Kunti, and the great ascetic went away.

The bulls among men set out with their mother in front, going north by level roads, as they had been told. Travelling day and night, the tigers among men, the sons of Pandu, came to Somashravayana, a holy bathing place on the Ganga. Dhananjaya went ahead of them, holding up a torch, to light the way and to guard them.

There, in the lovely waters of the Ganga, in a lonely place, the jealous king of the gandharvas had come to play in the water with his women. He heard the noise of them coming down to the river, and at the sound the mighty one flew into a rage. When he saw the Pandavas there with their mother, the tamers of enemies, he twanged his terrible bow and said:

"The fearful dusk that reddens at the start of the night, except for eighty moments, is the hour set aside for yakshas, gandharvas and rakshasas, who go where they please. The rest belongs to men to go where they like. Men who go about at those hours out of greed, we attack and seize, with the rakshasas, the fools. So men who know the Veda blame all

men who come to the water at night, even strong men and kings. Keep away. Do not come near me. Why do you not know that I have come to the water of the Bhagirathi? Know that I am the gandharva Angaraparna, who relies on his own strength. I am proud and jealous, and a dear friend of Kubera. This forest is called Angaraparna after me, and here along the Ganga I live happily. Neither corpses nor horned beasts, neither gods nor men come near this place. So why are you coming near?"

"Fool," said Arjuna, "on the ocean, on the flanks of the Himalaya, and on this river, by night, by day or at dusk, who has any claim of ownership? We have strength, and we are not afraid of you out of season. It is the weak who worship you at your cruel hour. This Ganga came out of the golden peak of the Himalaya long ago, and when she reaches the ocean she becomes seven streams. She becomes one stream again, pure, and goes through the sky, and among the gods, gandharva, the Ganga becomes the Alakananda. And among the ancestors, gandharva, the Ganga becomes the Vaitarani, hard for sinners to cross, as Dvaipayana said. The river of the gods is open to all, holy, the way to heaven. How can you want to bar her? That is not the eternal dharma. How can we be kept by your word from touching the holy water of the Bhagirathi as we please, when no one may stop it and it is open to all?"

When Angaraparna heard this, he flew into a rage, bent his bow, and let loose blazing arrows like poisonous snakes. Whirling the torch quickly, and with his fine shield, Dhananjaya the Pandava turned all his arrows aside.

"This is a scare for those who do not know weapons, gandharva," said Arjuna. "Used against those who know weapons, it melts away like foam. I see that you gandharvas are all greater than men, gandharva. So I will fight with a divine weapon, not with magic. Brihaspati, the son of Indra's teacher, gave this fire weapon long ago to Bharadvaja, gandharva. From Bharadvaja it went to Agniveshya, and from Agniveshya to my teacher. And he, Drona, the best of brahmins, gave it to me."

When he had said this, the Pandava, in anger, let loose on the gandharva the blazing fire weapon, and it burned up his chariot. The mighty gandharva, thrown from his chariot, stunned by the power of the weapon, was falling head first. Dhananjaya caught him by his hair, wreathed with garlands, and dragged him, senseless from the weapon, towards his brothers.

Then his wife, named Kumbhinasi, came to Yudhishtira for shelter, wanting to save her husband. "Save me, great king," said the gandharvi, "and set my husband free. I am a gandharvi named Kumbhinasi, and I have come to you for shelter, lord."

"Beaten in battle, stripped of his fame, protected by a woman, without courage," said Yudhishtira, "who would kill such an enemy? Let him go, killer of enemies."

"Take your life, gandharva," said Arjuna. "Go, and do not grieve. Yudhishtira, king of the Kurus, grants you safety today."

"I am beaten," said the gandharva. "I give up my old name, Angaraparna, Leaf of Embers. I will not boast of my strength now, nor of my name, in any gathering of people. I have made a good gain, meeting one who carries divine weapons. I wanted to fight him with gandharva magic, when he is so much the better. My fine painted chariot has been burned by the fire of his weapon. So I, who was Chitraratha, Painted Chariot, have become Dagdharatha, Burned Chariot, by name."

"There is a knowledge I gathered here long ago by austerity. I will give it today to the great man who gave me my life. For the man who holds back an enemy by force, beats him, and then, when he comes for shelter, gives him back his life, what good does he not deserve? This knowledge is called Chakshushi, the Seeing. Manu gave it to Soma, Soma gave it to Vishvavasu, and Vishvavasu gave it to me. Given by a teacher, it perishes if it passes to a coward. I have told you where it came from. Now hear what it can do. Whatever a man wants to see with his eyes in the three worlds, he can see it, and see it as he wishes. A man who stands on one foot for six months may win this knowledge. But I will bring it to you myself, without your keeping the vow. By this knowledge, king, we are greater than men, and by the power it gives we are not less than the gods.

"And I will give each of your five brothers, best of men, a hundred horses born of the gandharvas. They carry gods and gandharvas. They have heavenly scents and go as fast as thought. Even when they grow thin, they lose none of their speed. Long ago Indra's thunderbolt was made to kill Vritra. It broke into ten, into a hundred pieces on Vritra's head. Then the gods divided it into parts, and each part of the thunderbolt is honoured. Whatever gets a thing done in the world is called a body of the thunderbolt. The brahmin's thunderbolt is in his hand. The kshatriya's is his chariot. The vaishyas' thunderbolt is giving, and the lowest class's is work. The kshatriya's thunderbolt is his horses, and horses are said not to be killed. The mare gives birth to the chariot's limb, and those counted among horses are the sutas. These horses born of the gandharvas take any colour and any speed, and come at will. They will fulfil your wishes."

"If a gift is given out of affection," said Arjuna, "or when a man's life is at risk, whether knowledge, wealth or learning, I do not want it, gandharva."

"Friendship is seen to bring joy when people meet," said the gandharva. "I give you the knowledge because I am glad you gave me my life. And I will take from you the fine fire weapon, and your friendship too, for a long time, Bibhatsu, bull of the Bharatas."

"In exchange for the weapon, I choose the horses," said Arjuna. "Let our friendship last for ever. And tell me, friend gandharva, why men need fear you."

Tapati

"Tell me the reason, gandharva," said Arjuna, "why you attacked us, tamer of enemies, when we are good men who know the Veda, travelling by night."

"You have no fire with you," said the gandharva, "no offerings, and no brahmin going before you. That is why I attacked you, joy of the Pandavas. Yakshas, rakshasas, gandharvas, pishachas, snakes and men all tell at length of the glorious line of the Kurus. I have heard divine seers, Narada and the others, telling the virtues of your wise forefathers, hero. I have seen for myself the greatness of your family as I roamed this whole earth, clothed by the ocean. I know your teacher in the Veda and in archery, Arjuna, famous Bharadvaja, known in the three worlds. I know Dharma, the Wind, Shakra, the two Ashvins and Pandu, tiger of the Kurus: these six who made your family grow, your fathers, Partha, the best of gods and men. All of you brothers are heroes of divine spirit, great-hearted, the best of all who bear weapons, and your vows are well kept."

"Even knowing that your minds and understanding are the highest, Partha, I attacked you here. When a man is near women, Kauravya, and sees himself attacked, he should not bear it, relying on the strength of his arms. And our strength grows greater at night. That is why anger came over me, Kaunteya, with my wife beside me."

"So I have been beaten by you in battle, Tapatya, you who make the Tapati line grow. Hear from me how it came about. Celibacy is the highest dharma, and it is fixed in you. That is why I was beaten by you in this fight, Partha. But any kshatriya who lives by desire and fights at night would never come out alive. Yet even a king who lives by desire, Tapatya, may beat all the night-roamers in battle, if a family priest goes before him. So, Tapatya, whatever good men want in this world, they should set self-controlled family priests to that work. The family priests of kings should be devoted to the Veda and its six limbs, pure, truthful, righteous and self-disciplined. A king who has a priest who knows dharma, speaks well, and is good and pure, is sure of victory, and heaven will follow. To win what he has not won and guard what he has, a king should appoint a priest with good qualities. A king who wants to win the whole earth, crowned with Meru and clothed by the ocean, should keep to his priest's counsel. For no king who has no brahmin will ever win the earth by courage alone, Tapatya, or by birth. So know this, you who make the Kuru line grow: a kingdom with brahmins at its head can be kept for a long time."

"You called me Tapatya," said Arjuna. "I want to know what that word means. Who is this Tapati, because of whom we are Tapatyas? For we are sons of Kunti, good friend. I want to know the truth."

When Arjuna said this, the gandharva told Kunti's son Dhananjaya the story famous in the three worlds.

"I will tell you this whole lovely story, Partha, just as it happened, a story of dharma, best of those who uphold dharma. Listen closely, and I will tell you why I called you Tapatya."

"The one who fills the heavens with his splendour from his place in the sky, the Sun, had a daughter named Tapati, who had no equal. She was the daughter of Vivasvat, Kaunteya, the younger sister of Savitri, famous in the three worlds, Tapati, full of

heat and austerity. No goddess, asura woman, yaksha woman, rakshasa woman, apsaras or gandharva woman was as beautiful. Her limbs were well formed and flawless, her eyes dark and long, her ways good, her life virtuous and her dress fine. There was no one like her in the three worlds, Bharata. Savitri, the Sun, looked for a husband for her in beauty, character, family and learning. When he saw his daughter grown up and ready to be given in marriage, he found no peace, thinking of whom to give her to.

"Then, Kaunteya, Riksha's son, the mighty bull of the Kurus, King Samvarana, worshipped the Sun all the time. The king was always disciplined, with water offerings, garlands and gifts, with rules and fasts and austerities of many kinds. Devoted, pure, eager to serve and without pride, the joy of the Pauravas worshipped the Sun as it rose. So the Sun thought Samvarana, who was grateful, knew dharma and had no equal on earth in beauty, a fit husband for Tapati. He wanted to give the girl to Samvarana, the best of kings, whose family was famous. As the Sun lights up the sky with his splendour, so King Samvarana shone on earth. As those who speak of Brahman worship the rising sun, so the people below the brahmins worshipped Samvarana, Partha. The glorious king outshone the moon in loveliness and the sun in splendour, for his friends and his enemies alike. The Heater himself set his mind on giving Tapati to a king of such virtues and such conduct.

"Once, so they say, the glorious king, whose fame was wide on earth, went hunting in the mountain woods, Partha. As he hunted, worn out with hunger, thirst and weariness, the king's matchless horse died on the mountain, Kaunteya. With his horse dead, the king went on foot on the mountain, and he saw a girl with long eyes who had no equal in the world. Alone, the tamer of enemies came upon the lone girl, and the tiger among kings stood looking at her, his eyes fixed. From her beauty the king thought she was Shri. Then he thought she was the light of the sun, fallen. On the mountain slope where the dark-eyed girl stood, the place seemed golden, with its trees, shrubs and creepers. When he saw her, the king thought little of the beauty of every other creature, and he thought his eyes had found their reward. Of all that the king had seen since his birth, he could think of nothing as beautiful as she. His heart and eyes were bound to her by the cords of her virtues, and he did not move from the place, and was aware of nothing. *Surely the Maker churned the world of gods, asuras and men and brought out this beauty for this wide-eyed girl*, he thought. So King Samvarana judged the girl, who had no equal in the world for the wealth of her beauty.

"As soon as he saw the lovely girl, the king of noble family fell to brooding, pierced by the arrows of love. Burning with the fierce fire of love, bold as he was, he spoke to the shy and famous girl. 'Who are you, and whose are you, you whose thighs are like plantain stems? Why are you standing here? How do you come to be wandering alone in this empty forest, you of the bright smile? Every limb of yours is flawless, and you are decked with every ornament. You seem to be the ornament that ornaments long for. I do not think you a goddess, an asura woman, a yaksha woman, a rakshasa woman, a snake woman, a gandharva woman or a human woman. Of all the fine women I have seen or heard of, I think none your equal, proud beauty.'

"So the king spoke to her. But she said nothing at all to him, sick with love in the empty forest. As the king went on pleading, the long-eyed girl vanished there and then, like lightning in the clouds. The king wandered all round the forest looking for the girl with eyes like lotus petals, roaming like a madman. When he could not see her, the best of the Kauravas lamented at length, and then stood a while without moving.

"When she had vanished, the king, the feller of hosts of enemies, bewildered by love,

fell to the ground. When he had fallen, the girl with the lovely smile and the full, wide hips showed herself to the king again. And the lovely girl spoke in a sweet voice to the king, the founder of the Kuru line, whose heart was struck by love. 'Get up, get up, bless you. You should not fall into a faint and lie on the ground, tamer of enemies, tiger among kings.'

"When she spoke to him in that sweet voice, the king saw the girl of the wide hips standing before him. Then the lord of men, his whole being on fire with love, spoke to the dark-eyed girl in a faltering voice. 'Dark-eyed one, proud beauty, love me, for I love you and am sick with love. My life is leaving me. For your sake, wide-eyed one, this god of love keeps piercing me with sharp arrows and will not stop, you who are like the heart of a lotus. I am swallowed by the great snake of love, good lady, with no one to help me. Take me, you of the wide, full hips, lovely-faced one. My life depends on you, you whose voice is like the song of the kinnaras, lovely in every flawless limb, with a face like the lotus and the moon. Without you, timid one, I cannot live. So have pity on me, wide-eyed girl. I am devoted to you, dark-eyed one. You should not abandon me. Save me with your love, lady. Come to me, timid, lovely one, by the gandharva rite of marriage. Of all marriages, you with thighs like plantain stems, the gandharva rite is said to be the best.'

"'I am not my own mistress, king,' said Tapati. 'I am a girl with a father. If you love me, ask my father. As I have taken your life, lord of men, so you have taken mine even more, by the mere sight of you. I am not mistress of my body, best of kings, so I will not come near you. Women are not free. What girl in all the worlds would not want for her lord a king of famous family, a husband who loves those devoted to him? So, as things are, ask my father, the Sun, with bowing, with austerity and with discipline. If he wishes to give me to you, tamer of enemies, I will always be yours to command, king. I am named Tapati, the younger sister of Savitri, the daughter of this lamp of the world, Savitri, the Sun, bull of the kshatriyas.'

"When she had said this, the blameless girl quickly rose into the sky, and the king fell to the ground again, right there. His minister, with his followers, found him in the great forest, fallen on the ground, like Indra's banner raised high and then fallen. When his counsellor saw the great archer fallen on the ground without his horse, he was as if set on fire. He hurried to him, in alarm and in love, and lifted up the king, bewildered by love, from the ground, as a father lifts a fallen son. Old in wisdom and years, in fame and self-control, the minister lifted him up, and his own fear left him. He spoke to the king, now risen, in a kind, sweet voice. 'Do not be afraid, tiger among men. Bless you, sinless one.' He thought the king, the feller of enemies in battle, had fallen to the ground worn out by hunger and thirst. He sprinkled the king's head with cool water scented with lotuses, without touching his crown.

"When he came to himself, the mighty king sent away the whole army, except that one counsellor. At the king's command the great army left, and the king sat down again on that mountain slope. There, on that fine mountain, purified, with joined hands, he stood on the ground with his arms raised, wishing to win over the Sun. And King Samvarana, killer of enemies, thought in his mind of Vasishtha, the best of seers, his family priest.

"The lord of men stayed in one place day and night, and on the twelfth day the brahmin seer came. The great seer, whose soul was perfected, knew at once by divine means that the king's heart had been stolen by Tapati. The righteous man spoke to the best of

kings, who was so disciplined, wishing to do what he wanted. Then, while the lord of men watched, the blessed seer, bright as the sun, went up to see the Sun. The brahmin came before the thousand-rayed one with joined hands and announced himself gladly: 'I am Vasishtha.'

"The splendid Vivasvat said to the best of sages, 'Welcome, great seer. Tell me what you wish.'

"Your daughter named Tapati, the younger sister of Savitri,' said Vasishtha, 'I ask you for her for Samvarana, Vibhavas. That king is of great fame, knows dharma and wealth, and is generous. Samvarana is a fitting husband for your daughter, sky-goer.'

"When he said this, Savitri the Day-maker, who had already decided, *I will give her*, welcomed the brahmin and answered, 'Samvarana is the best of kings, and you are the best of seers, sage, and Tapati is the best of women. What is there but to give her?'

"Then the Heater himself gave Tapati, flawless in every limb, to great Vasishtha for Samvarana, and the great seer received the girl Tapati. Then Vasishtha, given leave, came back to where the famous bull of the Kurus was. The king, possessed by love, his whole heart fixed on her, saw the divine girl Tapati, with her lovely smile, coming with Vasishtha, and he shone with joy. When the king's hard twelve nights were over, the blessed seer Vasishtha, pure of soul, came. So Samvarana won his wife by winning over by austerity the god who gives boons, the lord of light, and by Vasishtha's power alone.

"Then on that finest of mountains, the haunt of gods and gandharvas, the bull among men took Tapati's hand in marriage as the rites require. With Vasishtha's leave the royal seer wanted to enjoy himself there on that mountain with his wife. So the king put that same minister in charge of his city and kingdom, his carriages and his armies. When Vasishtha had taken leave of the king he went away, and the king enjoyed himself on the mountain like an immortal.

"For twelve years the king delighted there on that mountain, in forests and waters, with that wife alone. And for twelve years the thousand-eyed god did not rain at all in that king's city or anywhere in his kingdom. The city, with its people starving, joyless and like corpses, was like the city of the king of the dead, crowded with ghosts. When the righteous blessed seer Vasishtha saw it like that, he went to the best of kings, and brought that tiger among kings back to the city with Tapati, after he had lived there twelve years. Then, when the tiger among kings had entered the city again, the killer of the gods' enemies rained there as before. And the city and the kingdom rejoiced with the greatest joy, cared for by that chief of kings, whose soul was perfected. Then the lord of men offered sacrifices again for twelve years with his wife Tapati, like Shakra, lord of the Maruts.

"This was the fortunate Tapati, your ancestress, Partha, the daughter of Vivasvat, through whom I think of you as Tapatya. On her, on Tapati, King Samvarana fathered Kuru. So you, best of the heaters, are Tapatya, Arjuna."

The Cow Nandini

When he heard what the gandharva said, bull of the Bharatas, Arjuna shone with the greatest delight, like the full moon. And the great archer, the best of the Kurus, very curious about the power of Vasishtha's austerity, said to the gandharva, "I want to hear about the seer whose name you spoke, Vasishtha. Tell it to me as it is. Tell me, lord of the gandharvas, who was this blessed seer who was the family priest of our forefathers?"

"Desire and anger," said the gandharva, "unconquerable even by the immortals, were conquered for ever by his austerity, and they massaged his feet. He held back his great anger at Vishvamitra's offence, and the noble man did not wipe out the Kushikas. Though he burned with grief for his sons and had the power, the lord did not think of a cruel deed to destroy Vishvamitra. Though he could have brought his dead sons back from the house of Yama, he did not go past the end appointed for them, as the ocean does not go past its shore. The kings of the Ikshvaku line won this earth when they found that great man, who had conquered himself. When they found that best of seers, Vasishtha, the best of family priests, those kings offered sacrifices, joy of the Kurus. That brahmin seer led all those best of kings in sacrifice, best of the Pandavas, as Brihaspati leads the immortals.

"So find some brahmin with good qualities, who knows the Veda and dharma, whose heart is set on dharma, a priest you would want. A kshatriya born to win the earth should first appoint a family priest, Partha, for the growth of his kingdom. A king who wants to conquer the earth should put brahmins in front. So let some brahmin with good qualities be your family priest."

"How did the quarrel between Vishvamitra and Vasishtha begin?" said Arjuna. "They both lived in holy hermitages. Tell us all of it."

"This story of Vasishtha is called ancient," said the gandharva, "in all the worlds, Partha. Hear it as it happened.

"In Kanyakubja there was a great king, bull of the Bharatas, famous in the world as Gadhi, devoted to truth and dharma. The righteous man had a son, rich in armies and beasts of burden, known as Vishvamitra, the crusher of enemies. He went hunting with his ministers in the deep forest, shooting deer and boar in the lovely desert lands. Worn out with exertion, wanting game and thirsty, he came, best of men, to Vasishtha's hermitage.

"When the seer Vasishtha, who had the best of fortunes, saw Vishvamitra, the best of men, arrive, he received him with honour, with water for his feet, the guest offering, water for rinsing and a welcome, Bharata, and with food of the forest. Great Vasishtha had a cow that gave whatever was wished. When she was told, 'Give what is wanted,' she yielded what was wanted. She yielded plants of village and forest, and milk, and the finest elixir with six flavours and the taste of nectar, food and drink and delicacies of many kinds, things to lick and to suck, like nectar, Arjuna. The king was honoured with all these good things, perfect in every way, and he was very pleased, with his ministers and his army.

"She was long in six parts, well rounded in her flanks and thighs, broad in three and compact in five, with eyes like a frog's, handsome, with a full udder, faultless, with a

fine tail, ears like arrowheads, lovely horns, and a sturdy, long head and neck. Vishvamitra looked at her in wonder. He praised Nandini, Vasishtha's milch cow, and in his great pleasure he said to the sage, 'Give me Nandini, brahmin, for ten million cows, or for my kingdom. Enjoy the kingdom, great sage.'

"This milch cow Nandini is for the gods, the guests and the ancestors, and for the ghee of the offering,' said Vasishtha. 'I cannot give her away, sinless one, even for your kingdom.'

"I am a kshatriya,' said Vishvamitra, 'and you are a brahmin, whose means are austerity and study. What strength is there in brahmins, calm and self-controlled? If you will not give me what I want for ten million cows, I will not give up my own dharma. I will take your cow by force.'

"You stand on strength,' said Vasishtha. 'You are a king and a kshatriya, strong in your arms. Do as you wish, quickly. Do not stop to think.'

"When he was told this, Partha, Vishvamitra took Nandini, the cow white as a swan or the moon, as if by force. Beaten with whips and sticks and driven here and there, Vasishtha's lovely Nandini lowed. She came back, Partha, and stood facing the blessed seer, with her face turned up to him. Though they beat her hard, she would not leave the hermitage.

"I hear your cries, good lady,' said Vasishtha, 'as you low again and again. You are being taken by force, Nandini. But I am a brahmin, and forbearing.'

"But Nandini, terrified of Vishvamitra and his troops, bull of the Bharatas, came up to Vasishtha. 'Lord,' said the cow, 'I am struck with stones and sticks by Vishvamitra's terrible troops, and I cry like one with no protector. Why do you look on and do nothing?'

"While she was being mistreated like this, Partha, the great sage was not shaken, and he did not waver from his steadiness, firm in his vow. 'The strength of kshatriyas is their power,' said Vasishtha. 'The strength of brahmins is forbearance. Forbearance holds me. So go, if you like.'

"Have you abandoned me, lord,' said the cow, 'that you speak to me like this? If you have not abandoned me, brahmin, I cannot be taken away by force.'

"I do not abandon you, lovely one,' said Vasishtha. 'Stay, if you can. Here is your calf, tied with a strong rope, being taken by force.'

"When the milch cow heard Vasishtha say 'Stay', she raised her head and neck and became terrible to look at. With her eyes red with anger and her lowing like thunder, the cow drove off Vishvamitra's whole army. Beaten with the tips of whips and sticks and driven here and there, her eyes blazing with anger, she grew angrier still. Her body blazing with anger, she shone like the sun at noon, and poured out great showers of embers from her tail again and again. From her tail she created the Pahlavas, from her dung the Shabaras and Shakas, and from her urine, faint with fury, she created the Yavanas. From her foam she created the Pundras, Kiratas, Dramidas, Simhalas and Barbaras, and the Daradas and mlecchas. The great army of Vishvamitra was scattered by the hosts of mlecchas of many kinds she let loose, in all kinds of armour, carrying all kinds of

weapons, furious, while Vishvamitra watched. Each of his fighters was surrounded by five or seven of them. Driven off by a great rain of weapons, Vishvamitra's army broke and fled in terror on every side, while Vishvamitra watched. Yet not one of Vishvamitra's soldiers lost his life at the hands of Vasishtha's angry men, bull of the Bharatas. Vishvamitra's army was driven three leagues, crying out in terror, and found no one to save it.

"When Vishvamitra saw that great wonder, which came from brahmin power, he was sick of being a kshatriya, and he said, 'Shame on strength, the strength of kshatriyas! The strength of brahmin power is strength. Weighing strength and weakness, austerity is the highest strength.'

"He gave up his rich kingdom and his blazing royal glory, turned his back on pleasures, and set his mind on austerity alone. When he had reached perfection by austerity, and held up the worlds by his power, the blazing Kaushika scorched them all, and he became a brahmin. And the Kaushika drank the pressed soma with Indra."

Kalmashapada

"There was a king in this world named Kalmashapada," said the gandharva, "born in the Ikshvaku line, Partha, whose splendour had no equal on earth. Once the king went out of his city into the forest to hunt, and the crusher of enemies roamed about shooting deer and boar. Thirsty and hungry, on a path wide enough for only one, the king, unconquered in battle, saw a sage coming towards him: great Vasishtha's son, the best of seers, the fortunate Shakti, the joy of Vasishtha's family, the eldest of great Vasishtha's hundred sons.

"'Get out of our way,' said the king. The seer answered him gently, speaking softly. But the seer, standing on the path of dharma, did not step aside, and the king, in his pride and anger, would not give way to the sage either. When the seer would not leave the path, the best of kings, in his folly, struck the sage with his whip, like a rakshasa.

"Struck by the whip, the best of sages, Vasishtha's son, faint with rage, cursed the best of kings. 'Lowest of kings, because you strike an ascetic like a rakshasa, from today you will be a man-eater. You will roam this earth hungry for human flesh. Go, lowest of kings!' So said Shakti, whose strength was his power.

"Now there was a quarrel between Vishvamitra and Vasishtha over who should be this king's priest, and Vishvamitra was following him. While the two were disputing like this, Partha, Vishvamitra, the seer of fierce austerity, the mighty one, came near. Only afterwards did the best of kings realise that the seer was Vasishtha's son, as bright as Vasishtha himself. And Vishvamitra, making himself invisible, Bharata, came up to them both, wanting to do what would please him.

"The best of kings, cursed by Shakti, went to Shakti for shelter, trying to win his favour and paying him honour. But Vishvamitra, knowing what the king had in mind, joy of the Kurus, ordered a rakshasa into the king. By the curse of that brahmin seer and at Vishvamitra's command, a rakshasa named Kinkara entered the king. When he knew that the rakshasa had seized him, the sage Vishvamitra left that place, tamer of enemies.

"The king, who was wise, tried to guard himself, though he was sorely troubled by the rakshasa within him. Then a brahmin saw the king setting out again, and, being hungry, asked him for a meal with meat. The royal seer Mitrasaha answered the brahmin gently, 'Stay here a moment, brahmin. When I come back I will give you the food you want.' With that the king went on, and the best of brahmins waited. The brahmin's words slipped from the king's mind. He went into the inner rooms and lay down.

"At midnight he got up, called the cook quickly, and, remembering what he had promised the brahmin, said, 'Go to such and such a place. A brahmin is waiting for me there, wanting food. Give him food with meat.' The cook could find no meat anywhere, and he told the king so in distress. But the king, possessed by the rakshasa, said to the cook without concern, 'Then feed him with human flesh,' again and again. 'So be it,' said the cook, and without fear he went quickly to the place of the executioners and brought human flesh. He prepared it properly, served it with rice, and gave it quickly to the hungry ascetic brahmin.

"The best of brahmins looked at the food with the eye of perfection. His eyes troubled with anger, he said, 'This is not fit to eat. Because that king gives me food that is

not fit to eat, the fool himself will crave it. He will be given over to human flesh, as Shakti said before, and he will roam this earth, a terror to all creatures.'

"Spoken twice against the king, the curse grew strong. He was possessed by the rakshasa's strength and lost his senses. Soon after, Bharata, the best of kings, his senses struck down by the rakshasa, saw Shakti and said to him, 'Because you have laid this unfitting curse on me, I will begin my eating of men with you.' With that he took his life at once and ate Shakti, as a tiger eats the beast it wants.

"When he saw Shakti killed, Vishvamitra again set the rakshasa on Vasishtha's other sons. In his fury he ate the younger sons of great Vasishtha, the hundred, as a lion eats small beasts.

"When Vasishtha heard that his sons had been killed through Vishvamitra, he bore that grief as the great mountain bears the earth. The best of sages, the wisest of the wise, set his mind on his own destruction. But he never thought of wiping out the Kushikas. The blessed seer threw himself from the peak of Meru, but his head fell on the rock as if on a heap of cotton. When he did not die from the fall, Pandava, the blessed one lit a fire and went into it in the great forest. But the fire, though it blazed high, did not burn him. Though it blazed, tamer of enemies, it became cool. Then, overcome by grief, the great sage went to the sea, tied a heavy stone round his neck, and threw himself into the water. The force of the ocean's waves threw the great sage onto the land, and weary, he went back to his hermitage.

"When the sage saw his hermitage empty of his sons, he left it again in deep grief. He saw a river full of new water in the rainy season, sweeping along many trees of many kinds that grew on its banks, Partha. Then, joy of the Pauravas, he thought again in his grief, I will drown myself in its waters. So the great sage bound himself tightly with cords and, in deep grief, sank in the water of that great river. But the river cut his cords, crusher of enemy armies, set the seer on the bank and let him go, free of his bonds. The great seer came out, released from his bonds, and he named the river Vipasha, the Unbound.

"He set his mind on grief and could not stay in one place. He went to mountains, rivers and lakes. Then the seer saw a Himalayan river, full of fierce crocodiles, and threw himself into its current. But the best of rivers, thinking the brahmin was like fire, fled from him in a hundred streams, and so it is known as Shatadru, the Hundredfold. When he found himself on dry land even there, he said, 'I cannot die,' and went back towards his hermitage.

"As he went back towards the hermitage, followed by his daughter-in-law Adrishyanti, he heard behind him the sound of the Veda being recited, full of meaning and graced with its six limbs. 'Who is this following me?' he said.

"'I am Adrishyanti,' his daughter-in-law answered him, 'Shakti's wife, great one, devoted to austerity.'

"'Daughter,' said Vasishtha, 'whose is this voice reciting the Veda with its limbs? I have heard it before, the Veda with its limbs, from Shakti.'

"'This is the child of your son Shakti,' said Adrishyanti, 'conceived in my womb. He has been practising the Vedas here for twelve years, sage.'

"When she said this, Vasishtha, the seer of the best fortune, was glad. 'There is a line,' he said, and he turned back from death, Partha.

"As he was going back with his daughter-in-law, sinless one, he saw Kalmashapada sitting in the empty forest. As soon as he saw him, the king rose up in anger, Bharata, possessed by the fierce rakshasa, and wanted to eat him. When Adrishyanti saw the man of cruel deeds in front of them, she said to Vasishtha, in a voice shaking with fear, 'Lord, here comes a terrible rakshasa, like Death with his fierce staff, holding a stick of wood. No one on earth but you can stop him today, great one, best of all who know the Veda. Save me, lord, from this evil creature, terrible to look at. This rakshasa surely means to eat us both.'

"Do not be afraid, daughter,' said Vasishtha. 'You need not fear the rakshasa at all. What you see coming is no danger from a rakshasa. This is King Kalmashapada, mighty and famous on earth. He lives in this part of the forest, very terrible.'

"When the blessed seer Vasishtha saw him rushing at them, the splendid one stopped him with the single sound hum, Bharata. Then he sprinkled him with water made holy by a mantra, and freed the best of kings from the terrible rakshasa. For twelve years the king had been seized by Vasishtha's own power, as the sun is seized by Rahu at the time of an eclipse. Freed from the rakshasa, the king lit up that great forest with his splendour, as the sun lights up the clouds at dusk. When he came to his senses, he bowed to Vasishtha, the best of seers, with joined hands, and spoke to him at the proper time.

"I am Saudasa, great one, the king whose priest you are, best of brahmins. Tell me what you wish at this time. What can I do for you?"

"What has happened happened in its time,' said Vasishtha. 'Go and rule your kingdom. And never despise brahmins, lord of men.'

"I will never despise the best of brahmins, brahmin,' said the king. 'I will keep to your command always and honour the twice-born. But, best of brahmins, best of those who know the Veda, I want a boon from you, by which I may be free of my debt to the Ikshvakus. You should go to my queen, who is wanted for a child, and who has character, beauty and virtue, to make the Ikshvaku line grow.'

"I will give it,' said Vasishtha, the best of brahmins, true to his word, to that king, the great archer.

"Then, in time, sinless one, the lord of men went back with Vasishtha to Ayodhya, the best of cities, famous in the worlds. All the people came out joyfully to meet him, the great man freed of his sin, as the gods meet their lord. Soon the lord of men entered the city of people of holy deeds, together with great Vasishtha. The people of Ayodhya saw him, king, like the sun risen with the constellation Pushya. The best of the glorious filled Ayodhya with his glory, as the cool-rayed moon, risen in autumn, fills the sky. The fine city, its roads sprinkled and swept, decked with banners raised high, gladdened his heart. Crowded with contented, well-fed people, the city shone with him, joy of the Kurus, as Amaravati shines with Shakra.

"When the king of kings had entered the city, the queen came to Vasishtha at the king's command. In her season the great seer, Vasishtha of the best fortune, lay with the queen

by the divine rite. When a child had been conceived in her, the best of sages, honoured by the king, went back to his hermitage. The queen carried the child a long time, and when she did not give birth, she split open her womb with a stone. Then, in the twelfth year, bull among men, the child was born: the royal seer named Ashmaka, who founded Potana."

Aurva

"Then Adrishyanti, living in the hermitage," said the gandharva, "gave birth to a son, king, who carried on Shakti's line, as if he were a second Shakti. The blessed chief of sages himself performed his grandson's birth rites and the others, best of the Bharatas. Because Vasishtha, who was set on dying, was brought back by him while he was still in the womb, he is remembered in the world as Parashara, He Who Brought Back the Dying.

"The righteous boy thought of Vasishtha as his father, and from his birth he behaved towards him as a son to a father. He called the brahmin seer Vasishtha 'Father' in front of his mother Adrishyanti, Kaunteya, tamer of enemies. When Adrishyanti heard his sweet word 'Father', full of meaning, her eyes filled with tears, and she said to him, 'Do not say "Father, Father, Father", my son. The great sage is not your father. Your father was eaten by a rakshasa in the forest, son. The one you think of as your father is not your father, sinless one. This noble man is the father of your great father.'

"When she said this, the best of seers, truthful and great-hearted, was stricken with grief, and he set his mind on destroying all the worlds. As the great man was set on it, the great ascetic Vasishtha held him back with an argument. Hear it.

"'There was a king on earth named Kritavirya,' said Vasishtha. 'That bull among kings was the patron in sacrifice of the Bhrigus, who knew the Veda. At the end of the soma sacrifice the lord of the people satisfied those first-born, son, with grain and wealth in plenty. When that tiger among kings had gone to heaven, a time came when his descendants needed money. Knowing that the Bhrigus had wealth, all those kings came to those best of the Bhargavas, son, to beg. Some of the Bhrigus buried their endless wealth in the ground. Some, knowing there was danger from the kshatriyas, gave it to brahmins. And some of the Bhrigus gave the kshatriyas as much as they wanted, son, seeing another reason for it.

"'Then, son, a kshatriya happened to be digging in the ground and found wealth in a Bhrigu's house, and all the bulls of the kshatriyas came together and saw the wealth. Then in their anger they scorned the Bhrigus, though they had come for shelter, and those great archers killed them all with sharp arrows. They roamed the earth cutting them down, even to the unborn in the womb.

"'As the Bhrigus were being wiped out, the Bhrigu wives fled in fear to the Himalaya, son. One of them, a woman with lovely thighs, in her fear held her glowing child in one of her thighs, to make her husband's line grow. They saw that brahmin woman shining with her own light. Then the child split the thigh and came out of the brahmin woman, taking away the sight of the kshatriyas, like the sun at noon. Then, robbed of their eyes, they wandered lost in the mountain wilds. Their plans came to nothing, and the bulls of the kshatriyas, stricken with fear, went to the blameless brahmin woman for shelter, to get their sight back. Those kshatriyas, out of their wits, their light gone, in pain like fires that have gone out, said to that noble lady, "By your grace, lady, let the kshatriyas go with their sight. We will give up our wickedness and go away together. You and your son should be kind to us all, and save the kings by giving them their sight again."

"'I have not taken your sight, children," said the brahmin woman. "I bear you no anger. But surely this Bhargava, born from my thigh, is angry with you today. The great one

remembers his murdered kin, and surely it is he who has taken your eyes in his anger, without doubt. When you were killing even the unborn of the Bhrigus, my children, I carried this child in my thigh for a hundred years. The whole Veda with its six limbs entered him while he was still in the womb, to do a kindness again to the line of the Bhrigus. He surely wants to kill you, in anger for his fathers' deaths. It is by his divine power that your eyes have been stolen. So beg this fine son of mine, Aurva, children. If you bow down, he will be pleased and will release your sight."

"When she told them this, all those kings said to the one born from the thigh, "Be gracious," and he was gracious. And because he was born by splitting a thigh, uru, the good brahmin seer is famous in the worlds by the name of Aurva. When they had got their eyes back, the kings went away. But the Bhargava sage thought of the defeat of all the worlds. The great-hearted best of the Bhrigus set his whole mind, son, on destroying all the worlds, every one. Wanting to honour the Bhrigus, grown great by great austerity, he began to burn all the worlds, with gods, asuras and men, by his fierce, great austerity, to please his grandfathers.

"Then the ancestors, knowing what the best of the Bhrigus was doing, son, all came from the world of the ancestors and said to him, "Aurva, we have seen the power of your fierce austerity, son. Be kind to the worlds. Restrain your anger. It was not because we were powerless, son, that all we Bhrigus, perfected as we were, overlooked our slaughter by the kshatriyas who were killing us. When weariness came over us from our long lives, son, we ourselves wanted to be killed by the kshatriyas. It was one of us who buried that wealth in the Bhrigu's house, placing it there to cause hatred and to anger the kshatriyas. What need have we of wealth, best of brahmins, when we long for heaven? When death could not take us all, son, we saw this way, and we agreed on it. A man who kills himself does not win the fair worlds, son. That is why we thought this out, and did not destroy ourselves. What you want to do does not please us, son. Hold back your mind from this evil, the defeat of all the worlds. No kshatriyas, child, and no seven worlds, are spoiling your austerity or your power. Put away the anger that has risen in you."

"The vow I made then in anger, ancestors," said Aurva, "to destroy all the worlds, must not be made false. I cannot live with a vow of anger made in vain. If my anger is not carried through, it will burn me as fire burns its fire-stick. A man who forgives an anger that has arisen for a reason is not able to guard the three aims of life properly. Kings who want to win heaven should use anger in its place, restraining the wicked and protecting the good.

"When I lay in the bed of the womb, in the thigh, I heard the cries of my mothers when the Bhrigus were killed by the kshatriyas. When the worlds with the immortals let the lowest of the kshatriyas wipe out the Bhrigus down to the unborn, anger entered me. My mothers and my fathers, so they say, filled with fear, found no refuge in any of the worlds. When no one took in those wives of the Bhrigus, then this good woman carried me in one thigh. When there is someone in the worlds to stop a wrong, no wrongdoer is found in any world. But when the wrongdoer finds no one to stop him anywhere, many in the world take to wicked deeds. The man who knows of a wrong and has the power, yet does not stop it, though he is master, is tied to that deed himself. The kings and the lords were able to save my fathers, but they did not, thinking only of their own lives here. That is why I am angry with these worlds, and I am their master now. But I cannot go beyond your words. And if I, who have the power, look on and do nothing, I shall again be in great danger from the sin of the worlds. This fire born of my anger, which wants to take the worlds, will burn me myself if I hold it back by my own power. I know you want the

good of all the worlds. So do what is best, lords, for the worlds and for me."

""This fire born of your anger, which wants to take the worlds," said the ancestors, "let it go into the waters, bless you, for the worlds rest on the waters. All the juices are made of water. The whole world is made of water. So let this fire of anger go into the waters, best of brahmins. Let it stay in the great ocean, brahmin, if you wish, the fire born of anger, burning the waters, for the worlds are said to be made of water. So your vow will come true, sinless one, and the worlds with the immortals will not be destroyed."

""Then, son, Aurva let that fire born of anger go into the home of Varuna. And it consumes the waters in the great ocean. It has become the great Mare's Head, as those who know the Veda know, and, breathing fire from its mouth, it drinks the waters of the great ocean. So you too, bless you, should not destroy the worlds, Parashara, for you know the higher dharma, best of the wise."

Dhaumya

"When great Vasishtha said this," said the gandharva, "the brahmin seer held back his anger from destroying all the worlds. But the splendid seer Parashara, Shakti's son, the best of all who know the Veda, offered a rakshasa sacrifice. Remembering Shakti's death, the great sage burned rakshasas, old and young, in the wide-spread sacrifice. Vasishtha did not stop him from killing the rakshasas. He had decided, I will not break his second vow. In that sacrifice the great sage sat in front of the three fires, blazing, like a fourth fire. With that bright sacrifice properly offered, the sky blazed as if with the sun at the end of the rains. All the sages there, Vasishtha and the rest, thought him a second sun blazing in the sky with his splendour.

"Then the generous seer Atri came, wanting to bring that sacrifice, so hard for others to perform, to its end. So too Pulastya, Pulaha and Kratu came to the great sacrifice, tamer of enemies, wanting the rakshasas to live. Pulastya, wishing to save the rakshasas from death, bull of the Bharatas, said to Parashara, the tamer of enemies, 'I hope there is nothing to hinder you, son. Do you take joy, child, in the death of all these rakshasas, who knew nothing and did no wrong? You, the best of those who drink soma, a man of the highest standing, are doing this wholly unrighteous thing, destroying my offspring, Parashara. King Kalmashapada wants to go to heaven. And all great Vasishtha's sons, the younger brothers of Shakti, are rejoicing together with the gods. Great Vasishtha knows all this, great sage. This destruction of the rakshasas is ascetics' work, son, and you have been only its instrument in this sacrifice, joy of Vasishtha. Let the sacrifice go, bless you. Let it be finished for you.'

"When Pulastya and wise Vasishtha said this to him, Shakti's son Parashara finished the sacrifice. The sage let the fire he had gathered for the sacrifice of all the rakshasas go in a great forest on the northern flank of the Himalaya. There, to this day, that fire can be seen eating rakshasas, trees and stones, at every change of the moon."

"Why did King Kalmashapada set his own wife to lie with his teacher," asked Arjuna, "the best of those who know Brahman? And why did great Vasishtha, who knew the highest dharma and the ways of the world, lie with a woman forbidden to him? Tell me everything that happened then, for I ask."

"Dhananjaya," said the gandharva, "listen to what you ask me about Vasishtha, whom none can overcome, and King Mitrasaha. I told you before, best of the Bharatas, how the king was cursed by great Shakti, Vasishtha's son. Fallen into the power of the curse, his eyes troubled with anger, the king, the tamer of enemies, left the city with his wife. He went into an empty forest with his wife and wandered through it, gripped by the curse. It was full of herds of every kind of beast and creatures of every kind. It was covered with every kind of shrub and creeper and tree, and full of terrible noises.

"Once, overcome by hunger and looking for food for himself, he saw by a forest stream, in great distress, a brahmin woman and a brahmin who had come together to make love. When they saw him they were terrified and ran, before they had done. As they ran, the king seized the brahmin by force. When she saw her husband seized, the brahmin woman said, 'Listen to what I say to you, king, you of good vows. You were born in the line of the Sun, and you are famous in the world. You have stood carefully by dharma, and you delight in serving your teachers. You have been cursed, unconquerable one, but you should not do evil. My season has come, and I came to my husband today. I have not had

what I came for from my husband, and I long for a child. Be kind, best of kings. Let my husband go.'

"As she cried out like this, he, doing a most cruel thing, ate her husband, as a tiger eats the beast it wants. The tears that fell to the ground from her, overcome by anger, became a blazing fire and set that place ablaze. Then the brahmin woman, burning with grief and pain at her husband's fate, cursed the royal seer Kalmashapada in her anger. 'Base one, you cruelly ate my husband, my great and famous lord, before my eyes, before I had had what I came for. So you too, fool, wounded by my curse, will die as soon as you come to your wife in her season. And the seer Vasishtha, whose sons you have destroyed, will lie with your wife, and she will bear a son. That son will carry on your line, lowest of kings.' When she had cursed the king like this, that good woman of the Angiras line went into the blazing fire before his eyes.

"And the fortunate Vasishtha saw all this by his great yoga of knowledge and by his austerity, tamer of enemies. Long afterwards, when the royal seer was freed from his curse, he went to Madayanti in her season, and she held him back. Bewildered by the curse, the king had not remembered it. When he heard the queen's words, the best of kings remembered the curse and was deeply grieved. That is why the king, marked by the fault of the curse, set Vasishtha to his own wife, best of the Bharatas."

"Tell us of a family priest who would suit us," said Arjuna, "one who knows the Veda, gandharva, for you know everything."

"Devala's younger brother, Dhaumya, is practising austerity in the forest at the bathing place of Utkochaka," said the gandharva. "Choose him, if you wish."

Then Arjuna, pleased, gave the gandharva the fire weapon as the rules require, and said to him, "Let the horses stay with you for now, best of gandharvas. I will take them when the time for action comes. Farewell."

The gandharva and the Pandavas honoured each other and set out from the lovely bank of the Bhagirathi wherever they wished. Then the Pandavas went to the bathing place of Utkochaka, to Dhaumya's hermitage, and chose Dhaumya as their family priest, Bharata. Dhaumya, the best of all who know the Veda, welcomed them with water for their feet, with fruit and roots, and with his priesthood. With that brahmin at their head, the Pandavas hoped to win back their glory and their kingdom, and the Panchala princess at her bridegroom choice. Joined with that teacher, the bulls of the Bharatas and their mother felt as if they had a protector. For he knew the truth of the meaning of the Veda, their generous teacher, and that wise man who knew dharma made the Parthas his patrons. He thought the heroes, by their own dharma, had already won their kingdom, joined as they were with intelligence, courage, strength and energy, like gods. When he had blessed them, the lords of men thought they could go together to the bridegroom choice of the Panchala princess.

The Bow and the Target

Then the five Pandava brothers, tigers among men, set out to see Draupadi and that great festival of the gods. As the tigers among men, the tamers of enemies, went on with their mother, they saw many brahmins on the road, travelling in groups. The brahmins, king, said to the Pandavas, who looked like brahmin students, "Where are you going, sirs, and where have you come from?"

"You should know that we are brothers who have come from Ekachakra," said Yudhishtira, "travelling together with our mother. We worship the gods."

"Go today to the Panchalas, to Drupada's palace," said the brahmins. "There is to be a great bridegroom choice there, with very great wealth. We are going there too, in one company. There will be a great, wonderful festival. The daughter of great Drupada Yajnasena was born from the middle of the altar. Her eyes are like lotus petals. She is lovely, flawless in every limb, delicate and spirited, the sister of mighty Dhrishtadyumna, Drona's enemy, who was born in the blazing fire, bright as fire, strong-armed, with armour, sword, arrows and bow. His sister is Draupadi, flawless in every limb, slender-waisted, and the scent of blue lotuses comes from her two miles away. We are going to see Yajnasena's daughter, whose bridegroom choice is at hand, and that great festival of the gods.

"Kings and princes will come, men who sacrifice with rich gifts to the priests, who study the Veda, pure, great-hearted and strict in their vows, young and handsome, from many lands. Great warriors skilled in weapons will come, lords of the earth. Those lords of men will give gifts of every kind to win, wealth and cows, and food of every sort. We will take it all, see the bridegroom choice, enjoy the festival, and go where we like. Actors, bards and dancers, singers and heralds will gather from many lands, and mighty wrestlers. So when you have satisfied your curiosity, seen it all and taken your gifts, you great men will come back with us. Krishna may see you all standing there, handsome and godlike, and choose one of you by chance for her husband. This brother of yours is handsome and strong-armed. If he wrestles, he may win a great deal of wealth by chance."

"We will gladly go with you, sirs," said Yudhishtira, "to see that festival of the gods, the girl's bridegroom choice."

When they had been told this, Janamejaya, the Pandavas went on towards the southern Panchalas, protected by King Drupada. Then on the road the Pandavas saw great Dvaipayana, pure of soul and without stain, king. They honoured him properly, and he comforted them. When their talk was over, he gave them leave, and they went on towards Drupada's home. Looking at the lovely forests and lakes, and staying here and there, the great warriors went slowly on. Studying the Veda, pure, gentle and kindly spoken, the joys of the Kurus came in time to the Panchalas.

When the Pandavas saw the city and the camp, they made their lodging in a potter's workshop. There they lived on alms, following the way of life of brahmins. And no one anywhere knew that the heroes had come.

Yajnasena's wish was always, I would give Krishna to Kiritin, the Pandava. But he did not say this aloud. Looking for the Kaunteyas, Janamejaya, the Panchala had a stiff bow made that no one could bend, Bharata. He also had an artificial device made, hung in the

air, and with that device the king set up a golden target.

"Whoever strings this bow," said Drupada, "and with it strung shoots arrows past the device and hits the target, will win my daughter."

King Drupada proclaimed this everywhere, and when they heard it, all the kings came there, Bharata. Great seers came to see the bridegroom choice, and the Kurus led by Duryodhana, with Karna, king. Fortunate brahmins came from many lands. Great Drupada honoured the companies of kings. Then all the townspeople, roaring like the ocean, came to Shishumarapura, and the kings took their places.

North-east of the city, on level, fair ground, the arena shone, surrounded on every side by buildings. It had a wall and a moat, and was decked with gates and arches. It was covered all over with a bright canopy. It rang with hundreds of trumpets, was scented with costly aloe smoke, sprinkled with sandal water and adorned with garlands. It was enclosed on every side by fine tall palaces like the peaks of Kailasa, scraping the sky. They were hung with nets of gold, floored with gems, with easy stairs and great seats, covered with fine cloths, scented with the best aloe, white as swans, fragrant for miles around. They had a hundred wide doors, with beds and seats, their walls inlaid with many metals, like the peaks of the Himalaya.

There, on stands of many kinds, well adorned, all the kings sat vying with one another. People saw them sitting there, of great spirit and courage, lions among kings, fortunate, decked with black aloe, generous, good to brahmins, protectors of their kingdoms, loved by all the world for their good deeds. The people of the city and the country sat on costly platforms all round, to delight in seeing Krishna. The Pandavas sat with the brahmins, looking at the matchless wealth of the Panchala king.

The gathering went on for many days, king, with many gifts of jewels, and lit up by actors and dancers. On the sixteenth day, while the lovely gathering was going on, Draupadi came down into the arena, bull of the Bharatas. She had bathed, and she was beautifully dressed and decked with every ornament. She carried the golden bowl for the hero, finely adorned. The Somakas' family priest, a pure brahmin who knew the mantras, spread the grass and poured ghee into the fire as the rules require. When he had satisfied the fire and had the brahmins speak blessings, he silenced all the instruments on every side.

When it was silent, lord of the people, Dhrishtadyumna went into the middle of the arena, and in a voice as deep as a cloud he spoke these words aloud, gently, full of meaning.

"Here is the bow, here is the target, and here are the arrows. Hear me, all you kings. Shoot the target through the opening of the device with five arrows that fly through the air. Whoever does this very hard deed, and has family, beauty and strength, today this sister of mine, Krishna, will be his wife. I do not lie."

When he had said this to them, Drupada's son turned to Draupadi, and named for her the kings who had gathered, by name, by family and by deeds.

The Bow Is Strung

"Duryodhana, Durvishaha, Durmukha, Dushpradharshana," said Dhrishtadyumna, "Vivimshati, Vikarna, Saha and Duhshasana; Yuyutsu, Vatavega, Bhimavegadharma, Ugrayudha, Balaki, Kanakayu and Virochana; Sukundala, Chitrasena, Suvarchas, Kanakadhvaja, Nandaka, Bahushali, Kundaja and Vikata. These and many other mighty sons of Dhritarashtra have come for you with Karna, heroes, a hundred of them, great-hearted, famous bulls among kshatriyas.

"Shakuni, Bala, Vrishaka and Brihadbala, all the sons of the king of Gandhara, have come. Ashvatthama and Bhoja, the best of all who carry weapons, have come together for you, great-hearted, finely adorned.

"Brihanta, Maniman, mighty Dandadhara, Sahadeva, Jayatsena and Meghasandhi of Magadha. Virata with his two sons, Shankha and Uttara. Vardhakshemi, Suvarchas and King Senabindu. Abhibhu with his son, the glorious Sudama. Sumitra, Sukumara, Vrika and Satyadhriti. Suryadhvaja, Rochamana, Nila and Chitrayudha, Amshuman, Chekitana, and mighty Shreniman. Samudrasena's son, the valiant Chandrasena. Jalasandha, and the father and son Sudanda and Danda. Paundraka Vasudeva, and mighty Bhagadatta. The king of Kalinga, the king of Tamralipta, and the lord of Pattana. The king of Madra, Shalya, the great warrior, with his sons, the hero Rukmangada and Rukmaratha. Somadatta of the Kuru line, and his three sons, great warriors and heroes, Bhuri, Bhurishravas and Shala. Sudakshina of Kamboja, and Dridhadhanva of the Kuru line. Brihadbala, Sushena, and Shibi, Ushinara's son.

"Samkarshana, Vasudeva, and Rukmini's mighty son. Samba, Charudeshna, Sarana and Gada. Akrura, Satyaki, and mighty Uddhava. Kritavarma, Hridika's son, Prithu and Viprithu. Viduratha, Kanka, Samika, Saramejaya, the hero Vatapati, Jhilli and Pindaraka, and valiant Ushinara. These are named as the Vrishnis.

"Bhagiratha, Brihatkshatra, and Jayadratha of Sindhu. Brihadratha, Bahlika, and Shrutayu, the great warrior. King Uluka, son of the gambler, Chitrangada and Shubhangada, wise Vatsaraja, and the lord of Kosala.

"These and many other lords of many lands have come for you, good lady, kshatriyas famous on earth. These valiant men will shoot at the fine target for you. Choose today, lovely one, the man who hits this target."

The young men, adorned, wearing earrings, came together, vying with one another. Each thought that weapons and strength were in himself, and they all sprang up in their pride. Proud of their beauty, their courage, their families, their dharma and their youth, they were like the lordly elephants of the Himalaya in rut, bursting with passion. Eyeing one another as rivals, their bodies flooded with desire, they rose quickly from the kings' seats, saying, "Krishna is mine!" The kshatriyas gathered in the arena, each wanting to win Drupada's daughter, shone like the hosts of the gods gathered round Uma, daughter of the king of the mountains. Their bodies pierced by the arrows of the god of love, their hearts gone to Krishna, the kings came down into the arena for Drupada's daughter, and there even friends became enemies.

Then the hosts of the gods came in their flying chariots: the Rudras and Adityas, the Vasus and the two Ashvins, all the Sadhyas and the Maruts, with Yama and the lord of

wealth in front. The daityas came, and the great birds, the great snakes, the divine seers, the guhyakas and the charanas, Vishvavasu, Narada and Parvata, and the chief gandharvas with the apsaras.

Balarama was there, and Keshava, with the leading men of the Vrishnis and Andhakas. Those bulls of the Yadus watched, and they held to Krishna's view.

Then the hero of the Yadus saw the five Parthas. They were like mighty elephants in rut, like lordly elephants with their foreheads marked for battle, like fires covered with ash. He thought about them, and he pointed out to Rama Yudhishtira, Bhima, Jishnu and the twin heroes. Rama looked at them slowly, one by one, and then looked at Janardana with a glad heart.

The other kings, the sons and grandsons of many kings, their eyes, minds and hearts gone to Krishna, strained to look at her as she moved about, biting their lips, their faces red. So too the Parthas, strong-armed, and the twin heroes, the great-spirited pair, all looked at Draupadi then, and all of them were struck by the arrows of the god of love.

The place was crowded with divine seers and gandharvas, visited by the great birds, the snakes, the asuras and the siddhas. It was filled with a heavenly scent, and heavenly garlands were scattered over it. The sky was full of the great roar of kettledrums. It was thronged on every side with flying chariots, and it rang with the sound of flutes, lutes and drums.

Then the companies of kings, one after another, tried their strength for Krishna. But they could not string that tough bow, even with all their might. As they strained at it, the stiff bow sprang back and threw the lords of men. They were seen writhing on the ground, wretched, their hearts broken. The stiff bow had crushed and broken their armlets and earrings. Crying out, their hopes of Krishna gone, the circle of kings was in distress.

When all the people in the gathering were in turmoil, and the lords of men had given up their boasting, the hero Jishnu, Kunti's son, wanted to string that bow and fit the arrows to it.

When the kings had turned away from stringing the bow, generous Jishnu rose from among the brahmins. When they saw Partha setting out, bright as Indra's banner, the chief brahmins shouted and waved their deerskins. Some of them were downcast, and some were glad.

Some who were shrewd and lived by their wits said to one another, "Brahmins, the bow that Karna, Shalya and the other kings could not bend, men famous in the world, strong, and devoted to the science of the bow, how can a mere lad string it, untrained in weapons and much weaker in strength? The brahmins will be laughed at before all the kings if this task, taken on in rashness and without thought, is not carried through. If he has set out to draw the bow out of pride, or in excitement, or from a brahmin's rashness, he should be stopped. It would be good if he did not go. Then we will not be laughed at, we will not be made light of, and we will not earn the hatred of the lords of the earth."

Others said, "He is young and handsome, like the trunk of a lord of elephants, with thick shoulders, thighs and arms, and as steady as the Himalaya. This deed is possible

for him. You can tell from his spirit. He has power, and great spirit. A man with no power would not go up of his own accord. And there is nothing that happens in the worlds, among all that move and all that stay, that brahmins cannot do. Brahmins who live on water, who live on air, who eat fruit, firm in their vows, are strong though they are weak, for brahmins have the power of Brahman. A brahmin should not be despised, whether he does good or bad, whether the task that comes to him is pleasant or painful, great or small."

While the brahmins were talking like this, saying many things, Arjuna stood by the bow, as unmoving as a mountain. He walked round the bow, keeping it on his right. He bowed his head, and joyfully the tamer of enemies took it up. In the blink of an eye he strung it. He took the five arrows and shot the target, and the target fell through the opening to the ground, pierced through at once.

Then there was a noise in the sky, and a great uproar in the middle of the gathering. The god rained heavenly flowers on the head of Partha, the slayer of his enemies. People waved their cloths, and there were shouts on every side, and showers of flowers fell from the sky all round. The musicians played on instruments of a hundred kinds, and companies of bards and heralds sang praises there in fine voices.

When Drupada, the destroyer of his enemies, saw him, he was delighted, and he wanted to help Partha with his army.

While the great noise was going on, Yudhishtira, the best of those who uphold dharma, went quickly back to their lodging with the twins, the best of men.

When she saw the target pierced, and when she saw Partha, like Shakra, Krishna took the white garland of choice and went to Kunti's son, smiling.

He took her, having won her in the arena. Honoured by the brahmins, the man of unimaginable deeds went out of the arena, and his wife followed him.

The Kings Attack

When Drupada wished to give his daughter to that great brahmin, anger rose in the kings, and they looked at one another close at hand.

"He has passed us over," they said, "and treats us, gathered here, like straw. He wants to give Draupadi, the best of women, to a brahmin. Let us kill this wicked man, who does not respect us. By his qualities he deserves neither honour nor the respect due to age. Let us kill this evil-doer, this enemy of kings, together with his son. He invited all the kings, honoured them, and fed them well, and afterwards he insults them. In this gathering of kings, like a meeting of the gods, did he see no king who was a fit match? Brahmins have no right to be chosen. The bridegroom choice is for kshatriyas. That is the well-known tradition. Or if this girl does not want any of us here, let us throw her into the fire and go back to our kingdoms, kings.

"But the brahmin, even if he has done this thing that displeases the lords of kings out of childishness or greed, must not be killed on any account. For our kingdoms, our lives, our wealth, our sons and grandsons and whatever else we have, are there for the sake of brahmins. We do this for fear of dishonour, and to guard our own dharma, so that other bridegroom choices do not go this way."

When they had said this, the tigers among kings, with arms like iron bars, ran gladly at Drupada with their weapons, meaning to seize him. When Drupada saw the angry kings rushing at him, their bows and quivers in their hands, he took shelter with the brahmins in fear.

The two sons of Pandu, of great courage, the tamers of enemies, went to meet the kings as they came on at speed, like elephants in rut. Then the kings, their finger guards bound on, rose up with their weapons raised. They could not bear it, and they meant to kill the two Kuru princes, Arjuna and Bhimasena.

Then Bhima, of wonderful courage and deeds, of great strength, with a strength like the thunderbolt, the lone hero, tore up a tree with his arms and stripped off its leaves, like a lord of elephants. Taking that tree, the long-armed Partha, the crusher of enemies, stood near Partha, the bull among men, like the king of the dead with his fierce staff.

When he saw that deed of Jishnu's brother, beyond the reach of human thought, Damodara, whose deeds are beyond imagining, spoke to his brother Halayudha, of fierce courage.

"That man who walks like a bull in rut, and draws the great bow as tall as a palm tree, is Arjuna. There is no doubt of it, Samkarshana, if I am Vasudeva. That one who tore up the tree with force and turned suddenly when the kings made their move is Vrikodara. No one else on earth born to die could do such a thing today. The one who went out before them, Achyuta, with long lotus eyes, slender, moving like a great lion, well-mannered, fair-skinned, with a long, bright, handsome nose, is the Dharma King. And those two young men, like Karttikeya, I think are the sons of the Ashvins. For I heard that the sons of Pandu and Pritha escaped from the burning of the lac house."

Then Halayudha, like a cloud without a stain, said gladly to his younger brother, "I am pleased. By good fortune our father's sister Pritha has escaped with the best of the

Kurus."

The bulls of the brahmins, shaking their deerskins and water pots, said, "Do not be afraid. We will fight the enemy."

Arjuna, as if laughing, said to the brahmins as they spoke, "Stand to one side and watch. I will scatter these angry men with hundreds of straight arrows and hold them back, as snakes are held back with mantras."

With that the great warrior took up the bow he had won as the bride-price, and stood with his brother Bhima, as unmoving as a mountain. Then the two of them, without fear, rushed at the kshatriyas led by Karna, who had risen in anger, as elephants rush at rival elephants.

The kings, wanting to kill, spoke harsh words. "In battle even a brahmin who wants to fight may be killed. It has been seen."

Then Karna Vaikartana went at Arjuna with force, wanting to fight, like an elephant going at a rival elephant for the sake of a cow elephant. Shalya, the strong lord of the Madras, went at Bhimasena. Duryodhana and the others fought with the brahmins in that battle, lightly and without effort.

Then wise Arjuna drew his strong bow and struck Karna Vaikartana with three arrows as he came on. Dazed by the force of those sharp, fiercely bright arrows, Radheya pressed after him with an effort. Those two, the best of victors, fought in fury, each wanting to defeat the other, so fast that no one could follow them.

"See how I answer what you do!"

"See the strength of my arms!"

So they called to each other in heroes' words. Then Karna Vaikartana, knowing that the strength of Arjuna's arms had no equal on earth, fought on in anger. He struck down the swift arrows Arjuna shot at him and roared aloud, and the fighters cheered him.

"I am pleased, chief of brahmins," said Karna, "with the strength of your arms in battle, with your courage, and with your training in arms and weapons. Are you the science of the bow in person, best of brahmins, or Rama? Or are you Indra of the bay horses himself, or Vishnu, Achyuta, himself? You have put on a brahmin's form to hide yourself, and you rely on the strength of your arms to fight me. For when I am angry in battle, no other man can fight me except Shachi's husband himself, or the Pandava Kiritin."

When he said this, Phalguna answered him. "I am not the science of the bow, Karna, and I am not mighty Rama. I am a brahmin, the best of fighters, the best of all who carry weapons. By my teacher's teaching I am grounded in the Brahma weapon and in Indra's weapon. I stand here today in battle to defeat you. Stand firm, hero."

When he was told this, Radheya Karna, the great warrior, turned back from the fight, thinking that the power of a brahmin could not be overcome.

Meanwhile Shalya and Vrikodara, king, fought there. Both were strong, and both were

maddened with rivalry and strength. Challenging each other like two great elephants in rut, they struck each other with fists and knees, and for a while they dragged each other about the field. Then Bhima, the best of the strong, lifted Shalya in his arms and threw him down, and the brahmins laughed. And the bull among men, Bhimasena, did a wonderful thing there: when strong Shalya had fallen to the ground, the strong man did not kill him.

With Shalya thrown down by Bhimasena, and Karna afraid, all the kings grew uneasy and surrounded Vrikodara. "Well done, these bulls among brahmins," they said together. "Let us find out where they were born and where they live. For who can fight Radha's son Karna in battle, except Rama, or Drona, or Kripa, Sharadvat's son? Or Krishna, son of Devaki, or Phalguna, the tamer of enemies? And who can fight Duryodhana in battle? Or Shalya, the king of the Madras, the best of the strong, except the hero Baladeva, or the Pandava Vrikodara? Let us draw back from this fight with the brahmins. When we have found out who they are, we will fight them again."

Krishna, who had seen Bhima's deed, suspected that those two were Kunti's sons. He held the kings back, persuading them all with the words, "She was won by dharma."

So those kings, skilled in war, turned back from the fight, and all the best of kings went back to their lodgings, amazed. Those who had gathered there went away saying, "The arena has gone to the brahmins. The Panchala princess is surrounded by brahmins."

Hidden among the brahmins, who wore deerskins, Bhimasena and Dhananjaya made their way there with difficulty. Free at last from the press of people, wounded by their enemies, the two heroes shone, and Krishna followed them.

Their mother, meanwhile, thought of every kind of disaster, as her sons did not come and the time for alms went by. *Have the Dhartarashtras recognised the bulls of the Kurus and killed them? Or fierce rakshasas, full of magic, bitter enemies? Has even great Vyasa's word turned out the opposite?* So Pritha thought, in her love for her sons.

Then, late in the afternoon, like the sun hidden by clouds, Jishnu came in with the brahmins, with brahmins in front of him.

Share It All Together

The two great Parthas, the best of men, went to the potter's workshop and came to Pritha. Full of joy, they presented Yajnasena's daughter to her as "alms".

Kunti was inside the hut, and she did not look at her sons. "Share it, all of you together," she said.

Afterwards Kunti looked at the girl, and she said, "What a terrible thing I have said!"

Afraid of doing wrong, and ashamed, Kunti took Yajnasena's daughter, who was full of joy, by the hand, and went to Yudhishtira and said, "This is King Drupada's daughter. Your younger brothers gave her to me. And without thinking, son, I said what I always say: 'Share it together,' king. Tell me, bull of the Kurus, how what I said today may not become a lie, and how no wrong, such as has never been before, may fall on the daughter of the Panchala king."

King Yudhishtira, of the highest energy, the hero of the Kurus, thought for a moment. He comforted his mother Kunti, and he said to Dhananjaya, "You won Yajnasena's daughter, Pandava, and the princess will be happy with you. Let the fire be lit and the offerings made. Take her hand as the rites require."

"Do not make me a sharer in wrong, lord of men," said Arjuna. "This is not a dharma that others follow. You should marry first. Then this strong-armed Bhima, of unimaginable deeds. Then I. Then Nakula after me, and Madri's son Sahadeva last. Vrikodara and I and the twins, king, and this girl, we all belong to you. Things being as they are, think, and do what should be done here, what is right and brings honour, and what would please the Panchala king. Tell us. We all stand under your command."

They all looked at glorious Krishna standing there. Then, sitting there, they looked at one another, and each held her in his heart. For as they looked at Draupadi, love rose up in all of them, men of boundless energy, and threw their senses into turmoil. The Panchala princess's lovely beauty had been made by the Creator himself. It was greater than that of other women, and it stole the hearts of all beings.

Kunti's son Yudhishtira understood their looks and their feelings. Remembering all of Dvaipayana's words, bull among men, and afraid of a split among them, the king said to his brothers, "Lovely Draupadi will be the wife of us all."

When they heard their elder brother's words, the sons of Pandu, men of boundless energy, sat there, all of them turning the matter over in their minds.

Meanwhile the hero of the Vrishnis, who had guessed that these were the heroes of the Kurus, came with Rohini's son to the potter's workshop where those heroes were sitting. There Krishna and Rohini's son saw long-armed Ajatashatru seated, and the others sitting round him, shining like fire. Vasudeva went up to Kunti's son, the best of those who uphold dharma. Pressing the feet of King Yudhishtira of the Ajamidha line, he said, "I am Krishna." Rohini's son did the same after him. The Kurus welcomed the two of them with joy. And the two heroes of the Yadus clasped the feet of their father's sister, chief of the Bharatas.

Ajatashatru, the hero of the Kurus, told Krishna that all was well, and asked after him. "How did you find us out, Vasudeva," he asked, "when we were all living here in hiding?"

Vasudeva laughed. "Fire is known even when it is hidden, king. Who among men could do such a deed of courage, except the Pandavas? By good fortune all of you Pandavas, the crushers of enemies, have escaped from that fire. By good fortune the wicked son of Dhritarashtra and his ministers have not had their wish. Bless you. Grow, like a hidden fire that is fed. Let none of the kings here know you. We two will go back to our camp now."

With the Pandava's leave, he of unfading glory went quickly away with Baladeva.

Dhrishtadyumna, the Panchala, had followed the two joys of the Kurus as they went to the potter's house. Without being recognised, he set men all round, and he himself stayed hidden near the potter's house.

In the evening Bhima, the crusher of enemies, Jishnu, and the great twins went out for alms, and in good spirits they brought what they had been given to Yudhishtira.

Then generous Kunti, when the time came, spoke to Drupada's daughter. "Take the first portion of this, good lady, and make the offering to the gods, and give alms to a brahmin. Give to those who want food, the people who have come to shelter round us. Then quickly divide what is left. Half is for the four and for me and for you. Give the other half, good lady, to Bhima, the one who looks like a bull in rut, the dark young man, strong of build. This hero always eats a great deal."

The princess, delighted, and trusting that what she said was right, did just as she was told, the good woman, and they all ate.

Madri's son Sahadeva, the swift, made a bed of kusha grass on the ground. Each of the heroes spread his own deerskin, and they slept on the ground. The best of the Kurus lay with their heads to the south, the quarter ruled by Agastya. Kunti lay above their heads, and Krishna lay across at their feet. She lay on the ground with the sons of Pandu on the kusha grass, as if she had been made a pillow for their feet. There was no sorrow in her, and she did not think less of those bulls of the Kurus.

The heroes told one another wonderful stories about armies, about heavenly weapons, chariots and elephants, swords, maces and axes.

Then the son of the Panchala king heard the stories they told, and he saw Krishna lying there, and all his men saw them too. Prince Dhrishtadyumna went quickly to tell King Drupada everything that had happened and everything they had said in the night.

The Panchala king was downcast, because he had not found the Pandavas. The great man questioned Dhrishtadyumna. "Where has Krishna gone? Who has taken her? Surely she has not gone to a shudra, or to a man of low birth, or to a vaishya who pays tribute? Surely no foot smeared with dirt has been set on my head? Surely the garland has not fallen on a burning ground? Is he a man of the best of our own class, or even of a higher class? Surely no one has set his left foot on my head today, son, by touching Krishna? Shall I make offerings in great joy, joined with Partha, the bull among men? Tell me truly, great one: who is this who has won my daughter today? Are the sons of that hero of the Kurus, Vichitravirya's son, alive today? Was it Partha, the younger brother, who took up

the bow today and brought down the target?"

Drupada's Test

When he was asked this, Prince Dhrishtadyumna, the best of the Somakas, was delighted, and he told his father what had happened, and who had taken Krishna.

"That young man with long red eyes," he said, "wearing a black deerskin, as handsome as a god, who strung the finest bow and brought the target down to the ground, went away unhindered, swift, surrounded and honoured by the chief brahmins. He strode like the wielder of the thunderbolt among the sons of Diti, attended by all the gods and seers. And Krishna took hold of his deerskin and followed him gladly, like a cow elephant after her mate. The kings could not bear it, and they rushed at him in anger. Then another man, in the middle of the kings, tore up a great tree and drove the crowds of kings back, like angry Death driving living things before him.

"While the kings looked on, lord of men, those two best of men took Krishna and went, shining like the moon and the sun, to a potter's workshop outside the city. A woman sat there like a flame of fire. I think she is their mother. And round her sat three other fine men like fires. The two of them bowed at her feet, and told Krishna, 'Greet her.' They handed Krishna over to her and stayed there, and then those best of men went out to beg for alms.

"Krishna took their alms, made the offering to the gods, and gave a share to a brahmin. She served the old woman and those fine men, and then she ate herself. Then they all slept, king. Krishna was the pillow for their feet. Their bed was on the ground, spread with darbha grass and fine deerskins. Like dark clouds thundering, they told one another wonderful stories. The heroes did not tell the kind of stories vaishyas or shudras would tell, or brahmins either. There is no doubt they are bulls among kshatriyas, king, from the way they talk of war. Our hope has plainly come true, for we have heard that the Parthas escaped the fire. From the way he strung the bow by force and brought down the target, and from the way they talk to each other, the Parthas are surely going about in disguise."

Then King Drupada, delighted, sent his family priest to them. "Say to them, 'We would know you. Are you the great sons of Pandu?'"

The king's priest took the message, went, and praised them. Then, knowing the proper order, he gave them the king's whole message properly, point by point.

"Drupada, king of the Panchalas, lord of the earth, wants to know who you are, you who deserve the best. For since he saw this man who pierced the target, he can see no end to his joy. So tell us, in order, your kin, your family and your line. Set your foot on the heads of your enemies. Delight this heart of mine, the heart of the Panchala king and his people. King Pandu was King Drupada's dear friend, as dear as himself. This was his wish: 'If only this daughter of mine could be the Kaurava's daughter-in-law.' And this wish has always been in King Drupada's heart, you of blameless form: that long-armed Arjuna might win my daughter by dharma."

When the priest had said this, and stood there modestly, the king looked at him and said to Bhima, who was near, "Give him water for his feet and the guest offering. He is King Drupada's respected priest, and he should be shown more honour than most."

Bhima did so, lord of men, and the priest accepted the honour.

When the priest was comfortably seated, Yudhishtira said to the brahmin, "The Panchala king gave his daughter as he wished, looking to his own dharma. King Drupada set the price for her, and this hero met it. No question of class was raised there, nor of livelihood, nor of family or line. She was given for the bow strung and the target pierced. That is how this great man won Krishna here, in the middle of the crowd of kings.

"Since this is so, King Drupada of the Somakas has no reason to grieve today and make himself unhappy. And King Drupada's wish will come true as well. For I think, brahmin, that this princess, who could not be had by others, has been rightly won. That bow could not be strung by a man of little strength. Nor could a man untrained in weapons, or of low birth, bring down the target like that. So the Panchala king has no reason to grieve for his daughter today. No man on earth could have brought the target down in any other way."

While Yudhishtira was still speaking, another man came quickly from the Panchala king to announce that the food was ready.

"King Drupada has had food prepared for the wedding party," said the messenger, "for the wedding. Come to it when you have finished everything, and Krishna too. Do not be long. Here are chariots fit for kings, painted with golden lotuses and yoked with fine horses. Mount them, all of you, and come to the Panchala king's palace."

So the bulls of the Kurus set out. They sent the priest ahead and mounted those great carriages, and Kunti and Krishna rode together.

Now the king, Bharata, had heard what the Dharma King had said to the priest. So, simply to test the best of the Kurus, he gathered things of many kinds. He had fruit brought, and fine garlands, shields, armour and seats, and cows, king, and ropes, and other things for farming. All the things that belong to the other crafts were set out there, complete, and everything used for sport. The king brought all these there. There was gleaming armour for chariots and horses, great swords, and fine horse chariots, excellent bows and the best arrows, spears and lances decked with gold. There were javelins and bhushundis and axes, and all the gear of war, and beds and seats finely made, of every kind.

Kunti took the good Krishna and went into Drupada's women's quarters, and the women, in good spirits, honoured her, the queen of the Kuru king.

Then the king, and all the king's ministers, the king's sons and his friends, and all his servants, king, looked at those heroes. They had the gait of lions and the eyes of great bulls. They wore deerskins as their upper garments. Their shoulders were broad, and their arms were long, like the coils of lords of snakes. And they were all overjoyed.

Without hesitation the heroes sat down in order of age on the finest seats, with footstools, and they showed no wonder at the costly things. Men and women servants, finely dressed, and the cooks brought them food of every kind, fit for kings, on plates of gold and silver. When the heroes had eaten there as much as they wanted, well content, they passed by all the other goods and went to the gear of war.

When Drupada's son and the king, with all his chief ministers, saw this, they came up gladly and honoured Kunti's sons, the sons and grandsons of kings.

One Wife for Five

Then the glorious Panchala sent for Prince Yudhishtira and received him with the welcome due to a brahmin. The great man, undaunted, questioned Kunti's splendid son.

"How are we to know you? Are you kshatriyas or brahmins? Are you vaishyas of fine qualities, or men born of shudra mothers? Or are you perfected beings who wander everywhere by magic, and have come from heaven for Krishna's sake, wanting to see her? Tell us the truth, for our doubt is great. Will our minds be at rest when our doubt is ended? Will our fortune be good, tamer of enemies? Tell the truth, of your own free will. Truth becomes kings. And for the sake of the merit of sacrifices and good works, a lie should not be told. When I have heard your answer, godlike tamer of enemies, I will certainly go ahead with the marriage as the rules require."

"Do not be downcast, king," said Yudhishtira. "Be glad, Panchala. The wish you cherished has surely come true, without any doubt. For we are kshatriyas, king, the sons of great Pandu. Know that I am the eldest son of Kunti, and these are Bhimasena and Arjuna, by whom your daughter was won in the assembly of kings. The twins, king of kings, are where Krishna is. Let the sorrow in your heart go, bull among men. We are kshatriyas. Your daughter has gone like a lotus from one lake to another. This is the truth, great king. I tell you all of it. For you are our elder and our highest refuge."

Then King Drupada's eyes rolled with joy, and for a while he could not answer Yudhishtira properly. With an effort the tamer of enemies held back his joy, and then the king gave Yudhishtira a fitting answer. The righteous king asked him how they had fled before, and the Pandava told him everything in order. When he had heard what Kunti's son said, King Drupada condemned Dhritarashtra, the lord of the people. He comforted Yudhishtira, Kunti's son, and Drupada, the best of speakers, promised to win him his kingdom.

Then Kunti and Krishna, Bhimasena and Arjuna and the twins went into a great house, as the king had directed. They lived there, king, honoured by Yajnasena.

When they were at ease again, the king and his sons said to them, "Let the joy of the Kurus, strong-armed Arjuna, take her hand today as the rites require. Let him hold the celebration on a holy day."

Then Yudhishtira, the Dharma King, said to him, "I too must first take a wife, lord of the people."

"Then take my daughter's hand yourself, as the rites require," said Drupada, "or give Krishna to whichever of your brothers you think fit, hero."

"Draupadi will be the queen of all of us, king," said Yudhishtira. "So my mother said before, lord of the people. I am not yet married, and neither is Bhimasena the Pandava. And this daughter of yours, a jewel, was won by Partha. This is our agreement, king, that we share a jewel together. We do not want to give up that agreement, best of kings. By dharma Krishna will be the queen of all of us. Let her take the hand of each of us in turn before the fire."

"Many queens are ordained for one man, joy of the Kurus," said Drupada, "but never many

men for one woman. You are righteous and pure, Kaunteya. You should not do a wrong that is against the ways of the world and against the Veda. Why is your mind set on this?"

"Dharma is subtle, great king," said Yudhishtira. "We do not know its way. We follow the path that those before us have walked, one after another. My tongue has never spoken a lie, and my mind does not turn to wrong. My mother says so, and it is what I have in mind. This is firm dharma, king. Follow it without hesitating. Do not have any misgivings about it at all, lord of the earth."

"You, Kaunteya, and Kunti and my son Dhrishtadyumna," said Drupada, "talk over what should be done. Tomorrow we will do it at the proper time."

So they all met and talked it over, Bharata. And then Dvaipayana came there, by chance, king.

All the Pandavas and the glorious Panchala rose to meet him, and when they saw the great Krishna Dvaipayana they honoured him. The great-minded seer greeted them all in turn, asked after their welfare, and sat down on a bright golden seat. Then, at the word of Krishna of boundless splendour, all those best of men sat down on costly seats.

After a moment Drupada, Prishata's son, the lord of the people, spoke sweetly, and asked the great one about Draupadi. "How can one woman be the wife of many men, and yet there be no confusion of dharma? Let the blessed one tell us all this truly."

"This dharma has lapsed," said Vyasa, "and it is against the world and the Veda. On this I want to hear what each of you thinks."

"I think it is wrong," said Drupada, "against the world and the Veda. There is no one wife of many men, best of brahmins. Nor did the great men of old follow this dharma. And a dharma that is held in so many ways should not be followed as if it were eternal. So I cannot make up my mind to act in this way. It seems to me clouded with doubt about dharma."

"How can an elder brother," said Dhrishtadyumna, "if he is a man of good conduct, go to his younger brother's wife, bull of brahmins, rich in austerity? Because dharma is subtle, we cannot tell its way at all. People like us cannot decide whether this is wrong or right, brahmin. So I cannot resolve, in any way, that Krishna should be the queen of five."

"My tongue has not spoken a lie," said Yudhishtira, "and my mind does not turn to wrong. My heart goes this way, and it is not wrong in any way. We hear in the Purana, too, that a woman of the Gautama line named Jatila lived with seven seers, best of those who uphold dharma. They say that a teacher's word is dharma, best of those who know dharma, and of all teachers the mother is the highest. And she has said, 'Share it like alms.' So I think this is dharma, best of brahmins."

"It is as righteous Yudhishtira says," said Kunti. "I am terribly afraid of a lie. How can I be freed from a lie?"

"You will be freed from the lie, good lady," said Vyasa, "and this is eternal dharma. But I will not tell it in front of everyone. Listen to me yourself, Panchala, how this dharma was ordained and why it is eternal. As Kaunteya has said, so is dharma. There is

no doubt of it."

Then the blessed lord Vyasa Dvaipayana rose, took the king by the hand, and went into the king's house. The Pandavas and Kunti, and Dhrishtadyumna, Prishata's grandson, stayed there, anxious, waiting for the two of them. Then Dvaipayana told the great king how it could be dharma for many men to have one wife.

Chapter 78

The Five Indras

"Long ago," said Vyasa, "the gods held a long sacrifice in the Naimisha forest. There, king, Yama, Vivasvat's son, served as the slaughterer. So Yama, while he was consecrated there, king, killed no one among living creatures. Then those creatures grew very many, for time passed them by and they were freed from death.

"Then Shakra, Varuna and Kubera, the Sadhyas, the Rudras, the Vasus and the two Ashvins, and other gods too, came to Prajapati, the maker of the world. They gathered and said to the teacher of the worlds, 'A terrible fear has come on us from the growing number of men. Troubled by that fear, and wanting to be at ease, we have all come to you for shelter.'

"'Why should you fear men,' said Brahma, 'when you are all immortal? Let no fear ever come to you from mortals.'

"'Mortals have become immortal,' said the gods. 'There is no difference between us any more. That is what troubles us, and we have come here so that there may be a difference.'

"'Vivasvat's son is busy with the sacrifice,' said Brahma, 'and that is why these men do not die. When he is free again, and all his work is done, then their time to end will come. Vivasvat's son's body will be made mighty by your strength and set to work. It will be their end when the time of their ending comes. For that body will be a power among men.'

"When they had heard the first-born god's words, the gods went back to where the gods were sacrificing. As those mighty ones sat there together, they saw a lotus in the Bhagirathi. They were amazed when they saw it, and Indra, the hero among them, set out. Where the Ganga springs out for ever, he saw a woman as bright as fire. The woman was weeping there. She had come for water, and she stood in the goddess Ganga. A drop of her tears fell into the water, and there it was a golden lotus.

"When he saw that wonder, the wielder of the thunderbolt went close to the woman and asked her, 'Who are you? Why are you weeping? For whose sake? Tell me the truth, if you will.'

"'You will know who I am, Shakra,' said the woman, 'and why I weep, unhappy as I am. Come, king. I will go ahead. You will see why it is that I weep.'

"He followed her as she went. Close by he saw a handsome young man seated on a lion throne with a young woman beside him, playing at dice on the peak of the king of mountains.

"The king of the gods said to him, 'Know that this whole world is mine, under my power. I am its lord.' He said this in anger, when he saw the young man wholly absorbed in the dice.

"When he saw Shakra angry, the god laughed and looked up slowly at Shakra. Then the king of the gods was frozen. At that look he stood still like a post.

"When he had had enough of his game, the god said to the weeping woman, 'Bring him here, near me, so that pride never enters him again.'

"As soon as she touched him, Shakra's limbs went slack, and he fell to the ground. The blessed god of fierce power said to him, 'Never do such a thing again, Shakra. Roll aside this great king of mountains, for your strength and courage are beyond measure, and go into its heart, where others like you sit, bright as the sun.'

"He opened up the peak of the great mountain, and he saw four others of the same splendour. When he saw them he was grieved. *Surely I will not become like these?*

"Then the mountain god opened his eyes wide and said in anger to the wielder of the thunderbolt, 'Go into this cave, god of a hundred sacrifices, since in your childishness you scorned me just now.'

"When the lord said this to him, the king of the gods shook violently at the blow, his limbs slack, like a pipal leaf blown by the wind on the peak of the king of mountains. Told this so suddenly, he joined his hands, bowed his head, and, trembling, said to the fierce god of many forms, 'Blessed one, look on me with favour today.'

"The god of the fierce bow laughed at him. 'Those with such a nature do not win favour here. These others were like this before. So go into this cave and lie there. Your favour will come in this way, have no doubt. All of you must enter a human womb. There you will do deeds that no one can withstand, and bring many others to their death. Then you will come back to the world of Indra, the precious world you won before by your own deeds. All that I have said must be done, and much else, for many purposes.'

"'We will go from the world of the gods to the world of men,' said the earlier Indras, 'where release is ordained, hard to win. But let the gods place us in our mother: Dharma, Vayu, Maghavan and the Ashvins.'

"When he heard this, the wielder of the thunderbolt spoke again to the best of the gods. 'By my own power I will give a man for the task, born of me, to be the fifth of them.'

"The blessed god of the fierce bow, in his kindness, granted their wish as they had asked. And he appointed that woman, lovely to all the world, who was Shri, to be their wife among men.

"Then the god went with them to Narayana, who is beyond measure, and he too ordained it all. Then they were all born on earth. And Hari pulled out two hairs, one white and one black. Those two hairs entered two women of the Yadu family, Rohini and Devaki. Of the two, one became Baladeva, and the second, the black one, became Keshava.

"Those who were once shut up in the form of Indras in that cave of the northern mountain are these mighty Pandavas here. The Pandava Savyasachin is a portion of Shakra. That is how these Pandavas were born, king, who were Indras before. And Lakshmi was appointed long ago to be their wife. She is this Draupadi of divine form. For how else, except by the design of the gods, could a woman rise from the ground at the end of a rite, with beauty like the moon and the sun, and a sweet scent that carries for two miles?

"And here is another thing I give you gladly, lord of men, a wonderful boon: divine sight. See Kunti's sons in their holy, divine former bodies."

Then Vyasa, the pure brahmin of the most generous deeds, by his austerity gave the king divine sight. And the king saw them all, just as they were, in their former bodies. He saw them divine, wearing golden crowns and garlands, like Shakra, the colour of fire and of the sun. They wore bands in their hair. They were handsome and young, broad-chested, as tall as palm trees. They shone brightly in heavenly clothes without a speck of dust, golden, with the finest garlands. They were like the three-eyed gods themselves, or the Vasus, or the heavenly Adityas, with every good quality. When he saw the former Indras so handsome, King Drupada was pleased and amazed.

Having gained that boundless divine vision, the lord of kings saw his radiant daughter too. She was like Shri herself in bodily form, a wife worthy of them in beauty, splendour and fame.

When he saw that great wonder, he clasped the feet of Satyavati's son. "In you, great seer," he said, with a glad heart, "this is no wonder."

"In a grove of austerity," said Vyasa, "there was the daughter of a great seer. She was beautiful and virtuous, but she did not find a husband. She pleased Shankara with fierce austerity, so they say, and the lord, pleased, said to her himself, 'Choose what you wish.'

"The girl said to the lord, the god who gives boons, 'I want a husband with every good quality,' again and again.

"Then the lord of the gods, pleased, gave her that boon. 'You will have five excellent husbands,' said Shankara.

"Trying to win the god's favour, she spoke again. 'I deserve from you one husband with good qualities.'

"The god of gods, pleased with her, spoke again, kindly. 'Five times you said to me, 'Give me a husband.' So it will be, good lady. Bless you. When you have gone into another body, it will be as you said.'

"Drupada, she has been born as your godlike daughter. Blameless Krishna, the daughter of the Prishata line, is ordained to be the wife of five. She is the Shri of heaven, born in the great sacrifice for the Pandavas' sake. She practised terrible austerity here, and she has come to be your daughter. This lovely goddess, whom the gods love, is the one wife of five by her own deeds. She was created by the Self-born himself to be the wife of gods. Now that you have heard this, King Drupada, do as you wish."

The Wedding

"Great seer," said Drupada, "it was before I heard these words of yours that I tried to do what I did. What has been ordained cannot be turned aside, so this arrangement is fitting. The knot of fate cannot be untied. Nothing here is settled by our own doing. What was arranged to win one husband has turned out to be for many. As Krishna said before, again and again, 'Lord, give me a husband,' so the god gave her that boon. The god knows what is highest here. If Shankara has ordained this, whether it is right or wrong, the fault is not mine. Let them take her hand as the rites require, as they wish. Krishna is ordained for them."

Then the blessed Vyasa said to the Dharma King, "Today is a holy day, son of Pandu. Today the moon enters the constellation Pushya. Take Krishna's hand today, you first."

Then King Yajnasena and his son brought together everything needed for the wedding party, many things of the finest kind. He had his daughter Krishna bathed and decked with many jewels. Then all the king's friends came there, with his counsellors and ministers. The brahmins and the townspeople came too, in order of rank. They were all very happy to see the wedding. His palace, graced with guests, its courtyard strewn with lotuses and water lilies, bright with heaps of costly jewels, shone like the sky studded with clear stars.

Then came those young princes of the Kurus, adorned and wearing earrings, dressed in costly clothes and sprinkled with fine sandal water. They had bathed, and the blessing rites had been performed. With their family priest Dhaumya, bright as fire, they went into the hall one after another, lord, in due order. They went in gladly, like great bulls into a cow pen.

Then Dhaumya, who had mastered the Veda, laid the fire and offered into its flames with mantras. The priest, who knew the mantras, brought Yudhishtira and joined him with Krishna. The master of the Veda led the two of them, hand in hand, round the fire, keeping it on their right. Then the priest took leave of Yudhishtira, the ornament of battle, and went out of the palace.

In this way, day after day, the princes took the hand of that fine woman, each in his turn. They were great warriors who made the Kuru line grow, and each wore his finest form. And the brahmin seer told of a wonderful thing there, beyond the human: that great-spirited woman with the lovely waist, they say, became a virgin again as each day passed.

When the wedding was done, Drupada gave the great warriors wealth of many fine kinds. He gave a hundred chariots decked with the best gold, each drawn by four horses, with golden bridles and garlands. He gave a hundred elephants with lotus marks on their foreheads, like a hundred mountains with golden peaks. He gave a hundred maidservants in the first bloom of youth, with costly dresses, ornaments, clothes and garlands. With the fire as witness, Drupada of the Somakas gave each of them, separately, wealth to the count of a hundred thousand. He gave them clothes and ornaments too, of great power and great price.

When the wedding was done, and they had gained that Shri, rich in jewels, the mighty Pandavas, like Indras, lived happily in the city of the Panchala king.

Joined with the Pandavas, Drupada had no fear of anyone, not even of the gods.

The women of great Drupada came to Kunti. Each told her name and touched Kunti's feet with her head. Krishna, dressed in linen, with the wedding thread tied and the blessings spoken, greeted her mother-in-law and stood before her, bowing, with her hands joined.

Pritha spoke a blessing with love to her daughter-in-law Draupadi, who had beauty and every good mark, and good character and conduct.

"As Indrani is to Indra of the bay horses, and Svaha to the fire, as Rohini is to the moon and Damayanti to Nala, as Bhadra is to Vaishravana and Arundhati to Vasishtha, as Lakshmi is to Narayana, so be you to your husbands. Be the mother of living sons, good lady, the mother of heroes, blessed with many joys, fortunate, rich in pleasures, a wife at the sacrifice, true to your vows. May your years pass for ever in honouring guests who come, as is right. Honour good men, children, the old and your elders. In the kingdoms and cities with Kurujangala at their head, may you be consecrated after your husband, the king who loves dharma. Give all the earth, won by your mighty husbands' courage, to the brahmins at the horse sacrifice, the great rite. Whatever jewels of worth there are on earth, virtuous one, win them, lovely one, and be happy for a hundred autumns. And as I greet you today, my son's wife, dressed in linen, so I will greet you again, virtuous one, when you have borne a son."

Then Hari sent the married Pandavas golden ornaments inlaid with pearls and lapis. Madhava sent costly clothes from many lands, and blankets, skins and jewels, soft to the touch and fine. He sent beds, seats and carriages of many kinds, and large, and vessels by the hundred, inlaid with lapis and diamond. Krishna gave them thousands of serving women from many lands, with beauty, youth and skill, finely adorned. He gave well-trained elephants of good breed, fine horses well adorned, and chariots with trained horses, decked with fine golden cloths. And Madhusudana, whose spirit is beyond measure, sent them gold by the ten million, both raw and worked, in heaps.

The Dharma King Yudhishtira accepted it all with the greatest joy, wishing to please Govinda.

Good Fortune

Then the kings learned from their trusted spies that lovely Draupadi had been joined to the Pandavas as her husbands. The great man who had drawn the bow and pierced the target was Arjuna, the best of victors, who carries the great bow and arrows. The strong man who had lifted Shalya, the king of Madra, and whirled him round, and in his anger had frightened men in battle with a tree, and had not been flustered at all, that great man was Bhima, terrible to meet, the feller of the ranks of enemy armies.

When they heard that the sons of King Pandu, the Kaunteyas, had come in the form of brahmins, the lords of men were amazed. For they had heard that Kunti and her sons had been burned to death in the house of lac, and all the kings thought of them as born again. They cursed Bhishma, and Dhritarashtra the Kaurava, for the cruel deed that Purochana had done.

When the bridegroom choice was over, all the kings went back as they had come, knowing that the Pandavas had been chosen.

King Duryodhana, downcast, turned back with his brothers, with Ashvatthama, his uncle, Karna and Kripa, when he saw that Draupadi had chosen the man of the white horses. Duhshasana, ashamed, spoke to him quietly.

"If he had not been a brahmin, he would not have won Draupadi. No one knew him for what he was, king, for Dhananjaya. I think fate is supreme, and a man's effort is useless. Shame on our effort, brother, when the Pandavas are alive."

Talking like this, and blaming Purochana, they went into Hastinapura, downcast and dismayed. They were frightened, and their plans had come to nothing, for they had seen the mighty Parthas free of the fire and allied with Drupada. And they thought of Dhristadyumna, and of Shikhandi, and of Drupada's other sons, all skilled in every kind of fighting.

But Vidura had heard that Draupadi had chosen the Pandavas, and that the sons of Dhritarashtra had come back ashamed, their pride broken. Then the steward, glad at heart and full of wonder, said to Dhritarashtra, lord of the people, "By good fortune the Kurus prosper!"

When King Dhritarashtra, Vichitravirya's son, heard Vidura's words, he was delighted, Bharata. "Good fortune!" he said. "Good fortune!" For the king, whose eyes were his wisdom, in his ignorance thought that Drupada's daughter had chosen his eldest son, Duryodhana. Then he ordered many ornaments for Draupadi, and told his son Duryodhana, "Have Krishna brought here."

Afterwards Vidura told him that the Pandavas had been chosen, and that all the heroes were well, and honoured by Drupada, and that they had many other kinsmen through the marriage, men of strength.

"Pandu's sons are to me just as they were to him," said Dhritarashtra, "and even more. This is a greater joy, Vidura, and I count it as prosperity, that the heroic Pandavas are well and have friends. For who, steward, having won Drupada and his kin as a friend, would not wish to prosper, even a king who has lost his fortune and wants to thrive?"

"May your mind stay like this always, king," said Vidura, "for a hundred years."

Then Duryodhana and Radheya came to Dhritarashtra, lord of the people, and said to him, "We could not speak to you, king, in front of Vidura. Now we are alone, we ask: what is it you mean to do? You think your rivals' growth is your own, father. You praise them to the steward, best of men. You are doing one thing, sinless one, when another should be done. Their strength should be broken all the time, father. So we have come to consider what should be done now, so that they do not swallow us up, with our sons, our army and our kin."

"I think just as you two do," said Dhritarashtra. "But I do not want to show my face to Vidura. So I praise their virtues above all, so that Vidura will not read my purpose in my looks. Now tell me what you think fit, Suyodhana. And you, Radheya, tell me what you think fit."

"Let us divide Kunti's sons today," said Duryodhana, "and the two Pandavas who are Madri's sons, through clever brahmins, well trained and trusted. Or let King Drupada, his sons and all his ministers be tempted with great hoards of wealth. 'Abandon King Yudhishtira, Kunti's son,' they will be told. Or let them make the Pandavas want to live there. Let each of them describe to the Pandavas the faults of living here, so that, divided from us, the Pandavas set their minds on staying there. Or let some clever men, skilled in schemes, set the Parthas against one another through their love for her. Or let them turn Krishna away from them. That is easy, since there are so many. Or let them divide the Pandavas over her, and then her from them."

"Or, king, let men skilled in schemes arrange Bhimasena's death in secret, for he is the strongest of them. When he is dead, king, their spirit and their strength will be broken, and they will not strive for the kingdom, for he is their support. Arjuna cannot be beaten in battle while Vrikodara guards his back. Without him, Phalguna is not worth a quarter of Radheya in battle. When they know how weak they are without Bhimasena, and know that we are strong, they will perish, for they will be the weaker side. Or when the Parthas have come here, and are under our command, we will set about destroying them as we see fit, king. Or let each of the Kaunteyas be tempted by beautiful women, one by one, and then let Krishna grow cold to them. Or let Radheya be sent to bring them here, and let them be killed on the way by trusted agents in league with robbers."

"Whichever of these schemes you think free of fault, put it to use before the time passes. While they have not yet put their trust in Drupada, bull among kings, they can be overcome today. After that they cannot. This is my thinking, father, bent on holding them down, whether it is good or bad. What do you think, Radheya?"

"Duryodhana," said Karna, "I do not think your thinking is sound. The Pandavas cannot be overcome by schemes, joy of the Kurus. You tried before to hold them down by subtle schemes, hero, and you could not. When they were living here, close to you, king, children not yet fledged, you could not harm them. Now they are fledged, living abroad, grown in every way. The Kaunteyas cannot be overcome by schemes. That is my view, Achyuta."

"They cannot be brought to ruin, for fate is with them. They are wary, and they want the place of their father and grandfather. No split can be made among them. Men who delight in one wife do not split from one another. Nor can others divide Krishna from them. She

chose them when they were poor, and how much less will she leave them now they are prospering? For this is a thing women want, to be one woman with many husbands. Krishna has it, and she cannot easily be divided from them. The Panchala king is a man of noble conduct, and no lover of wealth. He will surely not abandon the Kaunteyas, even if he is given kingdoms. His son too is virtuous and devoted to the Pandavas. So I do not think they can be overcome by schemes in any way.

"But this is what we can do now, bull among men. While the Pandavas have not yet put down roots, lord of the people, they must be attacked. Let valour be your choice. While our side is great and the Panchala small, attack them. Do not hesitate. While they do not have many horses and chariots, and many friends, son of Gandhari, strike quickly. While the Panchala king and his mighty sons have not set their minds on war, strike quickly. Strike quickly, before the Varshneya comes, drawing the Yadava army after him, to win the Pandavas their kingdom. There is nothing, wealth, pleasures of every kind, or the kingdom itself, that Krishna would not give up for the Pandavas, lord of the earth.

"Great Bharata won the earth by valour. By valour Indra, the chastiser of Paka, won the three worlds. Valour is what men praise in a kshatriya, lord of the people. Valour is the heroes' own dharma, bull among kings. Let us crush Drupada quickly, king, with a great army of four branches, and bring the Pandavas here. The Pandavas cannot be won by conciliation, or by gifts, or by division. So destroy them by valour alone. Conquer them by valour and enjoy this whole earth. I see no other way to our goal here, lord of men."

When he heard Radheya's words, mighty Dhritarashtra praised him, and then he said, "This speech, so full of valour, is just what one would expect from you, wise son of a suta, master of weapons. But let Bhishma, Drona and Vidura, and the two of you, think again, and find the plan that will bring us happiness."

Then Dhritarashtra sent for all those very famous counsellors, great king, and took counsel with them.

Chapter 81

The Council

"A quarrel with Pandu's sons does not please me at all," said Bhishma. "As Dhritarashtra is to me, so is Pandu, without a doubt. As Gandhari's sons are to me, so are Kunti's sons. I must protect them, Dhritarashtra, and so must you. As they are to me and to the king, so they are to Duryodhana and to all the Kurus, and to others too, Bharata. Since things are as they are, I do not want a quarrel with them. Make peace with the heroes, and let land be given to them today. This kingdom belongs to them too, the kingdom of their great-grandfathers and of their father, those best of the Kurus.

"Duryodhana, my son, you look on this kingdom as your inheritance from your father. So do the Pandavas. If the glorious Pandavas have no claim to the kingdom, how can it be yours, or any Bharata's? And if you gained the kingdom by dharma, bull of the Bharatas, then they gained it before you. That is what I think. Let half the kingdom be given to them, kindly. That is for the good of all the people, tiger among men.

"If it is done any other way, it will not be good for us, and you will be wholly disgraced. There is no doubt of it. Guard your good name, for a good name is the highest strength. The life of a man who has lost his good name is said to be fruitless. As long as a man's good name does not perish, Kaurava, son of Gandhari, he lives. When his good name is lost, he is lost. Follow the dharma that suits the Kuru family. Do what is worthy of your forebears, strong-armed one.

"By good fortune the heroes are alive. By good fortune Pritha is alive. By good fortune the wicked Purochana has died without getting what he wanted. Ever since I heard that Kunti had met that end, son of Gandhari, I have not been able to look any living being in the face. The world does not blame Purochana as much as it blames you, tiger among men. So you should welcome it, great king, that they are alive and that we can see the Pandavas again. It wipes out your stain. While those heroes live, joy of the Kurus, not even the wielder of the thunderbolt himself could take their father's share from them. For they all stand by dharma, and they are all of one mind, and they were wrongfully driven out, above all from a kingdom that was equally theirs. If you want to do what is right, if you want to do what pleases me, if you want what is best, give them half."

"We have always heard," said Drona, "that counsellors called in to advise, who wish Dhritarashtra well, should say what is right and beneficial and brings honour. My view, son, is the same as great Bhishma's. The Kaunteyas should be given their share. This is the eternal dharma.

"Let some pleasant-spoken man be sent quickly to Drupada, Bharata, taking many jewels for the Pandavas' sake. Let him take many gifts to Drupada, and speak of the great good that will come of the alliance with him. Let him say, again and again, to Drupada and to Dhrishtadyumna, that you and Duryodhana are well pleased, king. Let him describe how fitting and how welcome the alliance is, and speak kindly, again and again, to the Kaunteyas and to Madri's two sons. At your word, king of kings, let him give Draupadi many bright golden ornaments, and give what is fitting to all Drupada's sons, bull of the Bharatas, and to all the Pandavas, and to Kunti.

"When he has spoken to Drupada and the Pandavas in this friendly way, let him then speak of their coming here. When the heroes are given leave, let a splendid escort go, and let Duhshasana and Vikarna bring the Pandavas here. Then, best of kings, honoured by you

always, they will take their father's place with the consent of the people. This, great king, I think is the right way for you to treat these sons of yours, and Bhishma thinks so too, Bharata."

"These two have always been given wealth and honour by you," said Karna, "and they are close to you in all your affairs. Yet they do not advise what is good for you. What could be stranger than that? When a man with a wicked mind and a hidden heart speaks what he calls the best advice, how can he do what good men approve? In hard times friends can bring neither good nor harm. For everyone's sorrow and happiness come as they are ordained. Wise or foolish, young or old, with allies or without, a man finds everything that is his, wherever he is."

"We hear that long ago there was a king named Ambuvicha, a king of the lords of Magadha, in Rajagriha. He had lost the use of all his senses, and could do little more than breathe. In all his affairs he depended on his minister. His minister was Mahakarni, who became the sole master. Thinking he had won power for himself, he despised the king. The fool took all the king's pleasures for himself, his women, his jewels and his wealth, and his sovereignty too. As he took these, the greedy man's greed grew with his gains. So, having taken everything, he wanted to seize the kingdom. But though the king had lost the use of all his senses, and could only breathe, the minister, for all his efforts, could not take the kingdom. So we have heard. What else could it be but that the man's kingship was ordained?"

"If the kingdom is ordained for you, lord of the people, it will surely stay with you while the whole world looks on. If it is ordained otherwise, you will not get it, however hard you try. Knowing this, wise king, judge which of your counsellors are good and which are not. Learn to tell the words of the wicked from the words of those who are not."

"We know why you say this," said Drona. "It is because your heart is bad. You are wicked, and because of the Pandavas you accuse us of wickedness. What I say, Karna, is the highest good, and it will make the Kurus grow. If you think it wicked, then say what the highest good is. If what I say is not done, though it is the highest good, the Kurus will perish before long. That is my view."

"King," said Vidura, "your kinsmen have certainly told you what is best. But words take no root in those who will not listen. Bhishma, Shantanu's son, the best of the Kurus, has told you what is good for you, king, and you do not take it. Drona too has said in many ways what is best and good, and Karna, Radha's son, does not think it good for you. But though I think hard, king, I cannot see a better friend to you than these two lions among men, or anyone who is wiser. For these two are old in years, in wisdom and in learning, and they think of you, king of kings, and of the sons of Pandu as equals. In dharma and in truthfulness they are no lower than Rama, Dasharatha's son, or Gaya, Bharata, without a doubt. They have never before advised you badly in anything. And you can see that you have never done them any wrong. How could these two tigers among men, whose courage is true, not advise you for your good, when you have done them no wrong, king? They are wise, the best of men in this world, lord of men. They will not say anything crooked for your sake. That is my firm belief, joy of the Kurus. And they know dharma, and will not take sides for the sake of wealth. They think this is the highest good for you, Bharata."

"As Duryodhana and the rest are your sons, king, so the Pandavas are your sons, without

a doubt. If your counsellors foolishly advise anything that would harm them, they are surely not looking to your good. Or if there is favour in your heart for your own sons, king, those who bring it into the open will surely not do you good. That is why these two great and glorious men said nothing openly, for that is not your resolve.

"And what these two bulls among men said, that the Pandavas cannot be beaten, is just so, tiger among men. Bless you. How could the glorious Pandava Savyasachin, the tamer of enemies, be beaten in battle, king, even by Maghavan? How could strong-armed Bhimasena, great, with the strength of ten thousand elephants, be beaten in war even by the immortals? And the twins, skilled in war, like the sons of Yama himself: how could anyone who wants to live stand against them in battle? How could the eldest Pandava be beaten in battle, in whom steadiness, compassion, patience, truth and courage are always found? They have Rama on their side, and Janardana as their counsellor, and Satyaki on their side. What can they fail to win in battle? Drupada is their father-in-law, and the sons of Prishata's line, Drupada's sons, the heroes led by Dhrishtadyumna, are their brothers-in-law.

"So, knowing that they cannot be beaten, Bharata, and knowing that they have first right to the inheritance by dharma, treat them well. Great is the disgrace that Purochana has smeared on you. Wash it off today, king, by showing them favour. King Drupada is also a great king, and he has been our enemy in the past. To win him over, king, is to strengthen our own side. The Dasharhas are strong and many, lord of the people. Where Krishna is, they will be. Where Krishna is, there is victory. And who, unless he is cursed by fate, would try to do by war what can be done by peace alone, king? The townspeople and the country folk have heard that the Parthas are alive, and they long to see them. Do what will please them, king.

"Duryodhana and Karna, and Shakuni, Subala's son, are unrighteous, foolish and childish. Do not do what they say. I told you this long ago, virtuous king: because of Duryodhana's wrongdoing these people will perish."

Indraprastha

"Wise Bhishma, Shantanu's son, and the blessed seer Drona," said Dhritarashtra, "have told me what is best, and you tell me the truth. As those heroes, Kunti's sons, the great warriors, are Pandu's sons, so by dharma they are all my sons, without a doubt. As this kingdom is meant for my sons, so it is meant for Pandu's sons, without a doubt. Steward, go and bring them here with their mother, with all honour, and with godlike Krishna, Bharata. By good fortune the Parthas are alive. By good fortune Pritha is alive. By good fortune the great warriors have won Drupada's daughter. By good fortune we all prosper. By good fortune Purochana is at rest. By good fortune my great sorrow has been taken away, glorious one."

Then Vidura went, at Dhritarashtra's command, to Yajnasena and the Pandavas, Bharata. When he arrived there, Vidura, who knew dharma and was skilled in all learning, went to Drupada, who was now joined with them, as was proper. Drupada received Vidura as dharma requires, and the two of them asked each other, in the proper way, how they were. Vidura saw the Pandavas there, and Vasudeva, Bharata. He embraced them warmly and asked them how they were. They honoured him in turn, in due order. And the man of boundless understanding asked the sons of Pandu, again and again, at Dhritarashtra's word and with affection, how they were, king. He gave jewels and wealth of many kinds to the Pandavas, to Kunti and Draupadi, and to Drupada's sons, as the Kauravas had given them.

Then that man of boundless wisdom, modest and courteous, spoke to Drupada, in front of the sons of Pandu and of Keshava.

"King, hear what I have to say, with your ministers and your sons. Dhritarashtra, with his sons, his ministers and his kin, sends you his greetings, king, again and again, with great pleasure. He is very pleased with the alliance, lord of men. So too Bhishma, Shantanu's son, and all the Kauravas, wise one, ask after your welfare in every way. Drona of Bharadvaja's line, the great archer, your dear friend, embraces you and asks how you are.

"Dhritarashtra, Panchala, now that he has made this alliance with you, thinks he has gained all he wished, and so do all the Kauravas. Winning a kingdom would not please them as much as winning this alliance with you, Yajnasena. Knowing this, please send the Pandavas. The Kurus are very eager to see Pandu's heirs. These bulls among men have long been away from home, and they and Pritha too will be eager to see the city. All the best women of the Kurus, and our city and our country, wait eagerly to see Krishna of Panchala. So please give the sons of Pandu leave to go with their wife, without delay. That is why I have come. When you have let the great Pandavas go, king, I will send swift messengers to Dhritarashtra: 'The Kaunteyas are coming, and Kunti with Krishna.'"

"It is as you say today, wise Vidura," said Drupada. "My joy too is great at this alliance, lord. It would be right for these great men to go home. But it is not right for me to say so myself. When the hero Yudhishtira, Kunti's son, thinks fit, and Bhimasena and Arjuna and the twins, bulls among men, and Rama and Krishna, who know dharma, then let the Pandavas go. For these two tigers among men are devoted to their good."

"We all depend on you, king," said Yudhishtira, "with all our people. What you tell us, in your love, we will do."

Then Vasudeva said, "I think they should go. Or as King Drupada thinks, who knows all dharma."

"As the hero thinks, the Dasharha, the best of men," said Drupada, "strong-armed Krishna, that the time has come, that is my firm view. For as the fortunate Kaunteyas are now to me, so the sons of Pandu are to Vasudeva, without a doubt. Kunti's son Yudhishtira, the son of Dharma, does not think as much of their good as Keshava, the tiger among men, does."

Then, with great Drupada's leave, the Pandavas and Krishna and wise Vidura took Draupadi Krishna and glorious Kunti, and went happily, at their ease, to the city named after the elephant.

When Dhritarashtra the Kaurava heard that the heroes had come, he sent Kauravas to welcome the Pandavas: Vikarna, the great archer, and Chitrasena, Bharata, and Drona, the supreme archer, and Kripa of the Gautama line. Surrounded by them, the heroes, great warriors, shining, slowly entered the city of Hastinapura. The city seemed to burst with eagerness to see those tigers among men, who put an end to sorrow and grief. Then the Pandavas heard all kinds of pleasing words, words that went to their hearts, from people who wanted to please them.

"Here is that tiger among men come back again, who knows dharma, and who protects us by dharma as if we were his own kin."

"Today it is as if great King Pandu, who loved the forest, has come back from the forest, wanting to please us. There is no doubt of it."

"What is there that has not been done today to please us all, when Kunti's heroic sons, our masters, have come back?"

"If we have given, if we have offered, if we have any austerity, by that let the Pandavas stay in the city for a hundred autumns."

Then they bowed at the feet of Dhritarashtra, of great Bhishma, and of the others who deserved it. They asked the whole city how it fared, and then, at Dhritarashtra's command, they went into their houses.

When the great and mighty men had rested for a while, King Dhritarashtra and Bhishma, Shantanu's son, sent for them.

"Kaunteya," said Dhritarashtra, "listen, with your brothers, to what I say. Let there be no quarrel between you again. Go and live in Khandavaprastha. No one will be able to harm you there, protected by Partha as the gods are protected by the wielder of the thunderbolt. Take half the kingdom and go and live in Khandavaprastha."

They accepted his words, and all of them bowed to the king. Then the bulls among men set out for that terrible forest. Taking half the kingdom, they went to live in Khandavaprastha.

The Pandavas, the unfallen, went there with Krishna at their head, and they made that city as fine as heaven. In a holy and auspicious place the great warriors performed a

rite of peace, and then, with Dvaipayana at their head, they had a city measured out. It was adorned with moats like the sea, and surrounded by a wall that stood hiding the sky. The wall gleamed like white clouds, like a heap of snow, and the finest of cities shone like Bhogavati with its snakes.

It was guarded by fearsome gates, like Garuda with his two wings spread, and by towers like banks of cloud, like Mount Mandara. It was hedged with weapons of many kinds, well placed and well covered, and with spears like two-tongued snakes. It had its practice grounds, and it was guarded by fighting men. It was bright with sharp hooks and hundred-killers, with nets of machines, and with great iron wheels. So that finest of cities shone. Its great roads were well laid out. It was free of harm from the gods, and bright with many fine white houses. That Indraprastha shone like heaven, like a swollen mass of clouds in the sky, wrapped in lightning. In a lovely, auspicious place in it the Kaurava's palace shone, full of wealth, like the house of the lord of wealth.

Brahmins came there, king, the best of all who know the Veda, and liked to live there, men who knew every language. Merchants came to that place from every direction, looking for wealth, and men who knew every craft came there to live.

All round the city there were lovely gardens, with mango and hog plum, nipa and ashoka and champak trees, punnaga and nagapushpa, lakucha and jackfruit, sal, palmyra, kadamba, bakula and ketaka. They were lovely, in flower, and bent low with fruit. There were amalaka, lodhra and ankola trees in full flower, rose apple and patala, kubjaka and atimuktaka, oleander and coral trees, and many other trees, always in flower and fruit, full of flocks of birds, loud with peacocks in rut and cuckoos always in song. There were houses as clear as mirrors, and bowers of creepers of many kinds. There were lovely painted halls, and little hills, and wells of many kinds full of the best water. There were very lovely lakes, fragrant with lotuses and water lilies, full of geese and ducks, bright with chakravaka birds. There were lovely pools of many kinds with woods round them, and fine, broad, great tanks.

As they lived in that great kingdom, full of good people, the Pandavas' joy grew all the time, great king. So, when Bhishma and the king had done what was just, the Pandavas came to live in Khandavaprastha. With those five great archers, like Indras, the finest of cities shone like Bhogavati with its snakes.

When he had settled them there, the hero Keshava, with Rama, went to Dvaravati, with the Pandavas' leave, king.

Sunda and Upasunda

"When my great-grandfathers had gained the kingdom in Indraprastha, rich in austerity," said Janamejaya, "what did those great Pandavas do next? How did Draupadi, their lawful wife, behave towards all of them, those great men, my forefathers? And how did those fortunate kings, living with one woman, Krishna, not fall out with one another? I want to hear it all in full, rich in austerity, how they behaved to one another, joined as they were with Krishna."

With Dhritarashtra's leave, the Pandavas, the tigers among men, the tamers of enemies, enjoyed themselves with Krishna now that they had their kingdom. When he had gained the kingdom, Yudhishtira, of great splendour and true to his word, ruled the earth by dharma with his brothers. The sons of Pandu lived there in the greatest happiness. Their enemies were beaten. They were very wise, and devoted to truth and dharma. Those bulls among men did all the business of the city, and sat on costly royal seats.

Once, when all those great men were seated, the divine seer Narada came there by chance. Yudhishtira gave him his own fine seat. When the divine seer was seated, wise Yudhishtira himself gave him the guest offering, as the rules require, and told him about the kingdom. The seer accepted the honour and was pleased. He blessed him, and said, "Sit down." Given leave, King Yudhishtira sat down. Then he sent word to Krishna that the blessed one had come. As soon as she heard, Draupadi purified herself and, with her mind collected, went to where Narada sat with the Pandavas. Drupada's daughter, who kept to dharma, bowed at the divine seer's feet and stood with her hands joined, modestly covered. The righteous seer, the best of seers, whose word is true, gave the princess many blessings. Then the blessed Narada said to that blameless woman, "You may go."

When Krishna had gone, the blessed seer spoke in private to all the Pandavas, with Yudhishtira at their head.

"The glorious Panchala princess is the lawful wife of you all. Make a rule so that there is no quarrel among you over her. There were once two asura brothers, Sunda and Upasunda. They were always together, no one else could kill them, and they were famous in the three worlds. They had one kingdom and one house. They shared one bed, one seat, one meal. And they killed each other for the sake of Tilottama. So guard your friendship, which keeps each of you well disposed to the others. Do something, Yudhishtira, so that there is no quarrel among you here."

"Great sage," said Yudhishtira, "whose sons were the asuras Sunda and Upasunda? How did the quarrel arise, and how did they kill each other? Whose was this Tilottama? Was she an apsaras, or a daughter of the gods, whom they longed for so madly that they killed each other? We want to hear all of it in full, rich in austerity, just as it happened, brahmin. We are very curious."

"Listen, Partha," said Narada, "with your brothers, Yudhishtira, while I tell you this ancient tale in full, just as it happened.

"Long ago, in the line of the great asura Hiranyakashipu, there was a lord of the daityas named Nikumbha, splendid and strong. He had two sons of great courage and fearsome might. They ate together, and neither went anywhere without the other. Each did

what pleased the other, and each spoke kindly to the other. They had one character and one way of life, like one person made into two.

"When they had grown up, the mighty pair were of one mind in all they did. So, of one mind, they set out to conquer the three worlds. They took the vow, went to the Vindhya mountains, and practised fierce austerity there. After a long time they were full of austerity's power. Worn out with hunger and thirst, wearing matted hair and bark, their whole bodies caked with dirt, they lived on air. They offered their own flesh into the fire. They stood on the tips of their big toes, their arms raised and their eyes unblinking, keeping their vows for a long time. Heated for a long time by the power of their austerity, the Vindhya gave off smoke. It was a wonder.

"The gods were afraid when they saw the fierceness of their austerity, and to break it, they put obstacles in their way. Again and again they tempted the two with jewels and with women. But those two, strict in their great vows, did not break their vow.

"Then the gods worked a trick of illusion on those great-spirited two. Their sisters, mothers and wives, and their household, seemed to be pursued and struck down by a rakshasa with a spear in his hand. In terror, their ornaments and hair falling loose, their clothes slipping from them, they all ran to the two and cried out, 'Save us!' But those two, strict in their great vows, did not break their vow. When neither of them was shaken or distressed, the women and the creature all vanished.

"Then the Grandfather himself, the grandfather of all the worlds, came to the two great asuras and offered them a boon. When the brothers Sunda and Upasunda, firm in their courage, saw the god, the Grandfather, they stood before him with joined hands. Then together they said to the lord god, 'If the Grandfather is pleased with this austerity of ours, and if the lord is gracious to us, let us both know magic, know weapons, be strong, take any form we wish, and be immortal.'

"'Apart from immortality,' said the Grandfather, 'you shall have all you ask. Choose some other way of death, to make you equal to the immortals. You took up this great austerity saying, "We will do this." Because of that, immortality is not granted to you. You undertook your austerity to conquer the three worlds. For that reason, lords of the daityas, I will not grant your wish.'

"'Let us have no fear,' said Sunda and Upasunda, 'from anything that exists in the three worlds, moving or still, Grandfather, except from each other.'

"'I grant you your wish,' said the Grandfather, 'what you have asked, as you have said it. And this will be the way of your death, just so.'

"Then, when he had given them this boon, the Grandfather turned them back from their austerity and went to the world of Brahma. And the two lords of the daityas, having gained all their boons and being beyond the reach of all the world, went home.

"When all their friends saw that the two great asuras had won their boon and had their wish, they were overjoyed. Then the two cut off their matted hair and wore crowns. They put on costly ornaments and clean clothes. They held a festival of moonlight out of season, with every pleasure, those two lords of the daityas, overjoyed, and their friends too. 'Eat! Enjoy! Make merry! Sing! Drink! Give!' was heard in every house. The whole city of the daityas was delighted and happy, ringing everywhere with great

drinking bouts and loud clapping. As the daityas, who could take any form they wished, amused themselves with all kinds of pleasures, years passed like a single day.

"As soon as the festival was over, the two, who longed for the three worlds, took counsel and gave orders to their army. With the leave of their friends, of the elders of the daityas and of their ministers, they performed the rite for setting out, and they left at night, under the constellation Magha. They set out with a great army of daityas, who shared their way of life, carrying maces and spears, lances and hammers. Praised by bards with blessings and hymns that promised victory, they went on with the greatest joy.

"The two daityas, who could go wherever they wished, flew up into the sky, mad for war, and went straight to the home of the gods. When the gods knew they were coming, and knew of the lord's boon, they left heaven and went to the world of Brahma. The two, of fierce courage, conquered the world of Indra, and the hosts of yakshas and rakshasas, and the creatures that move in the sky. The great asuras conquered the snakes that live under the earth, and all the barbarian peoples who live by the sea.

"Then the two, fierce in their rule, set about conquering the whole earth. They called their soldiers together and spoke harsh words to them. 'The royal seers with their great sacrifices, and the brahmins with their offerings to the gods and the ancestors, make the power, strength and glory of the gods grow. All of them, grown great in this way, are enemies of the asuras. We must all join together and kill them, with all our might.'

"When they had given all their soldiers this order, on the eastern shore of the great ocean, the two set their minds on cruelty and went out in every direction. Whenever the mighty pair saw people who offered sacrifices, or brahmins who performed sacrifices for others, they killed them all by force. In the hermitages their soldiers boldly seized the fire offerings of the seers, who had made their souls pure, and threw them into the water. The curses that the great ascetics spoke in their anger did not touch the two, who were swollen with their boon. When the curses did not touch them, like arrows shot at stone, the brahmins gave up their vows and fled. The men on earth who had won perfection by austerity, self-controlled and devoted to peace, fled in fear of the two, like snakes from Garuda. With the hermitages churned up and broken, and the water pots and ladles scattered, the whole world was empty, as if Time had struck it down.

"When the royal seers and seers could not be seen, the two great asuras, set on killing, made up their minds and changed their shapes. They became elephants in rut, their temples burst open, and they sent to Yama's house even those who hid in strongholds. They became lions, and then tigers, and then they vanished from sight. By all these means the cruel pair found the seers and killed them.

"Sacrifice and Veda study stopped on earth. Kings and brahmins were destroyed. Festivals and sacrifices ceased. The earth was full of cries, stricken with fear. Trade and markets stopped. The rites of the gods stopped, and holy marriages were no more. Farming and herding stopped. Cities and hermitages were laid waste. The earth was strewn with bones and skeletons, and terrible to see. The rites for the ancestors stopped. There was no call to the gods and no blessing. The world looked frightful, and hard to look at. The moon and the sun, the planets, the stars, the constellations and the gods of heaven all fell into despair when they saw what Sunda and Upasunda had done.

"So by their cruel deeds the two daityas conquered every quarter, and, with no rival

left, they made their home in Kurukshetra."

Tilottama

"Then all the divine seers, the perfected ones and the great seers," said Narada, "were in great distress when they saw that great slaughter. Having conquered anger, having mastered themselves and their senses, they went to the Grandfather's house, out of pity for the world. There they saw the Grandfather seated with the gods, surrounded on every side by perfected ones and brahmin seers. The god Mahadeva was there. Agni was there with Vayu, and the moon and the sun, Dharma, Parameshthin and Budha. The Vaikhanasas, the Valakhilyas, the forest-dwellers, the Marichipas, the Ajas, the Avimudhas and the Tejogarbhas, ascetics all, and all these seers, sat in attendance on the Grandfather.

"Then all the great seers went to him together and told him everything that Sunda and Upasunda had done. They told the Grandfather all of it, how it was done, what was done, and in what order. Then all the hosts of the gods, and the great seers, pressed the Grandfather on that very matter.

"When the Grandfather had heard what they all said, he thought for a moment to decide what should be done. Then, with a view to killing the two, he sent for Vishvakarman. When he saw Vishvakarman, the Grandfather, of great austerity, gave him this order: 'Create a woman here whom all will desire.'

"Vishvakarman bowed to the Grandfather and welcomed his words. After careful thought, he made a heavenly woman. Whatever was beautiful to look at in the three worlds, moving or still, he gathered with care from here and there. He set jewels in her body by the ten million. So he made her of heaps of jewels, in the form of a goddess. Made by Vishvakarman with great care, she had no equal among the women of the three worlds in beauty. There was no part of her body, however small, that did not have its fill of beauty, and no place where the eyes of those who looked at her did not linger. Like Shri in bodily form, lovely and beautiful in shape, she stole the eyes and the hearts of all beings. Because she had been made by gathering the jewels grain by grain, tila by tila, the Grandfather named her Tilottama.

"'Go, Tilottama,' said the Grandfather, 'to the asuras Sunda and Upasunda, and tempt them with your desirable beauty, good lady. Make it so that, as soon as they see you, the wealth of your beauty sets them at odds with each other.'

"She promised, 'So be it,' and bowed to the Grandfather. Then she walked round the circle of the gods, keeping them on her right. The blessed Brahma sat facing east. Maheshvara was on the south, the gods sat on the north, and the seers were all round. As she walked round the circle, Indra and the blessed Sthanu held firm and kept their composure. But Sthanu wanted very much to see her. When she went to his side, another face, with curling lashes, came out on the south. When she moved round behind, a face came out on the west. When she went to the north side, a face came out on the north. And great Indra too grew eyes, a thousand of them, large and red at the corners, all over him, at the sides, behind and in front. That is how Sthanu, the great god, came to have four faces long ago, and how the slayer of Bala came to have a thousand eyes.

"So too, among the companies of the gods and the seers, faces turned everywhere she went. The eyes of those great ones fell on her body, the eyes of all of them, except the god Grandfather alone. As she went, all the gods and the great seers thought, from the wealth of her beauty, that the work was as good as done. When Tilottama had gone, the

maker of the worlds sent away all the gods and the companies of seers.

"Meanwhile the two daityas, having conquered the earth, with no rivals and no cares, had put the three worlds at their feet, and they had done all they meant to do. They took all the jewels of the gods, the gandharvas and the yakshas, of the snakes, the kings and the rakshasas, and they were very content. When there was no one left to stand against them, they gave up all effort and enjoyed themselves like immortals. With women, garlands and perfumes, with plenty of food of every kind, and with drinks of every sort to delight the heart, they took the greatest pleasure. They amused themselves like immortals wherever they liked, in the women's quarters, in forest parks and gardens on the mountains.

"Then once they went to amuse themselves on a ridge of the Vindhya, on a level stretch of rock, among sal trees with flowering tops. All kinds of heavenly pleasures were brought to them there, and they sat happily on fine seats with their women. Then the women came to entertain them with music and dancing, and came to please them with songs full of praise.

"Then Tilottama, picking flowers in the forest, in an alluring dress of a single red cloth, picking the karnikara flowers that grew along the river banks, came slowly to the place where the two great asuras were. They had drunk the best liquor, and the corners of their eyes were red with drink. As soon as they saw that woman with the lovely hips, they were overcome. They sprang up, left their seats, and went to where she stood. Both of them were mad with desire, and both of them begged her. Sunda took the lovely-browed woman by the right hand, and Upasunda took Tilottama by the left.

"They were drunk with the boon they had won and with their own strength, drunk with pride in their wealth and jewels, and drunk with wine. Drunk with all these, they frowned at each other, and, filled with passion and desire, they spoke to each other.

"'She is my wife,' said Sunda, 'and so she is your elder, to be honoured.'

"'She is my wife,' said Upasunda, 'and so she is your daughter-in-law.'

"'She is not yours. She is mine.' So anger took hold of them. For her sake both seized terrible maces. Seizing the terrible maces, deluded by desire for her, they struck each other, crying, 'Me first! Me first!' Struck down by the maces, the two terrible ones fell to the ground, their bodies smeared with blood, like two suns fallen from the sky. Then the women fled, and the whole host of daityas went to the underworld, trembling with grief and fear.

"Then the pure-souled Grandfather came there with the gods and the great seers, to honour Tilottama. When Brahma offered her a boon, she asked only for his goodwill. Pleased, the Grandfather said to her, 'You will move through the worlds where the sun moves, lovely one. And because of your splendour, no one will be able to look at you for long.' When he had given her this boon, the Grandfather of all the worlds put the three worlds in Indra's charge, and the lord went back to the world of Brahma.

"So those two, who were always together and of one mind in all things, killed each other in their anger over Tilottama. That is why I tell you this, out of love for you all, best of the Bharatas. Bless you. If you want to please me, do what you must so that there is no quarrel among any of you over Draupadi."

When the great seer Narada had said this to them, king, those great men came together and made an agreement among themselves, in the presence of Narada, the divine seer of boundless power.

"Whichever of us sees another sitting with Draupadi shall live in the forest for twelve years as a celibate student."

When the Pandavas, who kept to dharma, had made this agreement, the great sage Narada was pleased, and he went away wherever he wished. So, long ago, urged on by Narada, they made the agreement, and they did not quarrel with one another, Bharata.

The Brahmin's Cows

When they had made that agreement, the Pandavas lived there, bringing other kings under their power by the might of their weapons. Krishna was obedient to all five Parthas, those lions among men of boundless energy. She was very happy with those five heroes as her husbands, and they with her, like the Sarasvati with the elephants. While the great Pandavas behaved according to dharma, all the Kurus prospered, free of faults and full of happiness.

After a long time, lord of the people, some thieves stole the cows of a certain brahmin, best of kings. As his wealth was being carried off, the brahmin came to Khandavaprastha, beside himself with anger, and cried out to the Pandavas.

"Pandavas! My cows are being taken from your country by force, by low, cruel, unbridled men. Run after them! When the brahmin is careless, the crows steal his offering. A base jackal is pawing at the empty den of a tiger. A brahmin's property has been taken by thieves, and dharma and wealth are destroyed, and I am weeping. Take up your weapons!"

The Pandava Dhananjaya, Kunti's son, was near the weeping brahmin, and he heard these words. As soon as he heard them, the strong-armed man said to the brahmin, "Do not be afraid."

But the room where the great Pandavas kept their weapons was the room where the Dharma King Yudhishtira was sitting with Krishna. The Pandava could neither go in nor go away, while the words of the distressed man urged him on, again and again. As the crying went on, Kunti's son thought about it in distress.

This ascetic brahmin's wealth is being stolen, and I must wipe away his tears. That is certain. If I do not protect him today, as he weeps at the door, the king will be guilty of a great wrong, the wrong of looking on and doing nothing. And the world will lose its faith in our power to protect, and we shall be in the wrong. If I go without asking the king's leave, there is no doubt I will displease King Ajatashatru, and myself too. But if I go in on the king, I must live in the forest. Let me face a great wrong, or death in the forest. Dharma counts for more, even than the loss of one's body.

When he had made up his mind, Dhananjaya, Kunti's son, went in on the king and took his leave, lord of the people. He took up his bow, and said gladly to the brahmin, "Come quickly, brahmin, while those low men who covet what is not theirs have not gone far. Let us go together, and I will bring back your wealth from the thieves' hands today."

The strong-armed man followed them, with his bow and armour, in his chariot, with his banner flying. He scattered the thieves with his arrows, defeated them, and won back the cows. The Pandava gave them back to the brahmin, and, having drunk his fill of glory, the hero Savyasachin, the tamer of enemies, came back to the city.

He greeted all his elders, and they welcomed him in turn. Then he said to the Dharma King, "Give me my vow. I have broken our agreement by seeing you. I will go and live in the forest, for that is the agreement we made."

When he heard these unwelcome words so suddenly, the Dharma King Yudhishtira was stricken with grief. "How can that be?" he said, in a faltering voice, to his brother

Gudakesha, the unfallen. "If I am any authority for you, listen to what I say, sinless one. Whatever you did that displeased me when you came in, hero, I forgive it all, and there is no grudge in my heart. When the younger brother comes in on the elder, it is no offence. It is when the elder comes in on the younger that the rule is broken. Turn back, strong-armed one. Do as I say. You have not broken dharma, and you have not wronged me."

"I have heard from you," said Arjuna, "that one should not practise dharma by evasion. I will not swerve from the truth. I take up my weapon by the truth."

Then, taking leave of the king, he took the vow of the celibate student and set out to live in the forest for twelve years.

As he went, many great brahmins who had mastered the Veda followed the strong-armed man, who brought glory to the Kauravas. There were scholars of the Veda and its limbs, and thinkers on the self, and pure devotees of the Lord, and bards who knew the old stories. There were storytellers too, king, and wandering ascetics who lived in the forest, and brahmins who recited heavenly tales in sweet voices. Surrounded by these and many other companions, with their graceful talk, the joy of the Pandavas went on his way, like Indra with the Maruts.

He saw lovely and varied forests and lakes, rivers and seas and lands, Bharata, and holy bathing places, bull of the Bharatas. When he came to Gangadvara, the lord made his camp there.

Hear from me, Janamejaya, the wonderful thing that he did there, that pure-souled man, the best of the Pandu warriors. When Kunti's son and the brahmins had settled there, Bharata, the brahmins lit many sacred fires. When the fires had been kindled and were blazing and fed with offerings, and flowers had been offered, and the fires set on the far banks, Gangadvara shone brightly, king, with those great men, learned and self-controlled, who kept to the good path, fresh from their bathing.

When the camp was full like this, the joy of the Pandavas went down into the Ganga to bathe. He bathed there and offered water to his forefathers. Then, as he was about to climb out of the water to tend the fire, king, the strong-armed man was pulled down under the water by Ulupi, the daughter of the king of the snakes, who desired him.

There the Pandava saw a fire, well laid, in the richly adorned house of the snake Kauravya. Dhananjaya, Kunti's son, performed the fire rite there. He made his offering without a qualm, and the fire was pleased. When he had done the fire rite, Kunti's son smiled and said to the daughter of the snake king, "What is this rash thing you have done, timid lady? What is this lovely place, and who are you, lovely one, and whose daughter?"

"There is a snake named Kauravya, born in the line of Airavata," said Ulupi. "I am his daughter, Partha, the snake woman Ulupi. When I saw you go down into the river that runs to the sea to bathe, Kaunteya, I was overcome with love. I am tormented by love for you, joy of the Kurus, and I have no one else. Make me happy today by giving yourself to me in private."

"Good lady," said Arjuna, "this is my twelve years of celibacy, and the Dharma King has laid it on me. I am not my own master. Yet I want to please you too, you who move in the

water. I have never told a lie in my life. So how can I do what you want without its being a lie, snake woman, and without harm to my dharma?"

"I know, Pandava," said Ulupi, "why you are wandering the earth, and how your elder laid this celibacy on you. You made an agreement among yourselves about Drupada's daughter: whichever of you in his folly came in on another would live in the forest as a celibate for twelve years. So this banishment of one another was made for Draupadi's sake, for the sake of dharma. Here, dharma is not harmed. And those in distress must be rescued, large-eyed one. If you rescue me, your dharma is not lost. And even if there were some small breach of this dharma, it would still be dharma for you to have given me my life, Arjuna.

"Love me, Partha, for I love you. Good men hold this to be right, lord. If you will not do it, know that I am dead. Practise the highest dharma, strong-armed one, by giving me my life. I have come to you for shelter today, best of men. You always protect the wretched and the helpless, Kaunteya. I come to you for shelter, and I weep in my misery. I beg you, because I love you. So do what pleases me. You should fulfil my wish by giving yourself to me."

When the daughter of the lord of the snakes said this, Kunti's son did all that she asked, for the sake of dharma. The mighty man spent that night in the snake's house, and when the sun rose, he rose and left Kauravya's house.

Chitrangada

When he had told the brahmins all that had happened, Bharata, the son of the wielder of the thunderbolt went on to the flank of the Himalaya. At the Agastyavata, at Vasishtha's mountain and at Bhrigutunga, Kunti's son purified himself. The best of the Kurus gave thousands of cows at the bathing places and shrines, and he gave dwellings to brahmins. The best of men bathed at the bathing place of Hiranyabindu, and saw the finest of mountains and its holy shrines.

Then the best of men came down with the brahmins, Bharata, and the bull of the Bharatas went on, wanting to reach the east. One after another the best of the Kurus saw the bathing places, the lovely river Utpalini on the way to the Naimisha forest, the Nanda and the Aparananda, the glorious Kaushiki, the Mahanadi, Gaya, and the Ganga, Bharata. So, seeing all the bathing places and the hermitages, and purifying himself, he gave wealth to brahmins. He went to every holy bathing place and shrine in Anga, Vanga and Kalinga, and when he had seen them as the rules require, he gave wealth there too.

At the gates of the kingdom of Kalinga, the brahmins who had followed the Pandava took their leave of Kunti's son and turned back, Bharata. With their leave, the hero Dhananjaya, Kunti's son, went on with a few companions towards the sea. The lord passed through the Kalingas and went on, looking at the lands and the shrines, righteous and lovely. He saw Mount Mahendra, graced by ascetics, and went slowly along the seashore to Manalura.

There the strong-armed man visited all the holy bathing places and shrines, and then he went to the lord of the land, the king of Manalura, Chitravahana, who knew dharma, king. The king had a lovely daughter named Chitrangada. Arjuna saw her by chance as she walked about in the city. When he saw Chitravahana's daughter, with her fine hips, he desired her. He went to the king and told him what he wanted.

The king spoke to him gently. "There was a king in this family named Prabhankara. He had no son, and wanting children, he practised the highest austerity. By that fierce austerity and by bowing down to him, he pleased Shankara, the lord, the great god, Uma's husband. The blessed god gave him one child for each generation of the family. So one child is always born in this family. All my forefathers had sons. But to me this daughter was born, and she is surely the one who will carry on the family. She is my son: that is how I think of her, best of men. By the rule made for such a case she has been named an appointed daughter, bull of the Bharatas. Let this be her bride-price: let a son be born here who will carry on the family. On this condition, Pandava, take her."

He promised, "So be it," and took the girl, and Kunti's son lived in that city for three years.

Then the bull of the Bharatas went to the bathing places in the southern sea, very holy, and graced by ascetics. But there were five bathing places there that the ascetics shunned, though ascetics had used them in the past: Agastya's bathing place, Saubhadra's, the very pure Pauloma's, the bright Karandhama's, which gives the fruit of a horse sacrifice, and Bharadvaja's great bathing place, which takes away sin.

The Pandava noticed that those bathing places were deserted, and saw that the sages, who had their minds on dharma, kept away from them. With joined hands the joy of the Kurus

asked the ascetics, "Why do those who speak of Brahman keep away from these bathing places?"

"Five crocodiles live in them," said the ascetics, "and they carry off the ascetics. That is why these bathing places are shunned, joy of the Kurus."

When he heard them, the strong-armed man, the best of men, went to see those bathing places, though the ascetics tried to stop him. He came to Saubhadra, the fine bathing place of the great seer, and the hero, the tamer of enemies, plunged in quickly and bathed. Then a great creature that moved under the water, a crocodile, seized that tiger among men, Dhananjaya, Kunti's son, in the water. But strong-armed Kunti's son, the best of the strong, took hold of the creature as it struggled, and by his strength he rose out of the water with it.

As soon as glorious Arjuna dragged the crocodile out, it became a lovely woman, decked with every ornament, shining with beauty, king, heavenly in form and delightful. When he saw that great wonder, Dhananjaya, Kunti's son, was very pleased, and he said to the woman, "Who are you, lovely one? And why do you move in the water? Why did you do this great evil in the past?"

"I am an apsaras, strong-armed one," said the woman, "who roams the forests of the gods, always dear to the lord of wealth. My name is Varga, mighty one. I have four other friends, all lovely, who can go wherever they wish. With them I set out once for the home of one of the guardians of the world. On the way we all saw a brahmin, strict in his vows, handsome, studying the Veda, alone, living in solitude. The forest there was filled with the power of his austerity, king. He lit up the whole place like the sun. When we saw his austerity, and his wonderful beauty, we came down to that place, meaning to disturb his austerity.

"I and Saurabheyi, Samichi, Budbuda and Lata went up to the brahmin all at the same moment, Bharata. We sang and laughed and tried to tempt that brahmin. But he did not turn his mind to us at all, hero. The man of great power did not waver. He stayed fixed in his pure austerity. Then the brahmin grew angry and cursed us, bull among kshatriyas. 'You will be crocodiles, and live in the water for a hundred years.'

"Then we were all deeply distressed, best of the Bharatas, and we went for shelter to that brahmin, rich in austerity, who had not fallen. 'We were proud of our beauty and our youth, and of love,' we said, 'and we did a wrong thing. Please forgive us, brahmin. It is death enough for us, rich in austerity, that we came here to tempt you, whose soul is disciplined. Those who think about dharma hold that women were made not to be killed. So you should not harm us, knower of dharma, by dharma. A brahmin is said to be a friend to all beings, knower of dharma. Let this saying of the wise come true, good sir. The good protect those who come to them for shelter. We have come to you for shelter. So you should forgive us.'

"When we said this, the righteous brahmin, whose deeds were good, and whose radiance was like the sun and the moon, showed us his grace, hero.

"'A hundred, a thousand, all,' said the brahmin, 'these are words that mean without end. But 'a hundred' here is a measure. It does not mean without end. When you are crocodiles, seizing men in the water, some best of men will drag you out of the water onto the land. Then you will all take your own forms again. I have never told a lie,

even in jest. And from now on all those bathing places will be known everywhere by the name of the Women's Bathing Places, and they will be holy, and purify the wise.'

"Then we bowed to the brahmin, walked round him, keeping him on our right, and left that place in great distress. We thought, *Where can we all meet, in a short time, the man who will give us back our forms?*" As we thought about it, Bharata, we saw, in a moment, the fortunate divine seer Narada. When we saw the divine seer of boundless splendour, we were all glad. We greeted him, Partha, and stood before him, our faces troubled. He asked us the cause of our sorrow, and we told him. When he had heard what had happened, he said, 'In the lowlands by the southern sea there are five bathing places, holy and lovely. Go there without delay. There that tiger among men, the pure-souled Pandava Dhananjaya, will soon free you from your sorrow, without a doubt.'

"When we heard what he said, hero, we all came here. And it has come true today. You have freed me, sinless one. But these four friends of mine are still in the water. Do a good deed, hero. Free them all."

Then the best of the Pandavas, undaunted and mighty, freed them all from that curse, lord of the people. They rose from the water and took back their own forms, and the apsaras looked as they had before, king.

When he had cleared the bathing places, and given the apsaras leave to go, the lord went back to the city of Manalura to see Chitrangada again. On her he fathered a son, King Babhruvahana. When he had seen him, the Pandava went on towards Gokarna, king.

Subhadra

Arjuna, of boundless courage, went in order to all the holy bathing places and shrines in the western lands. He went to all the bathing places and shrines by the western sea, and then he came to Prabhasa.

Madhusudana heard that Bibhatsu, the unconquered, had come to Prabhasa and was visiting the bathing places. Then Madhava came, unannounced, to Kunti's son, and Krishna and the Pandava saw each other at Prabhasa. They embraced, and asked each other how they fared in the forest. They were dear friends, those two, the seers Nara and Narayana.

Then Vasudeva asked Arjuna about his travels. "Why are you going round these bathing places, Pandava?"

Arjuna told him everything, just as it had happened, and when he had heard it, the lord, the Varshneya, said, "So it is."

When Krishna and the Pandava had enjoyed themselves at Prabhasa as they wished, they went to Mount Raivataka to stay. At Krishna's word, men had already decorated that mountain and brought food. The Pandava accepted it all and ate, and with Vasudeva he watched the actors and dancers. When he had given them all leave to go, and honoured them, the splendid Pandava went to a fine and heavenly bed. He told the Satvata about the bathing places he had seen, Bharata, and the mountains, rivers and forests. As he told his stories, Janamejaya, sleep stole over Kunti's son on that bed, fit for heaven. He was woken by sweet singing and the sound of the lute, with praises and blessings.

When he had done what had to be done, the Varshneya greeted him, and he went in a chariot with golden fittings to Dvaraka. Dvaraka was adorned in honour of Kunti's son, Janamejaya, even in its gardens. The people of Dvaraka, eager to see Kunti's son, came quickly to the royal road by the hundred thousand. At the windows there were hundreds and thousands of women, and there was a great crowd of Bhojas, Vrishnis and Andhakas. He was honoured by all the sons of the Bhojas, Vrishnis and Andhakas. He greeted those he should, and they all greeted him in return. All the young men greeted him with honour, and he embraced those of his own age again and again. He stayed many nights with Krishna, in Krishna's lovely house, which was full of jewels and good things to eat.

Some days later, king, there was a great festival of the Vrishnis and Andhakas on Mount Raivataka. At that mountain's festival the heroes, the Bhojas, Vrishnis and Andhakas, gave gifts to thousands of brahmins. The whole place round the mountain was bright with palaces inlaid with jewels, king, and with trees of lamps. Musicians played their instruments there, dancers danced and singers sang. The young men of the Vrishnis, adorned and full of energy, went about everywhere in carriages with golden fittings. The townspeople came on foot and in carriages of every kind, with their wives and their followers, by the hundred and the thousand.

Then the lord Haladhara, drunk, went about there with Revati, Bharata, followed by gandharvas. So did the mighty Ugrasena, king of the Vrishnis, sung to by gandharvas, with a thousand women in his company. Rukmini's son and Samba, drunk, fierce in battle, wearing heavenly garlands and clothes, enjoyed themselves like immortals. Akura and Sarana, Gada, Bhanu and Viduratha, Nishatha and Charudeshna, Prithu and Viprithu, Satyaka and Satyaki, Bhangakara's companions, Kritavarma, Hridika's son, and others not

named here, each with his own women and gandharvas round him, graced that festival on Raivataka.

While that great and happy uproar went on, Vasudeva and Partha went about together. As they strolled there, they saw Vasudeva's lovely daughter Bhadra, adorned, among her friends. As soon as he saw her, love rose in Arjuna. Krishna saw that Partha's mind was fixed on her.

Then lotus-eyed Krishna said, as if laughing, "What is this, Bharata? Is a forest wanderer's mind being churned by love? She is my sister, Partha, Sarana's sister by the same mother. If your mind is set on it, I will speak to my father myself."

"She is Vasudeva's daughter," said Arjuna, "and Vasudeva's sister, and she is beautiful. Whom would she not bewitch? Everything good would surely have come to me, if this Vrishni girl, your sister, were my queen. Tell me, Janardana, what way there might be to win her. I will do all of it, if a man can."

"The bridegroom choice is the kshatriya way of marriage, bull among men," said Vasudeva. "But it is uncertain, Partha, for there is no knowing which way a woman's heart will turn. Carrying a bride off by force is also praised, for kshatriyas and heroes who seek a wife. So say those who know dharma. So, Arjuna, carry off my lovely sister by force. For who knows what she would do at a bridegroom choice?"

Then Arjuna and Krishna decided what to do, king, and sent swift men to tell the Dharma King, in Indraprastha, all about it. As soon as he heard, the strong-armed Pandava gave his consent.

When that had been arranged, and he had been given leave, Dhananjaya learned that the girl had gone to Raivataka, Janamejaya. He told Vasudeva what he meant to do, and with his leave, knowing Krishna's mind, the bull of the Bharatas set out. He rode a chariot with golden fittings, harnessed as the rules require, yoked with Sainya and Sugriva, hung with nets of little bells. It was furnished with every weapon, it thundered like a cloud, and it shone like blazing fire, killing the joy of enemies. He was armed, in his armour, with his sword, his leather guard and finger guards bound on. He went under the pretext of hunting, Bharata, at the same moment as the girl.

Subhadra had worshipped the lord of mountains, Raivataka, and all the gods, and had the brahmins speak blessings. She walked round the mountain, keeping it on her right, and set out towards Dvaraka. Kunti's son ran at her and forced her onto his chariot. Then that tiger among men took the brightly smiling girl and drove towards his own city in his chariot, which could move through the sky.

When the guards saw Subhadra being carried off, they all ran shouting towards the city of Dvaraka. They came together to the assembly hall Sudharma, and told the keeper of the hall all that Partha had dared to do. When he heard them, the keeper of the hall beat the great war drum, decorated with gold, with its thundering sound. Stirred by that sound, the Bhojas, Vrishnis and Andhakas left their food and drink and gathered in the hall. The tigers among men, the great warriors of the Vrishnis and Andhakas, took their seats on hundreds of thrones, decorated with gold and costly covers, inlaid with jewels and coral, bright as blazing fire, like fires on their altars. When they were seated, like a meeting of the gods, the keeper of the hall and his men told them what Jishnu had done.

When they heard it, the Vrishni heroes, their eyes red at the corners with drink, sprang up in pride. They could not bear what Partha had done.

"Yoke the chariots, quickly!"

"Bring the lances!"

"Bring the costly bows and the great coats of mail!"

Some shouted to their charioteers, "Yoke the chariots!" Some led up the gold-decked horses themselves. As the chariots, armour and banners were brought, there was a great confusion in the uproar of the heroes.

Then Balarama, wearing his garland of wild flowers, drunk, like the peak of Kailasa, dressed in blue, swollen with pride, spoke. "What are you doing, you fools, while Janardana sits silent? You do not know what he thinks, and you are angry, and your roaring is empty. Let the great-minded one tell us his view first. Then do, without fail, what he thinks right."

When they heard those words of Halayudha's, which they could accept, they all fell silent, and said, "Good! Good!" Hearing the wise Baladeva's even-handed words, they all sat down again in the middle of the hall.

Then Balarama, Kamapala, said to Vasudeva, the tamer of enemies, "Why do you sit without a word, Janardana, only watching? It was for your sake, Achyuta, that we all honoured Partha. And he does not deserve that honour, the fool, the disgrace to his family. What man who thinks himself well born would eat a meal and then break the dish? Who, wanting an alliance, and honouring the one that already exists, would act so rashly? He has scorned us, disregarded Keshava, and taken Subhadra by force today, to his own death. How can I bear it, Govinda, that he has set his foot on the middle of my head, as a snake bears being trodden on? Today I will rid the earth of the Kauravas, alone. I cannot bear this offence of Arjuna's."

And all the Bhojas, Vrishnis and Andhakas agreed with him as he roared like a cloud or a kettledrum.

Chapter 88

Abhimanyu

When all the Vrishnis had spoken again and again, Vasudeva spoke words full of dharma and good sense.

"Gudakesha has not insulted this family. He has shown it greater honour, without a doubt. Partha does not think that you Satvatas are greedy for wealth. And the Pandava thinks a bridegroom choice cannot be counted on. Who would agree to a girl being given away like cattle? And what man on earth would sell his child? I think Kaunteya saw these faults, and so the Pandava carried the girl off by force, as dharma allows. The alliance is a fitting one. Subhadra is glorious, and Partha is the kind of man who would carry her off by force. He was born in the line of Bharata and of great Shantanu, the son of Kuntibhoja's daughter. Who would not want Arjuna?

"I see no one who could beat Partha by courage, sir, not in all the worlds, Indra and Rudra included. And there is that chariot, and those horses of mine, and Partha himself, the fighter, swift with his weapons. Who could be his equal? Go after Dhananjaya and turn him back gladly, with the greatest friendliness. That is my considered view. If Partha beats you and goes back to his own city by force, your good name will be lost at once. But there is no defeat in making friends."

When they heard Vasudeva, they did as he said, lord of the people. Arjuna turned back, and he was married there. Kunti's son stayed there for a year, and then the lord spent the rest of his time in Pushkara. When the twelfth year was complete, he went back to Khandavaprastha.

He went to the king, humble and composed, and honoured the brahmins. Then Partha went to Draupadi.

Out of her love, Draupadi spoke to the joy of the Kurus. "Go there, Kaunteya, where that Satvata girl is. Tie a bundle as tight as you like, and the first knot still slackens."

Dhananjaya comforted Krishna again and again as she went on complaining in many ways, and he begged her pardon again and again.

Then Partha quickly sent Subhadra in, dressed in red silk, looking like a cowherd girl. The glorious woman, the hero's wife, shone all the more in that form. When she reached the great house, lovely Bhadra, with her large coppery eyes, greeted Pritha. Then, with a face like the full moon, Bhadra went quickly to Draupadi and greeted her. "I am your servant," she said.

Krishna rose and embraced Madhava's sister, and said with pleasure, "May your husband have no enemies." And Bhadra, happy, said to her, "So be it."

Then the Pandavas, the great warriors, were glad at heart, and Kunti was very pleased, Janamejaya.

When lotus-eyed Keshava heard that Arjuna, the best of the Pandavas, had come back to his own fine city of Indraprastha, the pure-souled one came there with Rama, and with the chief men of the Vrishnis and Andhakas, heroes and great warriors. Shauri, the tamer of enemies, came surrounded by his brothers and sons, and by hundreds of fighting men,

and guarded by a great army.

Wise and glorious Akrura came there, the lord of gifts, the commander of the Vrishni heroes, the tamer of enemies. There came Anadhrishti of great splendour, and glorious Uddhava, of great wisdom and great fame, the pupil of Brihaspati himself. There came Satyaka and Satyaki, Kritavarma the Satvata, Pradyumna and Samba, Nishatha and Shanku, valiant Charudeshna, Jhilli and Viprithu, strong-armed Sarana, and Gada, the best of the learned. These and many other Vrishnis, Bhojas and Andhakas came to Khandavaprastha, bringing many bridal gifts.

When King Yudhishtira heard that Madhava had come, he sent the twins to receive Krishna. Received by them, that rich company of Vrishnis entered Khandavaprastha, which was bright with flags and banners. Its streets were sprinkled and swept and strewn with flowers. It was fragrant with cool sandal water and holy scents, and with aloe burning here and there. It was crowded with well-groomed people, and graced by merchants. The strong-armed Keshava, the best of men, came in with Rama, surrounded by the Vrishnis, Andhakas and great Bhojas. Honoured by the townspeople and by brahmins in their thousands, he entered the king's palace, which was like the house of Purandara.

Yudhishtira met Rama as the rules require. He kissed Keshava on the head and embraced him. Krishna honoured him humbly in return, for he was delighted, and he honoured Bhima, the tiger among men, as was proper. The Dharma King Yudhishtira received the best of the Vrishnis and Andhakas with honour, as the rules require, each as he came. Some he honoured as elders, some as friends. Some he greeted with love, and some greeted him.

Then glorious Vasudeva gave the finest wealth to the wedding party, as Subhadra's bridal gift from her kin. Krishna gave a thousand chariots with golden fittings, hung with nets of little bells, each drawn by four horses, with skilled and trusted drivers, and ten thousand cows. Glorious Janardana gladly gave a thousand milch cows from the country of Mathura, holy and bright, and a thousand white mares, bright as moonbeams, with golden trappings. He gave five hundred black-maned she-mules and five hundred white ones, tamed, as swift as the wind. Lotus-eyed Krishna gave a thousand fair women, well dressed and radiant, young and skilled at bathing and anointing, with golden necklaces of a hundred pieces, healthy and finely clothed, skilled in service. The Dasharha Janardana gave ten men's loads of the best gold, worked and unworked, bright as fire. And Rama, the plough-bearer, who loved daring deeds, gave Partha a thousand elephants as the gift for touching the bride's feet. They were in rut, their ichor flowing in three streams, like mountain peaks, never turning back in battle, well equipped, with loud bells and golden garlands, and with their riders. Haladhara gave this gladly, to honour the new alliance.

That great river of wealth and jewels, with clothes and blankets for its foam, great elephants for its crocodiles, and flags for its waterweed, poured into the ocean of the Pandus. It filled that ocean to the brim, and it brought grief to their enemies.

The Dharma King Yudhishtira accepted it all, and honoured those great warriors of the Vrishnis and Andhakas. The great men, the best of the Kurus, Vrishnis and Andhakas, came together and enjoyed themselves like men of good deeds in the home of the immortals. With great drinking bouts and loud clapping, the Kurus and Vrishnis enjoyed themselves as each thought fit and as each liked. So those men of great courage enjoyed themselves for many days. Then, honoured by the Kurus, they went back to the city of Dvaravati. The great warriors of the Vrishnis and Andhakas went with Rama at their head, taking the

fine jewels the best of the Kurus had given them. But great-minded Vasudeva stayed there with Partha, Bharata, in the lovely city of Shakraprastha, and he roamed the banks of the Yamuna with Partha.

Then Subhadra, Keshava's dear sister, bore a radiant son, Saubhadra, as Paulomi bore Jayanta. Subhadra bore a hero, a bull among men, long-armed, great-spirited, with the eyes of a bull, a tamer of enemies. Because he was fearless, abhi, and full of spirit, manyumat, they called Arjuna's son, the bull among men, the crusher of enemies, Abhimanyu. That great warrior was born to the Satvata woman from Dhananjaya, as fire is born from a shami stick, churned at a sacrifice. When he was born, strong-armed Yudhishtira, Kunti's son, gave ten thousand cows to brahmins, and as many gold coins.

He was dear to Vasudeva from his childhood, and to all his fathers, as the moon is dear to all people. From his birth Krishna performed the rites for him, and the boy grew like the moon in the bright half of the month. The tamer of enemies learned the whole science of the bow, with its four parts and ten kinds, divine and human, from Arjuna, who knew the Veda. The mighty man taught him special skills in the knowledge of weapons, in deftness, and in every kind of practice. In learning and in use he made him almost his own equal, and Dhananjaya was delighted as he looked at his son Saubhadra. He was well made in every limb, and had every good mark. He was hard to overcome, with shoulders like a bull's, like a snake with its mouth open. He had a lion's pride, he was a great archer, he moved like an elephant in rut, his voice was like thunder or a kettledrum, and his face was like the full moon. In courage, in strength, in looks and in bearing he was like Krishna. Bibhatsu looked on his son as Maghavan had looked on him.

And the Panchala princess, who had every good mark, bore her five husbands five heroic sons, fine men, like five mountains. To Yudhishtira she bore Prativindhya, to Vrikodara Sutasoma, to Arjuna Shrutakarman, to Nakula Shatanika, and to Sahadeva Shrutasena. The Panchala princess bore these five heroes, great warriors, as Aditi bore the Adityas.

The brahmins told Yudhishtira, from the treatises, "Let this one be Prativindhya, a match for the enemy in knowing his strokes." Bhimasena's son was born when a thousand soma sacrifices had been pressed, and she bore that great archer, bright as the moon and the sun, as Sutasoma. Because he was born after Kiritin had done a great and famous deed and come back, and people said, "A son is born to you," he became Shrutakarman. Nakula, the Kaurava, the joy of the Kurus, who made his family's name grow, named his son after the royal seer Shatanika, of the Kuru line. Then Krishna bore Sahadeva a son under the constellation ruled by fire, and they knew him as Shrutasena.

The glorious sons of Draupadi were born one year apart, great king, and they were devoted to one another's good. Dhaumya performed their birth rites, their first haircuts and their initiations, as the rules require, one after another, best of the Bharatas. When they had studied the Veda and kept their vows well, they learned the whole art of archery, divine and human, from Arjuna.

With sons like children of the gods, broad-chested and mighty, the Pandavas were happy, tiger among kings.

Agni's Hunger

Living in Indraprastha, at the command of King Dhritarashtra and of Shantanu's son, the Pandavas defeated other kings. The whole world lived happily, relying on the Dharma King, as an embodied soul lives in a body marked by holy deeds. The bull of the Bharatas served dharma, pleasure and wealth equally, as a man with kin honours three kinsmen as dear to him as himself. Those three, dharma, wealth and pleasure, were evenly shared, as if they had bodies on earth, and the king shone among them like a fourth. The Vedas found in him their finest student, the great sacrifices their performer, and the classes of society a good protector. Through that king, Lakshmi had a firm seat, wisdom its highest refuge, and all dharma a kinsman. The king, with his four brothers, shone the more, like a great sacrifice spread wide by the Vedas used in it. Dhaumya and the other brahmins, the first among them equal to Brihaspati, attended him, as the immortals attend Prajapati.

The eyes and hearts of the people delighted equally in the Dharma King, who was as spotless as the full moon. The people did not delight in him only because fate had made him king, but because of the kind of man he was. Whatever pleased their hearts he did in deed. Nothing improper, nothing untrue, nothing false and nothing unkind was ever spoken by the wise and sweet-spoken Partha. The splendid best of the Bharatas was happy, wanting the good of the whole world, and his own. So all the Pandavas lived gladly, free of care, and made the kings of the earth afraid by their power.

Some days later Bibhatsu said to Krishna, "It is hot, Krishna. Let us go to the Yamuna. We will enjoy ourselves there with our friends, Madhusudana, and come back in the evening, if you like the idea, Janardana."

"Son of Kunti," said Vasudeva, "I like it too, that we should enjoy ourselves in the water with our friends, Partha, as we please."

So, taking leave of the Dharma King, Bharata, Partha and Govinda went off with their friends. They came to a pleasure ground, the finest, full of trees of many kinds, with houses high and low, like the house of Purandara. It was stocked, for Varshneya and Partha, with food and drink of every kind, rich and full of flavour, and with garlands of many kinds. They went into it, and it was full of fine jewels of every sort. And all the people enjoyed themselves as they liked, Bharata.

The women of Krishna and Partha, lovely women, enjoyed themselves as the place allowed and as they pleased, some in the woods, some in the water, some in the houses. Draupadi and Subhadra gave costly clothes and ornaments to the women, who were merry with drink. Some danced for joy, others shouted, and others laughed. Some drank the finest wine, and others wept. Some struck at one another, and others whispered secrets. The rich forest was filled with the sound of flutes, lutes and drums, all lovely.

While this went on, the two joys of the Kurus and the Dasharhas went to a lovely spot close by. When they reached it, king, the two great Krishnas, the conquerors of enemy cities, sat down on costly seats. There Partha and Madhava talked of many deeds of courage and love from the past, and enjoyed themselves.

As Vasudeva and Dhananjaya sat there happily, like the two Ashvins on the vault of heaven, a brahmin came up to them. He was like a great sal tree, with the glow of molten

gold. He was tawny and green-gold, with a tawny beard, as broad as he was tall. He was like the morning sun, dressed in black, with matted hair, a face like lotus petals, and a tawny colour, and he seemed to blaze with power. When that shining best of brahmins came near, Arjuna and Vasudeva sprang up at once.

He spoke to Arjuna and to Vasudeva the Satvata, those heroes of the world, as they stood near the Khandava forest.

"I am a brahmin who eats a great deal. I always eat without measure. I beg you, Varshneya and Partha: give me one meal that satisfies me."

When he said this, Krishna and the Pandava answered him, "Tell us what food would satisfy you, sir, and we will try to get it."

When the two heroes asked him what food they should prepare, the blessed one said to them, "I do not want your food. Know that I am Agni. Give me the food that suits me. Indra always protects this Khandava forest, and while that great one guards it, I cannot burn it. His friend, the snake Takshaka, lives in it always with his people, and for his sake the wielder of the thunderbolt guards the forest. Many other creatures are protected there because of him. I want to burn it, but I cannot, because of Shakra's power. When he sees me blazing, he rains on me with the water of the clouds, and so I cannot burn the forest I long to burn. Now I have found the two of you, who know weapons, to help me, and I could burn the Khandava forest. This is the food I choose. For you two, who know the finest weapons, will hold back those streams of water, and the creatures on every side."

When he said this, Bibhatsu answered Agni, Jatavedas, who wanted to burn the Khandava forest against the will of Shatakratu. "I have many heavenly weapons of the finest kind, with which I could fight even many wielders of the thunderbolt. But I have no bow, blessed one, to match the strength of my arms, one that could bear my force when I strain in battle. And I need a great many arrows, arrows that never run out, when I am shooting fast. No chariot could carry as many arrows as I would want. I would want heavenly horses too, white and as swift as the wind, and a chariot that roars like a cloud, as bright as the sun. So too there is no weapon to match Krishna's strength, with which Madhava could kill snakes and demons in battle. Blessed one, tell us the means by which the work can be done, by which I could hold back Indra as he rains on the great forest. Whatever is to be done by human effort, Agni, we two will do. But you must give us, blessed one, the instruments equal to it."

When he was told this, the blessed Agni, with smoke for his banner, the eater of offerings, thought of Varuna, wanting to see him: the guardian of the world, the son of Aditi, the god who lives in the waters, the lord of the waters. Knowing that he had been thought of, Varuna showed himself to Agni. Then Agni, with smoke for his banner, honoured the lord of the waters, the fourth of the world's guardians, the protector, the great lord, and said to him, "Give me quickly the bow and the two quivers that King Soma gave you, and the chariot with the ape on its banner. Partha will do a very great deed with Gandiva, and Vasudeva with the discus. Give them to me for my sake."

"I will give them," Varuna answered.

Then he gave that jewel of a bow, wonderful and mighty, which made glory and fame grow. No weapon could harm it, and it could destroy every weapon. It was the greatest of all

arms and a crusher of enemy armies. It was equal by itself to a hundred thousand bows, and it made kingdoms grow. It was bright with colours of every kind, smooth and without a flaw, and worshipped for endless years by gods, danavas and gandharvas. And he gave the two great quivers that never run out.

He gave the chariot too, yoked with heavenly horses, with the finest of apes on its banner. It was drawn by silver horses of the gandharvas, wearing golden garlands, like white clouds, as swift as thought or the wind. It had every piece of equipment, and neither gods nor danavas could defeat it. It shone, it roared aloud, and it delighted the hearts of all beings. Prajapati, the lord of the world, had made it by his own austerity, and its form was as hard to describe as the sun's. The lord Soma had mounted it and conquered the danavas. It looked like a mountain or a cloud, and it seemed to blaze with glory. On that finest of chariots stood a fine flagstaff of gold, very lovely, beautiful as Indra's bow. On it was a heavenly monkey, with the marks of a lion and a tiger. Perched on the top, it seemed to roar, and it looked splendid. On the banner were creatures of many kinds, and huge, at whose roar the enemy's troops lose their wits.

Partha walked round that fine chariot, bright with many flags, keeping it on his right, and bowed to the gods. Then, armed, in his armour, with his sword, his leather guard and finger guards bound on, he mounted the chariot, as a man of good deeds mounts a flying palace of the gods. When he took hold of Gandiva, that heavenly best of bows, made by Brahma long ago, Arjuna was overjoyed. He bowed to Agni, and then the mighty man took up the bow, gathered his strength, and strung it. As the strong Pandava fitted the string, those who heard its twang were shaken at heart. Having gained the chariot and the bow, and the two great quivers that never run out, Kaunteya was glad, and ready to help.

Then Agni gave Krishna a discus with a hub like a thunderbolt, a weapon of fire, dear to him, and he too was ready. "With this, Madhusudana," Agni said to him, "you will defeat even beings who are not human in battle, without a doubt. With this you will always be greater than men in battle, and than gods, rakshasas, pishachas, daityas and snakes, without any doubt, in destroying the best of your enemies. Every time you throw it at enemies in battle, Madhava, it will kill them, and come back to your hand again, unchecked."

And Varuna gave him a mace that roared like thunder, a terrible weapon that brings the daityas' end, named Kaumodaki, for Hari.

Then Krishna and the Pandava, delighted, said to Agni, "Now we are armed, we have weapons, and chariots and banners. We are ready, blessed one, to fight even all the gods and asuras, let alone one wielder of the thunderbolt who wants to fight for a snake."

"When the Varshneya, the mighty one, lets fly the discus and this weapon in battle," said Arjuna, "there is nothing in the three worlds that Janardana could not conquer. And I too, Agni, with the bow Gandiva and the two great quivers that never run out, am ready to conquer the worlds in battle. Surround this forest on every side with a great blaze, lord, and set it all alight at once, as you wish. We two are ready to help."

When the Dasharha and Arjuna said this to him, the blessed one took on his form of fire and began to burn the forest. Surrounding it on every side, the fire of seven flames burned the Khandava in anger, as if showing the end of an age. He seized that forest and entered it, bull of the Bharatas, roaring like thunder, burning up all living things. As

it burned, the forest's form shone like golden Meru, the king of mountains, with its great splendour, Bharata.

The Burning of Khandava

The two tigers among men, in their two chariots, one on each side of the forest, made a great slaughter of living things in every direction. Wherever the creatures that lived in Khandava were seen running away, the two heroes chased after them. So fast did the chariots move that the creatures could see no gap between them. The two chariot fighters, in their fine chariots, looked like a single spinning wheel.

As the Khandava burned, creatures rose up in their thousands, crying out terribly in all ten directions. Many were burned in one part of the body, others were scorched all over. Their eyes burst, their bodies split, and they leapt about out of their wits. Some clung to their children, others to their fathers and mothers. They could not let them go, for love, and they died like that. Others rose up in their thousands, their faces distorted, and whirling round here and there they fell back into the fire. Here and there living creatures were seen dying, writhing on the ground, their wings, eyes and feet burned. As all the pools of water boiled, Bharata, turtles and fish were seen by the thousand, lifeless. With their bodies ablaze, the living creatures in that forest looked like fires with bodies, as their lives came to an end.

As they flew up, Partha cut them to pieces with his arrows, laughing, and threw them into the blazing fire. Their whole bodies stuck with arrows, they rose up with great cries, and fell back into the fire. The cries of the forest creatures, struck by arrows and burning, sounded like the ocean being churned. The great flames of the delighted fire rose into the sky, and they filled the gods with great alarm.

Then all the great gods went for shelter to the king of the gods, thousand-eyed Purandara. "Why are all these men being burned by the fire, lord of the immortals?" they said. "Has the destruction of the worlds come?"

When he heard them, the slayer of Vritra looked for himself, and then the god of the bay horses set out to save the Khandava. The wielder of the thunderbolt, lord of the gods, spread a great mass of clouds of every kind across the sky and rained. The thousand-eyed god rained on the fire, over the Khandava, pouring out streams as thick as axles by the hundred thousand. But those streams never reached it. They dried up in the sky itself, in the heat of Jatavedas, and not one reached the fire. Then the slayer of Namuchi grew very angry with the blazing fire, and he rained on it again, pouring out a great flood of water. With flames tangled in the streams of rain, full of smoke and lightning, the forest became terrible, and it rang with the roar of thunder.

As he rained water, the Pandava Bibhatsu held it back with a rain of arrows, showing off his finest weapons. The Pandava covered the whole Khandava with arrows on every side, and kept that rain off the forest. As Savyasachin shot, the forest was so covered with arrows that not a single creature could get out.

Takshaka, the mighty king of the snakes, was not there. While the forest was burning, he was at Kurukshetra. But his strong son Ashvasena was there, and he struggled hard to escape from the fire. He could not get out, hard pressed by Kaunteya's arrows. His mother, the snake woman, saved him by swallowing him. She swallowed his head first, and then his tail, and, greedy for her son's life, the snake woman rose up. As she went, the Pandava cut off her head with a sharp, broad-bladed arrow. The lord of the gods saw it, and, wanting to free Ashvasena, the wielder of the thunderbolt confused the Pandava for

a moment with wind and rain, and Ashvasena got free. When he saw that terrible trick, and knew that the snake had deceived him, the Pandava cut the creatures in the sky in two and in three, Bharata. Bibhatsu, in his anger, cursed the snake that moves crookedly, and Agni and Vasudeva cursed him too. "May you never find a place to rest."

Then Jishnu, in his anger, remembering that trick, covered the sky with sharp arrows and fought the thousand-eyed god. When the king of the gods saw Phalguna so enraged, he let loose his own blazing weapon, which spread over the whole sky. Then a wind with a great roar, stirring up all the oceans, rose in the sky and made clouds full of streaming water. To defeat it, Arjuna, skilled in countering, let loose the finest weapon, the weapon of the wind, with its mantra. It destroyed the strength and force of Indra's thunderbolts and clouds. The streams of water dried up and the lightning vanished. In a moment the sky was clear of dust and darkness, with a cool, pleasant breeze, and the sun's disc as it always is. And the eater of offerings, glad to have nothing in his way, blazed up in many shapes, with flames beyond compare, filling the world with his roar.

When they saw that the forest was guarded by the two Krishnas, the proud birds, led by Suparna, flew up into the sky. The garudas, their wings, beaks and claws like thunderbolts, swooped down from the sky, wanting to strike Krishna and the Pandava. In the same way hosts of snakes came out near the Pandava, their mouths blazing, spitting deadly poison. When he saw them flying in their fury, Partha cut them down with his arrows, and they fell helpless into the blazing fire, to lose their bodies.

Then the gods, with gandharvas, yakshas, rakshasas and snakes, rose up with a great roar, eager for battle. With iron balls, discuses, rocks and bhushundis in their raised hands, their strength swollen with anger, they wanted to kill Krishna and Partha. As they shouted and let loose their showers of weapons, Bibhatsu cut off their heads with his sharp arrows. And Krishna, of great power, the slayer of enemies, made a great slaughter of the hosts of daityas and danavas with his discus. Others, mighty as they were, pierced by the arrows and driven back by the force of the discus, stopped, like the sea at the shore.

Then Shakra, the great lord of the thirty gods, in great anger, mounted his white elephant and rushed at the two of them. He took up his thunderbolt and swiftly let fly that weapon. "They are dead," the slayer of the asuras said to the gods.

When they saw the great thunderbolt raised by the king of the gods, the gods all took up their own weapons. King Yama took up his staff of death, and the lord of wealth his club. Varuna took up his noose, and Shiva his strange discus. The two Ashvins took up blazing herbs. Dhatri took up a bow, and Jaya a pestle. Mighty Tvashtri in his anger took up a mountain. Amsha took up a spear, and the god Death an axe. Aryaman went about with a terrible iron bar, and Mitra stood holding a discus edged like a razor. Pushan and Bhaga and Savitri, in their anger, lord of the people, rushed at Krishna and Partha with bows and swords in their hands. The Rudras, the Vasus, the mighty Maruts, the Vishvedevas and the Sadhyas, blazing with their own splendour, these and many other gods, with weapons of every kind, came at those two best of men, Krishna and Partha, wanting to kill them.

In that great battle wonderful portents were seen, like those at the end of an age, foretelling the ruin of creatures, Bharata. But when the two unfallen ones saw Shakra enraged, with the gods, they stood unafraid in battle, invincible, their bows ready. As the gods came on, one by one, the two in their anger drove them back with arrows like

thunderbolts. Again and again the gods' plans were broken, and in their fear they left the battle and took refuge with Shakra. When the sages standing in the sky saw the gods held back by Madhava and Arjuna, they were amazed. And Shakra too, seeing their courage again and again in battle, was delighted, and fought them once more.

Then the chastiser of Paka let loose a great shower of rocks, wanting to test Savyasachin's courage further. Arjuna, unable to bear it, struck down that rain with his arrows. When Shatakrtu saw it made useless, the king of the gods made the shower heavier still. But the son of the chastiser of Paka, to his father's delight, destroyed that shower of rocks with swift arrows. Then Shakra tore up with both hands a great peak of Mount Mandara, with its trees, and threw it, wanting to kill the Pandava. But Arjuna shattered the mountain peak into a thousand pieces with swift, straight arrows, blazing at their tips. As the mountain broke apart, it looked like the sky itself breaking up, with sun, moon and planets. As that great rock fell headlong into the forest, it killed still more of the creatures who lived in the Khandava.

Frightened by the falling mountain, the dwellers of the Khandava, the danavas, rakshasas and snakes, hyenas, bears and forest creatures, elephants in rut, tigers, maned lions, deer and buffaloes, birds by the hundred, and other kinds of creatures, were thrown into panic and fled. Looking at the forest and at the two Krishnas with their weapons raised, they seemed terrified by the terrible noise. Janardana let loose his discus, shining with its own light, and those lesser creatures, with the danavas and the night-walkers, were cut down by the hundred and fell into the fire at once. There the rakshasas, torn apart by Krishna's discus, smeared with fat and blood, looked like clouds at dusk. The Varshneya went about like Death, killing pishachas, birds, snakes and beasts by the thousand, Bharata. Every time Krishna, the slayer of enemies, threw that discus, it killed many creatures and came back to his hand, again and again. As he killed every creature like this, Bharata, the form of that soul of all beings became very terrible.

Among all the gods and danavas gathered there, no one could defeat Krishna and the Pandava in that battle. When the gods could not protect the forest from their might, or put out the fire, they turned away. When Shatakrtu saw the hosts of the gods turn away, he was pleased, and he stood still, praising Krishna and the Pandava.

When the gods had turned back, a voice without a body spoke to Shatakrtu, in a deep and solemn tone.

"Your friend Takshaka, the best of snakes, is not here. He went to Kurukshetra before the burning of the Khandava. And you cannot defeat these two, Vasudeva and Arjuna, Shakra, standing here in this battle. Hear what I say. These are the gods Nara and Narayana, famous in heaven. You yourself know their strength and their courage. These two cannot be defeated. They are hard to overcome, unconquered in battle, even in all the worlds, those ancient seers, the best of seers. They deserve the greatest honour from all the gods and asuras, and from yakshas, rakshasas, gandharvas, men, kinnaras and snakes. So you should go from here with the gods, Vasava. And see that the destruction of the Khandava is fated."

When he heard this voice, the lord of the immortals said, "It is true." He let go of his anger and indignation and set out for heaven. When they saw the great one set out, the gods all followed Shatakrtu together, quickly, king. When they saw the king of the gods go with the gods, the heroes Vasudeva and Arjuna gave a lion's roar. With the king of the gods gone, king, Krishna and the Pandava, full of joy, went on burning the forest

without fear.

As the wind drives away clouds, Arjuna drove off the gods, and with showers of arrows he killed the creatures that lived in the Khandava. As Savyasachin shot, not one creature could get out, cut down by his arrows. Even the great creatures there could not look at Arjuna in battle, with his arrows that never missed, let alone fight him. He pierced a hundred with one arrow, and one with a hundred. They fell lifeless into the fire, as if struck down by Death himself. They found no comfort on the river banks or in rough places. Even in the dwellings of the ancestors and the gods, the heat was felt. Thousands of hosts of creatures cried out in distress. Elephants, deer and birds cried out, and at that noise the fish in the Ganga and the ocean shook with fear. No one could even look at strong-armed Arjuna, or at mighty Krishna, let alone fight them. Those rakshasas, danavas and snakes who rushed out all together, Hari killed with his discus. Their heads and bodies split by the force of the discus, those huge creatures fell dead into the mouth of the blazing fire.

Fed with floods of flesh and blood, and floods of fat, the fire rose above the sky, and could be seen without smoke. His eyes blazing, his tongue blazing, his huge mouth blazing and open wide, his hair blazing and standing on end, his eyes tawny, he drank the fat of living creatures. Having won that nectar, given him by Krishna and Arjuna, the eater of offerings was glad and full, and reached the greatest contentment.

Then Madhusudana saw an asura named Maya suddenly running from Takshaka's house. Agni, with the wind for his charioteer, wanted to burn him, and pursued him, taking on a body with matted hair, roaring like a cloud. And Vasudeva stood with his discus raised, wanting to kill him.

When he saw the discus raised and the fire wanting to burn him, Maya cried out, "Run to me, Arjuna!"

When he heard that cry of fear, Dhananjaya Partha answered Maya, as if giving him life, "Do not be afraid!"

When Partha had given Maya, Namuchi's brother, his promise of safety, the Dasharha did not want to kill him, and the fire did not burn him.

As that forest burned, the fire did not burn six: Ashvasena, Maya, and the four Sharngaka birds.

Jarita

"Why did Agni not burn the Sharngakas," said Janamejaya, "when things were as they were, while that forest was burning? Tell me quickly, brahmin. You have told the reason why Ashvasena and the danava Maya were not burned, brahmin, but you have not told it for the Sharngakas. The sparing of the Sharngas is a wonder, brahmin. Tell me how they were not destroyed in that onslaught of fire."

"I will tell you all of it, Bharata," said Vaishampayana, "just as it happened, why Agni did not burn the Sharngakas when things were as they were."

There was a great seer named Mandapala, the most eminent of those who know dharma, an ascetic strict in his vows, and learned. He followed the path of the seers who keep their seed drawn up, king. He studied the Veda, delighted in dharma, practised austerity and mastered his senses. When he had reached the far shore of austerity, he gave up his body, Bharata, and went to the world of the ancestors. But he did not find the fruit of his austerity there. When he saw that the worlds he had won by his austerity bore no fruit, he asked the gods who sat near the Dharma King, "Why are these worlds of mine, won by austerity, shut to me? What have I left undone there, that this is the fruit of my deeds? I will do there whatever it is for which this is shut. Tell me the fruit of this austerity, gods."

"Men are born debtors, brahmin," said the gods. "Hear to what. To the rites, to celibate study, and to offspring, without a doubt. All of this is paid off by sacrifice, by austerity, and by sons. You are an ascetic and you have sacrificed, but you have no offspring. These worlds of yours are shut for the sake of offspring. Have children, and then you will enjoy the eternal worlds. A son saves his father from the hell called Put, sage. So strive to have children, best of the twice-born."

When he heard the gods, Mandapala thought, *Where can I have offspring quickly, and many of them?* As he thought, he came to the birds that have many young. Becoming a male Sharngaka, he went to a female Sharngika named Jarita. On her he fathered four sons who could speak of Brahman. He left them there, in the forest, the little sons still in their eggs, with their mother, and the sage went off to Lapita.

When that fortunate one had gone to Lapita, Bharata, Jarita, anxious with love for her young, thought a great deal. Though he had abandoned them, she did not abandon her little sons, the seers in their eggs, whom no one should abandon, in the Khandava, king. In her distress, and faint with love, she reared them when they hatched, by her own labour.

Then the seer Mandapala, as he wandered in that forest with Lapita, saw Agni coming to burn the Khandava. Knowing what the fire meant to do, and knowing that his sons were small, the brahmin seer, in fear, praised Jatavedas, the mighty guardian of the world, and entrusted his sons to him.

"You, Agni," said Mandapala, "are the mouth of all the gods. You are the carrier of offerings. You move hidden within all creatures, purifier. The poets call you one, and call you threefold. Dividing you eightfold, they made you the carrier of the sacrifice. The great seers say that this universe was made by you. Without you, eater of offerings, the whole world would cease at once. Bowing to you, brahmins go with their wives and

sons to the eternal place they have won by their own deeds. They say, Agni, that you are the clouds that hang in the sky with the lightning, and that the flames that come out of you burn all creatures. Jatavedas, of great splendour, this making of the universe is yours. All that is, moving and still, is your work. By you the waters were made first, and in you is this whole world. In you the offerings to the gods and to the ancestors are rightly set. Agni, you are the blaze, you are the Ordainer, you are Brihaspati. You are the two Ashvins, the twins, Mitra and Soma, and you are the wind."

Praised like this by Mandapala, the sage of boundless power, Agni was pleased with him, king, and said to him with a glad heart, "What would you have me do for you?"

With joined hands Mandapala said to the carrier of offerings, "As you burn the Khandava forest, spare my sons."

"So be it," the blessed carrier of offerings promised him. And at that time he blazed up in the Khandava, wanting to burn it.

When the fire had blazed up, the Sharngakas were in great distress. Frightened and terrified, they could find no refuge. Seeing her little sons, their mother, poor Jarita, burning with sorrow, lamented, lord of men.

"This terrible fire is coming this way, burning the undergrowth, setting the world alight, fierce, making my sorrow grow. And these little ones pull at me, with their little sense, without feathers, unable to walk, the refuge of our ancestors. And the fire comes on, frightening them, licking at the trees. My sons have no strength, and cannot get away. And I cannot carry my sons away with me. Nor can I leave them. My heart seems to burn. Which son shall I leave, and which shall I take with me? What would be right for me to do? What do you think, my sons? I think about how to save you, and I can find nothing. I will cover you with my body, and die with you.

"'This family rests on Jaritari, the eldest,' your father said. 'Sarisrikva will have children and make the ancestors' family grow. Stambamitra will practise austerity, and Drona will be the best of those who know Brahman.' With that, your pitiless father went away, long ago. Which of you can I take and go with? Which of you faces the greatest danger? What can I do, so that I do what is right?"

So she was distraught, and by her own wits she could find no way to save her sons from the fire. As she spoke like this, the Sharngas answered their mother.

"Give up your love for us, mother, and fly where there is no fire. If we die, you will have other sons. But if you die, mother, our family will not go on. Think of both, and do what is best for our family. Now is the time for you to do it, mother. Do not let your love for us, your sons, destroy our family. For our father, who wanted the heavenly worlds, must not have acted in vain."

"There is a rat's hole in the ground, here, near this tree," said Jarita. "Go into it quickly. The fire will not harm you there. Then I will cover the hole with dust, my sons. That is how I think we can stand against the blazing, black-tracked fire. Then, when the fire has passed, I will come and clear away the dust. Choose this way to escape from the fire."

"We have no feathers," said the Sharngakas. "We are only lumps of flesh, and the

flesh-eating rat would kill us. We see this danger, and we cannot go in there. How can the fire not burn us? How can the rat not eat us? How can our father's work not be in vain? How can our mother live? In the hole, the rat would destroy us. For creatures of the sky, it is the fire. Think of both. Burning is better than being eaten. Death in a hole, eaten by a rat, would be a shameful death. Giving up the body to the fire is approved by the wise."

"A hawk carried off the rat that came out of this hole," said Jarita. "It took the little creature in its claws. So there is no danger from that."

"We do not know that the rat was carried off by the hawk," said the Sharngakas. "And there may be others here, and they are a danger to us too. It is not certain that the fire will come. The wind has been known to turn back. But death from the creatures that live in the hole would be certain, mother. An uncertain death is better than a certain one, mother. Fly in the sky, as is right. You will find fine sons."

"I saw the hawk coming near the hole," said Jarita. "The strong bird seized the rat as it moved about and carried it off from the hole. I followed the hawk quickly as it flew, and I blessed it as it carried off the mouse from the hole: 'King of hawks, who fly off with our enemy, may you live in heaven, golden, without enemies.' When the hungry bird had eaten it, I took leave of it and came back home. Go into the hole, my sons, without fear. There is no danger for you. The hawk took the rat while I watched. There is no doubt of it."

"We do not know that the rat was taken from here before, mother," said the Sharngakas. "We cannot go into the hole without knowing."

"But I know that the hawk took the mouse," said Jarita. "So there is nothing to fear. Do as I say."

"Do not try to save us from this great danger by a pretence," said the Sharngakas. "When minds are confused, such a thing is not done with good judgement. We have done nothing for you, and you do not even know who we are. You are suffering to rear us. Who are you to us, and what are we to you? You are young and lovely, and able to look for a husband. Go after your husband. You will have fine sons. And we, going into the fire, will gain good worlds. And if the fire does not burn us, you can come back to us."

When they said this, the Sharngi left her sons in the Khandava and went quickly to a safe place where the fire could not reach. Then the blazing carrier of offerings, sharp of flame, came to where Mandapala's little sons were. When the Sharngas saw the fire blazing with its own splendour, Jaritari spoke, so that Agni could hear.

Indra's Boon

"The wise man is awake before the time of trouble comes," said Jaritari, "and when the time of trouble comes, he is never shaken. But the fool who does not see trouble before it comes is shaken when it does, and knows nothing."

"You are steady and wise," said Sarisrikva, "and this is a danger to our lives. Among many, there is one who is brave and wise. There is no doubt of it."

"The eldest is the protector," said Stambamitra. "The eldest saves us from trouble. If the eldest does not know what to do, what can the younger do?"

"The fire with the golden seed is coming quickly, blazing, to destroy us," said Drona. "The hungry fire with seven tongues is creeping up on us, licking."

When his brothers said this to him, Jaritari joined his hands and praised the bright fire. Hear how, king.

"You are the self of the wind, the purifier," said Jaritari. "You are the body of the plants. The waters are your source, bright one, and you are the source of the waters. Your flames go up and down and spread out on every side, mighty one, like the rays of the sun."

"Our mother has gone, and we do not know our father," said Sarisrikva. "Our wings have not grown, god of the lotus banner. We have no protector but you, Agni. So protect us, lone hero. Whatever gentle form you have, Agni, and your seven flames, protect us with them today. We praise you, and we seek your shelter. You alone give heat, Jatavedas. There is no other who gives heat among the rays, god. Protect us, who are little seers. Pass us by, carrier of offerings."

"You alone are everything, Agni," said Stambamitra. "In you is this whole world. You sustain living things, and you bear up the world. You are Agni, the carrier of offerings, and you are the highest offering. The wise worship you as many, and as one. When you have made these three worlds, carrier of offerings, you cook them again when the time comes, kindled. You are the birthplace of this whole world, Agni, and again its resting place. You, lord of the world, living within, cook the food that creatures eat. Growing for ever, you cook it, and all things rest in you."

"Becoming the sun, Jatavedas," said Drona, "you take up with your rays the water of the earth and all the juices born of the earth, and when the time comes to release them, you give them back as rain and make things grow here, bright one. From you, bright one, come these plants with their green leaves, and the lotus pools, and the ocean, the great sea. This body of ours, sharp-rayed one, belongs to Varuna. Be our gentle protector. Do not destroy us today. Tawny-eyed, red-necked, black-tracked eater of offerings, pass us by. Spare us, as you spare the houses of the ocean."

When Drona, whose deeds were unwearied, said this, Jatavedas, glad at heart, spoke to Drona, mindful of his promise to Mandapala.

"You are the seer Drona. What you have spoken is Brahman. I will do what you wish, and you have nothing to fear. For Mandapala told me of you before: 'As you burn the forest,

spare my sons.' His words and what you have said here both weigh with me. Tell me, what shall I do for you? I am very pleased with your hymn, brahmin. Bless you, lord."

"These cats are always frightening us, bright one," said Drona. "Put them between your fangs, carrier of offerings, with all their kin."

The fire did so. Then, taking leave of the Sharngakas, he blazed up and burned the Khandava, Janamejaya.

Mandapala too, joy of the Kurus, kept thinking of his sons. Though he had spoken to the fire, he could not stop worrying. Tormented about his sons, he said to Lapita, "How can my little sons, Lapita, who cannot fly, escape, when the fire is growing and the wind is blowing hard? They will not be able to get away. How will their mother, poor thing, bear her misery, unable to save them, seeing no way to rescue her sons? How will she bear it, running about, crying out, tormented, over my sons, who can neither run nor fly? How is my son Jaritari? How is Sarisrikva? How are Stambamitra and Drona? And how is she, poor thing?"

As the seer Mandapala lamented like this in the forest, Lapita answered him, as if in jealousy, Bharata.

"You have no real care for your sons. You told me yourself those seers were full of power and strength. They have nothing to fear from the fire. And you entrusted them to the fire in front of me, and the great fire promised, 'So be it.' A guardian of the world never speaks a false word. And they are able to speak for themselves. Your heart is not with them at all. It is my enemy you are thinking of, and pining for. Surely you have no love for me, as you had for her before. It is not right for one who has wings, and could help, to look on without love while a friend is in torment. Go to Jarita, since it is for her you are pining. I will go about alone, like a woman with a worthless man."

"I do not go about in the world as you think," said Mandapala. "I go about for the sake of offspring, and that offspring is in danger. The fool who lets go of what he has for the sake of what may come is despised by the world. Do as you wish. This blazing fire, licking at the trees, raises a hateful, evil anguish in my heart."

When the fire had passed from that place, Jarita, longing for her sons, hurried back to them. She found them all safe, freed from Jatavedas, crying piteously in the forest. Again and again she could hardly believe the sight of them, and she went to each of her sons in turn, weeping.

Then Mandapala too arrived suddenly, Bharata. But none of his sons welcomed him. Though he spoke to each of them again and again, and to Jarita, they said nothing to the seer, good or bad.

"Which is your eldest son?" said Mandapala. "Which is the next, which the middle one, and which the youngest? Why do you not answer me, when I speak to you in my distress? I did entrust them to the eater of offerings. And still I find no peace."

"What do you want with the eldest son?" said Jarita. "Or with the next? What do you want with the middle one, or with the youngest, poor thing? You left me with nothing at all and went away long ago. Go to that Lapita, young and sweetly smiling."

"For women," said Mandapala, "nothing is so bad, except another man, as a rival wife. That is how it must be in the world. Even the lovely Arundhati, true to her vows and famous in all the worlds, suspected Vasishtha, the best of seers, whose heart was wholly pure, who always cared for her good, the hero among the seven seers. And she scorned that sage. For that ill thought she has become the colour of smoke and dusk, now seen and now not seen, not beautiful, and she is looked on as an ill omen. So you too, when I have come here for the sake of our children, turn from the one you love and behave as she did. A man should never trust that a woman is his wife. For a wife who has a son does not think of her duty."

Then all his sons attended him properly, and he began to comfort them, king.

"I asked the fire to protect you," said Mandapala, "and Agni had already promised, 'So be it.' I knew Agni's word, and your mother's knowledge of dharma, and your own great power, and so I did not come here before. You need not grieve over death, my sons. The eater of offerings knows that you are seers. And Brahman is known to you."

When he had comforted his sons in this way, Bharata, Mandapala took his wife and went from that place to another land.

The blessed sharp-rayed fire burned the kindled Khandava forest with the two Krishnas, making the world safe. When he had drunk the streams of fat and marrow there, the fire reached the greatest contentment, and showed himself to Arjuna.

Then the blessed lord of the gods came down from the sky, surrounded by the Maruts, and said to Partha and Madhava, "You two have done a deed that even the immortals would find hard. Choose boons. I am pleased with you, even boons that are rare and more than human."

Partha asked Shakra for all his weapons, and Shakra set a time for him to receive them. "When the blessed Mahadeva is pleased with you, Pandava," he said, "then I will give you all my weapons. I myself will know when that time comes, joy of the Kurus. And for your great austerity I will give them to you. All the fire weapons and all the wind weapons, and all of mine, you will receive, Dhananjaya."

And Vasudeva asked for eternal friendship with Partha, and the king of the gods, pleased, gave him that boon.

When he had given them their boons, the lord of the Maruts, well pleased, took leave of the fire and went back to heaven with the gods.

And Agni, having burned that forest, with its beasts and birds, for six days, was well satisfied, and stopped. When he had eaten the flesh and drunk the fat and blood, he was full of the greatest joy, and he spoke to the two of them, lord of the people.

"You two, the best of men, have satisfied me as I wished. I give you leave, heroes. Go wherever you wish."

When the great Agni had given them leave, Arjuna, Vasudeva and the danava Maya, all three, bull of the Bharatas, walked about, and then sat down together on a lovely river bank.

